Fireball

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/22688182.

Rating:	Explicit
Archive Warning:	No Archive Warnings Apply
Category:	M/M
Fandom:	僕のヒーローアカデミア | Boku no Hero Academia | My Hero Academia
Relationships:	Bakugou Katsuki/Midoriya Izuku, Minor or Background Relationship(s), Kaminari Denki/Kirishima Eijirou
Characters:	Uraraka Ochako, Iida Tenya, Todoroki Shouto, Bakugou Katsuki, Midoriya Izuku, Tokoyami Fumikage, Asui Tsuyu, Ashido Mina, Shinsou Hitoshi, Kirishima Eijirou, Kaminari Denki
Additional Tags:	Mutual Pining, Redemption, Bakugou Katsuki Swears A Lot, Character Growth, Idiots in Love, Protectiveness, Slow Burn, Midoriya Izuku is a Ray of Sunshine, Fluff and Humor, Bakugou? More like Bakuhoe, Adults, Happy Ending, Angst, Healing, Eventual Smut, Mutual Support, Midoriya Izuku is a Tease, Pining Bakugou Katsuki, Bakugou Katsuki Tries His Best, Gratuitous Smut, Rough Sex, loving relationship, Canon-Typical Violence, Canon-verse but I'm lazy with details, Mention of Humiliation Kink, Post-Canon, Choking, Alternate Universe - Mineta Minoru Doesn't Exist, Mention of Past Verbal Abuse, I do mean the rough sex tag, This is a Wholesome Fic I Promise!, Aged-Up Character(s), Switch Bakugou Katsuki, Switch Midoriya Izuku, Semi-Public Sex, Dirty Talk, Degradation Kink (but it's p chill and mostly dirty talk), Complete
Language:	English
Series:	Part 1 of Fireball
Collections:	BNHA Fanfic W(Rec)ks!, My hero academia, GBFOAT: Greatest BakuDeku Fics Of All Time 💥🥦, MyHeroAcademia1414, Katya's Korner Fic Recs, All-time BNHA Favourites, Zonc 'n' Zoof's BNHA Hell, COMPLETE, Histórias topzinhas, Absolute Favorites, misc favourite fic, BBDF (AEETWWW): Best BakuDeku Fics (And Everyone Else They Work Well With), Bakudeku fics that keep me going, shooks' fave bkdk fics, the perfect fic doesn't exi-, BNHA Fanfiction Archive, BakuDeku Things, Stellar Fics: A Wonder Duo Collection ☆★, Keep Coming Back 2, Fics that cause me to be sleep deprived, bkdk yuh, retro-triscuit's favorite (bkdkbk) fics, Storycatchers' pile of heroic hero stuff, Bnha fanfic who has my heart, ⭐My Hero Stories Worth Your Time⭐, 💖My Hero Smut Life💖, 🫧Lux's fav fics 🫧, my top top bkdk/dkbk faves, BKDK Brainrot (TiaLee), Fics That Altered My Little Brain's Chemistry, Bakudeku Fics That Ripped My Heart Out And Made Me Question Existence
Stats:	

Published: 2020-02-13 Completed: 2020-06-22 Words: 122,140
Chapters: 21/21

Fireball

by useless_donut

Summary

Izuku hasn't seen Bakugou in months. He hasn't spoken to him in two years, and it's been eight years since they had a meaningful conversation. Not that Izuku's counting, because adult Izuku has um, a spine and also self-respect. He wouldn't waste his entire life pining after someone who couldn't care less about him, right? Not even if that person is both figuratively and literally smoking hot? Right?

That would be ridiculous, and Izuku is... ridiculous. Because when Bakugou explosively (again, literally) lands back in Izuku's life, Izuku can't help but try one more time to reconnect. What could possibly go wrong?

Deku What the Fuck

Chapter Summary

Izuku and Katsuki finally meet again, and handle it kinda ok

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It's the first time Izuku's seen Bakugou in months. In typical Bakugou fashion, it happened in a shocking round of explosions.

Izuku was patrolling his sector of the city, minding his own blessed business, when a solid concrete wall in front of him explodes outwards in a bloom of flame and smoke. Rocketing out of the center of the fire was a familiar blond-haired form. Izuku staggered back, shocked enough that he'd frozen in place, iron-soled boots rooted to the pavement.

In contrast, Bakugou pushes himself further into the air with another explosion, vaulting flawlessly to land on the railing of someone's balcony. Show off. Something slimy and purple and vaguely human-shaped crawled out of the hole Ground Zero had rocketed from. With an audible growl, the other hero lept from the balcony, straight down onto it, arms outstretched.

The resulting explosion left soot five stories up the alleyway on both sides. Still frazzled, Izuku began to run forwards. What had Ground Zero been fighting? Was he okay? Was Izuku's own damn sector okay? His zone required a slightly more subtle touch than the constant explosions Ground Zero tended to provide.

"Ka-Ground Zero!" He shouted, voice coming out high and strained.

It's also the first time he's talked to Bakugou in two years.

After graduating UA, Bakugou had quickly rocketed to popularity. The last few years of school had sanded the cruel edge off of his personality, leaving him just palatable enough to be Japan's favorite bad boy. Bad *young man*, now, judging by the relatively scandalous "Japan's Hottest Heroes" calendar he'd posed for. Did Izuku own a copy? Of course not, Izuku had a sense of shame. He also had a picture of Bakugou's spread he'd taken covertly with his phone at a stationery shop. Izuku doesn't have quite enough shame, apparently.

Bakugou Katsuki was brash, loud, undeniably hot, unfailingly standoffish and unreachable, and therefore media's reluctant darling. If you didn't love him, you loved to hate him. And he looked good on a front cover. He looked good on anything, in Izuku's opinion, but that was just his long-dead childhood crush speaking. Izuku was older now, at twenty-five, and had spent plenty of time convincing himself out of it. Had he been successful in this? Yes. A

definite yes, as long as Bakugou stayed far away from him and out of his life. This was something that had been relatively easy after graduation.

The smoke cleared slowly, dramatically. The subject of Izuku's long-dead childhood crush stepped out of it, cracking his knuckles and surveying the area, likely looking for casualties. Izuku swallowed.

"You're supposed to look for bystanders before you explode things Kach-Ground Zero," he called.

Bakugou's head rolled towards him, lazy and amused. "You count yourself as a bystander, nerd?"

"At least you've stopped shouting, 'Now Die,' whenever you do anything," Izuku said, ignoring his question. He'd learned it was better to sidestep Bakugou's jabs then meet them head on.

To his surprise, Bakugou scratched his head. "I did actually check, idiot. Fucking wasn't supposed to be anyone here."

Izuku wasn't sure what to say. He'd lost the ability to speak normally to Bakugou after their second year at UA, when Bakugou had inexplicably stopped being a massive dickhole to him. Instead of being rivals, they'd become nothing. The silence stretched.

"Could've hurt you," Bakugou grumbled. Izuku didn't know if he was insulting him or being remorseful. He was surprised by how much the awkwardness hurt. His old friend looked different, he realized. Older. Outside of magazines and TV, the difference was more obvious. His hair was shorter, face sharper, and his hero costume had been altered. Still ridiculous and over the top, but undeniably sleeker.

"What are you doing here?" Izuku blurted. Bakugou blinked. Awkwardness stole another few seconds before Bakugou's natural temper set in. He gestured behind him wildly, arm flexing in a way Izuku studiously ignored.

"Kicking ass?" He said, a little loudly. "Want me to let my shitty villains run all over your sector just so you don't have to see me?"

Izuku found himself laughing. "You can just give me a heads up like everyone else," he said, good nature returning. That's right. Bakugou was just another pro hero, working like everyone else did. He could handle this situation. "This area's my responsibility, I'm happy to come help. And keep the property damage down," he found himself adding.

Bakugou eyed him suspiciously. "Were you always such a smartass?"

"I know when it's appropriate and when it's not," Izuku said, folding his hands behind his head. For once, he was enjoying the interaction with his old friend. He hadn't talked to him so long… but more to the point, he hadn't talked to Bakugou since he'd grown some self-respect. The other man was a lot less intimidating now that Izuku wasn't afraid of his own shadow.

His self-assuredness lasted exactly as long as it took Bakugou to stalk into his personal space, spelling like smoke and nitroglycerin. Bakugou's red eyes were narrowed, a faint sneer on his face. "You're different, Midoriya."

"Midoriya?" Izuku yelped reflexively, cheeks red. Bakugou didn't use his name. Any of his names. Even his hero name, he'd always said with disdain. Bakugou's frown lifted.

"But not too different."

Not too different? Izuku didn't know what on earth that meant. He did know that Bakugou's closeness and the smell of smoke was doing things to his knees. Up close, he could see how the sun hitting Bakugou's eyes made them warm to a shade of amber, and how he actually had a faint, faint dusting of freckles across his nose. Izuku swallowed his damn inconvenient libido and stared over his old friend's muscular shoulder.

Not moving away, Bakugo pulled out his tablet and began logging his take down, a process Izuku was all too familiar with. Izuku tried to wrap his head around the strange encounter. Apparently, it had just been a matter of time before Ground Zero turned up in his sector, and if it just happened to be when Izuku was nearby, well that wasn't too big of a coincidence. After all, if Bakugou hadn't been logging the times he'd crossed sectors, it might not even be the first time, and…

"You still mutter like a freak," Bakugou said, grinning like he'd won a prize. For Bakugou, that didn't mean a nice grin. Shaken out of his thoughts, Izuku stared up blankly for a moment. All he knew in that moment was that if Bakugou walked out of his life now, he didn't want to wait another two years to talk to him again. Better not to let him walk away. Good thing Izuku had spent the last eight years growing a spine.

If Bakugou had always been reckless, Izuku had always been impulsive to match. "Let's go out sometime," he said, staring into those red eyes.

Bakugou stopped his tablet straight onto the pavement.

"To catch up," Izuku added, bending to pick up the tablet. Its screen had cracked in several places. He looked up to apologize, and realized Bakugou was still standing there, hand outstretched, dumbfounded. Then he recovered himself.

"What the fuck," he shouted, snatching the tablet back. Izuku flushed, suddenly embarrassed. He hadn't asked Bakugou to hang out before. Well, not since 6th grade, when the other boy had forcibly shoved his face into a mud puddle for asking. Annoyed by the memory, Izuku crossed his arms.

"Take it or leave it, Lord Explodo Murder," he said quickly, before he chickened out. He would not be intimidated. He would not. Not even by burning eyes and sinfully defined biceps.

"Eh?" Bakugou was nearly shouting. "You!" Then he slapped a hand over his mouth. Izuku watched in amazement as the man reigned in his temper, right before his eyes. After a

moment, the hand dropped. Bakugou pocketed the tablet, shoving his hands in the pockets of his baggy shorts. “Sure,” he said, finally.

Izuku nearly dropped dead. Sure. Sure? Bakugou said ‘Sure?’ Since when?

“I’ll see you later then,” he blurted, and bolted, leaving a puzzled Bakugou in the distance.

Thanks to Full Cowling, he made it to the other side of his sector in a matter of minutes. When was the last time he’d run that fast?

Bakugou Katsuki. His childhood best friend, elementary school tormentor, high school rival. Adult *nothing*. Bakugou Katsuki had said, ‘Sure.’

Midoriya bolted like a frightened gazelle. Katsuki was left staring after him dumbly. What had just happened?

Then the press descended. Experienced in this, Katsuki gave them routine answers, only floundering when they asked where Deku had gone. Fuck if Katsuki knew. In his head, a subconscious chant was starting to repeat, going something like, ‘what the fuck, what the fuck, what the fuck, what the fuck-”

Katsuki made it all the way back to his flat before blue-screening. He slammed and locked the door behind him. “Want to go out with me?” He half-shrieked, the sound echoing around his empty apartment. His voice dropped to a whisper.

“Deku, what the fuck.”

He stormed over to the kitchen, and grabbed a kiwi from a fruit bowl his mother had left. He needed a snack. A small, green-haired snack that had not asked him out. “What the actual fuck, Deku,” he muttered, staring at the kiwi. The kiwi was placed back into the bowl. Gently.

The couch was Katsuki’s next victim, as he threw himself onto it. “Oh yes,” he snapped, glaring at the ceiling. “Don’t talk to me for years, don’t even look at me for longer. Then ask me the fuck out, why don’t you?”

The empty flat did not reply, but the ficus in the corner had the grace to look intimidated. Katsuki sighed, letting his anger drain away. Maybe anger was the wrong word. His anger management counselor had always been on him about naming and acknowledging his emotions. He wasn’t angry. He was frustrated. He was confused. He was also guilty, a life-long guilt leftover from endless cruelty to someone so important to him.

He’d never forget that day, even if Deku apparently had. He hugged a pillow, remembering it. Even now, it made him blush.

They'd been about to start their third year, and Electroboy had thrown a party to start the year off right. Katsuki had just discovered Fireball, and was determined to make it his best friend. Drinking a fifth of Fireball had not been a good idea, but he'd done it anyway. Gods above knew why he'd thought kissing Deku was a good idea, but he'd goddamn tried it anyway.

Katsuki stared at the ceiling, feeling tired. He'd gone over this a million times in his head already. Leaving out the travesty of kissing his unrequited love with Fireball-breath, the whole kissing-after-years-of-assholery had taken the cake.

God bless Deku, who'd shoved him away with a shout. It had felt like Deku had just shoved a hole straight through his goddamn heart. Then he'd realized Deku hadn't been standing quietly in the corner because he was sober. No, it was because he was smashed, and Deku had unleashed years and years of pent of frustration and hurt.

Katsuki's counselor, mandatory back then, had looked like she'd wanted to smack him when he told her. Apparently you're not supposed to go trying to kiss people you've been a shithole to. You're supposed to leave them in peace to heal at their own peace, or do whatever the fuck they ask of you. He'd never forget what Deku said. *Leave me alone and don't bother me ever again.* So Bakugou would do just that.

They were clear enough instructions. Less clear afterward, when Deku kept exchanging small pleasantries. The faint hello, the concern after a hard fight… Katsuki had acknowledged them all, with as little unpleasantness as he could manage. But they'd remained distant. It killed him to realize that maybe without all the toxic anger, they'd had nothing left.

Nothing until now. Katsuki wasn't going to fuck this up like last time, damn it. He'd had many long years to reflect on his behavior. After graduating, he'd launched straight into the pro hero world, hands blazing, refusing to watch what Deku did. Well, trying to. It was impossible to overlook Deku, the idiot's face was plastered over everything.

Fucking Deku. The sweetheart of Japan, saving everyone with a smile, making hero work look goddamn effortless. Everyone liked him. Everyone *loved* him. He was impossible to ignore, and Katsuki had felt strangely proud watching Deku grow into his role. But as time passed, he seemed more and more out of reach. They talked sometimes, at class reunions, interviews, post-disaster debriefs. Never more than was necessary, than was polite.

Katsuki had gotten over his crush ages ago, but he'd never really gotten over losing his childhood best friend. That ache refused to leave his chest. If this was Deku finally giving him a second chance, then Katsuki wouldn't fuck it up.

He was Ground Zero. He was one of Japan's top heroes. He could barely step outside without being swarmed by fans. He could level a city block with one palm. One tiny, green-haired soft little man wasn't going to take him down. Right?

Chapter End Notes

Right?????
Poor Bakugou :(
Lucky for him I'm as much a sucker for a bad boy as fictional Japan's media, so I'll probs give him a happy ending. If you know what I MEAN

This chapter is more of a prologue than a chapter, as it's p short. Hope you guys like it!

First post on here so please be gentle with me <3

Thirsty Boys Need to Hydrate

Chapter Summary

Deku is bad at texting and Bakugou is arguably even worse. It's a miracle they even see each other again, jfc

Chapter Notes

I edited Lida to Iida after the fact because I'm dumb. Shout out both to the people who called me out and also to my crippling inability to deal with the anxiety produced by leaving known errors in anything I do! Fun!

DISCLAIMER - I'm trying something new w/ the text conversations, please don't mind if they're inconsistent in style! Also if plz @ me if you have an opinion on whether you like the phone look or plain text! :^D

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A whole month of failure! That's what it was. Izuku has spent a week hoping Bakugou would text him first (and being busy with work). He'd then spent a week trying to get the nerve to text Bakugou. Apparently figuring out how to say, "You wanna hang?" is infinitely harder when it's a blond bombshell on the other end. He was so caught up in his head it took him until week three to realize he *didn't have Bakugou's number*. He wasn't even friends with him on social media. How had that happened?

So what? Ask Kirishima for his number? Add him on Instabook? All of his options seemed humiliating.

Sure, Bakugou had said. Just thinking about it gave Izuku shivers. What had he been thinking? Who asked pro heros to just, hang out? Who asked old estranged friends to hang out?

"Deku?" That was Uraraka, sweet and concerned. They were drinking matching iced mochas, and Deku was spacing out. A whole month. If Bakugou didn't hate him anymore, he probably did again.

"Deku." She poked him in the cheek, making Izuku squeak. In the background, Ground Zero was shown beating some fishy monster into fiery submission. "Earth to Deku!"

He looked at his friend mournfully, noting her tired eyes, glossy brown hair. “You okay, Uraraka?”

“Are you okay?” she countered. “Is the Association riding you too hard again?”

“Just picked up some night shifts for Momo,” he sighed. “She’s got a new girl, and keeps wanting to spend nights.”

“What? Who?”

“No idea,” Deku groaned. “I’ve been asking, but she just keeps asking me to ‘respect her privacy.’ I can’t keep pushing after that!”

“You’re too nice,” Uraraka sighed. “I’m gonna have to get to the bottom of this myself. We need someone to live vicariously through, you know? She’s being selfish.”

Izuku giggled despite himself. “Well then you’ll love this: I ran into *Bakugou* last month.”

Uraraka was silent for a moment, then exploded. “Last month? And you only tell me now? You hurt me, Deku.”

“It was weird,” Izuku whined. “So weird. One of his villains crossed over into my sector and he didn’t even notify me. He tries so hard to avoid me,” he sighed. Not that it made him sad. No, it was just, “It’s unprofessional,” he huffed out. Uraraka crossed her arms.

“He’s still such a jerk, huh?”

“I just don’t understand,” Izuku sighed, slurping his mocha. It was sweet and cool, perfect for a summer morning.

“What’s there to understand? He got what, 10% less jerky after school but still continues to be a jerk. So what?”

“Why would he agree to hang out if he wanted avoid me?” Izuku blurted out. Uraraka stared.

“What?”

“But I don’t even have his contact info, so I can’t even text him,” Izuku groaned, sliding down in his seat. “It’s so awkward, oh my god. I can’t believe I’m like this. We’re supposed to be adults, right?”

“You want to hang out with him?” Uraraka said, doubtful, but gentle. She knew how badly Izuku had missed his friend, at first. Izuku swallowed.

“Just to catch up, and stuff,” he mumbled. “I hate losing friends.”

Uraraka fished in her purse, finally yanking out her phone. After a few taps, she smacked it down on the table in front of Izuku. On the screen, a contact sat, named *#1 Asshole* with a bomb emoji.

“There. Text him. But if he hurts you you’re *out,* Deku. I’m not putting up with his bullshit ever again,” she snapped. “I don’t want to be responsible for connecting you with someone bad for you.”

Dutifully, Izuku put the contact in his phone, nearly vibrating with energy. Now he had no excuse not to text Bakugou. He stared at the contact in his phone. *Kacchan.* He’d written and erased the name *Bakugou Katsuki* five times already, but it felt too wrong.

“You think I should text him?” He murmured, then jumped as Uraraka slapped the table.

“Jesus Christ boy, after all this? The more you hesitate the harder it will be. Trust me, I know.” Her smile was gentle. Izuku was reminded of her unrequited crush, one she’d failed to act on over and over.

“Fine. But you can help me with it, right?” He opened a message, staring nervously at the name at the top of the screen. Kacchan. Why was his heart in his throat?

“Of course,” she grinned, a little evilly. “It’s easy. Just say, ‘Hey, when do you want to hang out?”

Obediently, Izuku typed it in. Then she continued, “And also I’ve been in love with you since I was four L.O.L. Spell it out, all caps.”

Izuku sent her a Bakugou-worthy glare. “No?” She asked, innocently.

“I hate you,” he mumbled. “I’m over that.”

“And I’m over Iida, eh?” She cackled, then hit send on Izuku’s phone. He watched in slo-mo horror as the little text bubble floated up. He waited in terrified suspense, but nothing happened. Uraraka soothed him, because he’d become an instant, pathetic nervous wreck.

That night, a reply still hadn’t come. Nor the next day. Then Izuku realized that Bakugou wouldn’t know who he was. He was on patrol when he texted next. He’d just bagged a gang of ATM thieves, and he was riding an adrenaline high. So he decided to try again.

Kacchan

Two Days Ago
Hey, when do you want to hang out?

Read 11:52 AM **Today** 6:42 PM
It's Deku

He shoved his phone in his pocket, determined not to worry about it. He nearly jumped out of his skin when it vibrated a second later.

Kacchan

Two Days Ago
Hey, when do you want to hang out?

Today 6:42 PM
It's Deku

wtf midoriya

Izuku stared at the screen like it had bitten him. Bakugou replied fast. He wasn't prepared. He wasn't prepared for the feeling stirring in his chest upon seeing *Kacchan* on his phone screen, either. He nearly dropped his phone when a second text came.

Kacchan

Two Days Ago
Hey, when do you want to hang out?

Today 6:42 PM
It's Deku

wtf midoriya

you been in a fucking coma? its been like a goddamn year jfc

I'm sorry!!!

Izuku texted him back, shaking with energy. No reply. He tried again. He didn't want to say how hard it had been to text but… he needed some excuse. So he sent,

Kacchan

Today 6:42 PM
It's Deku

wtf midoriya

you been in a fucking coma? its been like a goddamn year jfc

I'm sorry!!!

I got caught up with work and then I realized I didn't even have your number or Instabook and I just got your number from Uraraka

He sent it before he could stop himself.

Kacchan

wtf midoriya

you been in a fucking coma? its been like a goddamn year jfc

I'm sorry!!!

I got caught up with work and then I realized I didn't even have your number or Instabook and I just got your number from Uraraka

ty for the novel nerd

Took you a long ass time to find my #, u losing ur touch?

Izuku stared at the exchange. Bakugou wasn't being friendly, but he was texting back. Somehow, it made him happy. Way too happy. It was the closest they'd had to a real conversation for so long. They had no reason to be talking. No media, no disaster, no villain. Bakugou was talking to him because he wanted to. Izuku found himself grinning unreasonably at his phone.

Kacchan

you been in a fucking coma? its been like a goddamn year jfc

I'm sorry!!!

I got caught up with work and then I realized I didn't even have your number or Instabook and I just got your number from Uraraka

ty for the novel nerd

took you a long ass time to find my #, u losing ur touch?

thought maybe you changed ur mind

Izuku's mouth dropped open. Bakugous was being… he was being.. It couldn't be. Emotionally vulnerable? Even a little? It felt momentous, like someone should throw a festival to celebrate. A new national holiday. Izuku knew he had to protect this moment, do something to show Bakugou that it was okay to be vulnerable with him.

Kacchan

I got caught up with work and then I realized I didn't even have your number or Instabook and I just got your number from Uraraka

ty for the novel nerd

took you a long ass time to find my #, u losing ur touch?

thought maybe you changed ur mind

Ofc not! I was just uh… I was just a little nervous :)

y the fuck

Izuku was caught. Why indeed? Because he'd never stopped longing for Bakugou's attention? Because the man was more beautiful than fireworks? Than sunlight on a rainy day? Than a fireplace after being caught in the snow? Oh yeah, he could just text that. Bakugou would never speak to him again. Then his phone buzzed.

Kacchan

ty for the novel nerd

took you a long ass time to find my #, u losing ur touch?

thought maybe you changed ur mind

Ofc not! I was just uh… I was just a little nervous :)

y the fuck

but yeah, we can meet whenever u want

heard theres another lame ass class drinks night this weekend. u there?

dont be nervous, nerd. arent u a brave hero?

Damn. Izuku giggled to himself. Did no one ever tell Bakugou about double texting? What was this, a quadruple text?

Kacchan

thought maybe you changed ur mind

Ofc not! I was just uh… I was just a little nervous :)

y the fuck

but yeah, we can meet whenever u want

heard theres another lame ass class drinks night this weekend. u there?

dont be nervous, nerd. arent u a brave hero?

Now who sent a novel

Then, before Bakugou could get offended,

Kacchan

Ofc not! I was just uh… I was just a little nervous :)

y the fuck

but yeah, we can meet whenever u want

heard theres another lame ass class drinks night this weekend. u there?

dont be nervous, nerd. arent u a brave hero?

Now who sent a novel

I'll be there! Are you finally coming?

Read 6:55 PM

A long pause. Izuku started to feel nervous, and tried to tell himself that Bakugou was probably just busy with something. Then,

Kacchan

y the fuck

but yeah, we can meet whenever u want

heard theres another lame ass class drinks night this weekend. u there?

dont be nervous, nerd. arent u a brave hero?

Now who sent a novel

I'll be there! Are you finally coming?

..

ill come for u

Izuku flung his phone away, shrieking. Then raced to pick it up. The offending text was still there. Izuku could feel his composure dissolving. Fuck, fuck fuck. He had to pull himself together. There was absolutely no way that Bakugou had meant it like that. He just meant he'd be there, because Izuku had dragged him there.

That alone was an intense thought. Bakugou doing something because Izuku asked? What was the world coming to?

Izuku didn't bother replying. There was absolutely nothing he could say to that, not without his head combusting. He could barely even bring himself to look at the text message.

The weekend came slowly, but way too quickly. Would Bakugou show his stupid, gorgeous face? Would he come for Izuku?

Izuku growled under his breath. He was losing his mind. His friends had all met at a bar, and were already getting rowdy just thirty minutes in. Thirty minutes in with no Bakugou. Still, it was a good turnout. Kirishima and Kaminari were daring each other to order expensive shots at the bar - apparently it was manly - and Momo and Jiriou had claimed a large booth for everyone. Ojiro was bringing them beers, and Uraraka and Iida were arm-wrestling at a cocktail table. Tsu had turned up late with Aoyama, giving Izuku a friendly wave before sliding into Momo's booth.

Izuku was about to give up when Bakugou strode into the bar, strutting in like he owned the place. He plopped onto the bar stool next to Izuku, ignoring everyone's stares.

"Sup nerd," he said, with that trademark dangerous grin. Izuku swallowed hard. Despite the cool evening, Bakugou was just wearing a loose, concerningly revealing, black tank top and slouchy jeans. It looked too good. Too good for Izuku, who, after hours of agonizing, had merely picked out a green sweatshirt and pale jeans. He looked like an off-duty librarian.

"Bakubroooooo," Came a shout from behind them. Kirishima slammed into Bakugou's back, enveloping him in a hug. "You finally caaaaaameee ouuuuut!"

Izuku found himself laughing as he made eye contact with the abandoned Kaminari, who just looked fondly exasperated.

"Jesus H Christ, shitty hair," Bakugou snapped, turning around. Then to Izuku's surprise, snatched the red-haired man into a real hug. "It's been so long man, what the fuck."

Kirishima looked like he was about to cry manly tears of joy. Izuku felt that joy too - having Bakugou back in the group felt like filling a hole he hadn't even known existed.

"You're always so busy," Kirishima scolded, pulling back to punch his friend in the arm. "Never making time for you friends now, huh? Huh?! What happened to the dynamic trio?"

"You're drunk already," Bakugou snorted. "Fucking typical."

Behind them, Kaminari, raised a shot glass in cheers and explanation. Kirishima was inevitably drawn back to Kaminari. Those two were like magnets, never far from each other.

After they'd been assigned the same sector, they'd been inseparable. Were they dating? Izuku had 5k Yen in the pool that said they were, but the two had managed to not confirm anything despite everyone's efforts.

Bakugou nudged him, pulling him back to the present. "Whatcha drinking, space cadet?"

"Uh-" he panicked. Talking was a lot harder than texting. He was blushing already. Izuku wanted to fall of the stool and be swallowed by the floor. Bakugou rested his hand on his chin, propped up on the bar.

"Uh?" His tone was lazy, relaxed. Izuku pulled himself together.

"IPA. Space Dust," he said, and Bakugou waved down the bartender.

"You used to drink mojitos, right?"

"You remember?" Izuku was so surprised he was almost offended. What right did Bakugou have to go off remembering things about him? The man in question just snickered.

"I always thought it was because it matched your shitty green hair."

"Asshole," Izuku muttered, accepting his beer from the bartender. "Let's go to the booth," he added. Bakugou would be less intense if they were surrounded by everyone else, right?

Wrong. Bakugou was not less intense surrounded by everyone else. Well, less intense to Izuku, maybe, but the man was just loud person and everyone had a lot of catching up to do. Once he failed to viciously snap at the first few people who tried talking to him, the questions kept flowing in. Everyone wanted to catch up with their distant classmate.

They learned that Bakugou had been put in the highest crime rate sector, an industrial district neighboring Tsu's harbor sector. He'd be suspended *five* times as a sidekick, and had gotten his pro license a full year after everyone else, a fact that he laughed off. Old Bakugou would have exploded the table for anyone mentioning it. New Bakugou thought it was 'fucking hilarious,' and that he'd been 'such a shit, Jesus Christ.'

Izuku was playing a private game. Everytime Bakugou made him want to blush, he was taking a drink. He'd finished the IPA in record time, and suddenly a mojito had appeared in front of him, courtesy of Lord Explodo Murder. Embarrassing. He took another drink. So far, Bakugou had slung his stupid, buff arm over Izuku's shoulders, called him a 'flower bed,' said he'd *missed all you losers*, stared into Izuku's eyes slightly too long, had tipped his shitty beer back to drink the rest in a way that drew Izuku's eyes to his neck, his slow swallow, he'd arm wrestled Uraraka, he'd… the list went on and on.

Three drinks Izuku is drunk Izuku. He was, well, both good and not good at holding his alcohol. He couldn't hide that he was tipsy, though he was careful to slouch against Ojiro on his right, away from Bakugou. He could hide that he was drunk. He stayed relatively quiet, happy to listen to everyone talking, to watch Bakugou enjoying himself.

The issue came when he had to pee. Break the seal, as Kirishima had shouted once Izuku asked his side of the booth to let him out.

He was very focused. Very focused, keeping his balance, sliding out of the booth without knocking over anyone's drinks. Right until he was out of the booth, and the table wasn't here to brace against, and he immediately staggered. He snatched at the air, falling, but Bakugou was faster. He grabbed Izuku mid fall, setting back him on his feet.

"Oy, little nerd, how drunk are you?"

"Not drunk," Izuku glared. Bakugou stared at him for a moment, red eyes disbelieving. Then he snorted so loudly Izuku jumped.

"Midoriya's druuunk," He announced loudly to the group. Izuku groaned, steadying himself against Bakugou's arm.

"Bathroom," Izuku insisted. He needed to get away from everyone. To calm down. He'd gotten halfway through his fourth drink, and it'd start hitting soon.

"You need help?" Uraraka asked, sweetly. "I'm sure *Kacchan* will help you," she added, much less sweetly. Evilly. The girl was a witch.

"Call me that again and you die," Bakugou snapped, instantly vicious. Then he frogmarched a confused Izuku away from the table.

The bathroom was a relief. He spent some quality time staring himself down in the mirror, trying to pretend he wasn't drunk. Normally, he wouldn't worry about it. His friends were kind. He took care of them, and they took care of him.

No, his problem was waiting outside the door, lounging against the wall with his arms folded. Izuku was confronted with the sight upon leaving the bathroom. For a moment, his breath was stolen. Bakugou belonged in dingy bar hallways just as well as he belonged in a burning summer day. How did he look so at ease everywhere? He'd only snapped once this evening, at Uraraka. That was relatively little by Bakugou's standards. Had he really changed? Maybe he just hated that nickname. He wished that Uraraka had said nothing. Izuku's stomach turned over.

"You really hate that name so much?" he asked, heart stuttering in his chest.

Bakugo frowned at him, and reached out to steady him. Izuku jerked back, hitting the wall with a thud. "Kacchan," he snapped. "You didn't need to shout at Uraraka."

Bakugou flinched away, staring at Izuku with wide eyes. He was still for a moment, lips parted.

"Roundface has no right to call me that," he said finally, voice a low growl. "Shitty nerd. You know I only ever let you get away with it. S'not my fault you quit saying it. Doesn't mean everyone fucking else gets to say it."

He crossed his arms, and stared Izuku down like he was a villain. Izuku didn't know what to say. He *had* stopped calling Bakugou 'Kacchan,' even in his own head. The name reminded him of their sunny, childhood days, before his friend had turned selfish and cruel. He thought Bakugou had hated the name. That's why he'd stopped - for Bakugou, in hopes that calling him by his real name would bring him back to Izuku. It had never worked.

"Kacchan," he said under his breath, musingly. The name was familiar on his lips.

"Yeah?" Bakugou said, pushing himself off the wall and towards Izuku, before stopping suddenly. Izuku wanted to clarify he hadn't been *calling* Bakugou, but suddenly he couldn't talk. Bakugou's expression froze him in place. He looked… hopeful.

"Thought you hated it," Izuku muttered, pouting. He was never drinking again. This was too embarrassing. Suddenly, strong hands were on his forearms, as Bakugou finally crossed the space. Nervously, he looked up. Bakugou was staring down at him, forbiddingly intense. He was going to tell Izuku off, he was sure. Not to use such a shitty childhood nickname. He was going to cry.

"I did," Bakugou rumbled. "I was also shit-for-brains loser. Don't want you to call me anything else, now."

Izuku blinked up at him, eyes watery. He cursed his waterworks nature. His lip was trembling. Pathetic, he told himself. "Kacchan," he mumbled. Bakugou's hands squeezed his arms reflexively. Then the man leaned down in, right in Izuku's face.

One hand lifted, jabbing a finger into his own chest. "That's right, little Deku." He tapped himself in the chest again, for emphasis. "Ka-chan. Don't fuck it up."

He was so, so close. Izuku stared up at him, looking at his eyes. Bakugou looked partly amused, but mostly serious. And then there was his mouth. Izuku had to look away. It felt like he was about to be kissed. An impossibility. Bakugou had always been aggressively withholding about his relationships. Izuku didn't even know if he'd ever had one. It was a topic constantly discussed by trash magazines.

Izuku looked down and away, relieving the pressure of those red eyes. "You called me Deku."

Bakugou dropped his arms, stepping away. "Sorry. Midoriya."

"No," Izuku said, quickly. "Everyone else does, you know."

"I said it like it was a bad thing," Bakugou huffed, looking away. "I lost the right."

It was, well. It was really, really endearing. Drunk Izuku does not do well holding back from endearing things. He launched himself at Bakugou, wrapping his arms around that trim waist. Bakugou squawked in surprise.

"I hate Midoriyaaa," Izuku whined. "Just call me Deku like always. Kachaaaaaaaan, come onnnn."

He buried his face in Bakugou's back, unable to not be an emotional mess but also completely unwilling to let go. Bakugou twisted around, then ruffled his hair. It felt nice. *Nice* . He hummed in happiness, feeling comfortable and safe. Should he feel that way? Nope. But he couldn't help it. Bakugou was warm and solid and here, and he couldn't bear to pull away.

"Fine, lil' Deku. Fucking nerd," Bakugou huffed. "Come on, we should go back. People gonna be making fucking rumors, you know."

"M'not not little," Izuku said sternly, tilting his head up. Bakugou had grown as a teen. Izuku had not. Even looking up, his head barely passed Bakugou's shoulder.

"Compared to me, you are a tiny little grasshopper," Bakugou snickered, then tried to turn and go. Not allowed.

"Noo," Izuku said, tightening his hold. "I missed you," he added mournfully. "Kacchannn, I don't wanna go back to the extras, let's stay here forever."

Stiffly, Bakugou looked down at him. Then he relaxed. "Dude you're fucking blasted. I'm gonna take you back."

Izuku opened his mouth, about to retort something about being an adult and making his own choices, but Bakugou was more sober, and much quicker. He tucked Izuku under his arm, and towed him out of the hallway, grumbling something about small, shitty nerds.

Bakugou presented him to his table of friends like he was a show dog.

"I brought Deku back." The name sent a shiver of happiness up his spine, until Bakugou continued. "Nerd's completely smashed. He always like this?"

Izuku frowned, as his friends laughed.

"Maybe you should head home, Deku-kun," Uraraka called out. "You feeling okay?"

"Fine," Izuku said, defiant until the last. Like a real hero. He is a real hero. "I am so fine."

"So fine," Bakugou muttered.

"Take him home, Bakubro," Kirishima grinned. Kaminari smacked the back of his head.

"You good with that?" Uraraka asked, looking at Izuku, not even caring to ask if Bakugou was okay with it.

"Don't care," Izuku sniffed. His friends were right, he realized. He needed to head home before he embarrassed himself further.

"Yep, we're going," Bakugou said. "Later, extras." He gathered up their stuff, and before he knew it, he was being marched out of the bar to the sounds of wolf-whistles.

Bakugou hailed a cab, and Izuku gave the address. The car ride was quiet, with Bakugou staring out the window like his life depended on it. Or maybe it was finally time to think of him as Katsuki? Izuku resisted the urge to throw himself on the man. He couldn't come off too strong. He'd somehow lured his old friend out of exile, and he was terrified of scaring him off.

Bakugou- no, Katsuki walked him all the way to his apartment complex's door. "You can get to your place okay?"

"Of course," Izuku said, wanting desperately to seem like an adult. He was an adult, damn it. There was a pause, and he filled it, not wanting Katsuki to go. "Did you have fun?"

"With those idiots?" Katsuki scoffed, then softened. "Sure, I guess. Could be worse."

"Aw," Izuku grinned. "Cute." Then he slapped his hand over his mouth. Old Katsuki would have smacked him for that, but new Katsuki just cackled.

"I'm the cutest motherfucker out there, nerd. Text me when you're in your room, kay?"

"Um," Izuku said, realizing he was about to leave. "You want to uh-" he faltered, suddenly wishing he was sober. Katsuki shoved his hands in his pockets, waiting.

"Hang out later," Izuku choked out, feeling like a failure. Katsuki's eyebrows shot up.

"Hang out? Fine. I'm not on the fucking group chat anymore, though, so you have to tell me when."

"N-no," Izuku stammered. Damn, this was hard.

"No, I'm not invited back?" Katsuki said, voice dry. Izuku had the distinct impression that he was being toyed with.

"No, not that!" He gushed, then pulled himself together. Here goes nothing. "I meant, like. Hang out. Not with everyone."

"Alone," Katsuki drawled, a smirk crawling across his face. "Sure, Deku. We can hang out alone."

"G-good," Izuku said quickly. "Night."

Then he bolted, again.

Heart pounding, inside his apartment, he sent the promised text.

Kacchan

Today 11:12 PM
Got imside safe goodnigfht kacchann ;334

He didn’t see the replies until the next morning, thanks to flinging his phone on the couch and running for the safety of bed, and promptly passing out. In the morning, Katsuki’s replies waited for him.

Kacchan

Yesterday 11:12 PM
Got imside safe goodnigfht kacchann ;334

sleep well nerd

fcking text me when u want to meet k

dont forget to hydrate

Chapter End Notes

Yeah Deku, you better hydrate after all that thirst.

Bakugou's trying to pull himself together and seduce a lil nerd. Who knows if he'll succeed?

NOW WITH ART FROM @ra_kanoven!! It is so lovely and cute, please check it out and support them here.

"Bitchugou"

Chapter Summary

Izuku is brave and goes somewhere with Bakugou.

Bakugou tries his best :)

Chapter Notes

DISCLAIMER - I'm trying something new w/ the text conversations, please don't mind if they're inconsistent in style! Also if plz @ me if you have an opinion on whether you like the phone look or plain text! :^D

So far I've changed Chapters 1-3!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

When to hang out with Katsuki? Katsuki. He'd Ruffled Izuku's Hair. Izuku was officially overwhelmed. He could have his Pro Overwhelmed License at this rate.

Izuku had wanted to be friends with him, right? They'd been friends at one point, maybe from four to eight years old. Four years of friendship. Bakugo had flushed all that down the toilet, and Izuku had kept plunging away like an idiot for years after, hoping to bring back something already dead.

Now Katsuki was back. Really, actually back. Back in his life. Backugou.

Sober and awake, the reality of it floored Izuku. Bakugo had walked into their old class's night out like he hadn't just stormed out of their lives years ago. He'd actually had conversations with people.

Sure, he'd always been close with Kirishima and Kaminari, but then, those three were terrors together. Their rampages were legendary at UA, and were actually largely Kaminari's fault. Still, it would be a huge stretch to describe Katsuki as *friends* with anyone else in their class. And here Izuku was, bold as balls, trying to befriend him again.

Except now Izuku wanted to do decidedly unfriendly things to Kacchan after the night before. The whole concept of it was making Izuku unfairly irritable. It kept running through his head, an incessant movie of why Katsuki was stupidly irresistible. His pecs under that cursed loose tank top. How soft his hair had looked in dim bar lighting. The way he had

shoved his hands in his pockets, pushing already low-riding jeans lower. Izuku groaned aloud, despairing of any useful thoughts.

So he ignored the relatively friendly texts in his inbox, and instead poured himself into doing the best hero work he could, catching up on paperwork, running patrols, keeping everyone up to date on everything.

He was a great hero. Easy to work with. He focused on that, and made it through the whole day without losing his mind entirely. He managed not to check his phone until it was night. Momo's night shift this time, thankfully. Izuku was just about to hit the steam room at the gym, when his pocket buzzed, making him jump. With a sigh, he pulled his phone. Probably not Katsuki. He was absolutely not disappointed to see it really wasn't Katsuki.

Ochako (Sparkling Heart) (Rocket)

Today 9:12 PM
Yo, you get home safe last nite? Bitchugou didn't try anything shady?

Izuku snorted despite himself. Uraraka had a special way with words, sometimes.

Ochako (Sparkling Heart) (Rocket)

Today 9:12 PM
Yo, you get home safe last nite? Bitchugou didn't try anything shady?

Yeah, all good.

After a moment of thought, he decided to confide in his friend.

Ochako (Sparkling Heart) (Rocket)

Today 9:12 PM
Yo, you get home safe last nite? Bitchugou didn't try anything shady?

Yeah, all good.

It was OK to bring him back, right? When did he stop coming in the first place?

There was a long moment before he got a response. Apparently, she'd been typing.

Ochako (Sparkling Heart) (Rocket)

Yeah, all good.

It was OK to bring him back, right? When did he stop coming in the first place?

We sort of… um. We never told you, but we unofficially uninvited him? :///

You wouldnt come out if he was there, and then we noticed you would turn up when he skipped so we just sort of stopped but it wasn't really planned you no?

Izuku stared at the screen, feeling inexplicably guilty. When had that happened? Had he really been avoiding Katsuki? It was hard to figure out who had subtly avoided the other first, honestly. He sat down heavily on the locker room bench, ignoring the few other people messing with their stuff.

When had it started? If he was being honest with himself, he knew. It just hurt to remember. He'd been petty and mean, he realized. It was just before their third year at UA, and Katsuki had inexplicably pulled his head out of his ass enough not to scream at everyone who talked to him. He wasn't sure, but he vaguely remembered shouting at him at one of Kaminari's debauched parties. He'd never thought much of it, but Katsuki had seemed more subdued afterward.

Izuku hadn't been used to the silence, though, twisted as it was, and he had hated the lack of attention. After making a few timid attempts, Izuku had decided if Katsuki didn't want to engage, then he wouldn't either. Petty. Thinking back, he should have wondered if Katsuki hadn't actually been trying to grow. He should have helped him. He should have…

No. Izuku's head thumped back into the wall. He didn't owe Katsuki anything, regardless of how much Izuku wanted him. As a friend. It was hard to remember sometimes, but then Izuku had learned the hard way. One of his greatest strengths was his single-minded loyalty. It was also one of his greatest weaknesses. It was why he'd struggled so much with learning to use One for All, why he'd clung to Katsuki despite the bullying. Why he used to ruin himself helping one person, and fail to help others. And it was also why he made an amazing hero. Sweet, cruel irony.

His pocket buzzed. Katsuki?

Ochako (Sparkling Heart) (Rocket)

Hey you ok? Sry that was a lot

I feel kinda bad

Dont!!! B-face coulda avoided it all by not being a jerk for 10 sec ok? Anyway everyone is rly happy hes trying now tho as long as youre happy

...am I happy? OR AM I HORNY SEND HELP URARAKA

Yeah youre hopeless. Ill bring flowers to your funeral

Thank you very much (Person With Folded Hands ≅ Folded Hands) (Person With Folded Hands ≅ Folded Hands)

And the headstone will say "got a boner for explosions"

...I am no longer thankful

It didn't take Izuku an entire month to text Katsuki back, so that was an improvement. Positive thinking! This time, it only took him a week. In his defense, he'd taken three more night shifts from Momo (who *was* she seeing? Some fucking night owl?) and had grown a huge zit on his forehead. Which meant he couldn't text Katsuki, obviously. Then his drain had clogged, and he'd had to call a plumber, and he'd been called in for two emergencies, and and and… Excuses.

It turns out it's more awkward to text someone after a week than it is one day. Izuku didn't actually want to leave it any longer, and he was starting to feel kind of like a dick. He'd invited Katsuki out, then left him hanging for seven days. If Katsuki had done it, he'd have been pissed. So he did his best to send something.

Kacchan

Today 12:13 PM
I hydrated!

Read 12:13 PM

He managed not to drop his phone at the immediate response, but it was a close call.

Kacchan

Today 12:13 PM
I hydrated!

for a whole week? LMAO

Izuku laughed, worries banished. Apparently Katsuki wasn't holding it against him. What a saint. A model of forgiveness, the pinnacle of-his phone buzzed again.

Kacchan

Today 12:13 PM
I hydrated!

for a whole week? LMAO

better be rly fcking hydrated u piece of shit

u know ur lucky i even txt u back

Izuku sighed, more amused than concerned. Typical Katsuki.

Kacchan

for a whole week? LMAO

better be rly fcking hydrated u piece of shit

u know ur lucky i even txt u back

Yeah, yeah, you're so mad and scary. That's why you texted me back so quickly :)

my anger is swift ok?

and i wanted to txt u anyway

Izuku was shell-shocked. It felt faintly familiar, in a new kind of way. Katsuki's new one-two punch. Something typical and shitty, then something softer. Did he know how much it was affecting Izuku? It was unfair. Nothing he did bothered Katsuki at all. He may as well be Cementoss for all Katsuki cared.

Kacchan

better be rly fcking hydrated u piece of shit

u know ur lucky i even txt u back

Yeah, yeah, you're so mad and scary. That's why you texted me back so quickly :)

my anger is swift ok?

and i wanted to txt u anyway

Okay, yeah I am lucky. :) Let's do something this weekend?

He stared at his phone. He was waiting for a rejection, he realized.

Kacchan

Yeah, yeah, you're so mad and scary. That's why you texted me back so quickly :)

my anger is swift ok?

and i wanted to txt u anyway

Okay, yeah I am lucky. :) Let's do something this weekend?

im free tonight

I've got paperwork but should be done by like 3 PM?

Oh no. He'd answered without thinking. It made it seem like he wanted to go out today, which was um. Not what he'd mentally prepared himself for. He wanted to find an outfit that didn't look like a librarian trying to be cool. No, his outfit had to say, 'I'm an adult and also grew up attractive and sort of successful but I've known you since you were four so please be friends with me again.'

So like, a sweater and jeans? Fun sneakers?

Kacchan

my anger is swift ok?

and i wanted to txt u anyway

Okay, yeah I am lucky. :) Let's do something this weekend?

im free tonight

I've got paperwork but should be done by like 3 PM?

lol @ paperwork on sat. usually i joke about u being a nerd but its obv actually true

6pm at mcmarins? wait do u like dive bars or

See you there

Did Izuku like dive bars? He did not. Did Izuku feel like he had the mental bandwidth to continue texting Katsuki about where to go like it was some sort of godforsaken date? No, he did not.

Izuku rushed to the office, rushed through paperwork. Finishing by 3 PM and meeting Kacchan at 6 PM meant he had 3 hours to prepare but if getting home took 30 minutes then 2 and a half and and then maybe thirty minutes to get there so that was 2 hours and he'd need 20 minutes to shower and Izuku didn't know what to wear to dive bars that would also make him look adult and desirable and put together and he didn't know anyone but Kacchan who would-

He train of thought ground to a halt as he remembered when Katsuki had burst back into his life. He'd said… "You still mutter like a freak." Like his mind had taken a photo, he could remember that pleased grin, the sun warming his eyes, the cocky tilt of his head. Like

Katsuki had been *happy* to see Izuku doing something familiar. Shit. Uraraka would make so much fun of him for caring about this.

Izuku is actually a really adept hero and while not a natural at paperwork, his determination to do everything well meant he'd mastered the process even back as a sidekick. He was done by 2:30 PM and proceeded to spend as much time as possible agonizing over what to wear.

In the back of his closet, a Ground Zero hoodie was staring at him. It's black, and has a neon orange and yellow explosion in vaporwave style. Not exactly punk, but far punkier than anything else in his closet. He'd never worn it. Izuku tried to imagine exactly what Katsuki would do if he saw him in his merch. Probably laugh so hard he'd DIE. Izuku would die, that is, of embarrassment.

He ended up with distressed black jeans, charcoal and orange sneakers, and an old band T-Shirt. It wasn't quite cold enough for a jacket. Satisfied, he checked the clock. Only 2 hours before he had to meet Katsuki. Yes, he'd overprepared.

"mcmarins" was actually McMarin's Salt-Store Dive. Apparently it used to be some weird boutique apothecary back in the day, but it definitely wasn't now. Even at 5:50 PM, people were milling around out front. People not in Izuku's usual crowd. As Deku the Hero, Izuku could get along with pretty much anyone. As Izuku, it was intimidating. He wondered if he should go in, or loiter outside. At least he sort of looked like he fit in. He'd texted Tokoyami for advice, but Izuku had a fundamental lack of things with skulls on them (which was apparently all Tokoyami knew about punk things?), so it hadn't been helpful. Izuku spent a good five minutes debating what to do, until his thoughts were interrupted by a shout.

"Oi, nerd!" Izuku whipped around. He'd know Katsuki's voice anywhere, even though adulthood had unfairly deepened it.

Katsuki was stomping down the sidewalk towards him, one arm raised. He wore a dark green, satin bomber over (revealingly) tight black pants, and some bulky high top shoes that shouldn't look cool, but did. He also wore huge sunglasses and a beanie, like a goddamn celebrity.

Oh. He *was* a goddamn celebrity. Izuku raised one hand in a little wave, feeling strangely self-conscious. No one ever managed to equate Midoriya Izuku with Deku.

"Don't you look good enough to eat," Bakugo grinned, as soon as he was in earshot. Embarrassing. Izuku swallowed hard. Katsuki wasn't flirting. Katsuki wouldn't flirt. And if he did, it wouldn't be with Izuku.

"Glamorous sunglasses, Kacchan," he said, rallying himself. Katsuki just waved one hand, leading the way inside.

"Don't wanna be swarmed by shitty press tonight, sweetcheeks."

Sweetcheeks. Definitely not flirting. Izuku considered cutting his own head off and rolling it into the sewer where it belonged. Katsuki's pet names didn't seem that affectionate, if he was

being honest. More like, well, like a spirited attempt to reduce Izuku to a blushing mess, something that apparently still amused Katsuki to no end.

Some things never change.

McMarin's was dark inside, heavy rock music thudding in the background. Katsuki was already heading to the bar, and Izuku hurried to catch up. He made it in time to hear the bartender say,

"Yo, B-Man! Where ya been?"

"Don't you watch the news? Fucking working my ass off, Beni. Shitty villains all over the goddamn place these days."

Beni muttered something that Izuku couldn't catch. Bakugo pulled off the hat and glasses, and turned to Izuku. It was like someone had suddenly turned a million watt light on in Izuku's poor, innocent face. Katsuki's undivided attention was overwhelming, bright, and burning. Izuku felt like he was on a tiny boat in a flood, desperately trying to not tip and drown.

"I'll get your drink this time," Izuku said, quickly. Reclaim the situation. Take the high ground. He Could Do This.

"Thanks, shithead." The insult made Izuku snort with laughter. Only Katsuki could make *shithead* sound affectionate. In no time, they had their beers and were catching up.

Katsuki apparently had been recognized for excellent hero work six months ago. This wasn't news to Izuku, who apparently had a finely-tuned Kacchan-radar and an encyclopedic knowledge of every hero-related thing Ground Zero had ever done. Bakugo had only been a pro hero for three years to Izuku's four. Katsuki was suspended for a day last month for getting involved in a street brawl. Katsuki had stormed out of a TV's show segment when they'd asked him one too many personal questions. Katsuki had been on the front pages of four different National News issues in the last two years (one of which was shirtless). Katsuki had been instrumental in taking down the Slingbreak Gang. Katsuki had done three months of community service for exploding buildings he was not supposed to explode. Et cetera, et cetera.

Izuku knew all this already, so when Katsuki started talking about work, Izuku stopped him.

"No, I want to hear about what you've been up to. Not Ground Zero. Anyone can watch the news, you know?"

Katsuki blinked at him slowly. Izuku was coming to realize a pause from Katsuki usually meant he was turning something over in his mind, inevitably coming up with something that would make Izuku blush. Katsuki finally said, "Stalking me on the news, are ya?"

"I keep up to date on all hero activity," Izuku said, a little too quickly. Still, it was relatively true. "But I have no idea what you do. Do you just like, blow stuff up and sleep?"

“And work out,” Katsuki added helpfully. Yes, he definitely did. Adult Katsuki was taller, and had filled out. Of course he had. He’d always been a gym rat, always trained hard. Sure, he wasn’t as bulky as Kirishima. Izuku's personal opinion was that he wanted to avoid being too heavy, what with his explosive flying nonsense. But he was still built as all hell.

“Yeah, you do,” Izuku found himself saying. Katsuki’s mouth dropped open, but he recovered quickly.

“Of fucking course. Can’t explode shit with weak ass arms.” He took a sip of beer, something dark and horribly bitter, Izuku figured. He continued after a moment, “Got a fucking life though, ya know? Only kept in touch with a few of our shitty classmates, but I work with a lot of okay people. Got some friends. I mostly just, work and hang out and work out, I guess. Kinda boring.”

Izuku was completely charmed. Katsuki was actually talking about his life like he had the ability to self-reflect. He found himself smiling, chin resting on his hand. “Tell me more,” he said. His beer, a lighter, fruiter one, was giving him a pleasant buzz.

“Man Deku, I’m boring as shit,” he groaned. “Quit being nosy. Your turn to put out.”

Izuku heroically ignored the phrasing. “Mkay. My life’s not that cool either, you know?”

“Fucking shocked.”

“Kacchan,” Izuku fake-scolded. Katsuki’s lips curved into a smile that Izuku also bravely ignored. “As I was saying, not that cool. Though I did just get approved to have a sidekick! I’m not really ready yet, but it’s nice they believe in me. I have the third-best safety rating in my quadrant, actually, but this one time-”

“You leveled an evacuated city block when fighting King Rat or some shit,” Katsuki interrupted. “Everyone heard about that. Don’t cop out with work bull. What’s a nerd like you been doing all this time?”

“You know,” Izuku muttered, feeling a little flattered that Katsuki cared in the first place. He cleared his throat, “Um, you know. Stuff. Mostly work, and friends? I had a hardcore hero movie phase, and I’ve been trying to, I don’t know. Do more stuff. Like I’ve been learning to bake, and I did a ceramics class with Uraraka, stupid stuff.” He waited for the ridicule.

“I’ve been taking goddamn cooking classes,” Katsuki said. “No baking, but my curry is fucking amazing.”

Oh. Izuku knew, distantly, that he was smiling like an idiot. They were connecting. They’d never connected like this before, and it felt so good. So right. Like something in his chest was knitting itself back together. Izuku has a tendency to be impulsive when he’s happy, so of course he had to say the riskiest shit he could.

“Maybe I’ll bake you something.”

Katsuki covered his mouth with a hand. Izuku's heart fell. He'd stepped too far. Katsuki was being nice, and stopping himself from saying something rude. He sipped his beer again, nervous in the quiet moment.

"You wouldn't appreciate my curry," he said, finally, face solemn. "Too spicy for a shitty weakling like you."

Izuku blinked at him. Was he being insulted? Was Katsuki insinuating he'd consider *cooking for Izuku?*

"But I'd make it for you anyway," the other man finished gruffly, looking away. "Just don't bitch about how hot it is."

"O-okay," Deku stammered. Katsuki was still staring off into the distance, but Izuku would have paid a shocking amount of money to see his expression right now. Katsuki was… Damn. He was actually trying, wasn't he? Izuku knew it was dangerous. He had no damn self-control when it came to Katsuki, honestly. Even the slightest hint of interest made him overjoyed. So they sat for a few minutes in companionable silence. Izuku was having some very detailed daydreams about Katsuki cooking for him in an apron, and was therefore enormously shocked when someone slammed a hand down in between them.

"Katsuki!" The guy shouted. He was huge, blue-tinged, with gills on his neck. Katsuki, apparently unsurprised, glanced up. In contrast, Izuku jumped so much he nearly spilled his drink.

"Fish-face!" Katsuki shouted back. "Where you been?"

"The Maldives, and you damn well know it," the guy grinned. "Back at work tomorrow!"

Ah, it was a coworker. "Hey, I'm Deku," Izuku ventured. The guy blinked at him, looking vaguely confused. Katsuki jumped in.

"He's my- he's with me," he struggled. "This is Onito, also works in my shitty sector."

"Oy, our sector's the best," Onito grinned, then grabbed Izuku's hand to shake it vigorously. "Nice to meet you! So happy our fave bomb-boy's making new friends! No one ever wants to deal with his horrible personality!"

Katsuki's hands audibly smacked against his face, as he groaned. "Shove off, fishy. Keep that bullshit up and I'll sell you at PetSmart, fucker."

"So cute!" Onito shouted, slapping a surprisingly patient Katsuki on the back. Izuku found himself laughing. The two of them were obviously friends, and it was actually nice to see. Then Onito spun Izuku around on the stool, and placed two huge hand-flippers on his shoulders.

"Deku. Katsuki's a good guy, okay? I know he seems super shitty, but you should give him a chance. The news makes him look bad but he's actually super punctual and gets all his shit

done. Management's damn pet, I swear, I mean stuff they let him get away with? You wouldn't believe it."

"Um, thanks," Izuku said, trying to smother laughter. Behind him, Katsuki was clearly barely controlling his temper. Izuku threw him a cheeky grin. "He's kind of-"

"And he desperately needs more friends," Onito continued, shooting a conspiratorial glance at Katsuki, who looked about five seconds away from homicide. "You must be super patient and-"

"Oy, Fish-flakes! Deku is *Midoriya Izuku* . He's known me since I was four. He already knows this shit, you pushy fucker."

Onito jumped back, wides eye. "Oh shit!" He stared at Katsuki, then back to Izuku, who was full-on laughing now. "No way. Midoriya?! Izuku?! Your first fucking kiss?"

His what? Izuku, blinked, laughter fading, trying to understand. Katsuki looked thunderous, shoving himself up into Onito's face.

"What the fuck man? Shut the hell up. And get the fuck out."

"Dude, I'm sorry, I-"

"Out," Katsuki snarled, then turned to Izuku.

"But we never kissed," Izuku said, mind reeling. Why would Katsuki lie about that? Katsuki never lied. The man in question sat down heavily, rubbing his face. Izuku clutched his beer nervously, happy buzz long gone.

"You could say that," Katsukis mumbled. Then he took a deep breath, and looked Izuku in the eye. "You didn't kiss me. I kissed you. Back when we were in fucking UA. I thought you knew, or I wasn't sure if you did or if you remembered, but-"

"What?" Izuku was getting a little loud. His ribcage felt too tight. "You what? When? I don't remember this! Did you dream it? Are you messing with me? It's not funny!"

Katsuki rubbed his face, looking stressed. "No Deku, I fucking kissed you. Mouth and shit. I was- I was stupid, okay? Really drunk. Didn't know you were too plastered to remember, and of course I never did again and-"

"W-when was this?" Izuku asked quietly. Something else was playing through his mind. *His* first kiss. Todoroki Shouto, at the end of their third year at UA. A romance that had failed to start, but it had been such a good first kiss. They'd woken up to see the sunrise over cherry blossoms, and Izuku had...

"Right before our third year started," Katsuki said softly.

"So that was my first time," Izuku realized, eyes welling up. His treasured memory - apparently he didn't even remember his real first kiss. And it had been drunken, at one of Kaminari's parties. Unbearable.

“What the fuck, Katsuki?” he shouted. Katsuki flinched, his face tight. Izuku was relentless. “You took my first fucking kiss and never even told me? I can’t even remember it! Why would you do that to me? Why wouldn’t you say something?”

“I’m fucking sorry,” he said, holding Izuku’s glare. “Look, it was a huge mistake-”

“Of course it was,” Izuku snarled. Of course it’d be a mistake for *Katsuki* to *kiss* him and,

“I’d never do it again,” Katsuki blurted. “Look, it didn’t even mean anything, just-”

It was too much. First Izuku didn’t remember his own first kiss, and to learn it had meant nothing to Katsuki? He was shaking, he realized. Shaking with anger, and with hurt. He wasn’t supposed to break his heart over Katsuki this time. He’d thought it’d be different. Or that he could keep a safe distance. That somehow the years would have dulled any pain Katsuki could have caused. He'd been wrong.

“Fuck off, Katsuki,” he snapped, one hand brushing away tears. “You may not care, but I give a shit! I like fucking romantic shit and you just ruined something important to me!”

“Izuku, I-”

Izuku grabbed his phone and stormed out, making it halfway down the block before Katsuki caught up.

“Izuku, wait! Look, I-”

“No,” Izuku snapped, turning on him. He didn’t care that Katsuki looked absolutely gutted. “You don’t get this. You already took too much from me, damn it. I don’t have to be okay with this! I don’t have to forgive you! I don’t have to understand! Just leave me alone,” he finished, voice breaking. “I’m leaving. Don’t fucking touch me.”

He called a cab, hand trembling. Katsuki had backed off, watching him uncertainly.

Izuku went home, crawled in bed, and cried himself to sleep. He’d been stupid to think he could be friends with Katsuki again. Stupid, and naive, and childish. He needed to let go. His stupid childhood friendship didn’t *have* to mean anything now. He had to stop forcing this stuff. That’s why it always hurt so badly. He needed to stop. Forcing. Everything. He was done. He drifted off to sleep, eyes scratchy and throat raw.

Chapter End Notes

Oh no! Angry Izuku is swearing, Bakugou shoved his foot in his mouth and probably all the way through his intestinal tract, and now everything is ruined :'(
Yes, I did name Onito after Bonito, cause I’m a damn well of creativity. Poor dude meant well and was really excited for Bakugou.

Also I CANNOT and will not stop making shitty puns w/ Bakugou's name. I've got a list in my google docs and I plan to use all of them over the course of this garbage. If you thought "Backugou" was bad, you better buckle up sweetpea. I also apparently can't stop writing texting conversations, but I have been enjoying giving everyone their own texting style. Izuku spells everything out because he's a NERD

I struggled to decide whether to add a snippet of Bakugou's perspective at the end, but ended up deciding it was punchier to be left with super sad Izuku. But I'll definitely stick it in the next one!

Also sincerely, thank you all for your comments <3 I'm a monster who lives off of positive validation and I really appreciate anyone who makes time to say something

1,000/10

Chapter Summary

How to get Bakugou Katsuki to kiss you?

Well, insinuating he's not a good kisser is a start...

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Katsuki dealt with it relatively well. He went to the gym and punched things for about four hours until his knuckles were bloody and his arms shaking. Then he went home and meditated on how he was a massive fuckup, and should never have spoken to anyone or possibly shouldn't even have existed in the first place. Maybe Izuku would actually be happier if Katsuki had never existed. No, he *definitely* would be happier. Katsuki was a net negative in Izuku's life, and it made him want to put his head in his hands and set off his strongest explosion.

He didn't sleep that night, and by 4 AM he'd realized that no matter how much he *should,* he couldn't let Deku go again. At least, not so easily. But he was all too aware that in this case, he was the fucking villain. Deku wanted to be left alone, and Katsuki would do what he wanted. He just had to put something out there, some chance that maybe Deku would forgive him.

Bakugou Katsuki: *Izuku, I'm really sorry. I'm here if you want to talk about it or have any questions. Or I can just shut the fuck up and listen. Just please let me have a chance to properly apologize to you.*

He was shocked to get a quick reply, so shocked he nearly exploded his goddamn phone.

Midoriya Izuku (Deku): *FUCKK OF*

Izuku barely remembered the exchange. He felt hungover the next day, like a soggy shell of himself. He picked up his phone, looking at it blandly.

Kacchan: *Izuku, I'm really sorry. I'm here if you want to talk about it or have any questions. Or I can just shut the fuck up and listen. Just please let me have a chance to properly apologize to you.*

Izuku: *FUCKK OF*

He was too emotionally drained to care what he'd texted Katsuki. Maybe if it hadn't been 4 AM, he'd have replied more nicely. Or at least with correct spelling.

He was drained, physically and emotionally. He'd made a huge mistake. It was too painful to see Katsuki, after everything. He managed to get through the entire process of waking up, showering, and making black tea before he started crying again.

And Izuku felt like shit. He was torn, so torn. There'd been a time when learning Katsuki had *kissed him* would have made his whole life. He was so frustrated he couldn't remember what it felt like to kiss Katsuki. And even worse, Katsuki apparently hadn't cared? Kissing Izuku had meant nothing to him? So what if he was sorry now?

Izuku was just massively disappointed, and angry with himself. He should have known better than to go chasing after Katsuki again. He was older now. He knew better, damn it. Izuku ran through his familiar morning routines, calming himself. He took a slow jog to the HQ's gym, and carefully ran through warm-ups. Izuku treated his body with the utmost care, always stretching, warming up slowly, then intensifying his workout. The steam room came after, then the final stretches. Lunch was usually from the local market, and then he'd drop by the office in case there was paperwork.

Finally, he ran out of routine. And Katsuki had kissed him.

He might have overreacted a little, last night. Izuku hated becoming emotional, but he was growing to accept it was just a part of who he was, and Katsuki had always brought it out in him.

Finally conceding defeat, he called Shouto. Shouto was arguably his closest friend. He spent the most time with Uraraka, but it was with Shouto that he had the deepest conversations. He could count on Uraraka to champion him, but Shouto would call him on his shit. He perched on his balcony, unafraid of falling. His friend picked up on the 5th ring.

"Deku?"

"You weren't my first kiss," Izuku said, straight to the point. Small talk was generally wasted on Shouto, after all. There's a pause on the line.

"I know. It was Katsuki, right?"

"You knew?" Izuku half-shrieked, precariously leaning over the edge before regaining his balance. It was the last thing he'd expected.

"You didn't?" Shouto sounded amused, then concerned. "Wait, why are you bringing this up now?"

"Katsuki told me last night," Izuku muttered.

"Huh," Shouto said, which was about his equivalent of shouting. "He's back, then?"

“He was,” Izuku sighed. “But he, I don’t even, he didn’t, god I’m such a mess. I didn’t want my first kiss to be like that, you know?”

“It looked nice enough to me,” Shouto said, calmly. He may as well have smacked Izuku across the face with a brick.

“Nice? How?”

“I’m guessing you don’t remember it. We were all too drunk that night, if I remember correctly. None of us could hold our alcohol. Deku, how can I help you?”

Izuku sighed heavily. Shouto had an undeniable calming effect on him, but sometimes it was like talking to a wall. He needed to be instructed on *how* to interact, and while normally Izuku was more than happy to provide that, sometimes he didn’t have the emotional bandwidth.

“You’re right,” he said, stopping himself from whining. “I don’t remember it, and that really bothers me. Maybe you could tell me what happened?”

“Sure. I didn’t see that much. You were off in a corner, weirdly quiet. Really I just saw him lean in and kiss you for a few seconds.”

“A few seconds,” Izuku coughed.

“Yes. Then you left, and he followed you. Does that help?”

“Ugh,” was all Izuku could say. “Thank you.”

“Anytime. It’s strange that Katsuki would come back now, though.”

“What do you mean?”

“He just seems pretty busy,” Shouto mused. “We keep up, but he never said anything about getting in touch with you.”

That also kind of hurt. “It hasn’t been that long, and it was an accident. I ran into him and wanted to catch up, is all.”

“So he agreed, then,” came the quiet reply. Izuku tried not to be impatient.

“Yes, and it was a horrible idea,” Izuku added, a little spitefully. It felt wrong to be spiteful on such a nice day, but Izuku was a strong, independent man. He could feel spiteful in any weather if he wanted to. “I’m done with him now,” he added, the words tentative. It was surprisingly hard to say.

“Oh,” Shouto said. “Well, it’s up to you. I’m sure he’ll be there if you want him.”

If Izuku wanted him. It was impossible not to want him. God, that had been seven years ago. Was he really going to throw this away for one mistake from nearly a decade ago? With a massive sigh, Izuku decided he was being dramatic. Sure, Katsuki could have handled the conversation better, but Izuku begrudgingly acknowledged that at least he'd been willing to talk. It was Izuku who'd run out.

Without paying. Great, now he felt guilty too.

Izuku: *Ok, we can talk*

He waited for the reply. If the past was any indicator, it should be coming any second. But it didn't, and the ache in Izuku's chest was getting worse.

He spent an hour uselessly puttering around the apartment until his phone rang. He raced to it, snatching it off the counter.

It was work. There was an emergency: apparently some idiot villain had overloaded his quick in the wrong area and a massive wave was heading towards a beach. He had twenty minutes to get there.

Izuku got there in fifteen, armed and ready. He dropped by the temporary triage station, already full of frightened citizens. His heart lurched. There were just so many still in the water. His orders were to get everyone out that he could. There was already a team after the villain, apparently.

Full Cowling took over, and Izuku jumped clear to the water, soaring over tents, the street, the beach. In the air, he could analyze where he was needed first. To the north he spotted Ururaka, swimming for land with ten people suspended in the air above her. She was incredible.

Izuku landed in the surf with a splash. He went to help a family carry their four kids, and after that, an elderly woman stuck in her innertube, and it became a blur. An hour of constant running in Full Cowling could wear even Izuku out, but they got everyone out. Every hero that could be useful was there, all exhausted and dripping. The sounds of people crying was drowned out by the huge wave crashing on the beach, and rushing up past the road and through a couple of ice cream stands. People screamed, even though they were safe in their vantage point. Izuku was getting a headache.

He met up with Uraraka and Iida in the check-in, grabbing the forms for debrief. In cases like this, it was pointless to debrief everyone individually.

Izuku was almost finished by the time Katsuki walked in. Murmurs followed him, and Izuku soon realized why. He and Onito were dragging someone behind them. The guy looked half-dead. Was he a survivor that had been left in the surf?

Katsuki hefted him by the back of his shirt and tossed him in front of the desk. "Here's the guy," he barked, then spat on the ground. "Fucking seawater."

The man in question made some sort of blubbering noise. Izuku wondered who'd made the choice to set a guy who dealt with explosions against someone who could cause a tidal wave. Katsuki looked like a drowned cat, hair dripping into his eyes, knuckles bloody. Izuku knew it was pointless, but he was worried about him.

Katsuki turned to go, but the clerk shouted after him, "Ground Zero! Quit slinking out and debrief."

He must have been tired, because he didn't even snap back a retort. His eyes caught on Izuku's as he headed to the back of the tent, and he gave him a small nod. Izuku's heart twisted. Damn it, he missed him already.

He loitered only a little, hoping for another glimpse of Katsuki, but gave up quickly. He was too tired after having barely slept the night before. He even turned down an invitation from Uraraka to go get udon, which was a travesty all by itself.

At home, he switched on the news, hoping to learn more about the villain. There was an image of a reporter talking for a moment, then it cut to a replay of the fight. Ground Zero and Fishury were on screen, as tiny figures chasing someone down the beach. Some daring helicopter swooped in, just in time to catch the action.

Ground Zero jetted forwards, propelled by a massive, continuous explosion. Izuku knew the move - it was one Katsuki hadn't been able to do when they were kids, the stress on his arms being too much. Now, though, he rocketed forwards over sixty feet, smoke and fire trailing behind him. Fishury trailed behind him, diving into the surf to swim. Fishury, or Onito. Izuku curled up on the couch, eyes glued to the screen.

Ground Zero landed in front of a villain like a comet, making a glassy crater in the sand. Another explosion, and he was shooting towards the villain.

Instead of an explosion on impact, though, water swelled and covered them both. Izuku's hands flew to his mouth, despite already knowing the outcome. The water shifted and bubbled. Helicopters circled, and a reporter's voice offscreen said something about the boiling point of seawater.

Then the water was bubbling, no, boiling. Izuku was in awe. The reporters didn't seem particularly impressed, but did they not know the massive amount of effort it'd take to heat that much water? While holding your breath? What felt like an eternity later, a huge plume of water shot upwards, then it all washed away, revealing the prone villain and Ground Zero on his hands and knees. Fishury crawled out of the water, looking-half dead. Izuku realized they'd made a fundamental tactical error. Sending someone who relies on water against someone who can apparently control it?

He wanted words with whoever assigned missions in Katsuki's sector.

Apparently noticing he was on camera, Ground Zero pulled himself up off the ground, coughed, and flipped off the cameras. Izuku's heart felt tight, as it always did watching him

do hero work. He worked so hard, but all people wanted to look at was his fiery temper. They should appreciate him for how hard he tried, how many people he saved - not how many times he'd cursed at government officials.

The screen cut away, and Izuku found himself staring emptily at it. He checked his phone again. Nothing. Maybe Katsuki was still debriefing?

Maybe he'd never text Izuku again.

By the next morning, Izuku was irritated. He'd been called into work, which was a good thing. It kept his mind off of his phone screen, which remained stubbornly empty of notifications from *Kacchan.* Who sent such a well-written text begging to talk, then refused to text him back?

He gave in on his walk home, and called him. The number rang, rang, rang. The answering tone, Katsuki's voice snapping, "If I sent you to voicemail, get the fucking message and get lost, loser."

What a hero. Izuku was smiling at his phone until he realized *he'd* reached voicemail. He was the loser who should get lost. He was lost in thought enough that he didn't notice the figure in front of his building until he nearly ran into him. Black jeans, high-tops, and an enormous puffy jacket with a furry trim on the hood. Even with the face in shadow, Izuku knew who it was. He froze.

"Yo," Katsuki said, raising his hand. "Phone got wasted by the shitty villain, so I'm just giving you my new number." He thrust a paper at Izuku, who took it, mind racing. It was impossible to read Katsuki's expression behind the huge aviators. How long had he been waiting? He swallowed, trying to pull himself together, but Katsuki was already turning to leave.

Already?

"Wait!" Izuku shouted. Katsuki turned, hands in his pockets. "Did you get my text?"

He shook his head. Izuku swallowed. It was harder to do this in person. "I wanted to talk," he said, clenching his fists.

"Sure," said Katsuki. Izuku was instantly transported back to when they'd first run into each other. Katsuki and his 'sures' were going to be the death of him.

"Sorry for running off without paying," Izuku said, straightening his posture. Katsuki barked out a laugh.

"What the fuck, Deku."

"Shouldn't have done that," Izuku said, refusing to be swallowed by embarrassment. Katsuki pinched the bridge of his nose.

“You drive me up a fucking wall. That’s what you wanted to talk about?”

“No,” Izuku said quickly. “Come inside?”

“I’d love to,” Katsuki said, half-sarcastic, with a voice full of gravel.

Soon enough, Katsuki was perched on one of his barstools, puffy jacket and all. He reminded Izuku bizarrely of an angry, puffed-up bird. He put his sunglasses carefully on the counter, the clink of metal on marble too loud. An awkward silence stretched.

Feeling kind of like an asshole, Izuku sat on the back of his couch and faced down his former friend. “So, you wanted to apologize.”

“Fuckin’ yep.” Katsuki cracked his knuckles, shifting in his seat like he’d rather be anywhere but exactly where he was. Izuku waited. And waited. Finally, he gave in.

“You okay? After the whole beach thing? It looked pretty bad.”

“Pretty bad?” Katsuki was outraged. “I was fucking awesome, nerd. You ever tried to blow up shit underwater?”

“You were cool,” Izuku corrected himself without thinking. A grin slapped itself across Katsuki’s face instantly. “Looked like a hard fight.”

“S’right,” he said, making miniature explosions dance across his palm. “HQ interrogated me for five goddamn hours after that, for fuck’s sake.”

Then a pause. “I didn’t come here for that bullshit, though. I owe you an apology. Or an explanation, fuck if I know.”

Izuku could hear his heartbeat in his ears. He didn’t really want it to be like this. It felt wrong, to force Katsuki to apologize for something from so long ago, but it had hurt, damn it.

“I’m sorry, Deku. For kissing you without permission, for never talking to you about it, and for being an asshole to you for so long. You didn’t deserve any of it.”

Izuku felt himself tearing up. The words were hard to hear, after so long of hardening his heart to it. It reminded him of the day after their graduation. Katsuki had approached him and said largely the same thing, but relatively less sincerely. And without the bit about kissing. Izuku had said he’d forgiven him, because what else would Izuku say? Regardless of whether it was true or not, Izuku wasn’t about to admit he’d hold a grudge against anyone. Still, after that first apology, Izuku had hidden in a janitorial closet and sobbed next to some mops. He refused to do that now.

Apparently the silence had stretched for too long, because Katsuki folded his arms and lifted his chin.

“Look, Deku, I want to be friends again. Be back in your fucking life, but I’m not interested in spending all my fucking time groveling. It’s been a long ass time, and it’s up to you if you

want to move on."

Izuku's lips parted. He hadn't expected something like this. Maybe he *had* expected Katsuki to just grovel endlessly. Before he could marshal his thoughts, Katsuki continued.

"I've got my own shit going on, okay? Work, friends, all of that. So do you. We don't have to do this, if it's too damn painful for you. M'not interested in dragging all that old shit around. So if I can make this better, tell me how, and I'll do it. But only if it's going to fucking make things better."

It was overwhelming really, to be stared down by Bakugou Katsuki. Even if he was apologizing to you. Especially if he was apologizing to you. Izuku's fingers were digging into his knees, and he tried to control his emotions. He wanted to go cry somewhere, maybe shout something, but he couldn't. Not if Bakugou fucking Katsuki had managed to cough up a real apology. He at least deserved a good answer.

"I'm not just sorry for running off without paying," Isuku said, proud his voice was only shaking slightly. "I'm sorry for running off without giving you a chance to talk. It's not how I want to be, as a person, you know? I think sometimes you bring out, I don't know. How I used to be back then, when even the slightest thing would overwhelm me."

"Huh."

"I'm not really that mad," Izuku sighed. "Just kind of sad, I guess. Kind of confused maybe?"

"Confused about what?"

Izuku stared at him. Maybe Katsuki was stupid after all. "About why you would kiss me? I thought you hated me back then? I actually thought you never stopped hating me, really. And um," he flushed, hating his need to be honest, "I don't like that I don't know what happened. That I can't remember it, what it was like. Did I like it? Hate it? I don't know! And why wouldn't you tell me? How did it never come up?"

Katsuki barked out a laugh. "Deku. How the fuck would I have brought that up? 'Hey nerd, I kissed you last night and you hated it so much you screamed at me after, thought maybe you wanted to chat about it?' And don't forget I was still too fucking proud for my own good, too."

"So I hated it, then," Izuku murmured. That didn't sound right. Katsuki shrugged.

"Dunno. You want to hear about it?"

"Y-yes," Izuku said, trying to ignore the feelings arising at the idea of Katsuki describing kissing him. Maybe he *did* deserve to have 'got a boner for explosions' carved on his headstone after this conversation fucking killed him.

"Can't say I remember it perfectly, 'cause my dumb ass thought drinking a fifth of Fireball would be a good idea."

“Kacchan, oh my god,” Izuku blurted. “That would give you alcohol poisoning! You were a kid!”

He snorted. “Yeah, I spent that night throwing up. Fucking Kaminari, man. Anyway, I got it in my stupid head to kiss you. You were kind of off that night. I thought you were just being quiet, but turns out you were also trying to hide how wasted you were. Anyway, I went up and said something stupid like, um, ‘I’m kissing you, nerd,’ I think it was-”

Izuku snorted so loud that Katsuki jumped, then scowled at him, “Hey, I thought it was a good idea at the time.”

“I’m kissing you, nerd?” Izuku repeated, starting to giggle. “Oh my god, Kacchan, what was that?”

Katsuki rubbed his face, clearly being extremely patient at great cost to his temper. Despite a newfound love of teasing Katsuki, Izuku had mercy on him. “Sorry, sorry, keep going.”

“Then I fucking kissed you. For a second or two. Thought you were kissing back, actually,” he mumbled. “But then you pushed me off and ran. I followed you, and you turned around and told me exactly how much you hated me, how many horrible things I did to you, explained why I didn’t have the right to touch you let alone kiss you, and then told me to leave you alone and never talk to you again.”

Izuku blinked at him.

“So that’s what I did. Left you alone, that is. Or I fucking tried, anyway. You weren’t following your own damn instructions and I didn’t know how the hell to act around you.”

“That um, explains a lot,” Izuku said, tone wondering. “I always wondered why you started ignoring me.”

Katsuki shrugged. “Now you know.”

“It was still a dick move to tell me it meant nothing to you,” Izuku said, hating how petulant he sounded.

“I didn’t say that-”

“Last night. You did.”

Katsuki stared, then groaned. “Jesus Christ Deku, I didn’t mean it like that. I meant that it didn’t have to mean anything to *you* . If you want your first kiss to be fucking Todoroki, then it can be. You didn’t ask for me to kiss you, hell, you don’t even remember it. Don’t see why you have to acknowledge it even happened if you don’t want to.”

“I-” Izuku tried to say, but Katsuki jabbed a finger at him.

“I’m not done,” he snarled. “Don’t get your shitty head twisted. It meant a lot to *me* . Fucking changed my fucking life. What you said that night was the whole goddamn reason I started trying not to be a walking shitstain, got it?”

Izuku's mouth dropped open. He could feel the blood rushing to his face. It had meant something to Katsuki. He was starting to feel both strangely flattered, and also really sad. He felt an overwhelming sense of loss for something he'd never known he had.

"I just don't understand why you did it," he finally managed to say. Katsuki swallowed.

"Fine. I'll say it once, but you gotta appreciate my fucking effort," he said, a little sharply. Then he sighed, leaning back. "S'fucking embarrassing. Second year of UA, didn't know myself for shit. All I cared about was fighting and winning. Except you were there, ruining my goddamn focus. I hated you for it. Didn't know I was just a fucking horny, bisexual teenager. Took me the entire fucking year to realize what I wanted to do to you. I think I tried to be nicer at some point, but I doubt it showed. Guess I thought I'd done enough to kiss you. Like, you'd always acted like you cared about me. Always telling me I was amazing, shit like that. Thought you wouldn't mind it. Fireball took care of the rest."

"Hmmm," Izuku choked out. What he wanted to do to Izuku? Katsuki had been attracted to him? Even for just a year? At all? Ever? He hummed again, trying to pull his brain into working order.

"So yeah. Sorry I did such a shitty job of kissing you."

"Huh," Izuku coughed. It took literally all his willpower not to shout *'Then make it up to me with a proper kiss!'* Because regardless of the past, Katsuki had clearly moved on. So had he, for fuck's sake. He'd had a couple of relationships. He knew his way around love and sex and… and then there was Katsuki.

Katsuki, sitting in his kitchen, staring at him. Waiting for him to say something.

"Okay," Izuku said.

"Okay, fucking *what,* " Katsuki growled.

"I mean, it sounds okay. Kind of dramatic, but I'll take it for a first kiss." Izuku shrugged, trying to sound casual. Katsuki's mouth dropped open.

"You fucking rating my first kiss?" Oh, that's right. He'd been Katsuki's first kiss, too. That was enough to fry his entire nervous system. But *damn.* Bakugou Katsuki's first kiss. It gave him enough of a rush that he couldn't resist teasing the man.

"2/10 for execution," Izuku grinned. Katsuki's face darkened considerably. Then Izuku added, "But 9/10 for dramatic retelling seven years later! That gives us an average of 5.5/10. I'd give Shouto's a good 9.5/10, for reference."

Katsuki made some sort of choking growl, slipped off the stool, and slammed both hands on either side of Izuku. Izuku hoped he wouldn't find burn marks on his couch later. Katsuki was staring up at him, lips parted, eyes narrowed. He looked like he was about to go in for the kill.

“ *Fuck* Todoroki. I fucking kiss a thousand out of ten now, Deku.” He sharply annunciated each syllable, eyes heated. “You’d be fucking blessed to have me kiss you,” he added with a snarl. Then he whipped away, stalking towards the door.

Izuku slowly reclaimed his brain from Katsuki-induced static. “Yeah, I’d be blessed,” he whispered helplessly. Katsuki looked at him, head tilted.

“What was that?” Izuku shook his head wordlessly. Apparently Katsuki had been profoundly less affected than Izuku by what had happened, because he just shrugged. “So, we good?”

“Good,” Izuku repeated, still reeling. He wanted a thousand out of ten kiss. Badly. Or even just a thousand 5.5/10 kisses. Anything that involved Katsuki’s mouth on his, Izuku would take, he wasn’t picky. It was taking all his willpower not to demand it right now, but things were so tenuous with Katsuki that he didn’t dare to risk it. After all of this, he really *couldn’t* bear to lose him again. So he wouldn’t. No matter how it hurt, how much he yearned for more, he wasn’t going to risk what they were trying to build.

Katsuki pulled on his shoes, then looked up at Izuku. “Friends?” He asked, voice quiet. Izuku’s heart lurched.

“Always, Kacchan,” he said quickly, sincerely, the words slipping out before he could even think about it. Then, to his eternal shock, Katsuki blushed. Hard. Izuku was pretty sure he’d never seen him blush before, but now his entire neck and face were bright red. Katsuki flipped his hood up.

“Sentimental bullshit,” he murmured, then said. “See ya ‘round, nerd.” The door slammed behind him.

“I’m fucked,” Izuku told the door, because he was definitely fucked. He thought he’d had a crush on Katsuki before? Ha. Hilarious. That was nothing compared to now. Gods above, he wanted that man in every imaginable way. He wanted to make him blush, to make him smile, to make him moan, to make him c-

Izuku took a cold shower, then spent the night trying not to text Katsuki a thousand times, only barely succeeding.

A thousand out of ten.

What would that kiss be like? It was too easy to imagine Katsuki kissing him. He’d be rough, then achingly gentle, sharp teeth, red eyes…

Izuku had two cold showers that night.

Always? What kind of fucking reply was that?

Katsuki left Deku’s apartment at a half-jog, head spinning. He desperately needed to put some distance between them. He'd literally just apologized for kissing him when they were seventeen, and he’d almost fucking kissed the idiot *again* . In the same conversation. Aggressively. And even worse, he wanted to do so much more than just kiss. All it took was seeing him again, all fucking grown up and fucking beautiful, and Katsuki wanted to destroy him. To make Deku his, once and for all, even when he had no fucking right to want that. Damn, he was so fucking possessive, and way too turned on. He slowed to a walk about three blocks from Deku’s place, and slapped his own cheeks.

When was he ever going to goddamn learn? Deku was dangerous. Deku’s green-ass eyes and soft lips and broad shoulders and shitty freckles were *dangerous*. Deciding to spend time around Deku was going to fucking end him. If that idiot kept pushing him, he was going to snap and actually go for it, and then he’d actually ruin everything. He’d just barely talked his way out of the misguided kiss from seven years ago, for fuck’s sake!

Katsuki was trying his best, but he only had so much self-control. Good thing he always liked playing with fire, right?

Also, 5.5/10? What the fuck, Deku?

Chapter End Notes

Poor Bakugou, only 5.5/10 :^(

That's not going to bother him AT ALL.

...Sorry if anyone thought they were going to kiss! Poor Bakugou's gun shy now, and can we really count on Izuku to take initiative? Still, the good news is that the weather forecast says there's more steam in our future!

(Bakugou always writes out people's names in his phones because he thinks it's a sign of maturity even if the rest of his texting is trash.)

Boom Boom Boom Boom

Chapter Summary

What happens if you show Bakugou a fan-made music video featuring his ass?

Izuku finds out! Hooray!

Chapter Notes

Couple disclaimers:

1. So I know I'm writing Bakugou as bi, and also as a guy who likes to sleep around. As a bi person myself, I'm sensitive to these stereotypes and just wanna say that B-face isn't sleeping around because he's bi. It's just cause he's a horny bastard.
Besides, I think we all know (adult) Bakugou fucks

2. The rating is now going up to Explicit in anticipation of future chapters (͡° ͜ʖ ͡°)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It took a good four days to get a reply from Katsuki after Izuku texted him. He'd sent something extremely neutral, after spending an embarrassing amount of time writing and erasing messages.

Izuku: *Hey*

So neutral. Maybe too neutral, because Katsuki didn't reply, and Izuku refused to double text. It took four whole days for Izuku to realize that because Katsuki's phone had died, he wouldn't have Izuku's number. Again. Katsuki had been right, Izuku was fucking stupid.

Izuku: *Um, it's Deku*

The immediate response brought a wash of relief. Izuku hadn't realized how tense he'd been, constantly wondering how things were between them. Had Katsuki decided he didn't want to be friends after all? Was he upset about the conversation? Had Izuku said something that bothered him? Apparently not.

Kacchan: *Then fcking say so jfc deku ur useless*

Izuku: *I know, I know, I'm sorry! I thought you just weren't texting me back >.<*

Kacchan: *When have i ever not*

Izuku: *#allofUA #elementaryschool #mostofourlives*

Kacchan: …

Izuku: *Sooorryyyy Kacchan, I know I'm the worst :(*

Kacchan: *Ur shitty txting is at best a 5.5/10*

Kacchan: *;)*

And just like that, Izuku was laughing over his phone again, like a massive dork. When had Katsuki grown a sense of humor? Maybe it had been covered up by his constant bad attitude, before. Now though, Izuku was quickly becoming addicted. Maybe he had just been too scared before to pick up on when Katsuki was actually serious.

They finally agreed to meet again, this time for coffee on a day when they each had evening shifts. Izuku picked a place he hadn't been to yet, called Pothos Place. It was perfectly set between his and Katsuki's sectors, and therefore a very fair place to meet. If it just happened to be a highly-rated date spot, Izuku wasn't at fault. Still, with a while to go before meeting Katsuki, he decided to check out the place first. A good hero is always prepared, right?

Uraraka was the friend of choice, and soon enough they were sipping mochas in Pothos Place. It was a fairly large cafe, with high, white ceilings and an open sitting area. Shelves lined the walls, dripping with vines and bushy plants. One of the walls was covered in moss, even. The iced mochas were absolutely heavenly, and Izuku was in bliss right up until they reached their table.

"I cannot believe you're bringing me here as a pre-date for Katsuki," she said, as soon as they sat down. Izuku choked on his mocha, coughing violently.

"It's not a date." He managed to make his voice sound reasonable, and not like he was a kid denying a crush.

"Mmm yes, you're right. Katsuki would totally come to a plant-covered coffee shop just to chill, for fun, with someone he's not into," Uraraka rolled her eyes. "Have you met him?"

"Yes?" Izuku said. "Maybe he likes plants now. Idk, I went to his noisy dive bar last time, so…"

"This is your second date?" Uraraka screeched. Izuku clapped his hands on her cheeks, gently.

"Not. A. Date."

"Hmph," she said. "If you say so. I don't know what his game is then, because his flirting is outrageous."

She'd finally succeeded in making Izuku blush, at least. "Kacchan isn't. He wouldn't. He's not, he doesn't, um,"

"Sweet, darling, baby Deku-cheeks," she said. "Come on! Get your head in the game! I saw you guys together, remember? He was all over you, it was ridiculous. Like, 'Oh, let me help you walk to the bathroom 'cause my sweet little nerd baby can't do it by himself?' Give me a break."

"You're making stuff up," Izuku sighed. He didn't even want it to be a date. The idea of dating Katsuki was nearly impossible to conceptualize, it was so strange. Just calling them friends was making his heart pound through his stupid ribcage. The whole situation was hurting his poor brain.

"Nah, he's been checking you out shamelessly. If Iida ever looked at me like that, I'd just strip on the spot."

"Oh please, like you'd ever make a move." Izuku graciously refrained from pointing out Iida's love-sick glances, because that would fall on deaf ears. Pot calling the kettle black, and all.

She stuck her tongue out. "You're right, you're right. But Deku, I hate to say this but… you should be careful, okay? I don't want you getting hurt."

"I won't," Izuku said, trying not to sound annoyed. "I can handle him. Besides, he said he just wants to be friends again." Yes, friends. Friends was safe. Well, relatively safe, at least. Right? Izuku sighed heavily. "It's fine. I just don't think that's what's happening. It's not like he can't get what he wants anywhere else, you know? Like, why go to all the effort of getting with, with me?"

"I'm not answering that one," Uraraka said wisely. Then she gave Izuku one of those blinding smiles that you just can't resist being cheered up by. "As long as you know I'm here for you no matter what, right?"

Life can be so strange. Somehow, Izuku was more at ease with Katsuki in some chic, heavily-planted cafe than he'd been with Uraraka, even if it was just due to her teasing. Izuku was having a latte this time, concerned about the potential for being teased about a mocha. He realized this was stupid when Katsuki ordered the most sugary, over-the-top frappuccino Izuku had ever seen.

"I need calories for tonight's shitty-ass shift," was all he said. Izuku just barely managed to refrain from teasing him, and was rewarded shortly with a happy and relaxed Bakugo, reclining in a chair by, legs stretched out gloriously. It was a sight. Sunlight dappled his face, softening his normally hard expression.

"How's your sector been?" Izuku tried making conversation. Katsuki's faint sneer told him it was a lame attempt, but he played along anyway.

“Shitty. One of our companies just started up some weapons manufacturing and goddamn, these fucking extra villains will not stop trying to break in.”

“It’s that bad?”

“Literally my whole shift tonight is just guarding this one building. Fucking drudge work, I tell you. I’m a goddamn security guard.”

“Every time I go into work, they’re on me about interns,” Izuku sighed, commiserating. “I still feel like I can barely handle myself sometimes.”

“You can handle yourself fine,” Katsuki snorted. “You’re just a fucking coward.”

“Real nice,” Izuku snapped, instantly irritated. Apparently Katsuki couldn’t keep his nice act that long, after all. Katsuki just waved a hand, looking out the window like he couldn’t possibly care.

“No, no, not like that. You’re too fucking brave for your good, always have been. I mean that you’re scared you’ll fuck it up. Don’t wanna take the risk, even though it’s a sign you’re a damn good hero.”

Oh . Izuku found himself nodding, his face folding into a frown.

“You’re right. I *wouldn’t* be able to handle it if something happened to someone on my watch,” he said, thinking of Iida and the fight against Stain. So many things could go wrong, and it was already so hard just caring for civilians. “Like I’m actually worried it would really mess me up, you know?”

He nervously watched Katsuki, hoping his admission wouldn’t be torn apart. But Katsuki only sighed, letting his head lean back against the chair.

“I wish someone would trust me with an intern,” he said. Izuku’s jaw dropped. “I’m fucking stuck at #19 right now because everyone thinks I’m just gonna kill everything around me. As if I’d explode some idiot kid intern. They’d be safer with me than with half the fucking trash heroes in this city, anyway.”

It was an interesting thought. Katsuki was historically known for charging in alone, but with an intern? Maybe it would be the chance he needed to show his caring side, which he technically did seem to have. “You’ll get there,” Izuku said, automatically. Katsuki raised his eyebrows.

“Ya think? I don’t fucking know anymore, man. Maybe this is all I can do. Rankings are all popularity bullshit anyway. Best Jeanist had it right, except that I can’t win a goddamn popularity contest.”

“Well, Shouto’s #9 right now, which is pretty amazing,” Izuku said. “And everyone does seem weirdly fixated on him.”

“Maybe I should dye half my hair,” Katsuki snorted.

“Or wear a muzzle,” Izuku said, without thinking. Katsuki let out a bark of a laugh.

“Didn’t know you were into that kind of bullshit,” he snickered.

“Just, just no,” Izuku groaned. “No. Just, maybe consider not acting like literally everyone is a villain you plan on killing?”

“Maybe,” Katsuki finally said, looking pensieve. “Doesn’t fucking matter as long as I’m taking out trash, though, you know?”

Long after they’d left for their respective shifts, Izuku was still thinking about that conversation. It kept bothering Izuku, and it took him a while to pinpoint why. Katsuki hadn’t seemed, well himself. He’d expect him to be more rabid, frothing at the mouth to hit #1. He always had been, after all. Bakugou Katsuki content at #19? Bakugou Katsuki content with being behind Deku? It felt viscerally wrong. As much pain as it had caused him back in the day, Izuku found that he missed that single-minded ambition in his friend.

So he was relieved when Katsuki agreed to come to another UA drinks night. Izuku got there before everyone else, mostly because he’d already texted Katsuki, who’d instantly replied with, *Ill come for you* . Again. If he didn’t know better, Izuku would start to think the phrasing wasn’t an accident.

But did he know better? The issue he was facing was strange - he knew Katsuki inside and out, but well, he actually didn't, not anymore. It would be more accurate to say that he knew *teenage* Katsuki inside and out. Adult Katsuki was a different beast entirely. Maybe he actually was a flirt? Maybe he was that way with everyone? Izuku was no stranger to tabloids, and there'd been so many photos taken of Katsuki leaving someone's building early in the morning, sunglasses on, middle finger up that the papers didn't even bother reporting on it anymore. There were Instabook accounts dedicated to following pro hero’s various flings, and after seeing far too many pictures of Katsuki’s walk of shames, Izuku had pointedly stopped looking. So he could admit that maybe Uraraka hadn’t been entirely wrong to suspect him of being on the prowl. It just didn’t feel like that, though.

And anyway, it was all speculation. Izuku had to admit that he couldn't really read Katsuki as well anymore, and it was bothering him.

Momo and Jirou slid into the booth next to him.

“Can’t believe we didn’t get tapped for the beach fiasco,” Jirou complained, flopping on the table. “I saw you guys on the news. It looked fun. Tsu’s gonna be pissed she missed it.”

“Search and rescue isn’t fun,” Momo said, placing menus in front of them. “It’s serious work.”

“But it’s fun when I’m so good at it,” Jirou grinned, rolling sideways to stick her tongue out at the tall girl. Momo met Izuku’s eyes over her back.

“I can’t believe they put Kacchan against a water manipulator,” Izuku found himself saying. “Was there really no one better suited?”

“No one’s better than fucking Ground Zero,” Jirou scoffed in a fairly passable Katsuki impression, making Izuku snort. “I missed the fight on the news, though, how’d he do? That jerk’s been kicking ass up north, I hear.”

“Mm, it wasn’t bad. Not his flashiest,” Izuku found himself saying, like he was some sort of expert. “Look, it’s gotta be on YubeTou.”

A very kind waitress dropped off a pitcher of beer, and Izuku typed “Ground Zero” into the search bar. Strangely enough, there wasn’t a clip of the recent fight on the front page yet. He scrolled a bit until he saw something that looked like, well. An ass. A familiar ass.

Katsuki’s ass in tight pants. Izuku squeaked.

“What’s that?” Jirou asked, prying herself off the table. The video was titled, “BOOM.” Izuku clicked it. He couldn’t not.

It opened with a muted news clip overlaid with some heavy dance beat. Katsuki was in the video thumbnail behind the reporter, wearing street clothes and clearly being mobbed by paparazzi. Then the news clip cut to Katsuki’s feed, just as he propped one foot on a bench, bending forwards to shout at some reporters. But he was facing away from the camera.

Then the song went, *Bring that ass back like a boom boom boom boom.*

Each *boom* zoomed in closer, ending with a close-up shot of Katsuki’s very muscular, well-defined ass. Izuku screamed.

“Oh my fucking god,” Jirous whispered in awe. “No way.”

As the dance music continued, expertly-cut sections of various news-sourced videos of Katsuki as either himself or as Ground Zero were stitched together. Each time the song dropped, it synced with one of his massive explosions.

There was a clip of Ground Zero being debriefed, looking absolutely exhausted, his lips somehow synced perfectly with *when the pussy splash like water then it make your dick get harder* . Izuku was starting to laugh uncontrollably.

Each *Fuck it* line had actual audio from Katsuki’s interviews overlaid. Well, there was no shortage of material there; the guy never stopped swearing. Izuku’s eyes were tearing up with the hilarity of it.

Finally it was over, ending with one of Katsuki’s biggest explosions. He’d vaporized some huge, insect colony villain by incinerating a three-mile radius out in some desert county. (The county was Morocco, it was two years ago, in April, and Izuku knew literally everything about it like he did with everything Ground Zero did.) The resulting mushroom cloud looked apocalyptic.

Izuku's phone fell to the table with a clatter. Jirou was staring at it, soul vacating her body. Izuku could relate.

"Where the fuck is my music video?" She suddenly screeched. "I'm the audio one, damn it! Why'd he get one instead of me?"

Izuku hit replay, and began dissolving in laughter. "He hasn't seen this, right? He's gonna kill someone."

"It's so good," Jirou groaned. "I wanna hire this person to do mine, but like. With a less slutty song."

Momo was the third victim to watch it, and was notably less impressed. Uraraka appeared later, Iida in tow.

"Uraraka. Look." Izuku thrust the phone in her face. On the screen, quick cuts of every inadvertent hip thrust Katsuki had ever done on screen were playing in rapid succession.

"Oh yeah!" She grinned. "I love that video." She grabbed the phone, and scrolled down to the comments. "See? I have the top comment. 1.7k likes," she snickered.

Izuku snatched the phone back. The comment, from *tastemyfistsuwu* read, "Katsuki? More like BakuHO." Izuku stared at her.

"What?" she said. "He's clearly flaunting it."

"Kill me and lay me in my grave," Izuku groaned. "This conversation isn't happening."

"Low hanging fruit, sorry!" She grinned, sliding into the booth. Iida followed, looking relatively calm.

"There's not actually anything in regulations about this," he said. "So knock yourselves out."

"I am currently knocking myself out," Jirou said, in a way that could only be described as vicious. After fiddling on her phone, she presented it to the group. Her official, verified Cheeps hero page read,

LOL @ BAKUHO'S NEW MV: yu.tu/239rty658/BOOM *Who will make me an mv?????? <crying emoji> #GroundZero #KatsukiKatsuki #Dead #DatAssTho #LordExplodoMurder*

It had 250 recheeps already.

"He's going to kill you," Uraraka cackled.

"He can try," Momo said, calm in the face of what clearly was a disaster.

Izuku's phone buzzed.

Kacchan: *Omw*

Shit.

“So, what are the chances we don’t bring this up when Kacchan gets here?” Izuku said, feeling the end of his life approach. He didn’t know if Katsuki could actually go supernova, but had a feeling he was about to find out.

“Bring what up?” Shouto’s cool voice could never be mistaken for Katsuki, but Izuku jumped nonetheless.

“Bring that ass back,” Uraraka said unhelpfully, as Iida patted the seat next to them.

“Get ready for your eyes to melt out of your head,” Jirou added, cheerful as all hell. She laid her phone down on the table, and they all watched the cheeps add up.

“It appears to be going viral,” Momo said, looking amused. “Jirou, why?”

“This girl just wants to have fun,” she laughed. Uraraka slapped the table.

“Damn straight! Okay, here’s the real question. What music would our fan-made videos be set to? I call dibs on Anaconda!”

Iida spit his beer out, coughing violently. “What,” he choked out. “Why-”

“Mmf, good choice,” Jirou said. “Gotta own that shit! I’ve gotta do something by Rezz, maybe one of the newer remixes actually…” she proceeded to go off muttering something. Momo rubbed her temples.

“Ice Ice Baby mixed with This Girl is on Fire,” Shouto said, with a completely straight face. The table erupted in laughter. Izuku was laughing so hard he cried. He’d almost forgotten Katsuki was coming, but come he did. Only twenty minutes late, actually, which was pretty good for a social outing as far as Katsuki was concerned. Izuku noticed him the moment he entered, and desperately tried to get everyone to shut up. At the very least, they’d managed to pause all the iterations of the BOOM video currently playing at their table.

So they were all suspiciously quiet when he showed up, the occasional snicker escaping Uraraka and Jirou. Izuku barely trusted himself to speak. With a frown, Katsuki pulled a chair over to the end of the booth. Jirou had turned away from him, looking religiously at her Cheeper feed, Momo was staring fixedly at the ceiling, and Shouto had covered his mouth with one hand. Uraraka had just face-planted on the table, arms hiding her head. Iida was trying to clean up the beer he’d sprayed.

“What’s...up,” Katsuki said, looking vaguely disgusted.

“Hi,” Izuku squeaked.

“Ice. Ice. *Baby* ,” Uraraka whispered, then dissolved into laughter. Shouto’s other hand went over his mouth, eyes squeezed shut to keep the laughter in. He was wheezing softly with the effort to stifle his laughs. It warmed Izuku's heart to see it; Shouto was still very reserved in groups, and it was nice to see him loosen up.

“I’d just leave, if I were you,” Momo said. Katsuki’s face began to shift into his trademark scowl, but she held up her hands in a gesture of peace. “For your own good.”

“Let’s just get it over with,” Jirou said, too happy with herself. “1k recheeps now, by the way.”

“Yep, you lot are freaks. I’m leaving,” Katsuki stood, suddenly. “Deku, you coming?”

“Ohhhhh?” Uraraka said instantly, earning a dark glare. “But Katsuki, don’t you wanna see what video got our Deku all worked up?”

“No, he doesn’t,” Izuku said, wishing he could disappear. “I wasn’t-”

“You def screamed when you saw dat ass,” Jirou added, unhelpfully. Katsuki pointedly sat back down.

“I changed my mind, Kacchan,” Izuku said quickly. “Let’s leave now. Or you can kill them all, I don’t care.” He tried to stand but was immediately pushed back into a sitting position by Katsuki’s hand. Damn, he was strong.

“There’s literally no way I won’t regret this,” he said, “But what video?”

“This is a mistake,” Shouto added, apparently having calmed himself. “I don’t want to pay for property damage.”

“Oh fuck off,” Katsuki snapped. “Can’t be that bad if I’m in it.”

“The bigger they are, the harder they fall,” Momo sighed, and pulled Jirou’s phone out. The music started up, and Izuku hid his face in his arms. He did not need this.

He could hear the music playing, and Katsuki’s perfect silence was deafening. Finally, the song came to a stop. He dared to look up and saw Katsuki pull his phone out of his pocket. He seemed to be typing something, face alarmingly blank.

“Whatcha doin there?” Mina had arrived, innocent of all things BOOM-related. Katsuki looked up at her, eyes staring a thousand miles past her, like he was in his own private dimension of murder explosions.

“Oh, nothing. Just looking up how to find out where someone lives from their YubeTou account name SO I CAN GO MURDER THIS MOTHERFUCKER,” he shouted. Smoke was coming from his phone.

Izuku dissolved in laughter again, and Uraraka was wiping tears while holding her sides.

“What?” Mina looked deeply confused, which was fair. She’d arrived at possibly the worst time. Katsuki offered her his chair, and slid in next to Izuku, pushing Momo and Jirou unceremoniously deeper into the booth.

“Nothing,” he growled, voice deep and dark. He turned on Izuku, who shrank away, giggling helplessly. “You watched this shit?”

“Maybe,” he managed to say. “One or twice.”

“Think we’re up to ten, now,” Iida said, sounding like a martyr.

“Izuku found it,” Jirou said, very helpfully.

“Woops,” Izuku said, glaring at Jirou, the traitor.

“Technically I found it first, Baku *ho* ,” Uraraka chimed in, but Katsuki was ignoring them, leaning over Izuku.

“So you saw it and showed fucking everyone, huh?” He said, his voice shivering over Izuku’s skin.

“Kind of,” Izuku said, holding his sides. They were cramping with the effort not to laugh.

“I’m going to kill you for this,” Katsuki snarled, holding up a smoking fist. Izuku just giggled harder, helpless against the ridiculousness of the situation. Sparks escaped from between Katsuki’s fingers. His growl ghosted over Izuku's skin, and if he hadn't been laughing so hard, he'd probably be hopelessly turned on. Katsuki continued, “Gonna melt your flesh off your goddamn bones. You’re gonna be in an urn by the time I’m fucking done, you shady video-sharing piece of filth, you-”

“Katsuki!” Iida exclaimed. “You can’t talk to him like that!”

Izuku took the chance to bury his face in his arms again, shaking in silent, helpless laughter. He heard Shouto’s cool voice cut in, waving Iida away. “Don’t worry, Iida. I think this is some sort of twisted foreplay for them, actually.”

“I hate you all,” Izuku cried, sucking in breaths between laughs. “Seriously. Kacchan, go off. Take ‘em out. I don’t wanna live in this world anymore. I wanna move in with Onito because *he doesn’t make fun of me, unlike you guys.* ”

Instead, he felt a friendly slap across his back. “Cheer up, nerd,” Katsuki was saying, looking hugely pleased with himself. “I know it’s hard to resist checking out my ass.”

“Not the only thing that’s hard,” Shouto said, levelly, pointing a finger at Izuku.

“God, Shouto, why! Why would you say that? You know what!?” Izuku proclaimed, glaring at Shouto, who just gave him a thumbs up. He turned on Katsuki, who still looked viciously smug. “Go ahead and *do* kill me. I’d rather be a pile of dust and listen to anything any of you say ever again.”

“It’s the best thing I’ve seen this year,” Uraraka said, leaning across the table to interrupt. Bless her. It was near the end of the video, where each *boom* was accompanied by a different shot of Katsuki’s ass. “Look at the comments! It's blowing up!"

Izuku pulled it up on his phone, ignoring how Katsuki crowded into his space to look at the screen. It wasn’t as easy to ignore the muscular arm on the back of the booth behind him, but Izuku made a valiant effort.

2.2k likes - tastemyfistsuwu: Bakugou? More like BakuHO amirite?

1.9k likes - johnnymiko69: Ground Zero can Pound Zero me any day jfc

1.8k likes - [deleted_account]: guys dont comment on this, ground zero's gonna find us and kill us lmfao (seriously though I'm deleting after this)

1.2k likes - letsgoh444rd: this shit actually slaps tho, gz actually looks cool af

1.1k likes - Corinthians420: Wow, are there no standards for pro heros anymore? What happened to respectable heroes like All Might and Endeavor? They'd be so disappointed in all of you. GZ, please at least try to be a worthwhile hero #bakuNO

1.1k likes - bestpurpleboi: bakugET OUT OF HERE. i swear if I have to see this guys ass ONE more time im gonna explode myself and save him the trouble

There were several thousands of comments, most of them either horrifyingly thirsty or laughing about Katsuki's inevitable retribution. Izuku could practically feel the explosion building next to him.

"You're right, Deku," Katsuki said, looking up. "I'm going to explode you, this bar, the rest of the city, and then myself. In that order."

"Aw, I get to be first," Izuku snickered, chronically unable to take this seriously.

"Look, just a suggestion, but could we not talk about Katsuki's ass for at least some part of tonight?" Iida asked, in a hilariously polite voice.

"Finally a good fucking idea!" Katsuki shouted. "Come on losers, what do you normally get up to these days?"

"Kaminari says we should go to this club he's at," Mina said, holding up a text message with way too many emojis in it. "We haven't been out in ages guys, we should go!"

"Fuck no," Katsuki said, just as Izuku pounced on the idea. He'd have jumped on anything to get them out of this hell situation.

"I want to go dancing!" He said, excited despite himself.

"Fuck yes," Katsuki said, in exactly the same tone of voice he'd used to shoot the idea down, and that was that. Izuku couldn't deny the bubble of happiness warming in his chest, though, because there was no denying that Katsuki was going somewhere just because he wanted to.

Kaminari's club was ten blocks away, but the night wasn't cold yet and a nice walk never hurt anybody. Having Katsuki back in the group was strange. He fit in seamlessly, in a way he never had in high school. Izuku couldn't tell if it was just that he'd mellowed out, or the rest of them had learned his sense of humor. Or maybe he just hadn't had a sense of humor

before? He felt that strange sense of disconnect from Katsuki again. Would he ever know him as well as he used to?

Then from up ahead, Iida stopped. “Have you guys been checking the rankings? I just got pinged by my agency. I’m up five spots away from Top 30 Rankings!”

Izuku pulled out his phone, hitting the browser. He had the page bookmarked. He was at #15, which was honestly very impressive given his age. It was also very, very far from #1. He couldn’t help the disappointment that came from seeing the score, though. To his right, Katsuki was also checking, sharp face lit by his phone screen.

Then he saw Katsuki tense, his shoulders pulling in and steps faltering. Izuku checked for Katsuki’s name. #30. Izuku was shocked. Ground Zero had been floating around #17 for a while, rising and dipping with his various victories and outbursts respectively, but he hadn’t dropped under #20 for years. Izuku’s throat felt tight. What had happened? If anything, Katsuki should be up after the beach thing, since he’d resolved the situation and only flipped off the cameras once.

“Kacchan,” he said softly.

“I’m almost off the fucking top thirty,” the man muttered, slowing to a stop.

Maybe Izuku could still read him, because he could feel the heartbreak from here. Their friends continued on, but Izuku couldn’t leave Katsuki. “What, what happened?” he asked, hating how hesitant he sounded.

“Fucking video,” Katsuki ground out, hanging his phone to Izuku. There was an email from his PR agency, which Izuku quickly skimmed. Essentially, they were notifying Katsuki of the video, explaining that the scandalous nature of some shots and reminders of his potty mouth (yes, they used that phrase) had trashed his rankings. He’d dropped eleven whole spots. Then came the inane suggestions to improve his ratings. Izuku didn’t even realize his hand was covering his mouth.

It was horrible. Katsuki had clawed his way out of the top hundred by sheer force of will, leaving behind a myriad of insulted civilians, reporters, and officials. Hitting top thirty had been a big deal, and Timesweek had even run an article on whether he deserved it or not.

To be back at #30? He looked up at Katsuki, who looked like he was either about to fall to pieces or spontaneously combust.

“Kacchan, I-”

“It’s nothing,” he growled. “Look, you go dancing. I’m going to go drink ‘til I black out. See ya later, Deks.” He turned, and began slouching away. Izuku’s heart hurt for him.

Before he knew it, he’d caught up with Katsuki, grabbing his arm. “Kacchan, wait. I’ll come with you.”

“For what,” Katsuki sighed, jerking his head away from him.

“Company,” Izuku said, a little forcefully. He knew he was taking a big risk. Katsuki historically never accepted comfort of any kind, and hadn’t confided in anyone except maybe Kirishima, and then only on a good day. Or except for Izuku, when they were four and told each other everything.

Katsuki finally slowed, turning to look at Izuku, his expression heavy and resigned. “Fucking hell, Deku. Can’t believe this shit, you know? I didn’t even do it this time, and the fuckers docked me eleven spots. I’m pissed as all hell, and I don’t want to take it out on anyone. On you.”

It was hard to hear. Bakugou Katsuki never accepted defeat, never backed down, fired on all cylinders all the time. And as Ground Zero, even more so. Everyone knew that if it was an impossible fight, too dangerous to risk, you sent in Ground Zero. Yet here he was, looking exhausted. Drained. Like finally, somehow, this was what had turned it all into too much to bear.

“I’m not #15 for nothing,” Izuku said, with a little bite to his words. Katsuki’s eyes snapped to his, but he rushed on, “So I can handle a pissed off Ground Zero, okay? You don’t have to be alone. I’m here. I don’t want to go dancing when my friend is, is… when my friend is having a rough time,” he finished lamely.

Katsuki swallowed, clearly trying to decide whether or not to let him in. Izuku had said his piece though, and the ball was in Katsuki’s court.

“I’m going to chug booze till my liver fails,” Katsuki finally said, voice rough. “So it can be at the shittiest bar in the city, at my place, or at yours. You pick.”

Izuku’s mouth dropped open. He was in. Holy shit. Then came the crushing realization that while Katsuki might have let him in, even a little, and now he couldn’t mess it up. If he ruined things tonight, who knew if Katsuki would ever speak to him again? He knew instinctively that Katsuki’s aggressive personality hid someone that really, truly cared about what he did. Who cared about everything, exhaustively. It was actually something they had in common.

“My place,” Izuku said, trying to sound decisive. “People keep gifting me alcohol but I never drink it, so…”

“Fucking using me to get rid of your booze?” Katsuki scoffed.

“Yep,” Izuku said, risking a small smile.

“Smart move,” Katsuki hissed. “I’m gonna get trashed. Hope you’re ready to take care of a useless sack of fucking garbage.”

Chapter End Notes

Sad Bakugou alert! I actually made myself sad writing about this ;-;
If only there was someone who knows him really well and loves him for who he is and who would encourage him and help him regain his (terrifyingly intense) drive! And you thought the angst was resolved.

Anyone else curious about what super drunk Bakugou will be like? On a super super unrelated note, I actually fully intended the smut to happen in THIS chapter, but it was getting pretty long so it'll have to be in the next one. Woops, guess we all have to wait :^)

So I was listening to Bakugou-themed playlists while planning this chapter, and I fully admit that the whole BOOM arc is literally just because I listened to BOOM from this Spotify playlist called bakugou doesn't listen to 21 pilots u dork ass losers which is magical.
Anyway, I could not get this scene out of my head, so now it can be in your head too

The song in question is BOOM by Tiësto with Gucci Mane & Sevenn. Jirou's cheep does have a live link to it, haha. Three of the comments in the video are from heroes we know and love btw

Since I'm on the topics of songs and I often listen to music to get in the mood for a scene, here's some I've been into for this fic:

1. Bakugou being Bakugou I mean, *"I bet you like that, mean when I bite back?"* So good.
2. Our boys being useless & pining
3. Deku's a soft boy & I love him even though I keep overwhelming him

All your kudos & comments are a blessing, ty everyone! Hope you like this chapter <3

Incandescent

Chapter Summary

Izuku deals with Bakugou dealing with his hero ranking, but it's very hard.

Speaking of hard things...

Chapter Notes

This chapter is going full steam ahead! (。◕‿◕。)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Before he knew it, Izuku found himself standing in his kitchen, with an enormously sulky Katsuki laying on his couch. He was looking for something for the other man to drink. Some sort of beer, or liquor, but he'd forgotten that he was exclusively gifted with fruity wines for some reason. How had he ended up in this situation? Just a few months ago, everything was normal in his life. He'd been doing perfectly fine hero work, spending time with his friends, learning to cook buns and cupcakes and nonsense. But of course, everything Katsuki touches explodes, and his life had apparently been infected by the chaos. He heard a groan coming from the couch, and he eyed the culprit warily.

"Kacchan?" He called hesitantly.

"Where's the fucking booze, nerd? Your resident piece of garbage wants to get wasted."

"I just have um, Riesling, champagne, and like ten bottles of rosé." Izuku knew what was coming long before Katsuki said anything.

Katsuki's head rose from behind the back of the couch like a corpse from the grave. "You seriously brought me here to drink that crap? Is this some fucking revenge plot for the past, Deku? 'Cause count yourself avenged. This is cruel."

"I wasn't thinking," Izuku mumbled, feeling kind of bad. "Everyone just gives me sweet things for some reason, but we can go somewhere else!"

"Fuck no," Katsuki said, oozing over the back of the couch so his arms dangled down. "You're stuck with me now, so hit me with your least-sweet shit."

Izuku brought him a glass of Riesling, setting it on the coffee table nervously.

“I cannot fucking believe I’m trying to drink myself blind with a wine glass of Riesling in some fucking nerd's apartment,” Katsuki sighed. “Just when I thought I couldn't get any more pathetic.”

“You’re not pathetic,” Izuku said, automatically. Katsuki heroically downed the entire glass in one gulp. Izuku poured him another, which was summarily rejected when Katsuki grabbed the whole bottle. Izuku sipped on the abandoned glass, trying not to fixate on how Katsuki’s throat moved as he chugged the wine.

“Gonna have a hell of a hangover,” Katsuki muttered.

“Isn’t this self-destructive?” Izuku was concerned, but also unsure how much he could push.

“I’ve destroyed everything else, so I may as well add my goddamn self to the list.” Katsuki held up a hand, watching small explosions dance across it. He seemed pensive and moody, which was a departure from any other mood Izuku had seen on the man. It unsettled him.

“Wouldn’t have pegged you to be so dramatic,” Izuku said, hoping to lighten the atmosphere. Anything to stop Katsuki from looking so down.

Katsuki practically melted across the couch, turning so he was nearly on top of Izuku. Izuku shrank down, looking up at the other man. One of Katsuki’s hands had landed next to his hip, and the other precariously held the bottle, propped against the back of the couch. He was half-caging Izuku in, and the proximity was frying his brain. His heart pounded, as he took in the muscles bunching in Katsuki’s shoulders, his burning expression, his slightly parted lips. God damn.

“Wouldn’t mind being pegged by you,” Katsuki drawled, and Izuku actually choked, fire shooting through his limbs. This was bad. He did *not* need that image in his head right now.

“Y-you can’t say that,” Izuku said, holding onto his glass for dear life.

“No, no,” Katsuki admonished him, taking another drink from the bottle. “I’ll say what I fucking want, nerd. I’m being self-destructive, remember?” It was unfair, really. Izuku had planned on being there for Katsuki emotionally, and had zero idea what to do when Katsuki acting like this. It was pushing the limits of Izuku’s self-control, and he was seconds away from either bolting from the room or kissing Katsuki himself.

He snatched the bottle from Katsuki and downed the rest, ignoring how Katsuki’s gaze fixated on his mouth as he drank. His head was buzzing. Distantly, he knew this was a perfect storm for something they’d inevitably regret. He’d meant to be there for Katsuki, not bang him. Could he not do both, though? No. No! Izuku would be a good friend. He wouldn’t take advantage of the other man while he was down.

But it was hard to care about that when Katsuki was staring straight through his soul. It was impossible to deny his attraction any longer. Despite his nerves, despite how badly he wanted to be a good friend, Izuku couldn’t resist reaching out. His trembling hand gently touched Katsuki’s cheek. Izuku nearly expected them to both explode on the spot, but Katsuki just leaned into the touch, eyes half-closed.

“Deku,” he said, voice low and rough. He moved even closer, one large hand bracing on Izuku’s thigh. The touch burned, and Izuku longed to leave it there, to see where else Katsuki would go. But he wasn’t here to mess around, after all.

“It’s not going to work,” Izuku said, voice catching. He scuttled backward, climbing awkwardly over the arm of the couch. Katsuki followed, ending up draped across the couch, looking sinfully good. Izuku swallowed. “You’re not destroying this. I brought you here to keep you company, not to let you try and ruin everything around you. You can’t do anything that will ruin this.”

“You’re so fucking good to me, Deku,” Katsuki purred. Izuku backed up against the wall. Bekugou didn’t follow, but his red, dangerous stare pinned Izuku in place. “Just how are you planning to keep me company, then?”

“Carefully, and from a safe distance,” Izuku squeaked.

“Smartass.”

“You’re drunk,” Izuku countered. Katsuki climbed up to perch on the arm of the couch, tilting his head at Izuku. His loose tank top had dropped to the right, one sleeve dropping over a well-defined shoulder. Izuku stared at it, feeling like he was living in some strange, parallel universe. This couldn’t be real, right? Horribly attractive men didn’t hit on him in his apartment. He was boring, he was straightlaced. Yet, there was Katsuki, sitting on his couch, looking like a mountain cat considering its prey.

“Not nearly drunk enough to excuse my behavior,” he finally said. “Got some more shitty Riesling? I’m planning to do some things I’ll definitely need excuses for.”

“You would be easier to deal with if you just passed out,” Izuku mumbled, making Katsuki snort with laughter.

“Yes, the #30 hero, knocked out by Riesling and passed out on someone else’s couch. Fucking glorious. Would you like that? Is that what you want from me?”

“Kacchan, don’t,” Izuku pled.

“Don't what?” Katsuki snapped, vaulting over the couch easily. The wall was nice and solid behind Izuku’s back, and he refused to back away further. It felt like in those nature documentaries, where they say not to turn your back on a predator. Katsuki was on the prowl, and Izuku had to stand his ground. He swallowed.

“Don’t talk about yourself like that!” It came out a little forceful, and a sneer lifted Katsuki’s lip. “You’re not pathetic. You’re amazing, and one of the strongest people in this whole country, and, and, and a good person. It’s stupid that the rankings don’t reflect that.”

Katsuki was getting closer, socked feet silent as he moved across the floor. “Fuck, Deku, don’t stop.”

“W-what? Stop what?” Izuku stuttered. He had to look away from the intensity of Katsuki’s gaze. Katsuki’s forearms landed heavily on the wall, framing Izuku’s head. His heart nearly lept out of his damn chest. Katsuki leaned in, eyes narrowed.

“You know I like praise,” he whispered, voice grating. Izuku’s body reacted subconsciously, head tilting up, hands pressing against Katsuki’s chest. The man was so warm, so strong. Izuku was short of breath, overwhelmed by the moment. But still, he had to be strong. It was hard though, with his head swimming and how goddamn irresistible Katsuki was. He cursed how much of a lightweight he was.

“Kacchan,” he breathed.

“Tell me what you want from me,” Katsuki ordered, voice harsh. “You want to keep me company? Fine. Tell me what you want to do. I’ll fucking do anything.”

The words broke something in Izuku, crushing his self-restraint. Fine. If Katsuki wanted this, then who was Izuku to stop him? He’d only been dreaming about it for most of his life. He reached up, fingers winding through the blonde hair at the nape of Katsuki’s head. He pulled him down for a kiss, ready to face whatever consequences came of it.

Instead of warm lips, a hand slapped across his mouth. Izuku squeaked in protest, then realized Katsuki looked pissed.

“*Fuck*, no,” he growled, lips next to Izuku’s ear. “Can’t fool me. I’m not fucking kissing you drunk again, lil’ Deku.”

“B-but,” Izuku protested, his words muffled. Relenting for a moment, Katsuki’s hand slipped from his mouth, gripping his chin instead. Nearly wordless with desire, Izuku managed to say, “But I wanted you to-”

“Shh,” Katsuki hissed, dropping his head lower, mouth ghosting against the skin beneath his ear. “I’ve got other fucking things to do than kiss you.”

Izuku made some sort of strangled noise, trying to look at his expression, but Katsuki’s grip on his jaw tightened, forcing his chin up. Then Izuku felt him kiss the side of his neck. Then bite. His knees nearly gave out, and he was suddenly grateful Katsuki was helping support his weight. His hand threaded through Katsuki’s hair, his last three brain cells marveling at how soft it was.

“Izuku,” Katsuki whispered, pulling back. Izuku grabbed a handful of his hair, and pushed his face back into his neck. The man growled, and obediently went back to biting the sensitive skin, making his leisurely way down Izuku’s neck. Izuku stared at the ceiling, lost in pleasure. Bakugou Katsuki was kissing him, even if it was just his neck. It was heaven on earth, and he never wanted it to stop.

Katsuki’s hand finally dropped his from chin, moving to his sides, thoroughly feeling him up. “So fucking nice,” Katsuki whispered, nipping at the skin beneath Izuku’s jaw. He tried not to writhe with pleasure. “How you doing, lil’ Deku? Having a good fucking time? Enjoying my *company?* ”

Izuku whimpered, trying to find words. Katsuki pulled back, concern briefly flashing across his face. Never mind that he'd managed to push Izuku's shirt all the way up his chest, and at some point had unbuttoned his pants. He was an absolute menace. A menace who was starting to look worried.

"Deku?" Katsuki asked. Right. Izuku should say something. Anything.

"Don't stop," Izuku snapped, annoyed by the pause. Katsuki's eyes flew open. Izuku didn't care. He'd been dreaming of this for so damn long, and feeling Katsuki want him, Katsuki's hands on him… he wouldn't let anything stop this. He didn't care about the emotional fallout after, he didn't care about how his friends would judge him, he didn't care about looking desperately horny in front of Katsuki. He had what he wanted now, and he was going to take it.

"Deku," Katsuki rumbled, sounding approving. "You-"

Izuku grabbed the back of his neck, and pushed him back down to his neck. "Get back to work," he ordered. He was shaking, he realized. He was too turned on, too much adrenaline.

"Fucking Deku," Katsuki snarled, and with a thud, dropped to his knees. His hands slip up Izuku's sides as he licked a stripe down Izuku's abs. Shameless.

Looking down and seeing Katsuki's blond head between his legs was mind-blowing. It was all too easy to imagine Katsuki blowing him, and just the thought alone made his legs tremble. Katsuki's hands gripped his hips, steadying him. He rested his chin on the zipper of his pants, looking up. He was smiling, the smug bastard. Completely shameless. Izuku wanted to fuck that insufferable, cocky mouth.

"Tell me," Katsuki said, looking like he expected a medal. One hand crept between Izuku's legs, brushing over him. Just the light touch made Izuku shake. Fuck. He fisted his hands, trying to pull himself together. It was no use, as Katsuki purred, "Tell me what you want."

"Blow me," he choked out, cheeks burning with shame.

"There you go," Katsuki breathed, quickly unzipping his pants and yanking them down. Izuku whined with impatience, bucking into Katsuki's face, hands coming to uncertainly grab his hair. Katsuki's fingers tucked into the waistband of his underwear, giving it a gentle tug. "So good, Deku," he murmured. "You taste so good. Want more."

"Getting impatient, Kacchan," Izuku choked out. Katsuki shot him an amused glance, but agreeably pulled his underwear down. The cold was sudden. Then, even more shocking, was Katsuki's hot tongue running down the length of his cock. He was already rock hard, aching with need. He was too turned on to be embarrassed anymore.

"Fuck," Izuku hissed, hands gripping Katsuki's hair. He tried to keep still as Katsuki mouthed him, finally taking him all the way in. His mind was static, lost to the pleasure growing between his legs. "Please," he whispered, abs shaking with the effort not to move. He didn't want to make Katsuki uncomfortable, but the urge to move was overwhelming. Katsuki

pulled away from his cock, making an obscene slurping noise. He hated the absence of sensation.

He looked up at Izuku, mouth wet and open. “Deku,” he said, voice hoarse. “I’m fucking good at this. Don’t fucking hold back, idiot.”

“You-” Izuku gasped, eyes wide.

“Fuck my mouth,” Katsuki said, running his tongue across his lower lip.

“Shit,” Izuku mumbled, pushing himself against Katsuki’s lips. He gave a small, experimental thrust. Heaven. Katsuki was right, he was fucking good at this. His hands gripped Izuku’s hips, fingers digging into his flesh almost painfully, steadying him as Izuku thrust completely into his mouth. His eyes were open, just red slits, looking up at Izuku. Mind-blowingly hot.

Izuku couldn’t last like this. He just couldn’t. Even in his wildest fantasies, he’d never been able to imagine Bakugou Katsuki on his knees, mouth on his dick. Fucking hell.

“I’m going to come,” he gasped out, “You should-”

Katsuki growled, the sound vibrating against Izuku, and pulled his hips viciously into his face. The message was clear, and Izuku was too close to hold back. With a cry that sounded nearly like a sob, he came into Katsuki’s mouth, feeling the man swallow around him. Shuddering, he doubled over, fingers dropping from Katsuki’s head.

“Fuck,” he whispered. He was shaking as Katsuki waited him out, then gently pulled away, expertly pulling his underwear back up over him. He appreciated it; he was starting to feel horribly exposed. His mind was suddenly clear. What the fuck had he done? Katsuki had been drunk, he’d taken advantage of him, he’d… Katsuki’s voice interrupted his thoughts.

“Hey, lil’ Deku. How you doing?” He stood, looking down at Izuku. Izuku felt horribly vulnerable, pants around his ankles, shaking in the aftershock of his orgasm.

“I’m good,” he managed to say, bravely. Was he though? Izuku honestly didn’t know.

“Thought I was better than just fucking good,” Katsuki snorted. Izuku opened his mouth to say that no, Katsuki was the best, better than everyone, better than his wildest dreams, but before he could the other man continued, “But I’ll take it. Nothing wrong with room for improvement.”

“Hmm,” Izuku said, voice a little too high. Was this real? He was still struggling to wrap his head around what happened. Katsuki stepped away, stretching enormously.

“I feel fucking great,” he said, rolling his shoulders. The sight was magnificent, and Izuku marveled at his own ability to be so damn thirsty. He’d literally just been blown within an inch of his life, and he wanted nothing more than to eat Katsuki alive. The man in question yawned, jaw cracking. “Nothing like some action to clear your head.”

So that's what he was. Some *action* to push Katsuki's shitty thoughts out of his shitty head. Uraraka had been right to warn him. Izuku pulled his pants up, hands shaking. Katsuki turned, nearly tripping over his own feet. He glared at Izuku. "Nerd. I can hear your shitty thoughts from here. Whatcha thinking?"

"Nothing," Izuku sniffed, unhelpfully. "I'm going to clean up."

"Can I come?"

"No," Izuku said, a little too harshly, and Katsuki looked put out. Great, now he was the jerk. "Sorry," he said. "I'm just um, a little overwhelmed." And heartbroken, and used, and...

"Come here," Katsuki said. Izuku looked at him blankly. Katsuki sighed as if Izuku was stupid. "Where's your bed? We're going to fucking cuddle until you quit looking like I kicked your puppy."

"Why," Izuku muttered, leading the way to his bedroom regardless. Katsuki followed after him, large and shuffling. He sat on the edge of his bed nervously, but Katsuki bonelessly laid down, tugging Izuku onto his broad chest. "Why," he whispered again.

"Cause that shit was intense, idiot. It can be overwhelming for anyone." Katsuki pulled him tighter, pushing his face into the crook of his neck. Izuku hesitantly hugged him back. "There you go," Katsuki said quietly. "You know I'm gonna take care of you, right?"

"Mmm," Izuku said helplessly, burying his face in Katsuki's neck. He smelled faintly of sweat, Riesling, and smoke. What Bakugo was saying was too close to what he'd always wanted to hear. He was going to cry. He wanted Katsuki so damn badly, wanted him to be someone he could count on, someone he could say was *his* … God damn, he'd really done it now.

Katsuki gently stroked his back, apparently blissed out and completely immune to Izuku's silent meltdown. His regular breathing was strangely comforting, and eventually, despite the storm of thoughts in his head, Izuku drifted off to sleep.

Izuku woke up, feeling warm, safe, and boneless. It took him a couple of minutes to remember the night before, and he sat bolt upright. Then winced. Damn, he was hungover. He wondered if Katsuki was too. Katsuki. Katsuki who wasn't in his bed anymore.

Much faster than was reasonable, Izuku was out of bed and searching his apartment. It quickly became obvious that he was alone. Trying to not feel crushed, he looked around and saw a note on his table. It said,

Deku-

Saw the fucking press outside and left before they swarmed the place. Had a great time last night. Hoping you don't have any regrets, I definitely don't. This doesn't have to change

anything, k? I'm going home, just gonna work out and hide from the entire fucking internet. See you soon? Text me when you're up. Breakfast's in the fridge. You need to buy real groceries btw

-K

Izuku stared, trying to wrestle his feelings. Katsuki had had a great time last night? Blowing him. Fuck. He braced himself on the table, trying to get a grip. But then, he said that it didn't have to change anything? What would it change to? Did Katsuki want nothing to change?

Quickly realizing he was going to hopelessly overthink things, Izuku padded to the fridge to find out what breakfast was. Fried rice with peppers, and Katsuki had drawn a goddamn happy face on it with hot sauce. Izuku stood in the cool fridge air, blushing like an idiot.

Yep, he was a goner. Totally gone for Katsuki. He could only hope that his heart wouldn't end up in pieces, but at this point, he couldn't even bring himself to care.

Then came the next realization. If he wanted a relationship with Katsuki, how the hell did he go about it? Just ask him out? Get him to go on a date? Hadn't they done things out of order? Weren't kisses and dates supposed to come before late-night sloppy blow jobs?

Fuck. Katsuki on his knees, mouth open. Izuku realized he was still standing before the open fridge, and grabbed the fried rice, and slammed the door shut. The smiley face looked at him mockingly, as if it knew how much of a pervert he was. And the fried rice was delicious of course.

One cold shower later, Izuku decided it was a great time to do some stress baking. Oh, and he had to text Katsuki.

Izuku: *Morning. What do you spice your curry with?*

Kacchan: *Curry powder with chilies etc. Y?*

Izuku: *:)*

Kacchan: *Dont cook fcking shitty curry w/o me*

Izuku didn't deign to reply. Besides, he wasn't cooking curry, per se. Just curry buns, and then he was bringing them to Katsuki because he was such a good friend. Yep. A friend.

Katsuki had been right about the press. They were literally camped out in front of his building, but thankfully with his hood on, no one recognized him as he scooted past.

By the afternoon, he was done baking. The buns smelled amazing, and Izuku only tried two of them. To quality test. They were way too spicy for Izuku, which meant they should work for Katsuki.

Katsuki obligingly texted him his address, warning him that he was working out and would take a second to get to the door. Izuku was reminded of all the times he'd gone over to Katsuki's house as a kid. He'd been terrified by all the yelling at first, until he realized there was no ill-will behind it. Maybe that was why he'd never been as affected by Katsuki's loud nature. No, it was never the shouting or cursing that had bothered him. It had been Katsuki's complete denial of their friendship, the intentionally cruel words, the way he'd pushed him away.

Damn, Izuku was making himself nervous. Still, he made it to Katsuki's place without incident. He lived deeper downtown than Izuku, just outside of his sector, in a modern-looking apartment complex. Nervous, he hit the code Katsuki had texted him. Sure enough, he was buzzed in. An elevator took him to the seventh floor, and somehow Izuku ended up in front of Katsuki's door. He took a deep breath and rang the bell. No answer.

Izuku: *I'm here?*

Another couple of seconds, then he heard feet pounding on the ground. Katsuki opened the door suddenly. Izuku froze at the sight of him. He *had* been working out. He was breathing hard, skin glistening with sweat. He wore a sweat-drenched, relatively transparent white tank top and low riding sweatpants, and looked illegally good.

"Brought you something," Izuku mumbled. Katsuki blinked at him.

"Fuck, Deku, come on in." He stepped aside, giving Izuku a view of his place. It was a fairly typical apartment, and was surprisingly tidy with black countertops and framed artwork. Once again, Izuku was faced with just how much his friend had changed over the years.

"You were right about the press," Izuku said, a little self-consciously, setting the basket on the table. He could feel Katsuki staring at his back. "They were all over the place when I left."

He finally turned, only to find Katsuki right in front of him. He jerked his chin up, refusing to be intimidated. Katsuki had the strangest expression on his face, like he was trying to hold back a laugh. He'd somehow expected Katsuki to be angrier, or sulkier, or even hornier after how he was acting the night before.

"Is everything okay?" He ventured.

"Did they," Katsuki said, wheezing slightly, "Did the press recognize you?"

"No?"

Katsuki broke down in laughter. "That's good, because holy shit, Deku. Did you look in the mirror today?"

Izuku hadn't, actually. He'd studiously avoided it, because he couldn't face himself yet. "Um…"

Katsuki stepped in, reaching out. Izuku stood stock still. He wasn't drunk, now. Was Katsuki finally going to kiss him? Instead, he merely took ahold of Izuku's chin, gently lifting it. His eyes were dropped to Izuku's mouth, one thumb drifting over his bottom lip. Izuku was boneless in his grip. Damn, Katsuki affected him way too much. It was embarrassing. Then Katsuki took out his phone.

"Can I take a picture?"

"Sure, I guess? Why?" Izuku's eyes were wide. He had no idea what was going on, but he wasn't about to stop it, not if it meant Katsuki touching him. Katsuki lined up the shot, hand still lifting his jaw.

"Fuck, that's hot," he muttered, then turned the screen towards Izuku. Izuku saw a picture of himself. At first, all he could notice was how Katsuki's hand looked on him, and how pathetically turned on Izuku looked. Then he saw his neck. It was absolutely covered in hickeys, on both sides, from his collar bones to his ears. Oh no. Oh god, no. Izuku flushed from his neck to his forehead.

"Oh my god," he groaned. "Kacchan, why? Why would you do this to meee?"

Katsuki was back to snickering again. "Fucking couldn't help it," he laughed. "Oh, Deku, it's so bad. Jesus Christ. I'd say sorry, but I'm fucking not."

Izuku shoved him away, then covered his face. "How can I go to work like this," he whined.

"Oh relax, nerd," Katsuki said, stifling laughter. "I've got a great concealer for this. You can borrow it for as long as you need. Let me go shower and I'll grab it for you."

Izuku glared at him, both touched and very annoyed. "It had better work, or it's your ass on the line."

"Keep dreaming about my ass, nerd," Katsuki said, padding off to the bathroom. "Make yourself at home!"

While Katsuki showed, Izuku checked himself out in his camera's selfie mode. He managed to count eleven individual hickeys. God, it was like he was a teenager. Except he'd never even gotten hickeys as a teenager, because apparently teen Izuku was more damn professional than adult Izuku. He groaned. What was he getting into? He didn't need to ask how Katsuki had concealer for this on hand, either. It was all too easy to imagine everyone in the goddamn city thirsting after that neck.

His phone buzzed.

Ochako <3: *Hey, saw you and BK left early last night. Everything good?*

Bless her for checking in. Was everything good? Izuku had no idea, but he was buzzing with energy.

Izuku: *Kacchan just wanted to get away for a bit, so I went with. Everything's fine :)*

Ochako <3: *Was it about the rankings? I saw when I was looking at Iidas, I bet he was pretty pissed*

Izuku: *It was pretty rough I think :/*

Ochako <3: *Yeah but Deku, have you checked today. It went VIRAL. Like, hard core. Jirou had to turn off notifications on Cheeper*

Izuku opened the internet, and was immediately assaulted by the BOOM video. It was about 4:00 PM, and since the night before the video had hit… 100 million views? Izuku's jaw dropped. Holy shit. His stomach dropped. Katsuki was finally seeming happier, but if this had knocked him entirely the off of the top thirty…

Throat dry, Izuku checked the rankings. He scrolled down quickly, and saw Katsuki's name wasn't at #30. He felt cold, angry. How dare they. How dare they throw out all of his hard work over something so stupid? Angrily, he scrolled back up, resenting all the heros who hadn't had their ambition ruined by some stupid video. Then he saw Katsuki's name. #16, right behind Izuku.

What? He paged back to the news, spotting a headline saying, *Ground Zero's Popularity Explodes After Viral Video Makes Angry Hero Approachable*

Damn. It was good news, technically, though he couldn't predict how Katsuki would feel about his popularity being defined by a video, even if it was positive.

Katsuki finally came back, dressed in a simple green t-shirt and sweats. Still looking ridiculously good. Izuku glared at him. How dare he.

"Here, I'll put it on for you," Katsuki said without preface, whipping a tube out of his pocket. Izuku sat perfectly still as Katsuki carefully dabbed the cool concealer on his neck with a small sponge. It was strangely intimate. Izuku just wished Katsuki would kiss him, or something, but the other man remained focused on his task, the tip of his tongue poking out in concentration.

Cute.

"There," he said, finally. "You'd never know I practically ate you alive last night." The last bit was accompanied by a sharp grin. All of Izuku's thoughts about hero rankings went straight out the window. Katsuki seemed completely unaffected. "You know, I love a good mark, but I'm not usually that fucking bad."

"Mmm," Izuku mumbled.

"Hey," Katsuki said, leaning in. "We all good? I'm worried I came on too fucking strong and you're freaking out, or something."

"When am I not freaking out?" Izuku sighed. "No, it's fine. I was actually worried I took advantage of you, cause you were all drunk and sad and…"

Katsuki looked at him appraisingly. “You’re fucking sweet, Deku, but you didn’t take advantage of me. You think I can get that drunk off half a bottle of shitty wine, huh?”

“Guess not,” Izuku mumbled. Katsuki stretched again, groaning. The sound went straight to Izuku’s libido. “Look, about the rankings,” Izuku began.

Katsuki waved him off. “Don’t worry about it, nerd. I was pissed last night, but it’s fucking fine. I climbed up before and I’ll damn well do it again.” Izuku’s mouth dropped open. That was the Katsuki he knew, and it was really, really attractive.

Katsuki cracked his knuckles, expression thunderous. “You were right, before. I can’t expect to be #1 if I just fuck around doing my own shitty thing. People want a fucking nice Ground Zero? I’ll mind my fucking- I'll mind my goddamn,” he sighed. “I’ll mind my blessed manners. And maybe then they’ll see that I can be at the top.”

Izuku’s heart twisted. Somehow, this wasn’t at all how he wanted things to go. He cleared his throat. “I just, um, well I checked the rankings today?”

Katsuki’s expression went thunderous. “What the fuck am I know? Negative six hundred?”

“Sixteen,” Izuku said, swallowing. Katsuki cocked his head.

“Sixty?”

“Sixteen,” Izuku repeated, then added, “Just one spot behind me.”

“I’d love to be in a spot behind you,” Katsuki said automatically, but clearly didn’t have his heart in the innuendo. He looked lost in thought. “Fucking why am I #16?”

“I haven’t looked at all the news, but I guess people liked you in the video,” Izuku said, blushing for some reason. Maybe because *he* liked Katsuki in the video. The truth was he liked that Katsuki had a horrible personality, he liked how much he swore, that he took absolutely no bullshit from anyone, ever. He never wanted to see that change.

“No way,” Katsuki said, expression shifting from wondering to angry and back again.

“Look, Kacchan, about what I said earlier…”

“Hmm?” Katsuki had already wandered away, poking at the basket. “What’s this? You bring me some food?”

“You made breakfast,” Izuku said, momentarily side tracked. “They’re curry buns,” Izuku said. Katsuki’s stare switched to him.

“You’re the perfect fucking man,” he said, then vigorously dug into the basket, making Izuku blush again. So much blushing couldn’t be good for his circulation, or something. Katsuki found a bun and shoved the whole thing in his mouth, sighing in pleasure.

“Wait, Kacchan, I was trying to say something,” Izuku protested.

“Best head of your life or what?” Katsuki said, voice muffled around the bun. Izuku glared.

“Shut up. I’m being serious.” Katsuki waved a hand, inviting him to go on, but stuffing yet another bun in his stupid, handsome face. Izuku took a deep breath. “Kacchan, what I said earlier, about you being nice and stuff?”

“Yeah, yeah, I heard you,” he mumbled around his food. “Gonna be a nice lil’ hero.”

“ *No* ,” Izuku said, trembling slightly. He was getting louder, but he couldn’t stop. “You shouldn’t. You are who you are, Kacchan. I *like* who you are, okay? And why the hell can’t you get to #1 while being a complete asshole? Aren’t you strong enough? Can’t you show this stupid country that no matter what, no one can compare to you?”

He finished his rant, hands clenched. Katsuki was staring at him, eyes wide. He looked absolutely floored. A piece of bun fell out of his mouth. After a pause, he swallowed hurriedly.

“Fucking hell, Izuku,” he said. Izuku shivered at the sound of his name. Katsuki slid around the counter, and pulled Izuku into a tight hug. He yelped in surprise, but let it happen. “Fucking hell, Izuku,” Katsuki repeated, softer. He pulled back, taking Izuku’s face in his hands. “That’s what you really think?”

“Yes,” Izuku whispered emphatically, meeting his eyes. “Show everyone they can’t stop you. Take this whole goddamn city.”

“Fine then,” Katsuki said, his grin gaining a dangerous edge. “I’ll fucking wipe the floor with these losers.”

Izuku was grinning up at him, happy to see his friend back to normal. If normal was the right word - Katsuki looked incandescent, motivated. Beautiful. He half-turned away, as if lost in thought, but Izuku was high on success and adrenaline and his impulsiveness would not be stopped.

“And if you don’t kiss me right now, I’m going to kick your ass all the way to the USA,” he said, lifting his chin. Katsuki’s head whipped around, eyes narrowed.

“Deku,” he snarled, one hand snaking out and grabbing the back of his neck. In an instant, Katsuki had pulled him flush with his body. The other man leaned own, his hand cradling Izuku’s cheek. Izuku met his eyes in wonderment. “So damn pretty,” Katsuki whispered, then leaned in.

The kiss was gentle at first, an achingly sweet brush of the lips. Trembling, Izuku lifted his chin, leaning into it. And then Katsuki was kissing him hard, fingers catching in his hair, pushing him back, back, until his back thumped against the wall. Katsuki's hands dropped down, grabbing his ass and then hoisted him up effortlessly. Izuku obligingly wrapped his legs around Katsuki, leaning down to kiss him. Katsuki was merciless, head tilted up, kissing, biting. Izuku was utterly lost in the moment. He never wanted to be anywhere else, just here, kissing Katsuki, forever.

Eventually they stopped, breathing hard. Izuku was lost in the sight of Katsuki glaring up at him.

The moment lasted right up until Katsuki said, “Rate me, bitch.”

Izuku blinked at him, mind barely working. Then it sunk in, and Izuku dissolved in laughter. Maybe it was because he was releasing the pent up tension, the worry, the desire, but Izuku leaned back against the wall and howled in laughter. Growling, Katsuki gently lowered him to the floor. Izuku steadied himself with a hand on Katsuki’s chest, wiping tears of laughter from his eyes.

“Oh my god, Kacchan, you’re so-”

“I’m so what? Give me a fucking number, nerd. If it’s less than 10/10 I’m going to fucking murder you.”

Izuku dissolved into giggles again. “Okay, okay, fine. You get a million, alright? A million out of ten. Now leave me alone before I die of laughter.”

“Damn straight I do,” Katsuki huffed, backing up.

Izuku was still giggling helplessly, but he was so damn happy. Katsuki had *kissed* him, and he might actually have a chance. He might actually have a chance to get what he always had wanted. He looked at Katsuki, who’d wandered inevitably back to the curry buns. Yep, he was done. He’d found the person he wanted to spend the rest of his life with, and all he had to do was win him over.

Chapter End Notes

Eyyooo! They did it! I guess usually people kiss before going down on someone, but Bakugou takes his ratings very seriously and couldn't afford the risk of a low rating due to shitty Reisling :/

This is the absolute first time I've ever let anyone read any explicit thing I've written, and now I've posted it all over the internet! Terrifying. I really really hope you guys enjoy this chapter, now excuse me while I go die of embarrassment in a corner :^)

Semi-Cheerful with a Hint of Homicide

Chapter Summary

> Kirishima is loud, Mina gets blackmail material, Kaminari gets insulted (sorry Denki) and Bakugou lends Izuku a hand.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Katsuki, Katsuki, Katsuki. Izuku was walking on clouds. His whole life had taken on a tinge of the unreal, as if Katsuki himself had blasted reality away with the palms of his hands.

He wasn't what to call their connection or where it was going, but Izuku damn well knew where he wanted it to go. But how do you ask out Bakugou Katsuki? Fireworks that said *'I've been in love with you my entire life?'* Bring him to a curry store? Take him rock climbing, give him a heart-shaped rock? Izuku was rapidly becoming aware that the more he thought about this, the worse his ideas were getting.

He should just ask Katsuki out, specifically on a date. And he would have, he totally would have, except for one small thing. Katsuki might say *no.* Was it likely? Izuku had no idea, but he figured Katsuki at least liked him a little after sucking his damn soul out through his dick.

But did Katsuki want a relationship? Had he ever had any? Maybe he didn't date, period? The real question was if Izuku could handle rejection from Katsuki, and the answer was a resounding *no* . Maybe if Izuku was patient, Katsuki would spare him the agony and just ask him out.

And then there was the press. After the BOOM debacle, they were practically hunting Katsuki down with pitchforks. He seemed to be handling it fine, the same way he always did: forcibly shoving people out of the way while cursing wildly. If Izuku was being honest, it was actually amazing Katsuki was even in the top thirty with that behavior. Izuku never wanted him to stop. It was like watching a tornado tear through a town, terrifying, exhilarating, and he couldn't bear to look away.

Still, due to the press and a very drawn-out lightning storm, it was a while before Izuku saw Katsuki again. Kirishima had invited everyone out to "boy's night," and because it was Kirishima, everyone was invited. The man was possibly even friendlier than Deku, and couldn't bear to leave the girls out. That wouldn't be "manly," apparently.

It was pouring out, but Izuku made it to the tavern relatively dry thanks to his completely ridiculous frog-shaped umbrella. It had been a gift from Tsu, and technically matched his

color scheme so… You just didn't turn Tsu down for things. It wasn't done.

Izuku shook out the umbrella and was immediately wrapped in a hug by Kirishima, hoisted in the air, and spun around.

"Bro," he said, meaningfully. He set Izuku down gently. Not that many people could lift Izuku like he was a kitten, but Kirishima was built like a semi-truck. "Bro," he repeated again, then wiggled his eyebrows. Oh. Katsuki's friend. Oh, no.

"What did Kacchan tell you?"

"Nothing!" Kirishima nearly screamed. "He's so impossible! But I know something happened because the bastard's been smug as all hell and it's driving everyone nuts."

Kaminari appeared over his shoulder, looking friendly. If Kirishima was an outgoing, friendly golden retriever, Kaminari was the stupid, adorable puppy that tried to hump people's legs. Both of them, adorable. Kaminari said, "Specifically driving Eijiro nuts. Please tell us, Deku. He literally won't shut up about it and I'm this close to losing my mind." He held up two fingers pressed together.

So Izuku was led very firmly by the two back to a booth, where Mina sat, looking deeply pleased with herself. She was sipping something pink, and gave Izuku the 'sup,' nod.

"Ready to get interrogated?" She grinned.

"No," Izuku said emphatically. "I'm dead if I say anything."

"Say anything about *what* ," Kirishima groaned, just as Kaminari added,

"Ah, death. The French word for orgasm is 'the little death,' did you know?" A pause, as Kaminari sat him down forcibly in the booth. "Did you know that?" He repeated, with an attempt at being menacing. Good luck. Nothing looked menacing if you were used to Bakugou Katsuki.

Everyone jumped as the restaurant's door slammed shut. Katsuki stood in the doorway, absolutely soaked and absolutely pissed off. Behind him, reporters were clamoring at the door. He stalked over to the table, cursing under his breath, finally flopping down next to Kirishima. Kaminari gave him one look, then returned to Izuku.

"So, as I was saying, the French word for *orgasm* -"

"Nope," Izuku said, slapping a hand over Kaminari's mouth. "Nope, interrogation over."

"You losers interrogating Deku?" Katsuki growled, looking exactly like a wet dog. Izuku smiled at him. He was Izuku's savior, his knight in shining armor, his foul-mouthed benefactor, he was perfection right up until he added, "Sounds like fun, I'm in."

"Kacchan," Izuku groaned, covering his face. So much for that.

“Katsuki! That’s no way to treat your…” Kirishima trailed off suggestively, as if that would trick Katsuki into explaining their relationship. Deku would love to hear what Katsuki would fill that blank with, but he only said,

“Treat my nerd? Little shit had it coming, let's do this.”

“Kacchan...”

“Yes, nerd?”

“I hate you!” Izuku glared. Katsuki put his chin on his hand, ignoring whatever Kirishima was trying to say to him.

“Yeah, yeah, that's old fucking news. So what are we talking about? I haven’t seen you since we kissed.” Izuku froze.

Kirishima dropped his drink in shock, and without even trying to clean the spill, threw his arms in the air and shouted, “Brooooo! You ballsy bastard! You finally did it!” Then he dove across the table and grabbed a very surprised Izuku’s hands. “Deku, sweet Deku. Was he good to you? Did he-”

Kirishima jerked forwards as Katsuki smacked the back of his head. “Oy, shitty hair, don’t scare him.”

Izuku was a little shell-shocked, but then, why had he expected anything different? Katsuki didn’t even exist in the same dictionary as *subtle.* The single, glaring exception being how he guarded All Might’s secret, but that clearly did not apply here. Katsuki leaned back in his chair, grinning like the asshole he was.

“I got that on video,” Mina said, leaning on the table. “How much you paying me to not post it, Baku *ho?* #BringDatAssBack is trending right now, I could get tons of recheeps. ”

“I’ll pay you by not toasting your corpse over a fire,” Bakugo snapped, his grin instantly replaced with a snarl. Then he switched tactics. “Besides, look at that sad little face. You wouldn’t hurt poor Deku, right?” He pointed at Izuku, who responded with his best death glare. Not that Izuku’s death glares were anything to write home about.

“I’ll just keep it as blackmail for now,” Mina said with a smirk. “And *only* because Midoriya does not deserve to be caught up in your bullshit.”

“You are such a nice person, Mina,” Izuku praised her, just knowing it would bug Katsuki. He was right, as Katsuki leaned back with an impressive sulk. Unfair, that he could make sulking so cute.

“I am,” she grinned, then proved it by changing the subject ham-handedly. “So, how about this weather? Think there’s a villain behind it?”

“Yes,” Kaminari said, uncharacteristically solemn. “The static tastes weird.”

“Fuckin’ electric freak,” Katsuki responded, acting like this was a helpful thing to say.

“No, really! It’s been striking really specific things, too. Like it’s maximizing structural damage.”

“I love it when you use big words,” Kirishima interjected, grinning at the other man. “Did the Association say anything yet, though? I haven’t heard about any new major villains.”

“I’ve got one,” Katsuki said. “Bastard’s some kind of earth-munching weirdo, though. He’s so deep underground we can’t track him right now. Driving me up a wall, but definitely not related to the weather shit.”

“So nothing about the lightning though, huh,” Izuku murmured, his mind turning everything over. Kaminari was right, actually. Lightning should be going to the plentiful lightning rods over the city, but instead hit things like bridge supports or power plants. If there was a villain involved, they were very powerful. Realizing he’d been spacing out, he looked up. Katsuki was watching him, an almost fond expression on his face. Izuku’s heart beat just that much faster.

They left the place in high spirits, Kirishima leading the charge to desserts. Izuku very generously allowed Katsuki under his frog umbrella. Sure, Katsuki only accepted the offer after he realized that it would hide him from the press, but he didn’t protest as much as he could have.

While the others dashed ahead, they walked leisurely under the umbrella. Izuku decided it was time to be brave, and ask something he’d been wanting to for ages.

“Kacchan?”

“Sup, Deks?” Katsuki looked down at him sharply, and Izuku was suddenly awash with the memory of his lips. It had been too long, in Izuku’s opinion.

“You want to start training again?”

“I’m always fucking training,” he snorted. “What do you think I’ve been so goddamn busy with?”

“Training with me,” Izuku clarified with saintly patience. Katsuki could be surprisingly sensitive, but sometimes it was like talking to a brick wall.

“Oh.” Katsuki slowed to a stop. “It’s been forever, hasn't it? When did we last spar?”

“A training match televised for viewers six years ago on the PLU Network, but they had to cut to commercial when it got too heated and the match ended prematurely,” Izuku recited promptly. He was basically an encyclopedia on the topic, at this point. Katsuki snorted, shaking the umbrella with his laugh.

“Shit, you’re right. What did I do again?”

“You held me down and set off an explosion point-blank in my face,” Izuku said, annoyance lacing his tone. It was a sore point for him because, “They cut to commercial before they could show me kicking your sorry ass into the stands.”

“Mmm, that was a good hit,” Katsuki nodded, looking strangely pleased. “My hit, that is. Fuck, I want to see what you can do now. Got any more nerd books filled out on me?” Izuku did, actually, but he would not admit it.

“You wish. Think you can take me now, #16?” Izuku gave him a sassy grin. It was the wrong thing to say, or maybe the right thing to say, because Katsuki yanked him into an alleyway, and shoved him up against a wall.

It had happened before, many times, when they were kids, albeit in a much less pleasant way. “I’m damn well planning to find out,” he said, voice low and forceful. Izuku swallowed hard. He’d always expected Katsuki to be a rough kisser, but he hadn’t lived up to it so far. Operative words being ‘so far.’

“Any day now,” Izuku whispered. Apparently Katsuki’s prior tenderness didn’t hold up in rain-soaked alleyways after dark, because the man kissed him hard enough his head cracked against the concrete behind him. Katsuki didn’t let up, deepening the kiss for a moment before pulling back, breathing hard, pupils blown wide with desire. Irresistible.

“Your head?” It took Izuku a second to process what he was saying.

“S’ fine,” Izuku muttered, pulling Katsuki back in. The frog umbrella was dropped into the mud as Katsuki devoted both hands to the effort of pinning Izuku against the wall. Izuku couldn’t feel the cold, the rain hitting his face, the only things that existed were the hard body pressed against his, the thick thigh pushing between his legs. The feeling of his wrists pushed against rough concrete next to his shoulders, the way Katsuki was moaning into his mouth.

“Yooo!” they heard in the distance. Izuku glanced over, seeing an over-excited Kirishima waving, Kaminari in tow.

“Kacchan,” he protested. “Our friends...”

“One sec,” Katsuki said, eyes never leaving Izuku’s. He took one hand, extended it towards their friends, and slowly, deliberately flipped them off. Izuku blushed hard, whatever he was about to say interrupted as Katsuki kissed him again, his mouth soft and sweet. He pulled away gently, smirking like the devil. “That’s better,” he said, and picked up the umbrella. “Dessert?”

“Mmhm,” Izuku said, gathering up his remaining brain cells and hoping he could use them later. He was much more lucid by the time they reached their friends, and ready to be humiliated.

“First fucker who says something gets their face melted,” Katsuki said, cheerfully. Or what passed as cheerful for him, which was sort of semi-cheerful with a hint of homicide. Kirishima wiped away tears, as Kaminari patted his back.

“So happy for you, bro.”

Katsuki handed the umbrella to Izuku so he could flip Kirishima off with both hands, but the gesture felt more good-natured than not.

Training ended up being a great idea, because the press was strictly forbidden from any Hero Association grounds. That, and Izuku actually wanted to try his hand at fighting Katsuki. He spent the morning warming up and stretching, figuring he’d need all the prep he could get. Katsuki was there early, because he’s always punctual for hero-related things. When Izuku arrived, he was stretching gloriously in the studio. Izuku paused in the doorway, admiring the sight.

“We gotta use the arena outside,” Katsuki said by way of hello. Izuku watching his muscles straining as he leaned to the side, rolling one shoulder. “I’m banned from the indoor courts because I exceeded the shitty repair budget.”

“How many times?”

“Four,” Katsuki laughed. “Come here."

Izuku found himself stepping forward before he could even decide to. Katsuki stepped in, one finger under his chin. Izuku only had a second to process before he was being kissed, teasingly. Then he felt one large hand shamelessly squeeze his ass, and he scuttled away, yelping. Time for revenge.

“Kacchan?”

“Yeah?” Katsuki looked pleased with himself, like a cat who’d knocked something off a shelf. In this case, that something was Izuku’s sense of pride.

“I’m gonna kick your ass,” Izuku said once he’d reached a safe distance. Maybe he did know his old friend after all, because he was already running when Katsuki launched himself across the room.

Being chased by Katsuki is a little scary, even if Izuku knew it was friendly. The man was enormous, and ran through the halls like a velociraptor in Jurassic Park - skidding, sliding, all teeth and menace and perpetually seconds away from catching him. Too bad for him that Izuku was fast as hell, and he made it to the outdoor arena entirely unscathed. Katsuki was laughing as they stumbled to a halt in the arena.

“You got faster, nerd. What're the terms?”

Izuku knew what he meant. “All out, barring major property damage,” he said pointedly. Katsuki snickered.

“You’re on, loser. Prepare to get crushed.” He rolled his neck, vertebrae popping grotesquely loud. “Say when.”

Izuku was glad he'd stretched at home. He could feel the adrenaline building; it had been a while since he'd been in an all-out brawl. "Go," he said.

Katsuki cannoned forwards instantly, a mere flash of blonde and red. Izuku jerked out of the way, Full Cowling flickering to life. Damn, Katsuki was fast. The follow up attack came just as fast, redirected by gratuitous explosions. Izuku dashed away effortlessly, because he was fast too. Not fast enough - Katsuki once again changed course effortlessly, a hand full of explosions pushing him into an airborne rotation that ended with a nasty haymaker to the side of Izuku's head.

It *hurt* , and Izuku rocketed to the ground, landing hard on his side. His breath whooshed out, as he watched Katsuki gracefully vault out of the air to a hard landing.

"That all you got?" Katsuki shouted. With a shrug of his shoulders, his hands engulfed in flames, smoke tricking up his shoulders in twin plumes. "Fucking fight me!" His hoarse scream echoed in the silence of the arena.

Izuku swallowed hard, realizing with a flash of guilt that he hadn't taken this as seriously as Katsuki obviously was. Gritting his teeth, he amped up Full Cowling, the power flickering through his body. It felt like burning lines of pure adrenaline, heat, *energy* . Katsuki launched himself forwards again, arcing up, clearly planning to come down in a finishing blow - he was showboating, now.

Izuku waited, nerves screaming, until Katsuki's momentum was fully committed. Then, lightning-fast, he rolled onto his shoulders and pushed his feet skywards with all of his core strength. That is to say, a metric fuck-ton of strength. His feet connected with Katsuki's jaw, hurling him off to the side. He rolled to a stop, covered in dirt. Izuku didn't wait for him to get up; he'd learned that mistake long ago. If you wanted to beat Katsuki, you better hit him while he's down.

Katsuki pushed himself out of the way just in time, kicking up a cloud of dust. Spitting blood, he locked eyes with Izuku. In that moment, they understood each other perfectly. It was electric - and the fight was on.

Izuku quit running and elected for the risky choice of close combat with Ground Zero. Taking direct hits would cause too much damage, so his game was to always evade, counter-attack, adjust. He didn't have the same kind of distance attacks that Katsuki did, so this was a technically better match up. But Katsuki was a smart fighter, which made things difficult. His ability to predict Izuku's movements, to adjust his strategy on the fly, and raw damage output were overwhelming - they would be overwhelming to almost anyone. The air quickly filled with the smell of nitroglycerin, sweat, and smoke. Izuku could die happy in that smell.

But he was too invigorated to be distracted, even for an instant. His laser focus had always been an asset, and he was reading Katsuki's updated fighting style even as he kept up with the fight. He landed the next major hit - a kick to the shin that sent Katsuki horribly off-balance, falling forwards, body in an uncontrolled spin. Izuku meant to follow up with a strike to the back of his descending head, but Katsuki whisked himself out of the way, coming full circle to stomp Izuku's chest point-blank. He staggered back, barely blocking another explosive strike.

After a few hits, neither of them were nimble enough to evade every strike, and it became a test of endurance. Full Cowling made Izuku's body impossibly strong, and he weathered the repeated strikes. Despite being massively strong, Katsuki couldn't take the same kind of damage Izuku could, and he began to steadily lose ground. Izuku followed up with a steady supply of heavy strikes, sweat flying, green lightning crackling over his limbs. It felt damn good.

Caught up in the moment, he didn't notice Katsuki's expression change. He should have been watching it; Katsuki has possibly the worst poker face in existence. Because the instant his expression changed from vicious focus to a sneer of victory, Izuku should have been on high alert.

So he wasn't prepared when Katsuki snatched one of his strikes out of the air, and flung him away. He followed up with something Izuku had only rarely seen - a long-range, focused explosion. The travel time was nearly instantaneous, and Izuku was engulfed in blinding heat and smoke before he could regain his footing. He desperately threw himself to the side, running laterally. Instantly, Katsuki switched arms, unleashing another roiling beam of smoke and fire. It hit Izuku in the hip, knocking him off his feet. Another, double-handed plume of fire hurtled towards him - in the last few moments, Iuzku realized it was a move that Katsuki couldn't afford to use in close combat - it was too risky to keep both of his weapons occupied. Now, though? It was perfect.

Izuku, already down, was blown backward another few feet by the blast, swallowed by smoke and fire. Eyes watering, he struggled to get up. A sliver of blue sky split the smoke as it cleared, and a second later Katsuki came crashing down through it. One smoking hand grabbed Izuku's face, slammed him back into the ground. Katsuki landed hard, knees on either side of Izuku's shoulders, hunched over and grinning in victory.

"Yield?" he said, eyes burning into Izuku's. He desperately tried not to be turned on, and nearly succeeded.

"Yield," Izuku coughed. Katsuki rolled off him, flopping into the dust. Izuku waited for the inevitable gloating. Ultimately, he was pissed about losing, and he couldn't pinpoint why it was bothering him so much.

"That was fucking good," Katsuki said, filling the silence. "You're not too bad for #15."

"You're #16," Izuku snapped, pushing himself upright. His whole body ached. It was painful, but mostly with the way any good workout is painful, though his ears were ringing from hitting the ground so hard.

"Not for long, if I can beat you like that," Katsuki snickered, rolling onto his side. "So, Deku, what're your notes?"

"What?"

"I know you've got notes rolling around in that giant head of yours, nerd." He stood, stretching leisurely. "I'm going to be fucking #1 soon, Deks, and I want that dorky-ass hero analysis backing me up."

Izuku didn't have notes though, and it felt wrong. Everything felt wrong, actually, and suddenly he was tearing up. He should be happy that Katsuki wanted him to analyze the fight, but he just couldn't do it. He angrily pressed the heels of his hands into his eyes, wishing Katsuki wouldn't see.

"Shit, Deku, did I hurt you?" Katsuki scooted over to crouch in front of Izuku, but the concern made his eyes water more.

"No, Kacchan, I…" he faltered.

"Damn, Deku, I was just talking shit. You were great, okay?"

"I don't want compliments," Izuku insisted, finding his resolve. "It's not deserved. I haven't properly sparred in so long that I didn't even- I wasn't able to go as hard as I should have. I didn't even learn anything from it."

"Well, you've got me now," Katsuki grinned, as if that solved everything.

"That's not it," Izuku said, emphatically. "Why haven't I been sparring with anyone? Why have I been content with putting away low-tier villains and running whatever miscellaneous crap I'm assigned? What have I been *doing* ? I'm never going to matter like this! I'm never going to mean anything!" Shit, he was crying now. He pushed his hands against his eyes, as if he could force his tears back in.

Katsuki watched him, face grave. "Fuck if I know, Deku. We've both failed, haven't we?" He leaned back heavily on his elbows. He always avoided using his hands after a fight. Izuku always wondered if they got sore from all the abuse he put them through. Palm-striking things was rough, no matter how much reinforcement his Quirk provided.

"What do you mean?"

"Just look at me," Katsuki scoffed. "Fucking bitching about falling in rankings? I haven't even *liked* myself in ages, isn't that fucking funny? Most goddamn self-obsessed guy around doesn't even give a shit about himself."

"It's not funny," Izuku muttered, wondering where this was going.

"I think it's just growing up," Katsuki grumbled. "It's one thing to say you'll be at the top when you're a shitty kid, but it's not like you can do anything about it then. So what if you ace some tests? Win some tournaments? We've only been able to actually chase that goal that since getting licensed and eligible for rankings, anyway. And what have I done since then? Nothing, except what the fuckers at HQ told me to."

"It's true," Izuku said, sniffing. "I just get so caught up with doing everything perfectly. I can't stand failure. I stopped even thinking about if the things I was doing perfectly were actually what I should be focusing on, you know?"

"Yeah, I did the same shit." Katsuki's voice was hoarse, full of self-recrimination. "But hitting #30 again was the last straw for me. It's great that I'm #16 and all, but I'm done

fucking around. I know what I want - I've wanted it my whole fucking life. I'm going to do whatever it fucking takes, and I'm going get to the top."

He stared Izuku down like it was a promise. It was unbearably intense, and Izuku felt the need to meet Katsuki's words with his own. "I want to be the best," Izuku replied. "Being at the top is great and all, but I want to be what people imagine when they say the word 'hero.' I want my very existence to stop people from taking the wrong path, to guide people towards being the best version of themselves."

"Fucking cheesy," Katsuki said, but he said it with a smile. "So whatcha gonna do about it?"

"Everything," Izuku said. "Train. I'm going to take interns. I'm going to insist on getting bigger assignments. I'm going to push myself every day to be better."

"Damn straight," Katsuki grinned. "I've got your back, ya hear?"

Izuku's heart was suddenly beating faster. It was everything he'd wanted as a kid. Katsuki there for him, listening to his fears and his dreams, supporting him. He swallowed hard, crossing the distance despite the ache in his limbs. He crawled on top of the reclining man, and rested his forehead against Katsuki's. "You're amazing, Kacchan," he whispered.

"That's fucking right," he said, voice gravelly. Pushing himself up on his forearms, he leaned up and stole a kiss. His mouth tasted like blood and dirt, but Izuku kissed him back anyway. He could feel the vibrations in Katsuki's chest as he said, "Hell, I could get used to this."

The words echoed around in Izuku's head. *I could get used to this.* The implication was clear, right? Katsuki wanted him around, at least in the foreseeable future. Despite the residual pain from their sparring, despite Izuku's own fear of failure, it made him feel invincible.

They showered in the locker room, and even Katsuki seemed too exhausted to make a move. Post-shower, Izuku found Katsuki sitting on one of the benches, scrolling through his phone. He'd thrown on a tight tank top that lovingly hugged his muscles, and old gray UA sweats. Izuku tried not to be thirsty, and failed spectacularly.

"Whatcha doing?" Izuku stood before him, starting to feel a bit awkward as he very noticeably checked Katsuki out. But it was okay now, right? He didn't need to hide it anymore.

"Looking at this viral bullshit. I called Jeanist up earlier to talk about how I could handle it, and the idiot nearly shat himself in excitement."

"He...what?"

"Said something about me finally pulling my head out of my asshole and coming to him for help like I should have years ago," Katsuki snorted. "He's probably right. He usually is."

"What are you planning?"'

“Not sure yet,” Katsuki replied, finally looking up, and he met Izuku’s eyes. Izuku knew that look, and it meant trouble.

“Come here,” Katsuki said, eyes lidded. He still looked tired, slouched against the wall, legs spread. He crooked one finger. Izuku went to him, wondering. Katsuki looked up at him. “Sit,” he ordered.

Izuku had to fight the urge to just sit where he stood. Since when was he so damn obedient? “Where?” he asked, trying to regain some control over the situation. Wrong question. Katsuki’s grin spread sinfully, and he wordlessly pointed at his crotch. Izuku tried and failed to look disinterested.

"Someone could come in," he protested. It was a token protest. Izuku wasn’t technically an exhibitionist, but he was very, very weak for Katsuki.

"I know," Katsuki replied, but Izuku, weakling that he was, was already climbing into the bench, knees on each side of Katsuki's hips. Katsuki looked up at him with something like awe. "Good boy," he whispered, hands coming up to cup Izuku's ass. He squeezed. "So good." The praise went straight to Izuku's dick.

"We probably shouldn't do this here," he said, making a last-ditch attempt to be a good hero and not defile the locker room. Katsuki gripped Isuku's hips, grinding against him.

"Want to stop, Deku?"

Somewhere in the depth of his mind, his inner Iida was screaming. Izuku ignored him, and bent down. His hair dropped into his face, hopefully hiding his blush as he leaned in to kiss the man below him.

"Deku," Katsuki murmured into his mouth. "Tell me you want me." He ground Izuku's hips forwards again, arms flexing. Izuku hissed a breath in - Katsuki was hard beneath him, and was making small, restrained movements upwards, each one sending electricity up his spine.

"You're very demanding," Izuku said, instead, tilting his head. Katsuki might be the asshole, but it's not like Izuku doesn't know how to tease. Predictably, Katsuki glared up at him.

Izuku leaned in, biting his lip lightly. "You like telling me what to do, huh? Get off on being bossy?"

"Deku," Katsuki said, his voice a deep rumble. "You-"

"Big, strong Katsuki," Izuku interrupted, putting a finger on his lips. "Show me who's in charge."

Katsuki blinked up at him for a moment, and if he didn’t know better, Izuku would have sworn he saw adoration in those red eyes. Katsuki huffed out a laugh, and flipped Izuku around.

"You asked for it," he said, sliding a hand up Izuku's shirt.

"Yeah," Izuku breathed, unable to properly think as Katsuki's other hand slid between his legs.

"Want me to jerk you off, lil' Deku?"

Izuku twitched at the sound of the nickname. Damn, he was being conditioned to be turned on by it. "The door," he gasped.

"You can keep your clothes on, baby," Katsuki assured him, hand sliding under his underwear. Izuku bucked into his hand, whimpering.

"What- what about you?" He managed to say. Not that he was complaining, but Izuku was usually the giver in bed. This was the second time Katsuki was taking care of him, and he was worried it was getting unfair. Then Katsuki ground his ass down on his dick, and moaned pointedly into Izuku's ear.

"I'm all set, Deks, worry about yourself. Here, help me out." He raised a hand up to Izuku's lips.

"What?"

"Christ, I'll do it myself." He leaned his chin over Izuku's shoulder, and sloppily licked his own hand. Izuku watched in horrified fascination. It was just, well, lewd. Despite all of Katsuki's flirting, he hadn't expected him to be quite so raunchy. He'd always acted a little uptight, but Izuku supposed he also always gave 100% - then his train of thought crashed and burned, and Katsuki began to jerk him off. The man knew what he was doing, pumping Izuku's aching dick and moaning into his ear. Helpless against the pleasure, Izuku bucked into the hand, rubbing back against Katsuki's cock.

He didn't even realize he was making noise until Katsuki clapped a hand over his mouth.

"Shh," he ordered, then, "Come for me."

Izuku had always listened to Katsuki, and this time was no exception. He came hard into Katsuki’s hand, cries muffled.

"So good, lil' Deku," Katsuki said, sounding choked, fingers digging into Izuku's hip. He shuddered for a moment, breath hitching, then fell back. Izuku jumped off him, trembling, and turned to look. Katsuki still sat there, legs spread, eyes closed, leaning against the wall. There was a tell-tale wet spot on his gray sweats. Fuck. Izuku was pretty sure he'd never seen anything that hot in his whole life. Nervously, he sat down next to him, and like it had a mind of its own, Katsuki's arm snaked around him and pulled him against his chest.

"Rate me," he murmured half-heartedly, simultaneously making Izuku laugh and erasing his nervousness.

"Kacchan, don't ask questions you don't want to know the answer to," he said, tucking his head under his chin.

"Sassy little fucker, aren't you," was all Katsuki said, fingers threading through Izuku's hair. They would definitely need to shower again.

"But you like it," Izuku said, realizing with a jolt that he actually believed it. He actually believed Katsuki liked him.

"Sure do, nerd. Keep up the good work."

Chapter End Notes

Enjoy the fluff while it lasts, folks!

I actually originally ended this chapter with like a 1k+ word throat-punch of angst, but I decided to leave it for later and gave you all some locker room spice instead, so you're WELCOME (I'm salty 'cause I wrote so much BS and scrapped it and now I'm posting a whole day later. And fucking when did this hit 30k???)

I actually have to try really hard to write Bakugou. He keeps getting uncharacteristically nice, and I have to go back and asshole-ify him. Also I've been seriously neglecting his first name this whole time (poor Katsuki) and am strongly considering switching to using it but idkk

Fun fact - the way I decide if I use a side character's first or last name is this: “Which one do I remember first?” lmao I suck

Growing Pains

Chapter Summary

Izuku and Bakugou are both great and terrible... at communication.

Chapter Notes

And the muse hath said to me, "Lo, which will you choose, lust or anguish?"
And I hath replied, "Fuck me up fam lmao"

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Katsuki was busy. One week after their first sparring match, he'd managed to top rankings for most villains bagged, and then stayed at the top. From what Izuku could tell, the man only slept, trained, and worked. And occasionally kissed Izuku silly in a concerning variety of places, though he'd had to put his foot down when Katsuki tried to pull him into a porta potty at a disaster site. Izuku had been trying his best to get the man alone, but for someone who Ochako claimed was 'wrapped around his little finger,' Katsuki had been impossible to tie down.

It's not that Izuku wasn't busy either, which actually made it more difficult. He'd been coming in 4th or 5th on the number of villains bagged (two spots behind Katsuki), but only because he'd taken down some major players that took large-scale operations, and didn't count for numbers. He'd also submitted an application to take an intern or sidekick, and had been vetting candidates. He still managed to make time for Katsuki, whether it was pre-late-shift coffee or crashing their friends' events, but time alone in private was rare.

Then, there was the time Katsuki finally passed Izuku in the hero rankings, pushing to #15. As salty as Izuku was about being #16, he was determined to be happy for Katsuki, because he was a good friend, or uh, lover, or whatever the hell they were. They'd been at some dingy sports bar with "the guys," which typically meant some combination of Kirishima, Kaminari, Mina, Sero, Shinsou, Jirou, or Tsu, depending on the day. Katsuki had been acting especially insufferable, and the reason became apparent when he leaned across the table towards Izuku, rankings glowing on the screen.

It was obvious that he was pointing out that he'd surpassed Izuku, if only from the delinquent grin on his face. In a moment, Izuku had shoved down his disappointment at falling behind and pasted a smile on his face.

“Congrats, Kacchan,” he said, aware of their friends watching intently. Their old UA rivalry was well known, after all. Katsuki’s grin widened, a sure sign of trouble.

“Fuck that, how’s it feel to fall behind me, useless Deku?”

“Temporary,” Izuku snipped back, feeling less tolerant than normal. Either Katsuki didn’t pick up on it or flat-out didn’t care, because he went right on with the gloating.

“Ha! As if I’d let you catch up. Eat my ass, loser,” he crowed, leaning back. Fine, he wanted to play it like that? Izuku gave him a hard stare, crossing his arms. It was more or less an intimidating posture - Izuku’s arms and chest were heavily muscled, and he knew the move highlighted it. He also had an adorable baby face which ruined the effect, so much so that there’d been *news articles* about it. Izuku digressed.

“Eat your ass?” Izuku repeated, then on impulse added, “Maybe I will.”

“Duuuuude,” Mina shrieked, “Yessss!” Everyone else looked completely appalled at Izuku’s words. Katsuki stared at him for a second, his grin gone. Izuku couldn’t understand his expression and was starting to worry, until It happened. *It* being the rare and beautiful full-face Katsuki blush. Apparently realizing he looked like a blonde tomato, Katsuki hid his face in his arms, elbows thumping onto the table.

“Fucking hell, Deku,” he muttered. Kirishima recovered first, slapping Katsuki across the back with maybe too much strength.

“Get it, Bakubro,” he laughed.

“I think he’s a bad influence on you,” Tsu said to Izuku, with a perfect deadpan.

“So do you just eat Katsuki’s ass, or are you looking for more asses?” Kaminari said, with an over-the-top perverted expression. “‘Cause I’ve got an ass.” 90% chance that he was joking.

Katsuki lifted his head, face still bright red, and glared. “I will really murder you, asshole,” he growled.

“This is actually the best day of my life,” Kaminari said, snickering.

“*Denki.* I will kill you.”

“Baku-go with the flow, man,” Kaminari said, waving a hand. He was being brave, largely because Kirishima was a very strong buffer between him and Katsuki. Despite Kirishima’s best efforts, the resulting shouting match nearly got them kicked out.

That night, Izuku got a text.

Kacchan: *U gonna follow thru on what u said or what*

Kacchan: *My place. tomorrow. im off at 11pm*

Apparently there were drawbacks to publicly sassing Bakugou Katsuki. Drawbacks that Izuku could not complain about, because it led to him sitting on Katsuki's kitchen counter, watching the man fuss around in the kitchen. Izuku was actually having a great time, because Katsuki clearly wanted to bring up what Izuku had said before, but was deeply struggling to get the words 'please eat my ass,' out. Seeing as Katsuki was normally so straightforward, this was a moment to be relished.

Besides, you can't really fall for Bakugou Katsuki without having *some* kind of mean streak. Even if it's strictly benevolent and reserved for teasing, like in Izuku's case.

"Hey Kacchan, was there something you wanted?" This was his version of mercy. Katsuki looked up from where he'd been aggressively drying dishes, expression thunderous.

"You know fucking what."

"How could I know?" Izuku smiled his best ray-of-sunshine smile. Katsuki stalked over, putting his hands on Izuku's knees. There was a faint blush growing on his angular cheeks, and Izuku was power-tripping, hard. Given that Katsuki seemed to be power-tripping constantly throughout his entire life, Izuku didn't feel bad taking a turn.

"What you said, before," Katsuki replied, voice like gravel.

"Gosh, Kacchan, I say so many things," Izuku smiled an innocent, baby-bunny smile. Katsuki looked like his head was about to combust.

"What game are you playing, lil' Deku?" He leaned in, his fingers spreading over Izuku's upper thighs.

"You tell me, Kacchan." Izuku leaned back on the counter, not missing how Katsuki stared at his shirt riding up. Oops. "If you want me to do something, just ask."

Katsuki's lips pulled back in a snarl, but Izuku cut him off fearlessly. "Ask *nicely* ," Izuku clarified. Katsuki's mouth snapped shut, his jaw tense. To be fair, Izuku was fully planning to eat his ass. He'd been completely unable to stop thinking about it, what with Katsuki's ass dominating social media for the last few weeks. Still, you can't blame him for messing with Katsuki first.

Katsuki dropped his head into Izuku's stomach, breath hot on his skin. "Please," he breathed out. Izuku ran his hands over Katsuki's bowed back, feeling the tense muscles. He almost felt bad for the guy, who was obviously struggling to choke down his pride.

"Please what?" Izuku asked, sweet as sugar. He *almost* felt bad.

Katsuki looked up, death in his eyes. "Unbelievable," he said through clenched teeth. "Little fucking Deku acting like the baddest motherfucker on the planet, huh? Me and everyone else in the fucking world were fooled by your stupid pretty face thinking you were some kind of goddamn decent, pure-hearted person when you're actually a piece of shit tease who is actively ruining my fucking life for no goddamn reason."

Izuku miraculously kept a straight face, despite the urge to giggle at Katsuki's theatrics. "Kacchan," he said, softly.

"What!"

"Say, 'eat my ass, *please.* "

Katsuki’s jaw clenched, and he stares at Izuku's knees. The way his hands dug into his thighs was almost painful, but Izuku could endure it if resulted in *this* .

"Midoriya Izuku, please eat my fucking ass. Fuck." He didn't look up, and Izuku couldn't really care because he was busy trying not to lose his collective shit over how goddamn turned on it made him. Katsuki had said one simple sentence, and he was already hard.

"Mmm," Izuku said hoarsely, "Not bad. Terrible attitude, too much swearing, but you got the important part in there."

"Piece of shit," Katsuki snapped, and snatched him off the countertop and stormed into the bedroom before bodily tossing him the last five feet onto the bed.

“I feel like that’s not the right attitude,” Izuku protested, breathless. He didn’t want to let on how much he liked being tossed around, because it would definitely give Katsuki ideas. Ideas that Izuku wanted to explore, but not right at this second. He had business to do.

“Fucking fine,” Katsuki snapped, stopping next to the bed. “What do you want, then?”

Easy. “Strip.”

Katsuki shot him an unreadable look, then yanked off his shirt violently, tossing on the floor. The rest of his clothes landed on the floor seconds later, and then Izuku had a buck-naked Katsuki standing in front of him, half-hard and breathing heavily.

It was a sight. Bakugou Katsuki naked (and angry) was basically god's gift to all genders. He stood awkwardly, letting Izuku drink the sight in. Every twitch of muscle, the way his hands clenched into fists, the scars covering his body. Izuku swallowed hard, amazed by the intimacy and the fact that he was here with Katsuki like this in the first place. Katsuki cleared his throat. "Happy now?"

"Yes, you're just…" Izuku trailed off. Then it hit him: Katsuki was self-conscious, and he was making him stand there like a huge jerk. He patted the bed. "You're so, so," he struggled. What word encapsulates Bakugou Katsuki? He sighed, giving up. "Beautiful. Perfect. Terrifying. I don’t know."

"Whatever," Katsuki muttered, lying on the bed. His gruff tone did nothing to hide his faint blush. It was overwhelmingly endearing. Izuku was so damn soft on him.

“No,” he said, leaning over him, running a hand up one muscled leg. “Really. You’re amazing. It’s amazing that I’m here with you like this.”

“You buttering me up, Midoriya?”

“Yep,” Izuku stuck his tongue out. “Now turn over, you beautiful asshole.”

“As long as you eat my beautiful asshole,” Katsuki mumbled, but turned over. Right. The task on hand. Izuku could only *dream* of a face-down-ass-up Katsuki, because the one in front of him was just chilling out on his stomach like he was at the beach, being completely unhelpful. Well, Izuku had wanted a chance to do some of the work, and he could certainly work with this.

He ran both hands up Katsuki’s legs, feeling each muscle, each scar. His ass was perfect, tight and unreasonably chiseled for a fatty part of the body. Izuku took a moment to just savor touching it, the fact that Katsuki allowed him to be here at all.

“Fuckin’ falling asleep up here, Deku,” Katsuki called. It was a lot more sass than Izuku was willing to allow, and Izuku instinctually slapped his ass in retribution. The man yelped, and twisted to face him, face outraged. Izuku automatically grabbed his hips and flipped him back onto his stomach, pinning him down with one hand in the small of his back. Then he realized what he’d done. Shit.

“Wait, Kacchan, was that okay?” He actually had no idea how Katsuki felt about all of this. It was hard to tell when he was being difficult just for the sake of it, or if he was actually truly uncomfortable.

“Shut up Deku,” Katsuki growled. “Do I have to fucking ask again? Do you want me to beg?” He sounded like he’d actually do it.

“How are you so hot when you’re being so difficult?” Izuku sighed, and returned to the real target: dat ass. He ran a finger over it, gentle at first. Katsuki’s whole body shuddered. Fuck. Izuku’s plans of going slow went straight out the window, and he spread those ass cheeks.

Katsuki reacted even better to a tongue than a finger, moaning into a pillow, pushing his ass up like he was asking for more. Izuku would damn well give it to him, pushing his tongue in, controlling Katsuki’s hips. He was so absorbed in what he was doing he almost missed Katsuki’s very sneaky attempt to jerk himself off, hand creeping from gripping the pillow to under his stomach. Izuku slapped it away.

“No, Kacchan. I’m taking care of you tonight,” he said. A pause, and whatever shred of pride Katsuki had been holding on broke.

“Deku,” he growled, “Please.” Izuku was too blown away to do anything for a moment. A moment too long, apparently, because Katsuki arched his back, shoving his ass up in the air impatiently, arms extended in front of him.

“Holy shit,” Izuku whispered. Literally nothing could have prepared him for this sight. Katsuki twisted to look Izuku in the eye.

“Like what you see, Deku?”

“Fuck,” was all Izuku could say, as Katsuki sneered at him.

“Yeah? Then do something about it.” He turned back around, clearly waiting. Oh, Izuku would do something. One lick had Katsuki groaning in pleasure, and soon Izuku was buried in his ass, one hand reaching around to stroke his dick. Izuku lost track of time quickly, lost in the bliss of Katsuki moaning beneath him.

Katsuki was not quiet in bed, apparently ever. He came with a half-screamed, “Fuck!” hands gripping a pillow, and then mumbled a stream of expletives Izuku couldn’t follow. He slowly rolled over, looking at Izuku pensively. Had Izuku done something wrong? He suddenly wasn’t sure, and he felt overwhelmingly awkward sitting at the foot of the bed while Katsuki watched him. Katsuki sighed, heavily.

“Remember when I blew you?” Katsuki’s voice was quiet. Izuku would never forget. “Well, now it’s your turn.”

It took Izuku far too long to realize what he meant - Katsuki wanted to be held. Like he’d held an overwhelmed Izuku back on that night. Izuku nearly fell over in his rush to get to him, and had Katsuki gathered up in his arms in no time.

“You good?” he said. Katsuki nodded, turning to push his head into Izuku’s chest. Izuku’s heart squeezed. He would literally kill for cuddly Katsuki, damn it. He was too precious for this world, like a little angry teddy bear.

“Don’t usually do it like that,” Katsuki murmured.

“Always top, huh?” Izuku smiled, petting his hair. He knew a lot of guys like that, and it didn’t surprise him that-

“Fuck no,” Katsuki said, sounding irritated. “I do whatever. I just usually do this with like…”

“Like what?”

“Not with tiny, cute-faced idiots,” Katsuki ground out. “It’s a different feeling, different headspace. Not bad.”

“But you were so good,” Izuku said, figuring praise was always a safe bet. He was right. Katsuki rolled over to look up at him, lips curving into a smile.

“You’re gonna fucking kill me with this bullshit, aren’t you?”

“I’ll do my best,” Izuku said, soberly. “It’s a little strange, isn’t it?”

“Mm?”

“Just like, if I’d told you I’d um, eat your ass back in UA, you’d have actually killed me. I’d be rotting in a grave somewhere, by now.”

Katsuki’s laugh was so loud Izuku flinched. He tilted his head up, a smirk playing across his lips. “Deku, no. I absolutely would have let you, even back then. I was fucking wasted over you.”

“What?” Izuku stared down at him. “You… what?

“I told you already,” Katsuki admonished him. “I wanted you so damn badly. If you’d ever shown even the slightest interest, I’d have made a goddamn fool of myself over it. I wanted you so bad I literally kissed you out of the blue, like some kind of desperate idiot. No, I straight-up was a desperate idiot.”

“No way,” Izuku snorted. “One time I said good morning to you, and you told me to, what was it? Fuck off and drown in a pool of my dork tears?”

“Knowing you, that’s probably an exact quote,” Katsuki snickered. “I didn’t fucking handle it well, okay? You’d walk over the place looking cute as all hell, and all I could think were these shitty sexual thoughts.”

“I had no idea,” Izuku said, disbelieving but deeply intrigued. “What kind of thoughts? I want examples, Kacchan.”

“You’re gonna think I’m a pervert,” Katsuki grumbled.

“I already do,” Izuku told him, and kissed his temple. Katsuki sighed in resignation.

“Hmph. Fine. Like uh, in class. You’d get all excited giving your damn over-prepared presentations, blushing like a bride and smiling at everyone. All I could think about was what you’d look like choking on my cock. Fuckin’ hated myself for thinking like that but I couldn’t stop.”

“Huh,” Izuku coughed. Katsuki had thought about him like that then? Ever? It made him strangely… self-satisfied. He felt sexy, for once. Izuku was cursed with a permanent babyface. Not only had it made it harder to get people to take him seriously, people didn’t tend to… want to be dirty with him. He’d had way too many lovers say things along the lines of ‘ *You’re so cute, let me make sweet gentle love to you.’* Apparently Katsuki did not suffer from that affliction.

“Deku? You think I’m a disgusting pervert now,” Katsuki huffed.

“No, it’s nice,” Izuku murmured, still lost in thought.

“Huh? Nice?” Katsuki almost shouted, and Izuku looked up at him, mind elsewhere. There was still one thing he was dying to know.

“Do you still think like that?”

“Like what?” Katsuki was still being loud, clearly having no idea what was going through Izuku’s head. Izuku didn’t care; he was on a roll, and would not be stopped.

“Do you see my adorable face on TV doing interviews and think about stuffing your dick in my mouth?”

Katsuki’s mouth snapped shut. “Jesus Christ Deku, when did your mouth get so dirty?”

“You don’t like it?” Izuku knew he did, but positive validation never hurts.

“Sure, I still think like that. Never stopped.” Katsuki said it so casually, ignoring Izuku’s obvious fishing for compliments. But what he said still broke Izuku's poor brain. This whole time? Apparently bored by the topic, Katsuki looked down at the mess on his stomach and sighed. “I should probably do laundry.”

Izuku followed Katsuki around his flat like a puppy, enjoying the quiet domesticity of watching Bakugou Katsuki toss his sheets in the washing machine. Feeling encouraged by their earlier conversation and intimacy, he finally got up the courage to ask the one question plaguing his mind.

“Kacchan, what are we?”

“We’re us,” Katsuki replied simply, with that strangely fond look on his face. He leaned back against the washer, looking up at something neither of them could see. “Kacchan and Deku, right?

Izuku was losing his mind. He'd never done well with unknowns, preferring to exhaustively prepare for everything. Katsuki was one enormous unknown, managing to squirm out of literally any way Izuku tried to feel out their relationship. He didn’t want to push it, but they’d been dancing around each other for weeks. The training, the flirting, everything. Katsuki was sending mixed signals. He'd aggressively flirt, he'd hover around Izuku like a bee around honey any time they were in public together. Then when Izuku would try to broach the topic, Katsuki would say something vague and positive-sounding, which actually didn't help Izuku at all.

Izuku finally seized the chance to talk after training one day, figuring that it couldn’t be that bad. Katsuki obviously liked him, right? They’d figure it out no matter what.

“So let’s compare notes later,” Katsuki was saying. Izuku pulled himself into the present moment.

“Of course,” Izuku said, maybe a little too eagerly. “As much as you want. Um…”

“Um?” Katsuki looked amused. Izuku found himself unbearably nervous. But he wanted to be brave. Izuku kept talking about how he wanted to be the best hero, right? If he was aiming that high, couldn’t he ask one angry boy out? He squared his shoulders.

“What is this? I’m not sure what we’re doing, Kacchan. Is it, I mean, are we-,” he faltered, breathing hard. This was difficult. Katsuki waited him out, looking vaguely concerned. “Do you want a relationship?” he blurted. Katsuki blinked, stiffening.

“A, a relationship?” He looked taken aback, and Izuku felt his bravery crumble away. He couldn’t stop himself from plummeting into damage-control mode.

“Um, I don’t mean,” he stuttered, waving his hands between them as if he could dispel the awkwardness. “It’s not, um, if you don’t want to it’s fine, I just thought-”

He stopped speaking abruptly, as Katsuki took his hands gently. “Deku, I can’t.” Izuku’s heart broke. All his energy diverted into keeping himself together long enough to get out of the room. Gym time was over. Heartbreak time was in, and Izuku was ready to cry in a scalding shower.

“Okay,” He said quickly, trying to pull. “I get it, it’s-”

“Deku, stop,” Katsuki insisted, pulling him closer. Izuku stood there, trying not to tremble. “It’s not that I don’t want you, okay? Quit thinking shitty thoughts. I think I’ve been pretty fucking obvious about how I feel, anyway.”

“Then why,” Izuku whispered. He would not cry. He wouldn’t.

“It’s not a ‘why’ kind of thing! I just can’t commit to that yet,” Katsuki replied, voice uncharacteristically quiet. “I take this shit seriously, Deks. I’ve, I’ve told you how much I hate myself for losing ambition and everything. How it kills me to know that I let it happen. I’m making some goddamn changes in my life, and I’m afraid if I change too much at once I’ll fuck up something important.”

Izuku couldn’t say anything. The rejection hurt too much. Sure, Katsuki’s reasoning was good, he knew it was. It made it hurt less, technically, but Izuku was experiencing a high-def recap of every time Katsuki had ever rejected him, and one more time was just. Too. Much. He shouldn’t have brought this up, he realized.

“Deku? You okay? Look, I just need some time to sort out my shit. If we do this, I’m doing it fucking right. For now, let’s just-”

“It’s okay,” Izuku managed to say. It didn’t matter how much he wanted Katsuki. He had to respect what the other man wanted. “It’s fine. I get it.”

“Deku, you sound upset,” he said bluntly.

“Well, Kacchan,” Izuku said, pulling away, hating how bitter he sounded, “You just rejected me. I don’t have to sound happy.”

“Izuku…”

“Don’t,” Izuku said, quickly, his throat tight.

“I didn’t reject you!” Katsuki growled, clearly getting frustrated. “Stop looking like I’ve ripped your shitty heart out! Let me finish!”

“You’ve pushed me away too many times, Kacchan, and it just hurts, okay? I thought we were done with that, and maybe I don’t feel like being kept at a distance anymore.”

“Not fair,” he frowned, rubbing his face.

“Why would a relationship be so hard?” Izuku backed away, knowing he should just shut up. He couldn’t, though. Katsuki brought out the most in him - the best parts of him, and also the most difficult parts. “What’s the problem? I’ve supported you your whole fucking life. You know I’d support you being the top hero. I already have been! I wouldn’t hold you back!”

And there it was. It felt like Katsuki was pushing him away because Izuku would somehow stop him from being the top hero. Just like when he’d shoved away the little useless, quirkless kid-Deku.

“I know you wouldn’t,” Katsuki said harshly, clearly trying to keep his temper in check. “Deku, it’s not about that. It’s about my own shit, okay? And I still want to-”

“I was always there for you,” Izuku shot back, pushing. “When you needed a friend, a punching back, a rival, there I was, just doing whatever the fuck you wanted.”

“No,” Katsuki snapped, temper reaching its breaking point. “You were fucking *clingy* and *overwhelming* . I never got any goddamn space! If you had done what I wanted, you’d have left me the hell alone! You never took a fucking hint, Deku!”

Izuku stared at him, completely shocked. It was the first time since they’d reunited that he felt he saw a glimpse of the old Katsuki, the one that didn’t want him around. The one from when Deku meant useless. Every shove, every insult, every time he’d reinforced Izuku’s insecurities...

“I guess you didn’t change, after all,” Izuku whispered, feeling cold. “You’re the same bully that you always were.”

The frown on Katsuki’s face dropped, replaced by blank shock. Izuku had never seen such a horrified, vulnerable expression on the man’s face. The moment stretched, and Izuku could see Katsuki’s temper making its inevitable return. And when it returned, it was vicious. Katsuki spoke quietly, forcefully.

“Fuck, Deku, maybe I am! Maybe I’m fucking selfish, but I don’t have to risk my life goals just to do whatever the hell you think will solve things, okay?”

His chest felt empty, like Katsuki’s words had just punched his heart clean through his ribcage. Maybe it was because he was older, or just that enough time had passed, but the perspective was dizzying. Katsuki was right. Katsuki, as a child, had told him over and over what he wanted - even if it was just Izuku getting out of his life. Izuku had never listened back then, and he wasn’t listening now.

“You’re right,” he whispered. “I’m sorry. I never respected your boundaries, and now I’m doing it again. You’re right. I’m clingy and needy and I can't blame you for not wanting this.” His voice sounded hoarse, dead, foreign to his own ears.

“Deku, *no* ,” Katsuki said, reaching forwards, face twisting. “Don’t- I don’t think- You’re not- Fuck! It was always complicated, okay?”

But Izuku was already leaving.

“Wait! Please!”

It took all of Izuku’s willpower to stop his feet. Because no matter how badly this conversation had gone, he couldn’t just run. He couldn’t ruin things with Katsuki completely, even if the effort ripped his heart out. He turned, woodenly. “Kacchan, it’s okay.”

“It’s not,” Katsuki growled. “I’m not done-”

“I am,” Izuku cut him off, finally tearing up. He was distantly proud he’d lasted this long without crying yet. “I didn’t mean for it to go like this, okay? I need time to think and I need to figure out what I want and I just can’t do it when I feel like this.” It killed him to admit it, but he was determined not to dig this hole any deeper. They’d both gone too far, and Izuku wouldn’t risk it getting worse.

“I need to calm down before we talk about this again. But we’ll talk again later, okay?”

“But, I mean - shouldn’t we figure this out now?” Katsuki looked shell shocked, his voice cracking. “Are you sure?”

“We’ll talk later,” Izuku promised shakily, and slipped out the door, abandoning his gym bag. He managed to make it all the way out of headquarters before texting Uraraka an SOS and breaking down to cry in an alleyway.

Katsuki had been right. Izuku was clingy, overwhelming, and selfish, and he’d been forcing what he wanted on Katsuki without considering how the other person felt. Katsuki was obviously too busy for him. He’d obviously been avoiding the relationship, and Izuku had just kept chasing him like he always had. Katsuki was striving to win the top seat, and what was Izuku doing? Crying in the street over a boy? No wonder Katsuki didn’t want to be with him.

Chapter End Notes

Sorrrrryyyyyyy T-T
Honestly, I made myself sad w/ the end of this and there’s even more angst to come RIP
Don’t worry though, present angst just means future fluff <33

Poor Izuku, his worst insecurities were brought to light by the person he’s most vulnerable to. He’s so hard on himself
Bakugou is also having a rough time, what with succumbing to his temper and having his worst fears confirmed: that he’s failed at becoming a better person and has hurt Deku as a result

Btw I fully intend to run this fic all the way to the point where they confess their embarrassingly undying love for each other so this is just like, growing pains :’)

#spoilers

Guys. Thank you so much for reading, for the kudos, and your comments. I have LEGIT read all the comments so many times I think I've memorized them <333

Big Bad Bakugou

Chapter Summary

Bakugou says a lot of things, some of them to Izuku.

Izuku attempts to get his shit together w/ varying degrees of success.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Uraraka was on an overnight shift, dealing with a building collapse down south, and was unable to come right away. Izuku dealt by hopping in the bathtub and attempting to wash the horrible conversation off of him with scalding water and an entire bottle of bubble bath. It didn't work. He spent the night obsessing over the conversation gone wrong and slept maybe a grand total of three hours. His phone didn't buzz until the next morning.

Kacchan: *Deku, you doing ok? Let's talk*

Kacchan: *What I said was wrong ok*

Kacchan: *I'm fcking sorry for losing my temper and I said shit I didn't mean*

Kacchan: *Izuku?*

The texts came spaced out over the next day, starting at 5:46 AM with the last at 2:00 PM. Izuku wasn't ready to deal with any of them. He was sick with self-loathing and still didn't trust himself to talk to Katsuki. How had that conversation gone so wrong? Izuku had a lot of ideas, and explored them liberally before Uraraka had time to come over.

Katsuki thought Izuku was clingy and annoying. Fine, Izuku knew that. He'd known it as a kid too, but it hadn't stopped him then. Katsuki had obviously been dodging the question of any kind of real relationship, and Izuku, instead of considering what Katsuki wanted, had just tried to enforce his own desires. The second Katsuki had shown any kind of temper and reminded Izuku of their past, Izuku had lost control of his emotions and said things he didn't mean. Katsuki had obviously changed, and Izuku hated that he might have hurt him by saying otherwise. It made him feel sick to remember how horrified Katsuki had looked.

Izuku had to acknowledge the truth. They didn't communicate well. More accurately, they'd communicated exceptionally badly, and Izuku held at least some of the fault. Izuku hated to imagine what would have been said if he hadn't left when he did. Katsuki had been right - a relationship was a bad idea, especially if they couldn't even talk like this. He couldn't keep bringing up the past whenever he felt hurt. It wasn't fair to Katsuki, and if he couldn't move past it, then there couldn't be a relationship.

Still, now that Katsuki had entered his life, Izuku couldn't bear to give him up. But they could be friends, right? He wouldn't be so needy, wouldn't ask for Katsuki's attention. His phone buzzed again. Izuku realized he couldn't put off replying anymore, not when Katsuki was obviously worried. He didn't want to be the kind of person who'd silently sulk, refusing to talk when the other person was obviously trying.

Kacchan: *Hey, you ok? Can I call you?*

Izuku: *I'm fine. Just processing everything. I'll tell you when I want to talk.*

Kacchan: *K, well I have important shit to say. Don't take too long*

How long was too long? Izuku added that to the list of things he was currently overthinking. Well, there was one way he dealt with his problems - avoid them through working. Uraraka had promised to come over that night, so Izuku went into the office and completed every piece of paperwork he could find. With that done, he made exhaustive reviews of his top three intern candidates - one who could extend their fingers into needle-like points, one who could absorb and reflect impacts, and one who could self-armor like an armadillo. They all seemed very promising. Unlike Izuku's love life.

Thankfully, Uraraka was there for him. She brought over IP Man and take-out katsudon, and listened to Izuku carefully explain how he was a horrible person and friend, and how certainly everyone hated him. She just gave him a huge hug.

"Deku, you're an amazing friend, and you know it. Everyone likes having you around, especially me. Now tell me, do I need to kill Katsuki? Because based on raw combat stats I can't win a head-on fight, so I'll probably need to poison his food. Since he eats such spicy crap, it shouldn't be hard to hide-"

"Uraraka, no," Deku said, laughing despite himself. "It's not his fault, okay?"

"I'll believe it when I see it," she sniffed, but thankfully listened when Izuku said he didn't want to talk about it. Instead, they enjoyed IP Man, and the entire Rush Hour series before passing out on the couch.

Uraraka was kind of enough to go out with him again the next day. In efforts to cheer Izuku up, they went to the popular shopping district and got some trendy crepes. They chatted about Uraraka's lack of a love life, about work, about pretty much anything that wasn't Bakugou Katsuki. He'd been struggling to make peace with the reality of their situation. Katsuki didn't want a relationship, and after their conversation, Izuku figured it had been a bad idea in the first place. In the light of day, Izuku could pretend like it didn't hurt. So, that left him with friendship or nothing. So, Izuku would make peace with just being friends, if Katsuki even wanted that.

It just hurt. He'd thought he'd had a chance, for once. Sure, it was the fulfillment of a childhood crush, years of longing, and so on, but had become more than just that. In the last few months, he'd gotten to know Katsuki in a new way, and he'd been surprised to find how well they actually fit together, how much chemistry they had. How easy it was to be around him, how effortlessly Katsuki eased Izuku's insecurities and motivated him to be the best version of himself. He was also unbearably attractive, but that's beside the point.

So it was hard to imagine being just friends. Fuck. He could do this, he just needed to calm down, and make peace with it. He took a deep breath, blinking back the tears already forming in his eyes.

"Deku?"

Uraraka. She was looking at him with concern, her strawberry crepe already mostly gone. "Just dealing with things," he smiled at her. "It'll be fine. I'll talk to him soon."

She squeezed his arm, and Izuku, for a moment, believed it would be alright.

Then, over loudspeakers, came Katsuki's voice. No - it was Ground Zero's voice, coming from a massive TV screen on the side of one of the shops, as the show switched to an interview segment.

Katsuki was lounging in a chair next to a reporter, dressed in full hero costume, minus the gauntlets and grenades. Izuku swallowed hard. It was so hard to forget what his lips felt like, how he smelled, what he'd said about watching Izuku on TV. Izuku was rooted to the spot, transfixed. Uraraka tried to tug him away, and utterly failed.

The interview went on, as the reporter asked inane questions about the BOOM video, and Ground Zero was clearly barely holding on to his temper. There was a thumbnail on the screen of the video playing silently. Izuku would have laughed if he hadn't been so torn up by seeing Katsuki in front of him in HD.

"So," the reporter was asking, "We've covered your dramatic spike in popularity thanks to video, but here's what we all want to know: You're known for your drive to win - are you happy about winning via a viral social media?"

Izuku could practically hear Katsuki's teeth grinding from here. Still, Ground Zero's temper was marginally more controlled than Bakugou Katsuki's, and all he said was, "Winning is winning. If I didn't deserve the #14 spot, then I wouldn't be here."

#14? When had that happened? Was Izuku still #16?

"Well," the reporter continued, scooting back to a safer distance, "Some would argue that your reckless behavior and bad manners mean you don't deserve to be on the rankings at all."

Ground Zero's expression went dark. "Some fuckers should try saying that to my face, then, huh?"

“Ahem, Ground Zero, please refrain from swearing during this segment.” The reporter only looked a little afraid, to his credit.

Ground Zero crossed his arms, muscles bulging. “Fine, I’ll stop fucking swearing. Look, buddy, here’s the deal: I’m here to kick ass and save lives, not to stop prude losers from getting their panties in a twist. I’ll win just the same whether I’m nice or not.”

Holy...shit. Katsuki was insane. It was career suicide, and Izuku could feel his heart in his mouth. He swore he could see Best Jeanist behind the corner of the stage, palm on his face.

“Well, there you have it,” the reporter continued, looking a little sweaty. “That’s Ground Zero’s take on his recent viral video, *BOOM* . I hesitate to ask, but Ground Zero: is there anything you’d like to say to close out? You don't have to say anything." Izuku suspected this last bit was more of a plea than anything else.

Izuku saw his jaw tighten, a gesture most people wouldn’t pick up on, and even if they did, they wouldn’t know what it meant. It told Izuku that Katsuki was about to say something that was very, very difficult for him to say.

“Sure,” Ground Zero said, then stood, walking to the center of the camera’s view, looking nearly casual and unconcerned. Izuku knew he wasn’t. He cleared his throat then said, “Everyone. I will be the next #1 hero. You better be fucking ready.”

Izuku’s jaw dropped. Around him, he could hear people whispering. Izuku was immediately reminded of their first sports festival at UA, when Katsuki had claimed he’d be first like an absolute madman. Then he’d fucking done it, looking like a rabid animal on the winner’s platform. Would this be any different? Was he trying to get knocked off the top #30 again? The reporter half-stood, trying to stop the trainwreck, but Ground Zero continued, the camera zooming in on his face. His voice was rough, loud, and deadly serious.

“I’m going to goddamn earn it by being the greatest hero this country has ever seen. I know I’m hard to like, that I have a fucking terrible attitude. I fucking know!”

Then his face vanished from the frame, and the camera panned out, revealing Ground Zero in a perfect, 90-degree bow. Izuku’s heart damn near stopped beating. Neither he nor anyone on the planet had ever seen Katsuki do anything like this.

“But no matter what,” he shouted to the ground, “No matter what you think of me, I will do my fucking best to serve each and every citizen, to keep you safe, and to remove every piece-of-shit villain in this country! So, please accept me for who I am! Please let me fight for you! Thank you very much!”

Then he snapped back to standing, face contorted in some strange mix of horror and rage. Then he turned and stormed from the studio. Now Best Jeanist was clearly in the shot, looking like he’d just been handed a live grenade. In a way, maybe he had.

It took Izuku a few moments to realize he’d teared up. He’d never, never in his life seen Katsuki say anything like that. Seen anyone say anything like that. He was deaf to the murmurs of everyone in the street who’d gathered around the screen. He couldn’t see

anything except the afterimages of what Katsuki had said. He could only think of one thing. One unfortunate, undeniable thing that echoed around his soul.

He was in love with Bakugou Katsuki. Again.

Ground Zero knocked over a grand sum of seven people on his way to the emergency exit, which he proceeded to storm out of. Eight flights of stairs disappeared beneath his boots as he half-ran outside. He slammed the exit door and leaned against the brick wall, chest heaving.

Only once he'd stopped running did he realize how badly he was shaking. What the hell had he done? Sure, he'd talked about it first with Best Jeanist, who'd advised him to apologize. Apologize for everything, in general. Katsuki had an overabundance of things he could apologize for, if he felt yanking his head out of his ass long enough to do so (Jeanist's words). But, he'd actually planned to apologize. He really had.

But when he was standing there in front of the cameras, in front of that studio audience, all he could see was Deku, looking at him with those huge green eyes, telling him that he *liked* him. Asking why he couldn't be #1 without changing who he was, and suddenly, Katsuki couldn't bear to apologize anymore.

So he'd fucking begged for acceptance. Live, on national TV. Humiliating. He leaned his head back against the warm bricks, trying to calm himself, but he couldn't. After probably the worst interview of his life, the only thing he wanted to do was call Deku, hear his voice, to soak up some of that irrepressible optimism. But he couldn't call, because Deku didn't want to talk to him, and he couldn't blame him. Just two days, and he already missed that little fucker so badly.

Katsuki pulled out his phone, looking at the last text Deku had sent. The message was clear. *I don't want to talk to you. Leave me alone.* Katsuki was sick to death of leaving him alone. That fucking conversation had gone about as well as Chernobyl, and he was seriously going to lose his shit if Deku ran out one more time during an important conversation.

But Katsuki knew he'd royally fucked up. Losing his temper with Deku wasn't an option, and he'd done it anyway. The guy was still too scared of him, and it killed Katsuki to know that it was all his fault. Between that and his wreck of an interview, Katsuki was batting 0-2 in terms of success at the things most important to him.

This was why he couldn't just jump into fucking relationship bliss. Just one argument with Deku, and he'd already lost his shit and jeopardized his goddamn career. Katsuki knew what he was good at - blowing up shit, being a hero, being an asshole, giving head, winning, whatever. What he wasn't good at was regulating emotions, and being a top-tier hero already took all of his ability to manage his temper. How could he be a good boyfriend to Deku like that?

As if in answer, the All Might ringtone started playing from his phone. Probably Best Jeanist, ready to explain what a walking disaster he was. Katsuki took a deep breath and promised himself he'd keep the swearing to a bare minimum.

But the screen said *Midoriya Izuku (Deku)* . Fuck. Katsuki was too surprised to act. It took a good six rings before he realized he needed to answer, and he picked up the phone gingerly.

"Kacchan?" Deku's soft voice came over the phone and took Katsuki's breath away. It took him a moment to remember to reply.

"Deku." It came out as a growl. Could he do nothing without sounding like an asshole? Still, he couldn't help the surge of hope in his chest. Maybe Deku was finally ready to talk, and maybe Katsuki could talk his way out of looking like the biggest asshole in the country. Maybe he could somehow make it up to him.

"I saw your interview," Deku murmured. Disappointment ran a crash course through Katsuki's emotions. He hadn't called to talk. Maybe he was calling to explain that no, he didn't believe in Bakugou Katsuki after all, not after that idiot interview and-

"It was probably the coolest thing I've ever seen a hero do on TV," he said, softly. Katsuki finally stilled.

"Oh." He sounded like an idiot, but his heart was pounding. Shit, if Deku thought it was cool, then who cared about the rest of the entire world? Not Katsuki, that's for sure. With just one sentence from Deku, Katsuki started to believe in himself again.

"Are you okay?"

"Sure," Katsuki said, despite not being okay in pretty much anyway. He swallowed hard, clutching his phone like he could hold Deku closer over the airwaves.

"I, um," Deku trailed off. Katsuki waited for him to finish, feeling existential uselessness. "Um, I just wanted to tell you. I'm proud of you." Holy shit. Katsuki was not expecting to be gut-punched in the feelings, but it was Deku he was talking to. Getting hit in the feels was always an option with him.

"Look, Deku, can we-" Katuski managed to get out, then the line clicked dead. He stared at his phone in disbelief. Motherfucker'd hung up on him? He'd already punched the *return call* button before he could think better of it. Shit. He heard it pick up, and found himself saying,

"Where are you?"

"Out with Uraraka," Deku said, as if this somehow answered anything. Katsuki was pacing in circles now, full of restless energy.

"Deku, we have to-"

"I know!" Deku's voice was high and determined. "We can talk. Tonight?"

Katsuki's brain flatlined. He had the emotional capacity of an overcooked cucumber at the moment, and he wanted to be at his best when he talked to Deku. Tonight was not his best.

"I…" he trailed off, not wanting to turn him down. Then he remembered the rest of his night. Interviews, signings, and fucking photoshoot that Jeanist had booked for him, out of the debatable goodness of Jeanist's heart. Katsuki was pretty sure the other hero only helped him out with things specifically designed to torment him. "I can't, Deku. I've got interviews and shit all night. Tomorrow?"

"Of- of course you do," came Deku's reply. Katsuki could imagine his worried face, the way his brow furrowed when he thought hard… "I work tomorrow, though," Deku said, finally.

"Fuck," Katsuki said, helpfully. "Well, call me when you're off?"

"Okay," Deku said, sounding sad. This time, when the line went dead, Katsuki didn't call him back. This was why he couldn't just leap into a goddamn relationship. He just disappointed people left and right, and Katsuki couldn't stand disappointing people. Especially not Deku. That's why he kept everyone nice and distant, and worked himself to death to live up to his own merciless expectations. If he met his own impossible standards, he could ignore the way he failed to meet others, right? He was starting to shake again. Shit. He took deep breaths, his hands forming fists. He could do this. Somehow.

Katsuki looked at his call history with Deku. So many calls in the last few months, and absolutely none before that one day he'd ventured into Deku's sector. He was getting fucking sentimental over their call history, Jesus Christ. He needed to quit pining and get to work. He took a deep breath, squared his shoulders, and prepared to apologize to seven people on his way back up to the studio.

He was Bakugou motherfucking Katsuki. He'd get the top hero spot. And he'd win the damn boy while he was at it. It was like Deku had said, back that day in his flat. Why couldn't he win the #1 spot while being an asshole? And why couldn't he do it while being a good partner to Deku? It wouldn't be easy for Katsuki, but he was damn well going to try. He just needed to convince Deku to give him a chance.

Izuku was being stared down by Uraraka. His phone sat in hand like it was an innocent electronic and not a portal to hearing Katsuki's rough voice from across the city. Hearing his voice over the phone directly after that interview had been shocking, to say the least. Izuku's heart was still thumping in his chest. *He loved him* . Shit, shit, shit, shit, shit.

"Deku, are you alright? That was Katsuki on the phone, right?"

"Yeah," Izuku said, voice still distant. The words fell lifelessly from his lips. "Uraraka, I'm in love with him."

“Huh??” She jumped back for a moment, then grabbed his shoulders, peering into his face. “Are you feeling okay? I thought Bitchugou was strictly friend-zone now?”

“Um, I mean, he is, but,” Izuku stuttered, thanks to Uraraka’s vigorous shaking. She finally stopped, looking worried, but Izuku's mind was a million miles away. Because Izuku was inspired. Katsuki had balls of steel to pull that move on TV, and to keep doing interviews on the same day? He was taking his future more seriously than anyone would have expected, even if he was making risky moves. There was no Katsuki without risky moves, anyway.

And like always, he’d inspired Izuku. Izuku decided he’d finally pick an intern for the next quarterly cycle, and he’d follow up on his applications to several hero societies dedicated to causes he cared about - equal pay for heroes, post-disaster relief funds, and so on. He wasn’t afraid of making a scene, but he’d never be as flashy or as attention-grabbing as Katsuki. But then, no one was. He had to climb in his own way.

“Deku, you really love that guy?”

“Right,” Izuku said, pulling his thoughts together. “Yeah, I know I'm fucked. But I’m going to pull myself together, Uraraka. We’re going to talk tomorrow. Even if we’re just friends now, that’s fine. I’m focusing on my hero career anyway, and maybe after some time’s passed we’ll have another chance.”

“Deku,” she gave him a hug. “I’m proud of you. Just do what’s best for you, okay?”

“Yeah, thanks,” he said, blushing. Admitting his feelings out loud had helped, he realized. He could handle talking to Katsuki again. He’d be honest about what he thought, and he was sure Katsuki would understand. “Uraraka, can I ask something?”

“‘Course, sweetface,” she smiled.

“Why do you love Iida?”

“L-love?” Her face went completely red, and Izuku felt a little bad. “It’s not like that, really. I just um, it’s just a crush,” she mumbled.

“But why? Your personalities seem so different,” Izuku said, hoping her answer would somehow make some sense of his own apparent need to fall for the most stubborn, infuriating, hot-headed man within a 1,000-mile radius.

“Well, not really, you know? The little stuff is different, like he’s a lot more uptight than me and is so strict, but we both care about doing the right thing and helping people, and about family. I really admire how much he cares about his family and stuff,” she rambled, blushing harder. “Even if he's so stiff most of the time! It makes it even cuter when he relaxes.”

“Huh,” Izuku said, amazed. He’d never thought of it like that, but it made sense. Shared values, and all. In the back of his head, his shared values with Katsuki ran like stocks on the bottom of a TV screen: being a good hero, saving others, honesty, never compromising his values, ambition, determination...

“And he’s a freak in bed,” Uraraka squeaked.

“What?!” Izuku screamed, as his soul departed his body in search of friendlier realms. “He, what? Uraraka, what? Why do you know?”

“Ummm,” she mumbled. “We hooked up once after graduation, before we moved out of the dorms.”

Izuku didn’t even have the emotional capacity to scream in shock anymore. He just stared. She rubbed her face. “It was probably the only time we ever got him to completely loosen up, and we just kind of snuck into my room after that. I know he didn’t know I had feelings for him, or he wouldn’t have done it, but oh my god. I would never have guessed he was into-”

“Nope!” Izuku said, way too loudly. People turned to look. “Please have mercy I cannot hear about Iida’s sex life, oh my god.”

“Into being pegged and being a power sub!” Uraraka finished, eyes gleaming. She’d apparently snapped out of her own embarrassment when she realized the potential to horrify Izuku.

“Oh my GOD,” Izuku clapped his hands over his ears, while Uraraka cackled.

“It’s only fair since you made me listen to the story of how Bakugo blew you like, ten times. My brain is forever scarred.” She paused, making a face like she was thinking hard. “Bakublowed you?”

Izuku snorted in laughter despite himself. “So you don’t want to hear about what we did in the HA locker room?”

“No!” Uraraka cried. Izuku was giggling, surprised at how little it hurt to talk about it. Even if it hadn’t worked out, he didn’t need to regret anything he’d done with Katsuki. He was certain there’d come a time when he could look back at this and cherish the good memories they’d made. The sparring, the stolen kisses, Katsuki’s burning looks, the way he blushed whenever Izuku surprised him...

“Fine, fine,” Izuku relented, if only because if news of the locker room nonsense got back to Iida, the man might actually have a stroke and Izuku didn’t want to be responsible for that.

“Look, Denki’s got a bunch of us going out tonight,” Uraraka said, deftly changing the topic. “Want to come? It’ll take your mind off a certain blonde idiot, yeah? We can watch Kirishima drool over him from a distance, it’ll be fun!”

Izuku shouldn’t, not really. He had patrols the next morning, and though it was unlikely, there were probably more notes he could make about something, somewhere. But also, he needed to look after himself. He couldn’t be the best version of himself if he worked himself to death, so why not have a little fun?

“Okay, fine.” He ducked his head as Uraraka squealed in happiness, and her hug literally lifted him off the ground.

Kaminari's clubs were always, well, interesting. This one was some strange, exclusive grunge-rave hybrid club, but the vibe was actually pretty nice inside. Uraraka wore a black and pink dress with very creative cut-outs, and Izuku had stuck with a sheer white shirt that showed off his muscles, and standard skinny jeans. No sense in going out if he wasn't going to try and look good, right? That's what he was telling himself, anyway.

He and Uraraka caught up with Kaminari and Kirishima at the bar. Shinsou, possibly the most reclusive member of their group (outside of Katsuki) was surprisingly there. He looked like he hadn't slept for the last eight years, as per usual. Izuku ran over and threw himself into a hug. He always fit perfectly under the other man's chin. He heard Shinsou's loud chuckle over his head.

"Izu!" He was uncharacteristically loud, trying to talk over the music. "How've you been?"

"Sad," Izuku wailed. "I haven't seen you in like a year!"

"Six months," Shinsou corrected, patting his head. They'd gotten close after UA, and Izuku had been the one to drag him into their friend group. His dry humor and determined personality had fit right in. Then Kirishima and Kaminari jumped onto the hug, and Shinsou managed to choke out, "We'll catch up soon, it's fucking loud," as the other two guys shouted over each other.

"Damn, Ochako, you're smokin'!" Kaminari was shouting. Uraraka gave them all a bright smile, as if she didn't know she was damn near the cutest thing in the place.

"Pff, you flatterer," she said, and ordered shots for her and Izuku. "Deku, we are *dancing* tonight! No excuses! Gonna find you a nice man!"

Izuku actually was having fun. Several shots made him very dancy, and they'd all somewhat scattered in the ear-shattering dance music. Uraraka nudged him, and he saw Kaminari dancing with Kirishima. Not *near* him, but on him, with Kirishima's face in his neck and hands on his ass.

"Oh my god," Uraraka mouthed. It was finally happening!

"Next is you and Iida," Izuku pointed out. She scoffed and pushed him towards what appeared to be other cute, dancing guys. Her implication was clear. *Get some.*

Izuku did find nice people to dance with. Dance on. A tall, dark-haired guy with kind eyes seemed especially friendly, and before he knew it, Izuku was dancing on him, ass to crotch, the works. Izuku liked clubbing, liked all the noise, the energy, the happy people, but it still wasn't particularly common for him to dance *with* people, as opposed to near them. So it was a thrill to let someone run their hands over his abs when he didn't even know their name, moving in time with the music.

He was having a great time for several more songs, until the guy stopped moving. He gently took Izuku's shoulders and turned him around. Izuku blinked up at him, trying to figure out

what was happening. Was he going to kiss him? Izuku didn't really want that. Before he could worry more, the guy leaned in to speak in his ear.

"Dude, you ok? There's some guy at the bar glaring at you, he looks really pissed."

"What?" Izuku shouted, trying to see through the mass of people.

"I can walk you home or talk to a bouncer for you," the guy offered. "He looks like he could break you in half."

Izuku was alarmed, right up until the crowd shifted and he saw the culprit. It was Katsuki, sitting at the furthest, darkest corner of the bar, holding a drink, with an expression so angry Izuku was surprised his head wasn't combusting like Nicolas Cage in Ghost Rider.

"Oh, that's just Kach-Katsuki," he said without thinking. Oops. The man blinked.

"Wow, he does look just like Bakugou Katsuki!" Izuku tried to keep a straight face, as the guy put two and two together. "No way. Ground Zero's here?"

Apparently catching them looking at him, Katsuki tipped his head back, baring his teeth in a growl. Izuku's guy swallowed hard and patted him on the shoulder.

"Man, I am sorry but this is above my pay grade. You should go find a bouncer." Then he vanished in the crowd, right along with Izuku's good mood. Was there nothing Katsuki wouldn't ruin for him? He stormed over to the bar, ready to chew Katsuki out. He didn't get a chance.

"Sorry for scaring off your guy," Katsuki said immediately, though he didn't technically look that sorry. "Though if you're gonna pick someone else, maybe choose someone with a fucking ballsack."

"Real nice, Katsuki," Izuku snapped. He wasn't happy drunk anymore, he was annoyed drunk. Katsuki shrugged, just looking tired. Now that he thought of it, Katsuki looked exhausted, bags under his eyes, face drawn. He was wearing the enormous, fluffy-hooded coat again, and looked like some sort of jaded movie star, sunglasses pushed up on top of his head. He looked like perfection. His words in the interview echoed in Izuku's head. *Please accept me for who I am* .

Okay, scratch what he'd said earlier. Izuku was now an annoyed and horny drunk. "So what are you gonna do about it?" He snapped. "Gonna keep scaring off everyone I find? Are you really that jealous?" He wanted Katsuki to say something about how he'd dance with Izuku himself. It was way too easy to imagine him on the dancefloor, feeling Izuku up through his clothes, pulling him to a dark corner of the club and-

"You have no idea how jealous I am," Katsuki rumbled, leaning back on the bar. "But if you want me to fucking find that loser and bring him back for you, I motherfucking will. Even if I want to melt his stupid, smarmy face off."

“Why are you here?” Izuku hated how plaintive he sounded. He meant to sound demanding, strong. He just sounded wounded. Why wasn’t Katsuki making some kind of move? Was he here just to torment Izuku?

“Shitty hair made me come,” he said. “I didn’t know you’d be here. I’m leaving.” He stood up, coincidentally putting himself right in Izuku’s personal space.

“Avoiding me?” Izuku demanded, knowing it was petty. Katsuki crossed his arms, clearly annoyed but coincidentally giving Izuku front row seats to ogle his chest. Katsuki should stop wearing such low-cut tank tops if he didn’t want Izuku to eye-fuck him every three seconds.

“Fuck that, Deku. I’ve been begging you to fucking talk to me, you little asshole. I’m gonna go home and sleep for twelve hours, then hope you actually fucking follow through and call me.”

He turned to go. Izuku had a hard time letting him leave. He hadn’t expected to see Katsuki before talking to him, but here he was. After they talked tomorrow, it would all be over. They’d just be friends, and he knew Katsuki would never flirt with him again once Izuku asked him to stop. So this was it. His last moments with more-than-friends Katsuki, and he found himself grabbing Katsuki’s arm, pulling the surprised man back around.

“One last kiss,” he said breathlessly, then pulled an unresisting Katsuki down kiss him. After a moment, Katsuki responded, deepening the kiss with teeth and tongue, yanking Izuku against him. Goddamn, Izuku had missed this. Katsuki forced them backward until Izuku’s back thumped into the counter. Izuku’s body was alight with pleasure. He moaned into Katsuki’s mouth, feeling both incredibly dirty and incredibly alive.

“Deku,” Katsuki snarled, “I’ve had a very long, very shitty day. My self-control is fucking shot so if you don’t want this, tell me now. I’m sick of holding back.”

“Don’t stop,” Izuku demanded. Damn the consequences. He wanted one last memory with Katsuki, and it may as well be a hot and heavy one.

“Fucking hell, Deku, I’m going to eat you alive,” Katsuki said, eyes dark with desire. He leaned in, picking up Izuku by his ass, then pinning him against the wall. Izuku was lost to the feeling of Katsuki’s teeth on his neck, the bass music vibrating in his bones, Katsuki’s hand slipping down the back of his pants. He knew how it looked, to be doing this in public. He just couldn’t bring himself to care. He was in ecstasy, hands fisted in Katsuki’s hair, legs wrapped around his waist, until something thumped against the wall next to him.

He flinched at the noise, looking over. Katsuki continued his merciless assault on Izuku’s neck, ignoring the very angry bartender pounding the wall to get their attention.

“Take it outside boys, before I call the bouncer!” he was shouting. Izuku’s had to pull Katsuki’s head away from him by his hair. Katsuki stared up at him, pupils wide, lips wet, teeth bared.

“We’re getting kicked out,” Izuku said, breathlessly. Katsuki turned to glare at the bartender, with enough venom the poor man actually backed away.

“Fucking voyeuristic piece of shit,” Katsuki snapped, then carried Izuku out the nearest emergency exit, effortlessly holding him up with one hand and shoving the door open with the other.

The night was surprisingly cold after the club, and Katsuki set him down gently, breath puffing out in a cloud. Izuku watched it vanish into the night, hypnotized. “Lil’ Deku,” he said, voice low, one hand reaching out to tenderly push Izuku’s sweaty hair out of his eyes. “I don’t think they’ll let us back in. I’ll call you a cab home, okay?”

Izuku leaned into his chest, inhibitions long gone. “You take me home instead, Kacchan,” he asked, blinking up at him.

“Fuck!” Katsuki shouted, looking up in the air, hands making fists against Izuku’s back, fingers catching in his shirt. He took a deep, shuddering breath. “Deku, no. You’re going home nice, safe, and *alone* in a cab.”

“Why though,” Izuku pouted, hating it. Izuku didn't care about Katsuki's shitty ideas. He wanted something to remember. “Kacchan, come on,” he pleaded, “I want you. Take me, please.”

“Fuck, fuck, fuck,” Katsuki chanted under his breath, hands digging into Izuku’s shoulders, pushing him away. Izuku didn’t like it. He wanted to be closer to Katsuki, but the man was holding him at a very firm distance. Katsuki took several more deep breaths, then looked Izuku in the eyes.

“As much as I want to take you home and fuck you ‘til you can’t do anything but scream my fucking name, it’s. Not. Happening. You are drunk and I am exhausted, and we need to *talk!”* He shouted the last word in frustration. Izuku was frowning.

“You’re no fun,” he told Katsuki.

“Fun?! You and your fun are going to fucking end my life,” Katsuki sighed, breath gusting out. They were saved by Uraraka, who slipped out of the fire exit. Her hair was mussed, lipstick smeared. Izuku struggled to process the significance of this.

“Thank fucking god,” Katsuki snapped, and shoved Izuku to her. She caught him, pulling him into a hug. She was nice and warm, and smelled like vanilla. Izuku hated being pushed away from Katsuki, but she was an acceptable alternative.

“What’s going on? You guys okay?” she frowned. Sweet, sweet Uraraka. Izuku loved her, but he hated her for stopping his Katsuki-seducing efforts.

“You take him,” Katsuki said gruffly, pulling his hood up. “He’s a goddamn monster, tryna make me do something he’s gonna regret.”

“Oh,” Uraraka said, as if this made sense to her. It didn’t make sense to Izuku, who attempted to make puppy eyes at them both. “I’ll take care of him,” she said.

“Thanks Ochako,” Katsuki said. “Owe you one.” Then he slipped away into the night. Izuku watched him go and tried to convince himself it wasn't breaking his heart.

Chapter End Notes

Yeah so I meant to have them make up in this chapter but I could NOT resist the chance for jealous Bakugou and a slutty club scene, so plz enjoy sexually frustrated Bakugou & drunk Izuku who gives ZERO shits jfc

Anyway, enjoy the angst while it lasts! :P

I’ve also had the scene of Bakugou asking the country to accept him stuck in my head since the start of this fic - I feel like him being willing to be humble while also being true to himself is like, possibly the most endearing thing in the world. Hyped to see how the public reacts when big bad Bakugou asks them to accept him!

Also @ Iida’s sex life… I think he heard one too many jokes about him having a stick up his ass and decided to try it for real LOL sorry not sorry

Binary Stars

Chapter Summary

Hashtag no take backsies!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Iida had driven him and Uraraka back to their places, giving them both some very judgemental vibes. Uraraka had personally delivered him to his door, muttering about Katsuki murdering her if she didn't tuck him in or something, Izuku couldn't really remember.

Izuku was hungover the next morning, and furious with himself. Being hungover for hero work was absolutely unacceptable. He chugged two hangover-cure smoothies and prepared to do his very best work that day.

And that included avoiding thinking about how he'd basically climbed down Katsuki's pants last night. Humiliating. And if Katsuki hadn't stopped him, he'd honestly have had sex with him. Sex! Right before explaining how he was accepting that they could only be friends. What was wrong with him?

Well, it didn't change anything. He'd uphold his promise to talk to Katsuki today, and he'd manage to communicate well even if it killed him. Katsuki's texts were short and to the point. They agreed to talk in a restaurant/cafe that stayed open late, as Izuku didn't want to go to either of their houses. He couldn't bear it if a corner of his house became the place where their pseudo-relationship officially became just friendship. He wanted to preserve his last memories of Katsuki's house. The way he'd said *Kacchan and Deku* , as if that meant something. Izuku didn't want to pollute image with the pain of losing more-than-friends-Katsuki forever. So, the restaurant it was. Maybe the public space would help Izuku not burst into tears.

The day went horribly slowly, and horribly quickly.

Before he knew it, it was dark out and he was walking to meet Katsuki. It was a cozy looking restaurant, its generous windows spilling warm light onto the sidewalk. It was strange to walk into such a nice place when Izuku felt like his world was ending. Strange to see happy couples ordering appetizers when he was pretty sure he was about to toss his heart over his shoulder and into the trash.

Izuku would face this. He'd invited Katsuki back into his life, and he'd deal with their difficult friendship. Even if it hurt to give up something he'd never even had. He could only imagine how gently Katsuki would explain he didn't want to be with him. How he'd try and

break the news gently that Izuku wasn't good enough, that he was too… He had to stop overthinking this. He squared his shoulders, about to go in when he heard his name.

"Deku!" Katsuki was strolling down the sidewalk in his green bomber. Izuku was surprised; he'd planned to get there early and settle his feelings. Apparently Katsuki had had the same plan, because it was a full twenty minutes before they'd agreed to meet. Izuku tried not to think about the night before, and how he'd begged him to take him home. Shame tasted bitter in his mouth.

Katsuki looked better than last night, but still seemed stressed. Izuku could only imagine. He'd seen some of the aftermath of the interview that morning, but for the sake of his focus had avoided most news the rest of the day. From what he could tell, public opinion seemed mixed, and people were hotly debating the topic of Ground Zero's worthiness. He'd passively contributed by recheeping the most positive cheeps, because he couldn't help himself.

"Kacchan," Izuku said, pulling his thoughts together. "Sorry for making you wait so long."

Katsuki shrugged him off. "You okay? You were pretty gone last night."

Izuku blushed. He'd half-hoped Katsuki would have the grace to not bring it up, but he should have known better.

"I was hungover this morning, but I'm fine now," he murmured. Katsuki reached out hesitantly, his fingertips brushing Izuku's cheek. His expression looked tender, and it killed Izuku.

"I don't want to be just friends," he blurted out. Katsuki's mouth dropped open.

"Who the fuck said anything about just being friends?"

Izuku had the strange sensation of being in a conversation where he'd fundamentally lost track of what was being talked about.

"Um," he managed. "You?"

Katsuki growled, and pulled him into a hug. Izuku was suddenly awash with warmth, with the faint smell of smoke and nitroglycerin. He may or may not have buried his face in Katsuki's eye-wateringly orange shirt. Katsuki's fingers were in his hair, holding him closer.

"Christ, Deku, you're really stupid for a smart kid."

"Not stupid," Izuku muttered, attempting to pull himself together. Proximity to Katsuki was making it difficult to think.

"You still pull this bullshit," Katsuki said, apparently intent on calling out Izuku for everything under the sun. "You hear one thing, then spiral like a motherfucker. Then god knows what idiot conclusion you'll come up with."

"Oh." Fine, Izuku was prone to obsessive overthinking. He could admit that. Katsuki's chest lifted as he let out a heavy sigh.

"This is why I wanted to talk so much," Katsuki rumbled, pulling Izuku off of him. "Let's go inside. I want to clear things up."

They found a table in the corner. Katsuki ordered coffee, and Izuku tried to organize his thoughts.

“Can I talk first?” Izuku asked quickly. Katsuki nodded tensely, his face unreadable. Was he mad at Izuku for overthinking? Did what he said earlier mean he wanted more than or less than friendship? And... he was overthinking again, damn it. Izuku took a deep breath. He'd thought hard about what he needed to say, and he was going to say it.

“Look, um, there’s some stuff I want to apologize for,” he said, starting out strong.

“You don’t need to-”

“I do,” Izuku insisted. “When we talked, I left before you could say what you wanted to. I let my emotions get out of control, and I lashed out at you. And you’re not cruel like you used to be. I’m sorry I said that.”

“Thanks,” the word ghosted past Katsuki’s lips.

“And Kacchan, I’m not overwhelming and I’m not needy,” Izuku continued, his jaw set. “I don’t know why you would say that, because I don’t think it’s true even between us. And it really, really hurt me. So I was really upset about that. What you said, about not wanting a relationship, about dealing with your own stuff? It reminded me of when we were kids, and how you used to push me away, tell me I was useless, and all that stuff. Every time I’m reminded of it, it hurts again. The closer we get now, the more I realize how fucked up it all was, when it's obvious you have the ability to not be such a dick. And then you called me clingy and overwhelming-”

“I didn’t,” Katsuki snapped, trying to keep his voice down. “I meant when I was fucking dumbass in elementary school, Deku. I haven’t thought like that since then. Even in high school I was over that shit phase. And you *were* fucking clingy back then, but that doesn’t excuse how I treated you. And for the record, I think you’re loyal and motivated and I like those things about you, okay?”

Izuku stared at him, jaw set. He appreciated what Katsuki was saying, but still. It had cut him really deeply. He wasn't done, yet. “Well, maybe I don’t appreciate being reminded of the past every time we talk.”

“I shouldn’t have said it in the first place, and I’m sorry,” Katsuki said, voice even. Even if he was clearly making an effort to keep his tone even. “When you were asking me about being in a relationship, it started to feel like you were bringing up the past to like,” Katsuki gestured uselessly. “It made me feel like shit. Like I owed you something. I got really defensive and lost my temper for a second, and I feel horrible. I promise I’ll do better, okay?”

Izuku thought back to the conversation. He knew Katsuki was right, in a way. He'd said things without any regard to their impact, without considering if they were helpful to the conversation. He felt horrible, and it just compounded what he needed to say.

"I shouldn't have brought it up either, Kacchan. I'm sorry too. I've realized that when you reminded me of our past, I got really reactive and defensive. I wasn't thinking about what you wanted or needed, and I'm sorry for being only thinking about myself. I should have considered your feelings. I've realized that this isn't even the first time I've done this, and I'm worried it will keep happening. But the thing is, I think you're right. About not wanting a relationship." The words were harder to choke out than Izuku had expected, but he bravely continued despite Katsuki's rapidly darkening expression. After this, they could be friends. Eventually, it would hurt less, right? He bravely continued.

"Every time something like this happens, I'm just reminded of what you put me through, and then I lash out at you. It's not a good dynamic, and I understand why you wouldn't want to start a relationship like this. *I* don't even want a relationship if this is how I'll act. So I wanted to say that we should just be friends, okay?"

Izuku took a deep breath, willing the tears prickling the corners of his eyes to go back to where they came from. Katsuki looked distinctly less than happy. Izuku held up his hand. He had one more thing he needed to say. "I sincerely am happy you're back in my life, okay? I want to be friends with you, real friends. So I'm hoping this doesn't change that."

There was an incredibly long stretch of awkward silence, then Katsuki cleared his throat. "Fuck, that's what you really want? Outside, when you said you don't want to just be friends, is that what you were talking about? I fucking thought you meant that *I* was the one who didn't want more." He rubbed his face with his hands.

Izuku's blood was rushing in his ears. Why did he feel like he'd done something wrong? He'd seriously considered this. Obviously, any relationship with Katsuki would be an emotional minefield, and Izuku already struggled with handling his strong emotions. It made sense to work on their friendship first, right? He tried to discreetly wipe at his eyes. He watched Katsuki's face, his internal struggle clear. He'd known Katsuki long enough to tell when he was trying very, very hard not to shout about something. He looked at Izuku for an unbearably long moment, turning something over in his head.

"So why the hell were you all up on my dick last night if you just want to be fucking friends?"

Called out again. Izuku froze, unable to say anything. Katsuki had plenty to say, to Izuku's mortification. "Were you just trying to get some before explaining how you only want *friendship?* "

Yes, that's exactly what had happened. Izuku couldn't say anything, his cheeks burning with shame. Katsuki just shook his head. "What-fucking-ever. Guess it doesn't matter now."

"Katsuki, I'm really sorry about that. I shouldn't have been so drunk, and I shouldn't have jumped you like that-"

“Deku. Shut up.” Katsuki stared at the ceiling, breathing slowly. He pulled a crumpled piece of paper from his pocket and looked at it for a moment. “Shit, I can’t do this.”

He stood, looking too large for the restaurant. Face set, he dropped some money on the table. “For the coffee.”

“Don’t leave like this,” Izuku whispered. Katsuki leaned over him, one hand on the table.

“Deku, you weren’t wrong. We obviously have a lot of history and it’s not easy for us to communicate. Let me explain something, though. I know I was avoiding talking about a relationship. I was being selfish - I wasn’t ready for the discussion, but I fucking know how you are. I should have known you’d hate not knowing what to call us, but it didn’t fucking cross my mind, so I’m sorry.”

“But let me be clear. I want to be with you,” he ground out, cheeks red. “Fucking hell, Deku, I just wanted to take things slow. My life is a raging shit show right now, and I felt like I couldn’t be a good fucking boyfriend and I wanted to be the best for you.”

Izuku’s mouth dropped open. Katsuki’s gaze dropped briefly to his lips, then back up. “I’d planned to ask you out tonight. I want us to date. We’ll work up to everything else.”

Yeah, Izuku had fucked up.

“I still think we should,” Katsuki said, fiercely, unrelenting. “We just gotta figure out how to talk. I’m so fucking keyed up right now I want to level the building, so I’m gonna go take a walk. No way I'm going to let myself lose my goddamn temper again, so I'm gonna get some goddamn air. But I fucking think we should be together, and if you agree, then tell me. I promise we’ll figure shit out.” He stared at Izuku for a moment longer, looking conflicted, and then he was gone.

Izuku was definitely the fuck up here. He’d shot himself in his own foot, and he was bleeding out. On the table sat enough money for maybe ten coffees, Katsuki’s untouched drink, and the crumpled piece of paper. Feeling shaky, Izuku reached for it. After carefully unfolding it, he saw Katsuki’s terrible handwriting. It was some sort of list. It was hard to read, but from what he could make out, it seemed to be notes on how to talk to Izuku.

-listen + don’t swear too much

-sincere apology - acknowledge what was wrong & explain understanding

-sorry for - calling him needy / not explaining relationship / losing temper / being an asshole

-ask deku to not run away / to not fcking guilt trip me

-reframe what he says so he knows you understand

-get space before losing temper

-ask to take it slow. Date???

-try not being a dickhole

Izuku didn't know whether to laugh or cry. He'd massively underestimated Katsuki, and he felt terrible about it. Somehow, in the back of his head, he'd never really believed Katsuki would *actually* want him. It was too ingrained in who he was, how he'd grown up, that even when Katsuki had said it to his face, he hadn't been able to believe it.

He smoothed the paper with trembling hands. Katsuki had left it behind accidentally, but there was no better proof that he was honestly trying. Izuku's heart had made a permanent home in his throat, his pulse hammering in his ears. He was distantly aware that what he did now would impact his foreseeable future.

Before he knew it, he was moving, paper shoved in his pocket, running out of the restaurant in search of Katsuki. He skidded to a halt on the sidewalk, cool night air at odds with his burning cheeks. Katsuki wasn't in sight. Restraining himself from just aimlessly searching the neighborhood, he pulled out his phone and hit Kacchan's number.

One ring, and he picked up.

"Yo, Deks," he said, like he hadn't just punched Izuku's heart clean out his ribcage.

"You left your paper," Izuku said into the phone, shivering slightly.

"Oh." Then he heard a gravelly laugh. "Embarrassing. Yeah, uh... I was in anger management for six years, and my counselor gave me a lot of tips for communicating. Fucking making a list of what I needed to say was one way to help me from losing my shit every time I have to cough up an emotion."

"Kacchan," Izuku trailed off. His chest hurt. He needed to get Katsuki back. "Where did you go?"

"Roof. Marseilles Hotel. I'm on top of the greenhouse." The line clicked dead. Well, that was an invitation, right? Unsure how Katsuki had got up there, Izuku indulged in some light Full Cowling to leap to the roof of the hotel. Katsuki was right where he'd said he'd be, reclining on a slanted skylight. He sat up as Izuku landed next to him. It was a cool night, stars just beginning to show. Sounds from the streets drifted up - a couple's laughter, a dog barking, vendors selling their wares. Katsuki gave him a small nod.

"Hey, nerd."

"I'm the nerd, but you brought notes," Izuku said, fondness overwhelming him.

"Motherfucker, I said I was going to do this right," Katsuki snorted. "Why are you here?"

"It's just… thanks for you know, this. For being here and for trying." Izuku's heart was pounding in his ears. When Katsuki was being like this, it was impossible to ignore his feelings. Damn, how he loved him. Friendship had probably been his worst idea to date. Would he look wishy-washy if he tried to take it back? He could taste the bitter regret in his mouth.

“Deku,” Katsuki said, his face in shadow. “Why are you here?”

What a great question. “How would it work?” Izuku said. “What if it goes badly? What if I keep being reminded of the past and lash out at you? What if I keep running?”

Katsuki’s expression softened, and he scooted closer, putting an arm around Izuku. “It’ll be fine.”

“Oh,” Izuku managed to say. He was tearing up, and he rubbed his eyes. Next to him, Katsuki sighed. Izuku continued, feeling the need to fill the silence. “But what I said hurt you, before. I hate that. I hate that it’s so hard for us to talk through things.”

“Yeah, I know. Seems like a shit idea, right?”

“Yeah,” Izuku sniffed. Katsuki took a deep breath, turning Izuku to face him.

"Yeah. Look, I know you said you want to be friends, but *fuck* that. I mean, fuck, if that’s your choice, fine. I can’t force you, but… Look, I don’t care if you bring up the past every time it hurts you. I don’t care if you lash out at me. Fuck, Deku, I deserve to feel bad for that. At least let me be there for you when it happens.”

“Kacchan,” Izuku whispered. In his wildest dreams, he’d never imagined Katsuki saying something like that. He was done for. There was no resisting this anymore.

“Please fucking date me.”

Izuku was unable to form words. If he’d been less overwhelmed, he’d probably have burst into tears. Happy tears. Katsuki cleared his throat nervously. “Um, I know you said you want to be friends, but maybe take some time to think it over and-”

“Does this count as a first date,” Izuku blurted, cheeks burning. Katsuki’s mouth dropped open. Then as what Izuku’d said sunk in, a smile formed. Not a sneer, or a grin, but a genuine smile.

“Fuck no,” he said, clearly struggling not to smile like an idiot. “I’m taking you somewhere nice for that. But uh, does this mean that you…”

“As if I could resist you,” Izuku sighed, fighting a smile of his own. “I guess we’re dating, then?”

Katsuki took Izuku’s cheek in one big hand. “Yes,” he simply said, and kissed Izuku slowly, his lips lingering. He pulled back, gaze searching Izuku’s eyes. “You could try sounding more excited about it, though. Jesus.”

Izuku snorted with unexpected laughter and threw his arms around Katsuki’s shoulders. The man straightened, lifting Izuku onto his lap and into a tight hug. “I’m so happy, Kacchan,” Izuku mumbled over his shoulder.

“Me too, baby,” Katsuki rumbled, squeezing him. Izuku’s brain melted out of his ears. They were already using pet names? And god damn, it was affecting Izuku a lot. He was blushing

hard enough his cheeks might actually melt off.

“So um,” Izuku said, as Katsuki released, “What do you wanna do now?”

“Go back to your place and look at all your nerd books,” Katsuki said promptly. “I need to research, and your’s is better than the crap I can find online.”

Miraculously, Izuku was able to blush even harder than before. Katsuki grinned at him. “You’re such a fucking happy dork when I compliment your nerd shit,” he said, as if he was deeply proud of this.

“I hate you,” Izuku replied, rubbing his face. “Let’s go.”

“Kay, baby.”

“Stop calling me that!”

“I will when you stop blushing like a virgin. It's too fucking funny.”

“Did I mention how much I hate you?”

“Keep it up, *baby,* I like it when you’re feisty.”

“Let’s break up,” Izuku growled, as Katsuki tested the fire escape.

“Fuck no, you’re stuck with me now,” Katsuki laughed, throwing an arm around Izuku’s shoulders. “Hashtag no take backsies.”

“I can’t believe that sentence just came out of your mouth,” Izuku grumbled, but a happy Katsuki was a shameless one, and Izuku was having a hard time being salty when Katsuki’s warm arm was holding him close.

They walked all the way back to Izuku’s apartment, enjoying the night. They were both quiet, thinking about the conversation they'd just had. Izuku's stomach growled.

"You eaten since your shift?"

Katsuki, being concerned about him. Izuku ate it right up. "Nope." Katsuki looked at him sidelong.

"Do you even have real groceries in your house? Chips and salsa do not count, Deku."

Izuku pouted. "I've been busy."

“You’re a walking disaster,” Katsuki muttered, dragging them into a convenience store. Izuku found it best to wait by the register while Katsuki stormed through the store, finally emerging with three bags of groceries.

“That’s gonna go bad in my house,” Izuku pointed out.

“I’m cooking,” Katsuki said, as if that explained everything. Izuku didn’t ask, because visions of Personal Chef Katsuki were dancing in his head.

Izuku hadn’t been far off the mark. He sat on the couch, draped over the back, watching Katsuki fuss around the kitchen. Izuku cut his finger *one* time and suddenly he was banished from the kitchen forever. Unbelievable. On the other hand, he could die happy watching Katsuki cook. He obviously knew what he was doing, and Izuku strongly suspected he cooked most of his own meals, most likely out of some anal need to get the perfect amount of nutrients.

Dinner was chicken katsu and rice, with vegetable sides. Izuku watched in horror as Katsuki upended a bottle of hot sauce over his, completely smothering it. He was dating a monster. Dating. Izuku made some kind of face.

“What?” Katsuki said.

“You scare me,” Izuku muttered, earning an eye roll. “I honestly don’t get why you even bother cooking. Why don’t you just drink the hot sauce and be done with it?”

Katsuki gave him a scornful look. “A diet of hot sauce wouldn’t hit my macros. You ever think about how many calories it takes to make explosive sweat? It’s fucking hard to build muscle when everything I eat… you’re not even listening anymore, are you.”

Izuku wasn’t. His brain had kicked into overdrive: all these years and he’d never even considered how calorie intake could factor into Katsuki’s quirk. Did he even have space left in his Kacchan notebook? And what if he ate different food - how did his body convert it into pseudo-nitroglycerin sweat? Would different food be processed differently or over a different rate in time? Would-

“Sweetheart,” Katsuki said, snapping in Izuku’s face. Izuku’s mind screeched to a halt, as he blushed horribly.

“Why,” Izuku groaned, face in his hands. His face was redder than Katsuki’s monstrous hot sauce puddle.

“You’re fuckin’ weak,” Katsuki snickered. “Oh wait, I meant: You’re fucking weak, *sweetheart* .”

“And you’re an asshole,” Izuku said, finally looking up. No sense in hiding his face. Let Katsuki see what hideous blotches of blush he’d created.

“You’ve got such a dirty mouth, sweetheart,” Katsuki replied, back to deadpan. “I thought you liked my asshole.”

“I know you’re just teasing me,” Izuku said, refusing to fall for the bait. He’d finally figured it out. Bakugou Katsuki, probably the most foul-mouthed hero to ever get their license, loved

to call people names. Of course that would apply to his relationships, too, and from the feel of things, his intention remained the same: to torment Izuku within an inch of his life.

“Not the kind of teasing I really want to do… Pumpkin.” Yep, just tormenting Izuku.

“I’m not talking to you,” Izuku said. “At least not until I’m done eating. Your hot sauce horror show is ruining my appetite.” It wasn’t true. Literally nothing would stop Izuku from eating something Katsuki had cooked for him, but he was starting to love the way Katsuki’s lips twitched with humor every time Izuku teased him.

Izuku left Katsuki with a pile of his journals while he did the dishes. It was surprisingly peaceful, especially once Katsuki had (at least temporarily) grown tired of making Izuku blush by throwing around pet names. There was something fundamentally endearing about Katsuki hunched over, paging through Izuku’s journals, occasionally humming or asking him a question. It made Izuku feel strangely whole, like there’d been a chunk of his life missing and he’d somehow never noticed before Katsuki had come and filled it.

He was nearly done with wiping down the counters when he noticed the screen of Katsuki’s abandoned screen lighting up.

“Kacchan? Someone’s calling you.”

“When aren’t they,” Katsuki muttered, not looking up. Feeling strangely guilty, Izuku watched the call go to voicemail. Izuku never missed calls, and he if did, he called back promptly. Then he saw his lock screen. 179 missed calls. 324 unread texts.

“Um, Kacchan? That’s a lot of missed calls.”

Katsuki finally looked up, eyes narrowed. “I’ve been avoiding my phone since yesterday,” he said, voice like death. “My PR rep is going to gut me. I finally got you to date me and I'm not ready to die yet.”

“Dude, you can’t just ignore it forever,” Izuku said, unthinkingly falling into concerned-classmate mode. Katsuki snorted.

“Sure, okay. Want me to answer it right now? I’ll put it on fucking speakerphone. It’ll be a fun bonding activity.”

Izuku stared him down, calling his bluff. “Yeah, do that.” He joined Katsuki on the couch, pushing his journals out of the way. They set the phone on the coffee table, and waited for it to ring again. Something about the situation had Izuku bubbling with barely restrained laughter - two top heroes, afraid of a phone call.

He was so focused on the phone’s screen that he squeaked in surprise when Katsuki dropped into his lap like a sack of potatoes.

With the absolute most bored expression possible, he said, “Hold me, I’m scared.”

Izuku burst into laughter but obediently pulled Katsuki into his arms. Then the phone went off.

“Ah, it’s Ono. This one’s PR.” Katsuki grabbed the phone, answering it and putting it on speakerphone.

“Yo, what’s up,” he said, eyes meeting Izuku’s. Izuku swallowed another laugh.

“ *-swear if you don’t,* wait, Bakugou-san? Are you actually there?”

“Why are you calling me? I’m busy.” Katsuki’s lips twitched in his typical not-smile. Izuku put a hand over his mouth, trying not to laugh. He felt almost guilty for having fun when whoever worked in Katsuki’s PR division must be living a daily nightmare.

“Busy?! Are you kidding me?! Busy ruining our entire firm, maybe! What were you thinking! Did you not think to discuss anything with anyone before you ever open your insolent, immature little mouth-” Katsuki muted the phone.

“Do your PR reps yell at you like this," he whispered to Izuku.

“I am a joy to work with and everyone loves me,” Izuku smirked at him. Katsuki stuck his tongue out, but switched the volume back on.

“-you ever pull something like that again I swear I will get you arrested and-”

“Ono?”

“What?!”

“Sorry for being a dick and not talking to you beforehand.”

“It’s fine, Katsuki,” came a heavy sigh. Apparently they were more familiar than the irate call had initially let on.

“Actually didn’t plan to say that bullshit,” Katsuki said, looking up at Izuku. That look was doing funny things to his heartbeat. “I was just sick of trying to tone down who I am.”

“Well,” the voice on the phone sounded simultaneously gruff and fond. “It’s okay. Just tell us next time, we could have prepped so much! We missed out on probably thousands of opportunities to capitalize on this success, but at least it went over well.”

“Wait, what?” Katsuki looked shocked.

“You’ve been hiding from the internet, again.” From her tone of voice, this was a frequent thing. Given how many controversial articles about Ground Zero there were, Izuku figured this made sense.

“Can you blame me after that video shit?”

“Katsuki, check the internet. Get a newspaper. Go outside. Look anywhere! Go on, I’ll wait.”

Izuku pulled out his phone. He hadn't been keeping track either, at least not since the day before. He'd been a little preoccupied. Katsuki propped himself up, looking over his shoulder. The #1 trending hashtag was #YoureWelcomeGZ. Confused, Izuku clicked it, and was suddenly awash in stories about Ground Zero.

"What the ever-living fuck…" Katsuki trailed off, pulling the phone from Izuku's hands.

"Yeah," Ono said, her voice full of meaning. "Apparently after you said 'Thank you very much,' like a complete and utter idiot by the way, someone thought it would be funny to say 'You're welcome' after describing a time you saved him from some muggers. I just sent you the original cheep."

Katsuki's phone pinged, and Izuku opened it. The thing had a shocking 5 million recheeps, and was a reply to the TV network's clip of Katsuki's shocking statement. The tweet read,

"@Ground Zero, you're welcome for the time I let you save my life from people willing to kill me for the 10 yen in my pocket. My daughter says you're welcome, too. <prayer emoji> #YoureWelcomeGZ #TYVM #BringDatAssBack #GroundZero #ProHero" The cheep was accompanied by a picture of an older man with his teenage daughter, who was sullenly smiling while wearing a shirt with the classic Ground Zero orange X on it. Izuku was floored and found himself recheeping it without a thought.

Katsuki was still scrolling through his phone, mouth open. Story after story appeared of times Ground Zero had helped someone, from bringing a crying kid's toy out of debris to stopping dangerous supervillains to everyday robberies. The stories were often accompanied by fan-taken photos, showing a blurry angle of a scowling Ground Zero, and very occasionally, a photo of one of Katsuki's rare smiles after a job well done.

"Right?" Ono's voice came through the phone. "The country decided, Katsuki. They want you."

"Oh," Katsuki said, voice sounding choked. Izuku held him tighter, heart constricting. The pure disbelief and awe on Katsuki's face was heart-wrenching; he clearly hadn't believed anyone would accept him. He'd thought he'd have to *fight* harder to gain people's trust. That the only way forward was to forcibly become the best, because then no one could deny him.

It turned out that the last seven years of back-breaking, constant work had made an impact. Izuku watched as Katsuki teared up, face tight.

"Holy fuck," Katsuki whispered, hand trembling over the screen. "Holy fuck."

Izuku kissed his forehead. "So proud of you, Katsuki," he murmured.

"Should I call back later?" Ono said, gently. Izuku loved her in that moment. She clearly knew Katsuki well and cared for his well-being. "I'll keep the dogs off your back a little longer. Maybe consider how you want to reply to this, though. I've only seen things like this a few times in my career, so treasure this. People won't always appreciate you, in this line of work."

“I know. Thanks, Ono. I’ll come by the office tomorrow, okay?”

“See you then.” The line clicked dead.

They sat in stunned silence for a moment.

“I’ve gotta,” Katsuki trailed off. “I can’t believe they would…”

“I know,” Izuku said, looking through the cheeps. Someone talked about a time Ground Zero had visited their kid in the hospital after they’d been burned in a fire, about how Ground Zero had demolished wall that had collapsed on them, had carried someone to the medics while under enemy fire, had faced down terrifying villains when no one else was there to help… the list went on and on.

Katsuki pushed himself up on the couch and took a selfie. After a moment of typing, he showed the screen to Izuku. It was a picture of him, looking strangely mundane in his orange shirt and tired eyes. He had the ghost of a smile, and his eyes were a little damp, full of emotion. The caption just read, “So fucking grateful. Thanks, everyone.”

“Send it,” Izuku said, watching as Katsuki hit the *cheep* button. Then immediately tossed the phone across the room, covering his face.

“I can’t believe this,” he groaned. Izuku pulled him into a hug, feeling Katsuki’s trembling under his hands. He traced slow circles over the man’s back, hoping to calm him. It was strange to see Katsuki vulnerable in any way, and it made Izuku feel extremely protective. “I thought they all hated me,” Katsuki muttered.

“It’s not that hard to see what a good person you are,” Izuku told him quietly. “I see it, and now everyone else can too. You earned this, Kacchan.”

Katsuki looked up at him, his face full of hope and longing. “It was you, you know. I said that shit because of what you told me. It’s always been you. You’re… everything.”

Izuku wasn’t sure exactly what he meant, but the momentous feel of the words stole his breath. Katsuki kissed him, and all hopes of breathing flew out the window, lost in the night sky. Because it was the same for Izuku - it had always been Bakugou Katsuki. They were binary stars, circling each other endlessly, their combined light brighter than it could ever be if they shone alone.

Chapter End Notes

So proud of them for trying their best <3

This chapter took so much rewriting, and I really struggled with handling such a long-ass conversation. That said, it was actually kind of cathartic to have them address the angst I've been slinging around this whole time.

I'm a total sucker for redemption stories, so I'm hard-core weak for Bakugou's. Poor guy obviously tries so damn hard that you just want people to look past his terrible attitude and acknowledge him.

Again, thanks all for reading, kudosing and commenting <3 it means the world to have people share the nonsense in my head, and I'm very grateful

Cute and Nice

Chapter Summary

Every time they touch, Izuku gets this feeling
Every time they kiss, he swears he can fly

Or,

Izuku works on his insecurities and Bakugou is very smug in general

Chapter Notes

If there's ever anything you think needs tagged, let me know and I'll add it <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Katsuki slept at Izuku's apartment that night. The revelation about #YoureWelcomeGZ had left them both emotionally raw, and Izuku was perceptive enough to be particularly gentle with Katsuki. So with tender kisses and other mind-numbingly sweet embraces, they fell asleep.

Katsuki slept amazingly. The man passed out while using Izuku like a teddy bear so Izuku hardly slept at all, because Katsuki was a goddamn furnace. Still, he must have slept at some point because eventually, he woke up naked with of all the covers kicked off of him, and *still* burning up from the way Katsuki had barnacled to his back. His clothes lay across the room, where he'd flung them in a half-awake, desperate bid to cool off.

He only spent like, five minutes having an existential crisis about Katsuki sleeping in the same bed with him. Or not sleeping, because when he fidgeted, a raspy morning voice came from behind him.

"Finally awake, nerd?"

Oh, the joys of dating Bakugou Katsuki. Izuku gets to be called 'nerd' before it's even 6:00 AM.

Like some kind of eldritch horror, Katsuki climbed over him until his face dangled above Izuku's. A handsome eldritch horror, with sharp cheekbones and sharp eyes and a sharp smile. Too sharp for morning-Izuku, who turned away.

"You are a horribly, horribly warm person," Izuku mumbled, blinking in the morning light.

“I noticed you lost your clothes.”

“Your fault, and for all the wrong reasons.”

Katsuki laughed, eyes creasing in humor. “Man, this actually happens all the time.”

“All the time?” Izuku managed to say, his brain struggling to catch up. He’d forgotten Katsuki slept around. He was barely even awake, damn it.

“Before you, dork,” Katsuki snorted, dropping himself onto Izuku’s stomach. So. damn. warm. Izuku squirmed, ignoring Katsuki's apparent morning interests. He grinned down at Izuku. “Anyway, that’s not what’s important.”

“I barely slept,” Izuku told him, slowly assembling some form of alertness.

“Tough shit. Ask me what’s important.”

“I can’t, I’m too sleepy,” Izuku yawned, turning away to hide a smile. Teasing Katsuki was too easy. Katsuki clambered over him again, dropping his phone next to his face.

“Todoroki texted me this morning.”

“And?" Izuku groaned. "I wanna sleep."

"And," Katsuki continued, squishing both of Izuku's cheeks with one hand, "The half n' half loser is congratulating me."

"That's nice of him," Izuku sighed. He needed to get up and start his morning workout routine, but he was sleepy and didn’t want to leave Katsuki. His eyes were drifting shut, until Katsuki savagely poked him in the cheek. Izuku’s eyes flew back open.

“You’re an asshole in the morning,” he grumbled.

“I’m always an asshole, but you aren’t always so grumpy,” Katsuki scoffed. “Not a morning person, Deku?”

“I am, but not when I have to sleep next to someone with a body temperature of 3,000 degrees.”

“Yes, I am *that* hot,” Katsuki replied, turning smug again. “You’re a lucky nerd, huh?”

“Hate you.”

"Wanna bet?" Katsuki started kissing his way down Izuku’s chest, apparently impervious to Izuku’s grumpy mood. “Let’s find out if you’re still saying that after I…” his voice trailed off as he nipped the inside of Izuku’s thigh.

“Mmm,” Izuku hummed, his voice sounding a little high-pitched. “Whatcha doing down there, Kacchan?” So what if he was already hard? He could blame it on morning wood, or he

could acknowledge that shirtless Katsuki was just that hot. 3,000 degrees, figuratively. He moaned as Katsuki began to stroke him, his hand warm and deft.

“I’m being an asshole,” he chuckled. Izuku could feel his breath against his skin. It was his only warning before Katsuki licked the length of Izuku’s dick, making him cry out softly. Izuku was wide awake now, and felt his whole body shudder when Katsuki took him in his mouth. For a moment, the sensation was too overwhelming to move. But Izuku had a pathological need to see Katsuki, so he pushed himself up on his elbows. Even that was a feat given how fucking distracted he was.

Katsuki was lounging across the bed, more or less perpendicular to Izuku. He was only wearing black underwear, and the dusky morning light threw shadows across his muscles in sharp relief. He was propped up on one arm, the other hand playing with Izuku’s dick while he grinned like the Cheshire cat. “Morning, sunshine,” he said, seeing Izuku had half-sat up.

“Well?” Izuku said, his voice husky. He hadn’t necessarily expected this. Actually, he’d rarely managed to fantasize about Katsuki, the thoughts feeling too off-limits. But when he did, it was never like this.

“Gonna blow your sleepy nerd mind,” Katsuki said before licking him again, slowly. "Gonna wake you up so you fucking listen to me."

When he finally started sucking Izuku off, he was still slow, languid, his body relaxed. Izuku could live forever in this moment, watching Katsuki’s messy, blond head move slowly up and down, each movement shooting fire through his veins. Yes, he could live like that forever, except that it was driving him absolutely mad. Katsuki was teasing him, and Izuku was tired, horny, and relatively annoyed.

Pushing himself up to his elbows, he reached down to grab Katsuki’s hair, just to hurry him up a little. And maybe a little, tiny bit of vengeance. Except once he had a hold of that choppy blonde hair, he couldn’t help but grab hold. Couldn’t help but push Katsuki’s head down harder, the need too strong to resist. A few more thrusts upwards and Katsuki was actually making choking noises. Izuku pulled him off his dick by his hair.

“Like it when I’m rough?” he found himself saying. He wasn’t exactly sure where this attitude had come from, but damn, Katsuki looked good with a thin line of drool falling from his lips, eyes wide and wet.

“I should piss you off every morning,” Katsuki replied, voice raspy.

“That’s not an answer,” Izuku told him, gripping his hair tighter. To be fair, Izuku usually *was* submissive, but there was something different with Katsuki. Maybe it was the sheer pleasure of controlling someone with such a massive ego, or watching a maybe the most prideful person in the country debase himself for Izuku but… he was addicted to it.

“Knock yourself out, Deku,” Katsuki said, voice rough. “Knock me out while you’re at it, too.”

It was all the permission Izuku needed. He wanted Katsuki's face back on his cock, and he got it. He blithely ignored his own obscene noises and focused on the jolt of pleasure that came each time he thrust into Katsuki's mouth.

He might deny it later, but what pushed him over the edge was holding Katsuki down while he choked, fucking Katsuki's mouth mercilessly. He came hard, with some kind of breathy wail, and finally released Katsuki, who coughed, face on Izuku's stomach. Izuku was too gone to care, his body buzzing pleasantly with the after-effects of his orgasm.

Then, Katsuki began his second eldritch horror impression of the morning by climbing up Izuku's stomach, mouth wet, eyes and nose streaming. Izuku blinked at him, his mind still static.

"Deku," Katsuki rumbled. "What the hell."

Izuku's eyes flew open. "Wait, was that too much? Oh my god I'm so s-"

"No," Katsuki laughed breathily. "Just. What. When? How did you get so fucking pushy, huh?" He dropped onto the bed next to Izuku, head on his chest. "I thought I was gonna have to fucking woo you with like, flowers and shit to make you put out."

"Who doesn't think that," Izuku muttered, a little resentful. Though not that resentful, because he really didn't have the ability for negative emotions yet. And Katsuki had considered *wooing* him? What?

"But you just drop into my life, ready to wreck my shit," Katsuki sighed. "So fucking good. Never change."

"Oh." Izuku blinked down at him, and with effort, Katsuki hauled himself up for a kiss. A deep kiss that tasted like cum. Ugh. Izuku kissed him anyway, because it was technically his own fault, and this was likely Katsuki's revenge. Which he deserved to have, given what Izuku had just done to him.

"Anyway," Katsuki said, eyes gleaming, "How did it feel to throat fuck the country's #8 hero?"

"What?!" Izuku shouted. "You, what?"

"That's what I was trying to tell you earlier," Katsuki grinned, looking horribly smug. Way too smug for someone just choking on Izuku's cock.

"You *jerk!* " Izuku wailed. "Kacchan, why didn't you say so! That's amazing!"

"Damn right," Katsuki purred. The smug effect was somewhat ruined as he wiped his face with a corner of the blanket. "Todoroki was so fucking sour I beat him that he congratulated me. What a joke."

"He was probably being sincere," Izuku sighed.

“For a guy with zero sense of humor, that fucker is never sincere," Katsuki huffed. Neither of those things was true. Todoroki had a great sense of humor, and Izuku didn’t know anyone more sincere than him. But there was no point in arguing with Katsuki about Shouto. The two of them had some weird truce that apparently didn't include viciously insulting each other, but Izuku wisely stayed out of it.

"Well, I'm being sincere. Congratulations." Izuku didn’t bother to hide how proud he felt.

"Thanks, baby." That was accompanied by a peck on the forehead. "Gonna clean up."

Izuku spent another five minutes marveling at how much pet names ruined his train of thought, before following him to the bathroom.

Apparently becoming part of the Top Ten meant Katsuki became hellishly busy. Izuku, amazingly, could hardly be bothered to miss Katsuki. He was also horrifically busy; he barely had time to breathe. And when he did, Katsuki’s face was plastered on something - someone’s merch, TV screens, posters. #YoureWelcomeGZ was overwhelming, and Katsuki was strutting around in the eye of the storm. Mina always called him an attention whore, and it was hard to refute at this point.

As the newest member of the Top Ten, he’d been immediately dragged into the highest-level investigations. He’d been working crazy hours, getting caught up on cases. Izuku saw him once when he dropped by to grab more of Izuku’s journals and exactly one heated kiss.

Izuku tried to quell the feeling that he was being left behind.

He still somehow found time to text Izuku constantly. Izuku wondered if anyone ever asked him to stop, but, well, he could easily imagine how well that would go. (Very badly.)

So, somehow, despite officially dating for over a week, the next time Izuku saw him was at work. It was at one of the rolling, monthly meetings meant to keep everyone up to date on major threats and efforts. To keep everyone on the same page, so to speak. Various top heroes gave rundowns, and Izuku took attentive notes.

Then it was Katsuki giving a presentation. Somehow, it had been ages since he'd seen Katsuki do anything in an official Hero Association capacity, and it was giving him a sense of vertigo. Katsuki was dressed in his typical inactive-duty Ground Zero outfit of a tight black tank top with the orange X, sleek gray sweatpants, boots, and sunglasses atop his blond hair. He slapped a big stack of papers on the lectern, and launched into a nuanced summary of the last year in his industrial sector, as well as projections for the future.

It was all too easy to forget that Katsuki had been consistently at the top of every class. It was all too hard to forget that he'd also been choking on Izuku's dick earlier that week. The persistent sense of vertigo returned, but Izuku was also an excellent student, so he took

meticulous notes even if he blushed his way through the entire talk. Even if he couldn't help but notice the other brave souls in the room checking Katsuki out. He even managed not to be that jealous about it.

He'd nearly made it out of the building when someone yanked him into an empty hallway. On guard, Izuku grabbed the arm, used their momentum against them, and slammed Katsuki into the wall. The man blinked at him, sunglasses askew.

"Wow, Deks, you really are a dom."

"Don't surprise me like that!" Izuku squeaked.

"I take it back, after hearing *that* noise," Katsuki snorted. "You sound like someone stepped on a chihuahua."

"And you look," Izuku meant to shoot back, but ended up losing his train of thought. Katsuki looked like sex and danger, leaning against the wall as if Izuku hadn't just thrown him there. The phrases *hot as hell* and *drop-dead gorgeous* (emphases on the 'drop dead') ran through his mind.

"Earth to Deku," Katsuki said. "I'm trying to ask you out, you fucker."

"I thought we were already going out?" Izuku said, considering the words. They had been, hadn't they? Even if they hadn't spent time together, they'd been in touch. Thanks to Katsuki's clingy texting, he even knew when the man was showering or… Actually, maybe that was intentional. There were some steamy photos of Katsuki with highly strategic camera placement in his messages, and-

"A date, Deku," Katsuki waved a hand in front of his face. "Did I actually suck the last brain cell out of your pretty little head?"

"Maybe," Izuku laughed. "Um, when?"

"Tonight," Katsuki grunted. "Don't care if you're working, take the night off."

"Wow."

"I'm on the Striker case now," Katsuki grinned, looking a bit maniacal. He must be excited about it. "I start next week. Gonna be swamped."

"Just tell me when and where," said Izuku. "Though Uraraka's gonna throw a fit if I skip karaoke again." He did feel guilty about it, actually. He didn't think she'd really begrudge him once he explained the situation.

Katsuki stared at him, red eyes turned amber in the afternoon sun. "I'm sorry, but when did I give you the impression I that gave a shit?"

It's typically hard to be mad at someone so pretty, but Katsuki makes it easy. "'Cause I give a shit about my friends," Izuku said sternly. "And you supposedly give a shit about me."

“Fine!” Katsuki threw his hands in the air. “Asshole. Dinner at seven, and we can go to your motherfucking karaoke nightmare after.”

“Thanks, Kacchan!” Izuku was immune to this particular form of temper tantrum, and darted forwards to hug Katsuki. “You’re the best.” He was rewarded with a soft kiss on the top of his head.

“I definitely am.”

Katsuki collected Izuku from his apartment at 6:45 PM.

“Exactly how many pairs of sunglasses do you have?” Izuku asked. These ones were ray bans with an incredibly tacky fire pattern on the sides. Katsuki was literally the only person who could have pulled them off, and then only because anyone who said otherwise might be found later, with limbs missing.

“Twenty or more,” Katsuki replied, like this was normal.

“Freak,” Izuku muttered.

“Yo, some of us don’t want to wear the same shit every day.”

“I’m cute, and I don’t care what you think,” Izuku replied. He'd put on a different shirt for this, damn it. Dark blue jeans and nice, crew neck sweatshirt were good, right? Maybe a little plain, but it was hard to look good next to Katsuki, who’d somehow developed an eccentric fashion taste over time in addition to his pathological need to stand out. No matter what Izuku wore, it was impossible to match him. Today it was a neon orange, velvet bomber over a white shirt with some violent-looking green graphic on it, and jeans so light they were nearly white.

“Anyway, you can’t talk. You look like a cheeto,” Izuku said, running his hands over the jacket. It was nice, he had to admit, if not a bit eccentric. Katsuki leaned into the touch. “A soft cheeto,” Izuku amended.

“You look like a freshman asked to prom by a senior,” Bakugo chuckled. “Fucking wanna rip your clothes off and dress you myself.” Izuku swallowed hard. He totally hadn’t imagined that scenario before. Definitely not.

“Some of us don’t want to wear cheeto-jackets,” Izuku sniffed instead, but Katsuki wouldn’t take the bait.

“Sure, nerd. Come on, katsudon’s waiting.”

Izuku made some excited, unholy screeching noise related to katsudon, which Katsuki barely tolerated, and the two of them were off. On a date. It only took Izuku the entire cab ride to stop blushing. They ended up somewhere south of the city, away from the towering high-rises and press of people.

“Two, for Katsuki,” Katsuki said at the door. Izuku supposed his last name was a little recognizable. The hostess led them into the restaurant, a small, homey affair filled with savory smells and the quiet chatter of happy people. They were led to a booth in the back, out of sight of most of the restaurant, and definitely of the street. Izuku wondered if Katsuki had planned this, too. The whole thing was surreal. He wondered if it would ever start to feel real. Could he live in a reality where Katsuki took him on dates? Called him pet names? Promised to go to karaoke with him?

Regardless of Izuku’s grasp on reality, Katsuki thumped a menu down in front of him. Izuku stared at it like he’d never seen a menu before.

“If you don’t order katsudon, I’m going to lose my shit,” he said. Izuku gradually returned to earth.

“What?”

“Supposedly this is the best place. Been thinking about this for ages.”

“What?” Izuku was starting to sound like Kaminari after sticking a fork in a socket (they’d only done it once, just to see what happened. What happened was exactly what you’d expect).

“Where I’d take you, if we went out,” Katsuki said, very patiently. Too patiently. When Izuku managed to look at his face, he could see the temper brewing. Izuku mentally added ‘Katsuki putting effort into dates’ into his improbable multiverse theory.

“What else am I getting, then?” Izuku offered a smile. Katsuki ordered for them, clearly having thought this through. Izuku was impressed, despite himself.

He was right. The katsudon was amazing. Barring the homemade version he’d grown up, it might be the best he’d ever had, though he could be biased by the company. Katsuki had put a relatively horrifying amount of chili flakes on his, enough that Izuku actually felt compelled to apologize to the waitress.

Eating was fine. Easy. Izuku didn’t have to talk, and Katsuki seemed relatively satisfied at Izuku’s rapturous expressions. After that it was harder. As Izuku straightened his napkin for maybe the thirtieth time, Katsuki slapped the table. He jumped.

“Are you fucking nervous, or something?” Katsuki demanded.

“Way to call me out,” Izuku folded his arms. Katsuki’s expression immediately softened.

“You don’t need to be nervous,” he said, much more quietly. He looked almost sad, and Izuku suddenly realized that it probably bothered him.

“It’s not you,” Izuku said, leaning in. “Well, maybe a tiny bit. But I actually haven’t been on a date in a really long time.” he blushed at the admission. Katsuki’s mouth quirked up.

“Same here.”

“Wait, really? I thought you saw like, a lot of people.”

“Deku, you’re way too pure to fuck like you do,” Katsuki snorted. “I don’t date hookups.”

“Oh. Right.”

Then Katsuki was chuckling, then laughing. “Shit,” he said between laughs, “It’s been, what, three years since I've been on a date? I’m fucking washed up.”

“Two, for me,” Izuku said, getting caught up in the humor. “At least one since I’ve gotten laid. Talk about washed up.”

Katsuki immediately started violently coughing. Izuku pushed a glass of water across the table, but otherwise watched in amusement. “I just never really felt the urge to hook up with people,” he said, as Katsuki sipped water.

“You...” he began hoarsely. “That’s so long. No wonder you’re so fucking horny.”

“Hey, not all of us want to fuck someone new every day,” Izuku snipped. Maybe, just maybe, he felt a little insecure about it.

“Don’t slut-shame me,” Katsuki pointed at him. Izuku almost felt bad, until Katsuki gave him a toothy grin. “I’m too busy to fit someone in every day.”

“And now there’s me,” Izuku risked saying. Did Katsuki miss his hookups? He was ready to spiral into that train of thought, until-

“I could fit in you every day.”

Izuku sighed. “Don’t know why I expected you to say anything else.” Katsuki looked enormously pleased with himself. “No, I actually expected you to be a lot more, uh. Pushy. Aggressive?”

Katsuki’s smile faded. “Deku, you’re like,” he trailed off. Then smacked the table again, making Izuku jump. “See! You’re jumpy as hell around me and I hate it. Not gonna throw you around when you’re like that. You’re supposed to enjoy it, not be fucking afraid.”

“I’m not afraid,” Izuku said automatically.

“And why’d you want to date me if you thought I was going to be like that, huh?”

“Maybe I liked the idea,” Izuku snapped, annoyed with Katsuki’s concern. He hated feeling like he was being babied, even if Katsuki was trying to be considerate. Which he technically did appreciate. Katsuki was staring at him, hands pressed together, apparently lost in thought.

“Kacchan?”

“Sh. I’m imagining what exactly you like the idea of.”

“Well, I didn’t expect you to be so, so,”

“Subby?” Katsuki grinned, shifting in his seat. “Bitch, I’m fucking good at everything.”

A pause, and Katsuki looked a little more thoughtful. “Actually, I thought it might be easier for you. Fuck, like, if you were in control, you’d be less nervous or something.” Izuku thought back to everything they’d done together - Katsuki was right. Outside of the time in the locker room, he’d done pretty much whatever Izuku wanted.

It was actually kind of sweet. “Kacchan,” Izuku said, meeting his eyes. “Thanks for taking me out. This is a great date. And I like you.”

Katsuki blinked at him, processing the shift in topics. Then he blushed violently as he jerked his head away, looking to the side.

“Fucking sappy, nerd.”

“You’re cute.”

“Nope.”

“So cute,” Izuku grinned, unable to help himself. His voice turned sing-song. “Sweet, cute Kacchan, being so nice to me.” Katsuki turned to him with a growl, face still flaming.

“Yes, I’m fucking cute and nice,” Katsuki snapped. “Now quit being a dick about it.”

Izuku dissolved into laughter. “So,” Izuku said, trying to move the conversation away from sex, “What’s up with the Striker case?”

Katsuki turned serious. “Deks, it’s confidential.” Oh. He wasn’t disappointed. Izuku wasn’t, he definitely didn’t feel the gap between them widening, and he wasn’t wondering just how far behind he had to fall before Katsuki stopped liking him.

“Deku,” Katsuki said, concern lacing his tone, “It’s just regulation. It’s not that I don’t trust you, but it’s my first major case and-”

“It’s fine,” Izuku said quickly. He hated this feeling, when you feel like you’re flying above the world and then something drops an anvil in your chest, and you fall from joy to shell-shocked sadness. He’d been too happy. Something had to happen to even it out.

“Is it?” Katsuki said, skeptical. “Don’t fucking lie.”

“Doesn’t matter,” Izuku said quickly, looking down at the table. “You’re on the case, and I’m not, so you shouldn’t tell me anything. I wouldn’t ask you to say anything you shouldn’t.”

“Well, there’s probably some parts I can say?” Izuku hated how Katsuki sounded, his pleading tone, the worry.

“Don’t bother,” Izuku said, then sighed. He was being a jerk, once again. Ruining their first goddamn date. Falling behind Katsuki. He couldn’t do anything right. “Sorry, Kacchan. I don’t mean to ruin the mood. I’m just being, well. It just sucks to feel like I’m below you.”

There, he'd said it. To his surprise, Katsuki snorted. "Yeah, I fucking bet. It's about goddamn time, though, I've been eating your dust for years."

"H-huh," Izuku stuttered, his spiral of self-hatred completely derailed. Before he knew it, Katsuki was out of his seat, around the table, and in his face.

"Deku. Don't get shitty about it. You're the most annoyingly determined person I know, and if you want it, there's no way in hell you'll fail."

"Kacchan," Izuku whispered, feeling deeply undeserving of Katsuki in that moment.

"I fucking believe in you," Katsuki bit out. "Can't wait to fight you for #1." Izuku looked up at him, memorizing the fierce expression on his face, noting when it shifted to sly, as Katsuki said, "And I'll fucking win."

With a laugh, Izuku shoved him away. "I don't get it," he said, as Katsuki dropped payment on the table. Izuku made a mental note to pay for their next date.

"What?"

"It's weird how your bullshit cheers me up," he said, stepping out into the cold of the evening. Katsuki followed, thanking the owners.

"And Kirishima says I'm not charming," Katsuki sighed, dropping an arm over Izuku's shoulders. "Walk to karaoke?"

"Mm. Sometimes I hate how insecure I still feel," Izuku said, barely paying attention as Katsuki steered them down the sidewalk.

"Yeah?"

"I mean, as a quirkless kid, I was so aware of everything. It was so hard to believe in myself despite it all, and then during elementary school…" Izuku trailed off, feeling Katsuki's arm tighten around him. He'd somehow forgotten the culprit of his past pain was right next to him. He cleared his throat. "I mean, even at UA. I was barely functional in the first year, and yeah. Always comparing myself to All Might, to you, to everyone. Self-confidence is hard."

"Everyone says I have too much self-confidence," Katsuki laughed. "If you average us out, we're like one reasonable person."

Izuku snorted with laughter, feeling much more comfortable. Katsuki goofing off was probably one of his favorite things in the entire world. It felt like the warmth of their childhood friendship reviving after decades of disuse. He took a deep breath. He could be vulnerable.

"Sometimes, I worry if you'll want me if I'm not as good, or better than you," he choked out. Katsuki stopped dead, turning Izuku to face him.

"Fuck that," Katsuki snapped. "I'm not a fucking kid anymore, Deku. There's more worth to someone than how fucking strong they are."

“I- I know.”

“And I know it too,” Katsuki said. “Even if I *love* how strong you are.”

“Oh.” Love?

“Deku.” Katsuki stepped in, his lips a whisper away from Izuku’s. “Listen up, idiot, and don’t forget this shit. I’d want you if you were at the bottom of the rankings. If you weren’t on them at all. If you weren’t even a hero. I’d want you if you’d grown up quirkless and decided to do something else entirely. I just. I’m not fucking around, Izuku.”

The phrase sounded strangely familiar. Izuku opened his mouth, but there wasn’t anything he could say to that except *I love you* , which he couldn’t bring himself to voice. So instead, he tipped his chip up, kissing Katsuki on the mouth, tugging him closer. Katsuki hummed with pleasure against him, wrapping him in a hug.

Then suddenly, Katsuki was gone, in a puff of smoke and a lingering smell of sweetness. Blinking at the loss of contact, Izuku looked around. Down the street, Katsuki was grabbing some poor man, shaking him. What the hell? Izuku was still running over by the time he saw Katsuki grab a camera, and explode it. The man wailed something.

“-my card for reimbursement,” Katsuki was snarling, pushing a hero card into the man’s chest. “You breathe a word of this to anyone, you’re fucking dead meat, got it?”

“Y-yes, Ground Zero, sir,” the man stuttered.

“Run,” Katsuki snapped. The man ran, half-sobbing. Izuku was appalled.

“What the hell, Katsuki?”

“Fucker was taking pictures,” Katsuki snarled, clearly still riled up.

“It’s just his job,” Izuku told him, frowning. “You shouldn’t threaten people like that.”

“I’ll threaten who I damn well want,” Katsuki snapped, dusting camera remnants off of his hands.

“I-”

“I don’t need your fucking preachy shit, Deku,” Katsuki told him, face hard. “We haven’t even talked about what we’ll do with the press yet. Hero couples are hot news, and fuck me but I’m not gonna let reporters eat you alive.”

“I'm not preachy, and I don't need you to protect me," Izuku snapped back. "Don't terrify people on my behalf. We're supposed to be heroes!"

Katsuki glared at him, bristling. Izuku stared back, unintimidated. A protective Katsuki unchecked would be, well, dangerous. He had to nip this in the bud, even if it was starting to feel like he was having a staring contest with a wild animal.

"Ungrateful fucker," Katsuki finally said, looking away. Izuku let out a silent sigh of relief. Tentatively, he put a hand out to one of Katsuki's fists. After a second, his hand relaxed, fingers interlacing with Izuku's. Nevermind that his palms were nearly scalding, post-explosion. Izuku wouldn't change him for the world.

"Guess we still have a lot to work out," Izuku said, gently. Katsuki glanced at him, confused.

"You're not pissed?"

I love you , Izuku thought. He said, "Even you have to have some flaws, Kacchan."

"Keep that up, and I'll kiss you in public again," Katsuki said, voice gruff. "And then I'll have to threaten even more photographers." Izuku gave him one of those wide, innocent smiles he was known for, one which he was not above weaponizing.

"Even though your flaws are enormous and overwhelming," he added, smile in full-force. Katsuki's face went through rapid expressions of rage, annoyance, tenderness, and shock.

"Ungrateful fucker," Katsuki finally repeated, his expression finally settling on fond. He squeezed Izuku's hand.

"Your hand is sweaty," Izuku said cheekily.

"Keep bitching and I'll make it explode," Katsuki snorted.

"So, so cute and nice," Izuku muttered under his breath.

Katsuki had not come to karaoke since UA. The last time, if Izuku remembered correctly, had included a shocking amount of begging from Kirishima, and Katsuki leaving after thirty minutes into the session to do "literally anything else, Jesus fucking Christ."

This time wasn't notably better. By the time they'd reached the place, Katsuki was sullen and withdrawn. It was half-touching that he'd come for Izuku, and half-gratifying to torment him with good times with friends. All in all, it seemed like a great deal to Izuku.

Uraraka flung herself onto Izuku the moment they walked through the door. Katsuki discreetly scooted away, out of the hug zone.

"Izuuuukuuu," she said, already flushed. "Everyone's upstairs. We have a room. And booze. You guys are late," she finished, glaring at Katsuki.

"Yeah, yeah, it's my fault," Katsuki growled. "Let's get this over with."

"You really like him?" Uraraka asked in a stage whisper, glaring at Katsuki, who was stomping on ahead. He paused to turn and flip off Uraraka, before continuing with a huff.

"I know, right?" Izuku sighed.

"He doesn't seem like he'd make a good boyfriend," Uraraka frown, concentrating on getting the whole sentence out. It was endearing, even if it forced Izuku to say,

"We're just dating for now," he said. It didn't bother him. He would go at Katsuki's pace or so help him god.

"Lame. Let's go sing about it, express your feelings through sooong!"

"Sure, sure," Izuku laughed. It was hard to be upset around a cheerful Ochako, and the truth was that He loved karaoke. Uraraka ‘guided’ him upstairs, which is another way of saying she hung off of Izuku’s shoulder while he half-carried her up the stairs. She, like Izuku, was a lightweight.

They opened the door to a beautiful sight. Kirishima and Kaminari had already dogpiled Katsuki onto the couch, Mina and Jirou were laughing their asses off, and Shouto was very enthusiastically cheering on Dark Shadow, who was singing “Enter Night,” by Metallica. Momo appeared to be having a headache.

Shouto’s enthusiasm could *maybe* be attributed to Inasa, who was perched on one of the stools lined against the wall, tambourining along with Dark Shadow. Tokoyami looked very put upon. Izuku carefully deposited Uraraka between Jirou and Tokoyami, thus taking the last seat in the place.

“Nerd!” Ah, Katsuki. He’d successfully wrestled Kirishima and Kaminari off of him, leaving them in an ‘accidental’ heap on the sofa next to him. “Looking for a seat?”

Pervert. But then, who was Izuku to refuse him? It’s not like there were better options. Without a second thought, he slid over the back of the couch and plopped into Katsuki’s lap. Reflexively, Katsuki’s arms slid around his waist, his chin resting on his shoulder. It was nice. They’d somehow become comfortable in each other's space, an easy companionship.

Izuku was an idiot. He’d told Uraraka about them dating. She’d been unsatisfyingly unsurprised, and a little concerned, but ultimately supportive. Uraraka was also a great friend, who never gossiped about anything important.

Kirishima and Kaminari combined looked smugger than Katsuki at his smuggest, which is saying a lot. The rest of the room was staring at Izuku. Or maybe at Katsuki, who’d taken the opportunity to slide one hand up his shirt.

“Hi guys,” he said, waving a little.

“ It's just the beasts under your bed,” Dark Shadow sang. Izuku could *feel* Katsuki smirking against his neck.

“Finally,” Shouto said. “You both are dense idiots. Glad you’re happy.” Inasa looked nearly moved to tears by the speech.

“Yeah, actually that took way longer than I expected,” Mina said.

“Hey, I was fucking putting in effort,” Katsuki protested. “Midoriya’s the goddamn dense one.”

Inasa started tambourining again, apparently unwilling to leave Dark Shadow without instrumentals.

“Sooooo, Katsukiiiiiii,” Jirou said, leaning all the way across Uraraka’s lap. “You gonna sing sweet Deku a love song?”

Izuku pointed at her triumphantly. “A great idea! Kacchan! Do it!”

“Hell no,” Katsuki snorted. “I’d rather fucking die.”

“Please,” Uraraka tried puppy eyes. Katsuki removed his hand from under Izuku’s shirt to flip her off. Then replaced it deliberately, fingers curling over Izuku’s abs.

“Kacchan,” Izuku said, trying to sound disapproving.

“Let me have my fun,” he sulked. “I hate this shit.”

“You suck,” Izuku proclaimed, and accepted a beer from Momo, who seemed to be enabling the chaos.

“You’ll want this,” she sighed, then leaned down to help Jirou upright. She was right, and Izuku sipped the beer while Kaminari did a fairly impressive rendition of “I am Electric’ by Heaven’s Basement.

“He does this one every time,” Izuku whispered to Katsuki.

“And I don’t care,” he said.

“So sulky,” Izuku chided him, moving against him just a little. Just enough to tease. Just enough to be rewarded by Katsuki’s growl in his ear.

Jirou was next, as she tended to at least go every third time, being by far the most enthusiastic about singing. Everyone really enjoyed Momo’s facial expressions while Jirou belted “Cherry Pie,” and Izuku was starting to deeply suspect who Momo’s late night outs had been with.

“Deku,” Kirishima said, leaning into his face. “It’s your turn.”

“It’s not,” Izuku groaned.

“No, it really is,” Katsuki said, the traitor. “Fucking dragged me here. Time to put out, baby.”

“Don’t be mean,” Kirishima punched his friend in the shoulder.

“Baby!” Jirou shouted, unhelpfully.

“I *am* mean,” Katsuki replied, sounding happier than he had since they got here, and bodily pushed Izuku off the couch.

“Time for your song!” Uraraka shouted, snatching the controls from Momo, who shrugged. Izuku took the mic from Jirou, wishing there was a window he could throw himself out of. The first sounds of CASCADA’s Every Time We Touch began playing. Izuku considered using Full Cowling to make a window to throw himself out of.

He looked out at everyone, realizing they were happy and cheering him on. Sure, Katsuki looked deeply pleased with himself, but he shouldn’t be enough to stop Izuku from belting out the best worst song of the century.

So he did it. The first few lines were hard. He was quiet, feeling so damn nervous. That was, until he realized Mina and Inasa (for some reason) were already belting out the song, albeit mic-lessly, and he started to feel the beer, and well, muscle memory. So what if he’d done this song maybe a hundred times before? Hero-ing was stressful. CASCADA was not.

Izuku threw himself into the song, putting on a damn performance. Katsuki wanted him to sing? Fine! Izuku did sing, going as far as pointing, gesturing dramatically, various improvised dance moves. Yes, Izuku really liked karaoke. No, Izuku did not half-ass things.

He ended the song to his friends cheerful, drunken applause, and walked back to Katsuki while doing his best not to be horribly self-conscious. Katsuki was clearly far soberer than anyone else in the room and had this weird, amused smile on his face. But once Izuku reached him, Katsuki grabbed his cheeks with both hands, pulling him close, their faces only inches apart.

“You’re so-” he started, then stopped, eyes searching Izuku’s face. Izuku took the opportunity to blush like an idiot. “Fucking stupid cute,” Katsuki finished in a rush, then kissed him on the nose, then forehead, and cheeks, peppering his face mercilessly with kisses while their friends wolf-whistled. Izuku was awash with happiness, and allowed himself to be scooped back on to Katsuki’s lap.

Kirishima started attempting Rap God by Eminem, a tradition for karaoke night that always ended badly.

“I’ve heard him practicing this,” Katsuki muttered. “Quick, Deku, gouge out my fucking ears.”

Kaminari looked over, face pained. Izuku felt bad that Katsuki had insulted his friend until Kaminari moaned, “Dude I know, I have to hear this all the time. Put me out of my misery.”

Noticing their complaining, Kirishima grinned and went even louder, making Kaminari dissolve into giggles. Cute, Izuku thought.

“It’s pretty fun, right?” Izuku said, looking at Katsuki.

“Could be worse,” he murmured. “But I’m ready to get out of here.”

Izuku turned to him with a frown. Was Katsuki having that bad of a time? “Already?”

“Deku,” Katsuki leaned in to whisper in his ear. “I’m tryna get laid, and I wake up at 5:00 AM tomorrow. I want to fuck, *now* . My place or yours?”

Chapter End Notes

Bakugou wants to fuuuuuuuuuuuuuuuuuck

Why have an angst cliffhanger when it can be a smut cliffhanger?

Yeah this chapter was getting long, and then I was like, why not add karaoke? So it got even longer. Don’t blame me. Blame my need for more BakuDeku PDA (it's not like Bakugou has social filters for any other part of his life, anyway)

Next chapter’s gonna be mostly gratuitous steam, oh well (ﾉ◕ヮ◕)ﾉ*:･ﾟ✧

Izuku is realizing he has more insecurities to deal with than he thought :/
That said, I really appreciate (canon) Izuku’s bravery and overcoming his insecurities, challenges, and facing his mistakes <3

UM also I'm still getting caught up in the anime and Kirishima's backstory? What? I love him so much?

Turtleboy

Chapter Summary

Bakugou and Izuku spend some quality time together.

Their PR reps prepare for the incoming apocalypse.

Chapter Notes

If I haven't replied to your comment, it's because I want to seem cool and aloof instead of desperate for attention

AKA I love & appreciate you all, but am shy even when posting what's essentially dressed-up porn on the internet

I'm currently updating tags as I go, so please check to make sure you're g with everything before proceeding <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

In no time at all, they were inside Katsuki's flat. Katsuki slammed the door behind them, face smug as all hell.

Izuku watched the door close with a sense of finality. He wanted this. He'd been literally dreaming about it lately, but now that it was here? Izuku looked at Katsuki, nerves rising. It had been a long time, after all. And this was *Bakugou Katsuki* . He'd never been quite *this* intimate with Katsuki before, and it was suddenly a bit intimidating.

Katsuki's grin had an edge to it, and he stared at Izuku while pointedly pulling off his jacket and tossing it carelessly on the counter. Izuku swallowed hard. Katsuki took off his shoes, kicking them into a corner. He looked up, red eyes narrowed and sharp. His grin suddenly widened, making Izuku's blood pressure skyrocket.

Then Katsuki said, "Ready to get dicked down by the country's #8 hero?"

"You're fixated on that," Izuku accused him, covering his own nervousness with bravado. Katsuki answered easily.

"Fuck yeah," Katsuki drawled as he strolled over to Izuku. He took his chin, tilting it up so Izuku had to meet his eyes. "I'm the goddamn greatest."

Desire coiled in Izuku's stomach. He didn't care what rank Katsuki was, but his cocky attitude was an inexplicable turn on. "Yeah you are," he breathed. Katsuki's lips parted.

"Deku," Katsuki said, voice low and rough, "I'm gonna be so fucking good for you. Just tell me what you want, baby."

"Fuck," Izuku whispered, melting against his chest. Katsuki smelled good, a heady mix of sweetness and smoke. Izuku's hand wandered up Katsuki's back, apparently having a mind of their own. His back was corded with muscle, supporting Katsuki's arm-centric fighting style. Izuku had spent so much time thinking about Katsuki's workouts, how they supported his quirk, and exactly how good he looked weightlifting. And now, how good he felt under Izuku's hands. Izuku swallowed. "I want you."

"You've already got me, idiot," Katsuki snorted, and started bodily pushing him towards the bedroom. Izuku stumbled backward, light in Katsuki's arms. In no time, he was pushed backward onto the bed, landing with a thump. Katsuki jumped on the bed after him, graceful as a cat, landing over Izuku.

Izuku stared up at him in awe. The messy blond hair, angular jaw, slightly parted lips. The muscled arms caging him against the bed, the thick thigh pushing between his legs. Katsuki's breath rushed out, like he'd forgotten how to breathe.

"Well, Kacchan?" Izuku tried to sound teasing, but ended up just sounding breathy. "What do you want, then?"

He watched Katsuki's expression shift to predatory, dangerous - the face he wore whenever he set his eyes on something he wanted. He leaned in and pressed his lips against Izuku's ear.

"Dirty, dirty things, lil' Deku. Want to make you scream. Want to fuck your overactive mind right out of your shitty little head. Flip you over and take your ass and make it mine," he bit the words out, ending it with a nip to Izuku's ear. Izuku moaned, bucking up against his thigh. The friction felt unfairly good. He chased the feeling, pushing against Katsuki's leg, eyes closing in pleasure.

"Good little nerd, " Katsuki praised him. "Keep making those pretty noises, okay?"

"Mmmm," Izuku managed to say, as Katsuki pushed against him hard. Almost painful, but the pressure felt good. He *liked* feeling crushed beneath the man, damn it. Katsuki was working on his neck now, biting, one hand sliding down his chest, grabbing his dick. He moaned at the contact, earning a harder bite on his shoulder.

"Good boy," Katsuki murmured. Izuku's dick twitched in response. God, embarrassing. He could feel Katsuki's smirk against his neck. "Is that what you like? Want me to praise you like the good boy you are, Deku?"

Humiliating. More specifically, it was embarrassing how much feeling humiliated was turning Izuku on. He turned his face away, trying to hide his blush, his body stiff under Katsuki's weight. Katsuki shifted over him, gently turning his face back up.

Oh god, not this. Not the tender touches when Izuku felt embarrassed. It always made him tear up, and now was the worst time for this. Katsuki looked down at him, concerned. Izuku was going to toss himself out the window if he cried the first time they had sex.

“Hey, lil’ Deks, you okay?”

“Fine,” Izuku said, face burning. He wouldn’t tear up. He would. Not. “I’m just uh, it’s a lot.”

“We don’t have to do anything, baby,” Katsuki said, voice quiet. A little sad, maybe. Izuku stared at him, his mind trying to fight through his roiling emotions.

“I want to,” Izuku told him, a little forcefully. He was telling himself, too. Self-doubt had no place here.

“Sure,” Katsuki sounded doubtful. “Well, you can always tell me to back off, you know?”

Izuku looked up at him, emotions twisted between lust and embarrassment and desire and bitter-sweet memories of how he’d always wanted this. Suffice to say, his mind was barely functioning.

He didn’t know how he’d ever expected Katsuki to be over-aggressive. Well, it was a fair guess given his explosive personality, but totally ignored that the man was all about fair play. He’d lost his shit when he thought he’d unfairly won against Shouto, and he’d been at the worst of his attitude problems then. It only stood to reason that the new, improved Katsuki cared even more about fairness. And so here Katsuki was, looking down at him, offering to back off at a moment’s notice. Izuku had never felt safer with anyone.

Izuku looked up at him, fondness pooling in his chest. But somehow, what his idiot mind came up with was, “Back-off-ugou?”

The tender expression dropped from Katsuki’s face. He looked dumbfounded, then outraged, then resigned. “Deku, how could you. That’s the stupidest thing I’ve ever heard.”

Izuku watched his emotional journey and found himself chuckling. It was irrational, but he couldn’t stop.

“Back-off-ugou,” Izuku snorted, and then Katsuki’s face crumpled, and he dropped onto Izuku, twitching. It took a second for Izuku to realize that he was silently laughing so hard his whole body was shaking.

“Deku, what the fuck,” he choked out. Izuku couldn’t answer, because he was laughing too hard. He could only pat Katsuki’s back in solidarity.

“I can’t,” Izuku gasped for air. Katsuki rolled off of him, lying next to him on the bed.

“You’re fucking killing me, man,” he said, wiping his eyes. “How could you do that to my name, damn you. Isn’t Kacchan bad enough already?”

Izuku hauled himself up, and straddled Katsuki’s hips. He’d derailed them, and he was going to get them back on track. Backugou’s head lifted with interest, taking in the sigh of Izuku on

top of him.

“Kacchan,” Izuku said, leaning forward, bracing his hands on Katsuki’s solid stomach. “I’m sick of you treating me like two seconds away from breaking.”

“Am I wrong?” His tone of voice was challenging. It was frustrating. Izuku had fought hard to be as strong as he was. He hated feeling like Katsuki only saw the past version of him, the one that was too *weak* to handle anything.

“Yes,” Izuku snapped. Okay, fine. He could admit that Katsuki underneath him was doing things to his attitude. He rolled his hips, feeling Katsuki shudder beneath him. “You know what?”

“What,” Katsuki said, drawing the word out. There was a challenge in his voice, and Izuku always liked a challenge. Tension crackled through the air, their earlier mirth forgotten.

“I’ll prove it,” Izuku said, his eyes searching Katsuki’s face for any trace of that hesitant concern that bothered him so much. He wanted to burn every ounce of worry out of Katsuki.

“How so?” Katsuki said, a smirk revealing his sharp canines. His hands ran up Izuku’s thighs, gripping them, trying to control his movement. Izuku allowed it for the moment, then grabbed his wrists, peeling them off his legs. Katsuki looked affronted.

Izuku tugged at the hem of Katsuki’s shirt. The green graphic on it was *Deku* themed, he realized. Katsuki had his merch? Izuku’s mind narrowly avoided short-circuiting. He tapped the shirt. “Off.”

“Shit, fine,” Katsuki grunted, struggling to comply with Izuku’s weight on top of him. Izuku made no move to help him, and instead admired the bunch and flex of Katsuki’s abs, the sharp v cut, his perfect pecs. He had a thick waist, his core intentionally built to throw as much power into a punch as possible. Izuku ran his fingers over the muscles, equally reverent and greedy for contact. “Fucking pervert,” Katsuki said, watching his hands. With a final shrug, he tugged the shirt over his head. Izuku ran his fingers up the fine trail of blond hair on his stomach.

“Yes,” Izuku told him, meaningfully. “That’s the point, idiot.”

“You’re the idiot.”

“No y-” Izuku stopped himself. They were both idiots. “Take off your pants.”

“You’re in the way. Idiot.” Katsuki’s gaze burned with challenge. Izuku should have known he’d be into some weird, competitive sex thing. Izuku decided to be the bigger man if only to get Katsuki naked, so he lifted himself up enough for Katsuki to shimmy out of his jeans. It was another very nice view, despite the unbelievable fact that his underwear had the same tacky flames as his sunglasses. It was completely ridiculous, but Izuku couldn’t laugh because he was fucking floored by the subtle intimacy of seeing the stupid things Katsuki decided to do with his day, like matching his fucking underwear with his accessories.

Katsuki used his distraction to rise up and yank Izuku's sweater off.

"Hey!"

"Don't worry, I'll let you do your own pants," Katsuki told him, head cocked. Rolling his eyes, Izuku did so, pulling off his briefs while he was at it. It was worth it for the way Katsuki's eyes bulged. "Jesus, Deku."

"Hush," Izuku told him, then more or less ripped Katsuki's stupid flame-underwear off, make the man mumble a string of curses. "I'm just getting started."

"With what, exactly? Taking your goddamn time? Emulating a fucking snail? Want me to call you turtleboy?"

"Aw, so impatient," Izuku smiled, leaning forwards.

"Turtleboy."

"That's not hot," Izuku scolded, taking Katsuki's half-hard dick in his hand, and leaning up to kiss his neck. "No, Kacchan, I'm going to show you that you don't need to be so stupidly gentle with me."

"By doing what," Bakuugou insisted, hands digging into Izuku's back. He'd started twitching upwards into Izuku's hand. For someone complaining about being impatient, he was restraining himself fairly well. Izuku would reward him.

"By fucking you straight through the damn mattress," Izuku said, his voice a soft growl. He bit Katsuki's neck for emphasis. Hard. He heard Katsuki's breath catch.

"Think you've got it in you?" Katsuki's words sounded more pleading than challenging, now.

"You're gonna find out, aren't you Kacchan?" Izuku tightened his grip for a moment, relishing in the control. Katsuki was going to leave scratches on his back, at this rate. He arched at the touch, pleasure shivering over his skin.

"Fuckin' hope so," Katsuki whispered, his eyes half-closed. "Lube's in the drawer."

Izuku felt a little bit self-conscious, leaning over Katsuki to hunt for the lube. Thankfully, the man seemed content to lay beneath Izuku for the moment. Izuku didn't typically top, but he'd done it more than enough to be familiar with making it comfortable for someone else, and he was slightly worried about Katsuki. Especially after the man twitched away from his questing fingers with a hiss. Izuku grabbed his thighs, pulling him closer. Damn, Katsuki was heavy.

"So, how often do you do this?" Izuku said, a little awkwardly. He didn't know how to ask this kind of thing in a sexy way.

"Not a lot," Katsuki said, voice low and rough. He readjusted his legs, and folded his hands behind his head. Izuku was lost for a few moments, looking at the muscles bunching in his shoulders and arms. So, so powerful. He cocked his head at Izuku. "What, losing your nerve?"

“You’re so annoying,” Izuku told him instead, focusing on the task at hand. He could hear Katsuki chuckling. Talking to Katsuki was distracting from what he really wanted. He kneeled behind Katsuki’s spread legs, and gently began to work in one finger, heroically ignoring Katsuki’s stare from the top of the bed.

He managed to push the whole finger in without any more smart-ass comments from the other man, which was a huge win in his book. Then he looked up. Katsuki’s head was thrown back, chest rising and falling with each heavy breath, his eyes half-closed with lust. It was unbelievably hot. Izuku moved his hand, lips parted, reveling in the sight. Katsuki’s answering moan was low and long.

“So much from one finger?” Izuku teased.

“Fuck you,” Katsuki hissed, clenching around him. “I told you it’s been a while.”

“Uh-huh. This is what you get for giving me so much attitude.”

“Forgot how good it feels,” Katsuki sighed, ignoring Izuku. “Give me more.”

“Demanding,” Izuku said, pleased despite himself. He eased in another finger, and was rewarded by the glorious sight of Katsuki arching his back.

“Come *on* , Deku,” he groaned. “What was that shit about the mattress?”

“Quit whining or I won’t fuck you,” Izuku told him, picking up speed, finger fucking the other man, half-leaning over him. He drank in every shift in Katsuki’s expression, the desire, the impatience, and the apparently limitless need to be a brat.

“As if you could resist,” Katsuki gasped out. Izuku pulled out his fingers slowly, torn between wanting to punish him for his terrible attitude and wanting to finger him further. Tormenting Katsuki won out, because he wanted more of Katsuki’s insolence. Who was he kidding? He’d always loved Katsuki’s bad attitude.

“Alright, Kacchan. Since you’d failed to ask nicely,” he trailed off, holding his hands up.

“Hey, who said you could stop?” Katsuki’s head lifted, eyes on Izuku. Izuku threw him an insolent grin, grabbed his hips, and flipped him over. It was easier than he expected; he still underestimated his own strength. Ten plus years of weightlifting had not gone to waste. Katsuki landed hard, breath puffing out of him.

“There we go,” Izuku said, just as Katsuki turned, face indignant. “Since I’m so nice, I’m going to fuck you despite your bad behavior.” Katsuki groaned in response, trying to lift himself. Izuku pushed him back down, one palm against his muscular back. And just like that, he was power-tripping again. He could feel Katsuki’s back flexing under his hands, skin warm and dotted with scars.

“Finally gonna follow through, Deks?” his voice was muffled. Izuku didn’t answer, grabbing his ass instead. Katsuki’s muffled moans were gratifying. So, so gratifying. “Dekuuuuu,”

Katsuki groaned. “Did you not find the condoms?” Right. Suddenly in a hurry, Izuku rolled it on.

“You’re being very patient,” he told Katsuki, patting him on the ass, even if it wasn’t true. He just got a growl in response. “Really, though,” Izuku continued, rubbing his dick along his ass. Fuck, he couldn’t believe he was doing this. “You’re good. So good.” He watched the muscles in Katsukis’ back ripple as he shifted on the bed.

“Gonna be real bad if you don’t hurry the fuck up.”

“Fine,” Izuku smiled. “Just admiring the view, you know.”

“Fuck you.” Katsuki made a considering noise. “Actually, fuck *me.* ”

“Quit being a smartass,” Izuku told him, and began rubbing his dick against his ass. Katsuki took a slow, steadying breath beneath him, as if he was trying to relax. “So good, Kacchan. Just like that. Nice and easy.”

“Mmmhmm,” Katsuki half-said, half-moaned. Izuku wasn’t listening. He was lost to the world, slowly pushing the head of his cock inside. Katsuki was fucking tight, and he was trying not to hurt him. It was taking all his damn focus not just thrust in hard and abandon all restraint.

So, breathing harshly, he started moving glacially slowly, controlling Katsuki’s hips. Katsuki took it like a pro at first, but quickly became impatient.

“Fuck, Deku, let me move,” he whined. Izuku clenched his teeth, then drove in until he bottomed out. He couldn’t help the moan falling from his lips, nor could he stop Katsuki from rocking back into him. He swore, fingers digging into Katsuki’s pale skin.

“Shit, you’re so good,” he choked out, moving slowly. “Kacchan, you’re-”

“Fuck me, *please,”* Katsuki growled, shoulders heaving. “Fucking turtleboy up here thinks he can-”

Izuku snapped his hips forward with a snarl. “Fuck, Katsuki, do you ever shut up?”

Katsuki moaned low in this throat, sounding unbearably sexy. But when he spoke, it was with a growl. “Yeah, you just have to fuck me hard enough.”

“Then shut the fuck up,” Izuku told him, and gripped his hips, thrusting in hard. Katsuki’s breath whooshed out.

“That’s it-”

“Sh.” Izuku picked up the pace, slamming into Katsuki again. His body was burning up with desire, he couldn’t stop the pleasure pooling, the need for more. Distantly, he realized he was driving Katsuki onto the bed, each thrust of his hips dragging out a breathy *fuck* from Katsuki, the words coming like a chant, a prayer.

Fuck fuck fuck fuck fuck fuck…

Izuku had set a brutal pace, one he kept up mercilessly. He crushed Katsuki into the mattress, one hand on his lower back, the other guiding his hips and he thrust as deep as he could. Katsuki's *fucks* became less of a chant and more of a shout. Izuku was trying not to cum, actually, and attempting to focus on hitting just the right angle to-

Katsuki let out a strangled cry, as Izuku finally found the angle he'd been looking for. Izuku had perfected control over his body long ago, and now he used every ounce of that control to keep himself at that angle, trying to ignore the inescapable pleasure lancing through him. Below him, Katsuki cried out at each thrust, sounding absolutely wrecked.

Fuck, with Katsuki sounding like that, he really couldn't hold back.

"Please, please, please," Katsuki was pleading. "Fuck, I can't, baby you're gonna make me-"

"Yes, come for me," Izuku snapped, self-control breaking. "Want to watch you."

"Yes," Katsuki groaned, voice ragged. "Yes, fuck…" then Izuku saw his whole body shudder as he came, hands grasping at nothing, as he gasped out obscenities. Too damn sexy. He clenched around Izuku, too hot and tight and sudden, and then Izuku was over the edge too, vision blurring at the edges, his whole body flooded with sensation. Time stretched, unreal, the pleasure burning up all his sense of self.

Reality crept back in gradually, bringing back the sounds of his pants, the sweat running down his chest, the way Katsuki bonelessly lay below him, occasionally twitching, his breathing slow and heavy. Izuku was bent over, head nearly touching Katsuki's back. There were long, red lines of scratches down his back. When had he done that? Groaning at the over-sensitivity, he carefully pulled out, and hobbled over to drop the condom in the trash. He went back to the bed on trembling legs, and snuggled up to Katsuki's side.

"Hey," he said, softly. He was completely spent, tired in the most enjoyable way.

"Damn," Katsuki muttered, slowly, slowly rolling over to face Izuku. Red eyes met his, soft and full of humor. "Deku, you can *fuck.* "

"Oh," Izuku said, blushing. Incredible that he's perfectly able to rail Katsuki into next week, but can't take a compliment without flushing. "Yeah, well. You're pretty good."

"Pretty good, he says," Katsuki groaned. "After I just took that dick like a goddamn champion."

"Fine. You're a billion out of ten."

Katsuki snapped his teeth at him. "That's more like it."

"I think I left scratches," Izuku said, feeling guilty. Katsuki's mouth pulled into a grin.

"Good. Now get over here."

Obediently, Izuku scooted in. Katsuki pulled him closer, wrapping him in hot, sweaty limbs.

“3,000 degrees,” Izuku mumbled in vague protest. Katsuki shushed him, burying his head in Izuku’s hair.

“Just wanna stay like this for a bit. You staying the night?”

“Of course,” Izuku sighed into his chest. He never wanted to leave.

This time, Izuku had gone to sleep naked as a simple pre-emptive measure against the monster he was sleeping with. He still woke up horribly overheated, blankets long gone, with Katsuki’s leg thrown over his. He sighed. At the noise, Katsuki shifted. It was ass-early in the morning; 5:00 AM. An alarm was beeping insistently. With a growled “Fuck,” Katsuki smacked it, then sat up with a groan.

“Deku, you’re here,” he murmured, looking down. Izuku blinked up at him, slowly making sense of where he was. He felt so sleepy, warm, and safe. The night was just beginning to drift towards dawn, and the gray morning light made Katsuki look soft and gentle.

“Morning,” Izuku mumbled, reaching for him. Katsuki let himself be pulled in.

“Sometimes when I wake up, I think I dreamt all of this,” he whispered. Izuku wanted to assure him that it was real, *this* was real, but then he said, “Then I feel how sore my ass is.”

Izuku giggled, kissing Katsuki’s nose. “Sorry, Kacchan.”

“You’re next, turtleboy,” Katsuki grumbled.

“I reject that nickname,” Izuku pouted, sitting up. “Wait, does that mean you’ll quit acting like you’re about to break me?”

“Sure,” Katsuki said, stretching luxuriously. “Gonna wreck you, baby.” Desire shot through Izuku like lightning through a storm.

“Mmm,” Izuku squeaked, unreasonably turned on for 5:00 AM. Katsuki shot him a look.

“You like it.”

“What?”

Katsuki swallowed. Izuku watched the shadows of his throat. “You like when I talk shit. Like, act rough. With you.”

“Been fantasizing about it since I was a teenager,” Izuku smiled sleepily at him, enjoying the way Katsuki’s face shifted from uncertainty to desire. “So yes.”

“Fuck me,” Katsuki said mildly. “Quit turning me on. I gotta go get a new baseline physical for this top ten bullshit. Don’t wanna have a boner the whole time.”

He dragged himself out of bed, and Izuku shortly heard the shower turn on. It was strangely domestic and peaceful, an achingly sweet change of pace from their violent day-to-day lives. With a sigh, he got up, wrapping a blanket around him. He had no idea where his clothes had gone. He'd made it into the kitchen and was heating water for tea when Katsuki came out of the shower. His hair was uncharacteristically flat and wet, and he was shirtless, swearing only slouchy sweatpants. He took Izuku's breath away.

"You're really, um," Izuku said, trying to simultaneously wake up and pull his mind out of the gutter. "Attractive."

You can't blame him for being overwhelmed. He was in the living room of the #8 hero, Ground Zero. Who was shirtless. Who was into Izuku. Who was his childhood friend, and childhood crush, and first love, and Izuku was blushing again. He pulled the blanket up to his eyes to hide it.

That was the wrong move, because Katsuki shuffled over and tugged the blanket down, stealing a kiss. "I'm really gonna call you turtleboy if you keep that up," he said, with a smirk. Then he looked down the blanket, biting his lip. "And where's your clothes?"

Izuku didn't know, and Katsuki just told him to pick whatever from *his* clothes. Izuku tried to not be overwhelmed at that. He was shepherded to Katsuki's closet, and tried not to succumb to the urge to be incredibly nosy.

He failed. Katsuki had a walk-in closet, with a dizzying array of clothes. Izuku was floored to see a variety of Deku merch, though admittedly, none of the obvious ones. Katsuki had been thinking about him this whole time, apparently. Sure, Katsuki himself had said so, but this was real, tangible evidence! Izuku was giddy. Eventually, he grabbed the most boring pair of sweatpants and what seemed to be an ancient Ground Zero hoodie.

He opened the door right into Katsuki, who looked him up and down.

"Yep, I could get used to that," he said, pulling Izuku out of the closet. "Those are yours now, Deks."

Katsuki wasted no time in getting ready. He'd dressed, packed a duffel bag, and was out the door in twenty minutes. Izuku was apparently supposed to "chill out and do whatever the hell he wanted," and the door would lock automatically behind him.

As much as he'd love to spend the day in Katsuki's flat, he had his own stuff to do. Like call his PR rep.

"And he destroyed the poor man's camera!" Izuku said, stabbing the remnants of his mocha with a straw. He was at Pothos' Place again, absently watching yet another shot of Ground Zero exploding a villain on the TV. Outside, rain pattered lightly against the window.

“Well, that's a little intense, but probably better in the long run,” said Suika. Izuku’s PR rep was calmer than expected, and Izuku hoped this wouldn’t be a problem. "Well, you're not the first gay hero. So, who's the guy? Hopefully it's someone we can market well."

"Uh," Izuku said. He'd been dreading this part. He looked around, making sure no one was listening. "Kacchan."

"That's a cute name," Suika said with a smile in his voice. "So what's he like? I'll work on media strats in case you two decide to go public." Of course. Suika wouldn't know his nickname for Katsuki.

"He’s um. He’s a lot. He’s, uh, he’s Katsuki. Bakugou Katsuki, like Ground Zero."

There was a moment of silence, then Suika laughed. "Midoriya, don't scare me like that. It’s funny that they have the same name, but it shouldn’t complicate things too much. I think-"

"No, Suika. Like Bakugou Katsuki, as in Ground Zero, *specifically* ." Izuku felt numb. He looked at the slushy ice in his glass and wished he could melt into oblivion, too. "Kacchan is what I call him. Is that uh, bad?"

"You're fucking with me."

"Suika!" Izuku had never heard him swear before. "I'm not! We've been dating for a few weeks, I mean, I can call him and prove it but I think he's working right now and-"

"Oh god no don't call him," Suika said quickly. "Oh my god. Someone had pictures of you two? Are there any more?"

"No, Kacchan patted him down after blowing up his whole camera," Izuku frowned. "And threatened him. A lot."

"Thank god one of you two idiots have sense," Suika sighed.

"Wait why-"

"Midoriya. Sweet angel. It's been wonderful working with you, and now I see that you were just buttering me up for the *biggest PR disaster of my career* ."

"Um," Izuku trailed off. "It's not that big a deal, I think?"

"Ha! Not a big deal, he says.” Suika sighed again, but even louder. “Well, I guess you haven’t encountered this in your career yet. I really should have known it was too good to last. That’s part of the problem - you are a good boy hero, as we call it. You don’t have any major mistakes, you’re likable to nearly all demographics, you’re not controversial in literally any way.”

“That’s good, right?” Izuku folded his napkin. On the TV, Ground Zero was cussing out the reporters swarming him as he bagged the villain. He could tell because the subtitles were all asterisks.

“Yes, Midoriya. Except if you date Ground Zero, because then your fanbases are going to interact. And Ground Zero’s fans are arguably as bad as he is. I mean, the guy makes *one* vaguely nice statement on TV and he’s suddenly national news! That’s how low the standard is! If people find out you’re associated, you’re going to be the one thrown under the bus.”

“But-”

“I’m not done explaining. Ground Zero’s reputation has already shown it can weather pretty much anything you could throw at it. Swearing, temper tantrums, sleeping around, wanton violence… you name it. He’s already popular, so honestly dating a sweetheart like you will just make him even *more* likable. It’ll give him the approachability he lacks.”

“Sounds fine,” Izuku mumbled. Even if it widened the gap between them, he was happy he’d be an asset to Katsuki.

“No, not fine. Because you don’t have that. The public has never questioned you, but they sure are gonna start when they figure out who you’re dating. Outside of all the homophobes crawling out of the woodwork, all your principles, morals, and so on will be called into question. It’ll be bullshit like ‘ *what else is he hiding?’* or *‘Deku shocks all by throwing away morals!’”*

Izuku could only think of only one thing. “Kacchan will kill them,” he whispered. It wasn’t a good thing. Katsuki was the last person you’d want to go on over-protective rampages.

“That’s another problem,” Suika groaned. “If Ground Zero actually likes you-”

“If?!”

“Then we have to deal with him throwing a bitch fit every time someone…” Suika trailed off. “You know what, I’m just gonna call their agency. We’ll have to coordinate regardless. In the meantime, I’m signing you up for a hero relationship sensitivity course.”

“A what?”

“All hero couples have to do it. Practical stuff like how to handle villains trying to use you against each other, how to avoid media traps, the likes. I’ll email you some options for dates.”

“Thank you, I guess,” Izuku said. He was a little shell-shocked.

“Of course, Midoriya. Don’t worry, I’ll take care of this. You’ve been the best client I could ask for and,” Suika sounded a little choked up, “And I’ll make sure nothing touches your perfect, beautiful reputation. Not even that hellion. Don’t worry. I’ll check in touch with Ground Zero’s agency and sort this out.” The line clicked dead. Thunder rolled outside ominously, and Izuku wished he had his frog umbrella.

About forty minutes later, he got a text from Katsuki.

Kacchan: *Thx for calling PR bby*

Izuku: *Was that sarcastic? >_>*

Kacchan: *No lol i actually meant to but forgot. Ono just broke my fckin eardrums w/ her screaming*

Kacchan: *Apparently i should have called her immediately and have now both ruined her life and broken her heart lmao*

Kacchan: *But yeah we should prob talk about we wanna handle this*

Kacchan: *<3*

Izuku was distracted by the heart emoji. Was this his first heart emoji from Katsuki? He screenshotted it for future reference. He sent a quick text saying something vague about talking whenever Katsuki was available, and headed into his sector's headquarters.

Upon walking in the door, he was pulled into a debriefing and sent out. Apparently lightning had struck several places in his sector, and Izuku spent the day pulling people out of rubble, bringing burn victims to hospitals, and helping with risky repairs. It was exhausting. No flashy villains to fight, no battle tactics to consider - just the heartbreak and pain of those injured and those who'd lost their homes.

It was a long, thankless day, after which he gladly accepted an invitation from Uraraka and Iida to have udon at their favorite place.

And again, the next day. And the next. His days became a blur of search and rescue on shift, getting hot food with his friends for dinner, listening to Katsuki complaining about his night shifts, and passing out. Katsuki remained cagey about whatever he was working on, and Izuku quickly learned that Shouto was in on it too, being #10. Apparently briefing anyone else was too much of a security risk, but that didn't stop the rest of them from guessing.

So it came as somewhat of a relief when Izuku got to face down an actual villain. Izuku was more prepared than anyone else in his sector, and it was all thanks to Katsuki. Or it was all thanks to Izuku's compulsive need to take copious notes on anything hero-related, because he'd essentially been debriefed on the "ground munching" villain that had last been seen in Katsuki's industrial sector.

The villain called himself Terrestrator, which was by all accounts a terrible name. He surfaced inside a bank vault, stuffed a bag full of banknotes and jewels, then *ate* the titanium safe doors on his way out. Izuku got the alarm as soon as he'd surfaced, and got there by the time he was leaving the building. The villain moved fast.

The villain was large, easily three times Izuku's height. Not nearly enough to intimidate Izuku, but the way his skin rippled with titanium was a concern.

Izuku nearly broke his hand the first time he tried punching him. Fine. Flat-footed, direct kicks were probably the only way his body could keep from shattering on impact. Terrestrator was already on the run, but Izuku was faster. He was always faster. Green lightning crackled

over his limbs, and he lept from building to building, avoiding the streets and pedestrians still seeking safety. He shut out the sound of sirens wailing, citizen's screaming, and made a calculated jump.

Air screamed past his ears as he plummeted straight into the back of Terrestrator's neck with both feet, driving the villain's face into the concrete with a sickening crunch. Izuku rolled away, narrowly avoiding the screeching tires of oncoming traffic. As police hurried to clear the intersection, Izuku regained his footing. His legs ached already, but he could see cracking on the back of the villain's back. It gave him a sick sense of satisfaction.

Then, with the strange creaking of asphalt, the villain's head lifted. His face swung around slowly, until he faced Izuku. His face was made of concrete, pebbled and gray. What?

"Oh, shit," Izuku whispered. He could hear the click of cameras behind him.

"That's right," Terrestrator roared. His voice sounded inhuman, echoey and horribly deep. "My power is unlimited! Everything here will only make me stronger! Give up now, while you still live." He rolled his neck, vertebrae creaking. Maybe the transition was difficult? He couldn't have *wanted* to become cement, when titanium was an option but it must have gotten in his mouth when Izuku had stomped him, and...

He was definitely still strong. Strong enough to give Katsuki's sector a headache. Izuku wondered if he had to eat normal food, or if he somehow got calories from what he was eating. At his size, he'd need at least 5,000 calories or more - and if he took on the qualities of whatever he ate, he would have to be relatively picky about what went into his mouth…

Terrestrator was charging him, but he was slow, and clumsy. Izuku was grateful for all the sparring he'd done with Katsuki. Most people seemed slow if you were used to Ground Zero.

Izuku led Terrestrator on a chase, antagonizing him with near misses, and bringing him to a deserted alleyway, past several overflowing dumpsters, to a dead end. Izuku had very little room to maneuver, but civilian casualties would be at a minimum. With a cocky grin, Terrestrator closed in on him. Izuku took deep breaths, calming himself while he waited for his chance.

The moment to strike was the briefest windows. Terrestrator lunging forwards, mouth open in a wordless scream, and Izuku threw himself forwards feet first, sliding between the villain's legs. It was a risky maneuver, but momentum was key.

He caught both of the villain's ankles with his hands, using his forward momentum to swing his legs up and around. A slight twist had him hooking one leg over the villain's shoulder. His core burned in protest as he violently brought his head up and over the villain's back. Terrestrator was stumbling forwards in surprise. He tripped, lurching down, giving Izuku an ideal chance to grab his face, fingers digging into cheekbones. With his free hand, he stuff a soda can into the man's mouth. Izuku jumped off of him, pushing him forward and down.

Terrestrator fell forwards, face-first into the wall, the can forced down his throat by the impact. Perfection. Before Izuku's eyes, he began to turn into aluminum. Without preamble, Izuku smash-kicked him into the wall, crumpling him like an empty soda can. With a few

more stomps, Izuku had him compacted into a square. Eyes and mouth stared up at him in silent rage, looking like a Picasso piece.

“That’s uh,” Izuku said, feeling winded. “Weird? But kind of cool?”

The aluminum mouth opened and closed like a fish. How would he turn back into human-shape? Did he need other minerals? Izuku stopped himself from circling that storm-drain of line of thought, or he’d be standing there all day.

“I hope this doesn’t hurt you,” Izuku finally muttered, then carefully picked up the scrunched villain by one corner, like he was a dirty sock. He collected the villain’s bag and carried it out of the alleyway. He was greeted by a wall of cop cars, camera shutters, and applause. He smiled awkwardly to the cameras and dropped the villain into a trash bag held out by the police.

“Make sure he doesn’t suffocate,” Izuku said, feeling bad. Even villains shouldn't be treated like trash.

By the time debrief and paperwork was done, Izuku had a raging headache. Four ibuprofens later saw him on his couch at him, eating a luke-warm microwave dinner and watching All Might cartoons. Who said hero life wasn’t glamorous? He decided to text Katsuki, who should be getting up for his morning shift.

Izuku: *Got your weird villain today, haha*

These days, Katsuki didn’t always insta-reply. Apparently the Striker case actually kept him off his phone sometimes, so Izuku was happy to see the quick response.

Kacchan: *Fuck yeah, I hate that guy*

Kacchan: *Hope you gave him an extra kick from me*

Kacchan: *You ok?*

Izuku smiled. He’d never get tired of Katsuki worrying about him. In response, he adjusted himself to get his dinner, his face, and the cartoons in his phone’s camera. A smile and a peace sign later, he had a cute picture to send to Katsuki. If he was lucky, he’d get a shirtless picture back. Izuku had come to strongly suspect that Katsuki had a folder of pictures of himself on standby, but he really couldn’t complain. Izuku loved steamy pictures of Katsuki, and Katsuki loved Izuku’s selfies for whatever reason. All Izuku wanted was to be called “fucking stupid cute” again, and his night could finally be a good one.

Izuku: [image attached]

Kacchan: *WHAT THE FUCK.*

Kacchan: *ARE U EATING.*

Oh. Izuku should have expected that, actually.

Izuku: *Dinner! See, I feed myself!*

Kacchan: *No u DONT. U survive off of garbage like a rat*

Kacchan: *Ur lucky im off tonight cause im gonna feed ur ratatouille ass some fucking food*

Izuku: *You're cute when you're angry*

Izuku: (◕‿◕✿)

Kacchan: *Im always angry*

Izuku: *You're always cute*

Kacchan: *Fck off. Ill be there in 30*

Kacchan: *Dont touch that shit deku i stg ill gut u like a fish*

Izuku usually liked Katsuki's aggressive need to see people eat nutritious meals, but he wasn't up for the attitude today. He was exhausted and didn't feel like waiting thirty minutes for Katsuki to get there and start cooking. He did the only thing he could: took a picture of himself putting microwave lasagna into his open mouth.

Izuku: [image attached]

Kacchan: *!!!!!!!*

Kacchan: *IM COMING FOR UR ASS*

Izuku grinned. That'd turn thirty minutes to at maximum fifteen. Sure he'd have to pay the price when Katsuki got there, but he had a feeling he wouldn't *really* mind whatever Katsuki planned to do to him.

Chapter End Notes

Idk if you were expecting ~2.5k words of smut, but you sure as shit got it. I definitely wasn't expecting it, yet it happened ANYWAY at great cost to my self-image as a reasonable person who doesn't spend days on end writing sex scenes

Plz appreciate my sacrifices

And I promise sexy aggro Bakugou is coming right up… he's just taking his sweet time cause he likes being pushed around by cute nerds (~¯⌣¯)~

Thank you all for sticking around and reading! Means the world to me and my brain’s allowance of serotonin & dopamine

Minty, Mint, Baby Green?

Chapter Summary

Izuku and Bakugou enjoy eachother's company again, and for twice the word count.

Bakugou gets pissed off on live TV again, and Izuku's friends are great friends.

Chapter Notes

Content Warnings:
I'm pretty sure everything in here is covered by the "rough sex" and "dirty talk" tags or otherwise isn't really significant enough for its own tag, so if you feel you may be at risk of not liking something, here's a list of specific BS in this chapter:
hair-pulling / using 'derogatory' terms like slut / "good boy" / control

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Katsuki actually took seventeen minutes to get to Izuku's apartment, not that Izuku was counting. He blew through the open door, dropped a bag on the counter, then made a beeline for the couch. He held up the half-eaten container of lasagna like it was a murder weapon and there was a dead body on the floor.

"How fucking dare you!"

"You were slow," Izuku told him, helplessly giggling. Katsuki's mouth worked in annoyance.

"It took me fifteen minutes, Deku! And I brought food!"

"Seventeen minutes," Izuku risked saying. Katsuki was on him in an instant, squishing both his cheeks with one giant hand.

"You're un-fucking-believable," he frowned, then kissed him on his squished-up mouth. Izuku's heart thumped at the casual intimacy. The newness hadn't worn off yet, at least enough that one kiss was still capable of driving every thought out of his head. He must have looked particularly spacey, because Katsuki pulled away to consider him. "You feeling okay?"

"It was a long day," Izuku sighed, hating to admit weakness. He was immediately rewarded for it though, as Bakuogu pulled him into a hug.

“Sounds like shit,” Katsuki said, quietly. Izuku had to smile at his attempt at being comforting.

“It’s fine. Just so much search and rescue. Where are all the villains? It’s just like, natural disaster after natural disaster. So many people injured, and I can’t fucking save everyone. I hate it. It’s exhausting. I feel like I’ve been lifting concrete for the last month.”

Katsuki just threaded his fingers through Izuku’s hair, massaging his scalp. Izuku melted against him.

“Want some real fucking food?” Katsuki murmured, his voice vibrating in his chest.

“I want to sleep for eight years,” Izuku sighed. “But I’ll settle for food.”

Katsuki deposited Izuku on one of the barstools and began clanking about in the kitchen. He’d apparently brought over some of his meal prep, whatever was the ‘least spicy.’ Despite that description, Izuku knew better than to have high hopes for edible. He was treated to curry chicken and rice. It was spicy as hell, but technically still tasted good. Even the rice was fucking spicy.

“You cooked this?” Izuku asked, sipping water. His mouth was burning.

“Yeah, so?”

“I don’t know how you find time to cook,” Izuku murmured, pushing curry around his plate. If he took another bite, his tongue might shrivel up and die. Katsuki just scoffed.

“I’m a functioning adult, is how.”

“And I’m a garbage-eating rat, apparently,” Izuku groaned, his head dropping to the countertop. He was so tired, he wanted to melt off the barstool and sleep on the floor. He glanced up, to find Katsuki watching him vacantly.

Finally, as if he’d really thought it through, Katsuki said, “I guess rats can be cute.”

Izuku cracked a grin. “Man, I’m sorry I’m so out of it.”

“It’s pretty typical Midoriya behavior,” Katsuki snorted. “I don’t mind.”

“You know my typical behavior?” Izuku was smiling for real now, pulling himself off the counter. He risked another bite of curry, and his eyes watered.

“Dumbass, I’ve known you since we were four.” Katsuki watched him carefully, looking a bit scornful. “Too spicy?”

“Noooo,” Izuku lied, sipping water. His nose was starting to run.

“That’s a weak-ass lie,” Katsuki snorted. “But I’ll make you something better when I have time.”

“That’d be nice,” Izuku murmured, exhaustion creeping up on him. “I wanna go to bed.”

Katsuki blinked at him. “Already? I just got fucking here.”

Izuku blinked back. Oh. Katsuki hadn’t realized it was an invitation. He rested his chin on his hand, and let his lips curl into a smile. “Bed, with you,” he purred. “I’m not *that* tired.” Katsuki’s spoon clattered onto his plate as he suddenly stood.

"Fuck yes. I'll just clean up-"

"Kacchan, *bed* ," Izuku insisted. "I've had a long, hard day and now I want-"

"Some long, hard dick?" Katsuki finished with a perfect poker face, already heading to Izuku's bed, dishes instantly abandoned. The man sure changed pace quickly, but Izuku happily followed him to the bedroom. Katsuki was already in his underwear by the time Izuku got there. No flame pattern this time, Izuku noted, though maybe he’d ripped Katsuki’s only pair. Whoops. It was probably for the best.

"Yo, nerd," Katsuki beckoned to him. “Let’s have some fucking fun.”

Izuku’s shirt was on the floor before he knew it, and his pants followed shortly after. He stared at Katsuki for a moment. Was he supposed to jump into his arms? Onto the bed? Was it normal to think about these kinds of things in times like this? He was ready to worry about this indefinitely, but Katsuki interrupted his thoughts.

“Deku, you gonna just stand there? Cause I’m gonna start calling you t-”

“Don’t call me turtleboy,” Izuku said quickly and hopped on the bed. Katsuki stifled a laugh, but followed suit.

“You nervous?” Katsuki asked. Was it a trick question? Izuku wanted to seem like the kind of person who wasn’t self-conscious. And he wasn’t really that self-conscious, it just takes him a while to warm up.

“You know,” Izuku murmured, scooting closer to Katsuki. “I just get caught up in my own head sometimes.”

“I know,” Katsuki hummed, pulling Izuku’s back to his chest, his arms snaking around Izuku’s waist. Izuku leaned back, letting his head fall on Katsuki’s shoulder.

“Sometimes,” Izuku said, forcing each word out past his insecurity, “I just need someone to get me out of my head.”

Katsuki’s hands flexed against his stomach. “I fucking volunteer for that, goddamn. Deku, we gotta talk though.”

“About what?” Izuku wasn’t sure what exactly they’d need to talk about. They’d already gone over STI safety (Izuku’d been tested months ago, Katsuki was waiting on results), and so on.

“What you like,” Katsuki trailed a hand up his chest, fingertip catching on his nipple. Izuku shivered at the touch. “Or what you don’t like.”

Izuku hummed, thinking it over. Katsuki’s hand kept up its gentle stroking, outlining his abs, his pecs, trailing over his throat. It was hard to concentrate, but Izuku pulled himself together for the sake of safe sex. Katsuki beat him to the punch.

“Because I want to do all kinds of shit to you, baby. Been thinking about it for fucking ever.”

“I like everything," Izuku managed to get out. Katsuki’s roving hand stilled.

“Everything.”

“Well, not like really messy stuff, like golden showers and, um,” Izuku blushed horribly. “I like most things. Just give me a chance to tell you to stop if you’re doing something new.”

“Fuck,” Katsuki said, his breath warming Izuku’s neck. Izuku shifted in his lap, just enough to turn and look at him.

“What? I’m not that innocent, you know. You should know that by now.” Izuku was a little indignant. Like Uraraka, he had cute-face syndrome. And like Uraraka, he liked all kinds of different things in bed. Katsuki was still quiet, looking at him with widened eyes. Izuku frowned. “You okay?”

“I’m just fucking…” Katsuki said, voice hoarse. “I’ve been fucking thinking about this forever. Now I can’t even fucking decide what to do with you first.”

“Well I can-,” Izuku said, starting to get up, but in an instant Katsuki’s hand was just below his throat, pressed against his collarbones as he stopped him from getting up.

“No no, lil’ Deku,” Katsuki growled. “Not letting you get away before I’ve even started.”

“Started with *what* ,” Izuku said, wishing that hand would go a little higher on his neck. “Turtleboy,” he added, because maybe he wanted to find out what would happen if he antagonized Katsuki.

“You *didn’t* ,” Katsuki growled. His hand moved from Izuku’s collar bones up his neck. Izuku whined slightly at the contact, enjoying the feeling of being vulnerable. But Katsuki’s hand kept moving up his jaw, the side of his face, to grab hold of his hair. Then he yanked Izuku’s head back, not hard enough to hurt, but enough to bare his neck. He leaned in, kissing his way up Izuku’s throat, sending a pleasant burn of desire down Izuku’s body. He shifted in place, settling against Katsuki’s hard body, making sure to move enough that Katsuki tightened his hold on his hair.

“Kacchan,” Izuku breathed out, boneless and warm. Then, remembering Katsuki’s reluctance to push him, he added, “I like that. When you grab my hair.”

“Shit,” Katsuki swore, tightening his grip. His other hand made its way between Izuku’s legs, palming his dick. Izuku bucked against the hand, breath shuddering.

“Please, Kacchan,” he found himself pleading. He could come like this, he realized. He just needed a little more time, a little more pressure from Katsuki and… Katsuki’s hand was gone. Izuku whined in protest.

“Greedy little…” Katsuki trailed off. “Deku.”

“What?” Izuku growled. He’d taken to stroking himself, because Katsuki was slacking.

“Dirty talk?”

“What about it,” Izuku sighed. He was getting a good rhythm going, and at least Katsuki hadn’t let go of his hair.

“I fucking hate you. Obviously, I wanna know how fucking dirty can I talk to you. Tell me Deku, are you a slut for me? How bad do you want me to shove my cock in you, huh?” He pulled his hair again, slowly and with intention.

“I-” Izuku started, but Katsuki’s free hand grabbed his wrist, stopping him from touching himself. Izuku was indignant. “Hey!”

“Tell me,” Katsuki growled in his ear.

“Aw,” Izuku sighed dramatically, feeling like some teasing was required after Katsuki ruined his fun. He twisted in Katsuki’s lap and stared down at him. Katsuki looked up at him, wearing half a snarl and fire in his eyes. Izuku smirked. “You know I’m a slut for that cock,” he said, tossing his inhibitions out the window. “Been thinking about how it would feel in my ass for *years.”* It was hard to feel self-conscious when Katsuki was looking at him like he was a bowl of extra-fiery-hell-flavored noodles. Like he wanted to devour Izuku.

Izuku started pushing him back on the bed, and suddenly found himself briefly in the air before he landed on his back, with Katsuki over him.

“Sassy mouth you got, there,” Katsuki told him, sitting up enough to shimmy out of his underwear. He was hard. Very hard. Izuku watched with a vested interest, barely even looking up when Katsuki growled, “Would be a shame if someone were to stuff it full of cock.”

“Such a shame,” Izuku murmured, eyes following Katsuki’s dick. Izuku propped himself up on his elbows, and bit his lower lip. “Kacchan…” he trailed off. Katsuki paused.

“You good?”

“I don’t want to turn this into a competition,” Izuku sighed, then looked up through his lashes. “But I’m definitely better at giving head than you.”

Katsuki’s mouth dropped open. Yeah, Izuku did want to turn it into a competition, actually. “Piece of shit,” Katsuki told him, apparently too turned on to use more relevant swear words.

“Try it and find out,” Izuku prodded him. Katsuki swallowed hard.

“Don’t mind if I fucking do, Jesus Christ.” Then Katsuki’s cock was at his lips, in his mouth, and Katsuki’s hands were back in his hair. Izuku did what he did best, which was tease the fuck out of Katsuki until the other man was practically face-fucking him. Something about the repetitive motion, the lack of air, and the heady smell of Katsuki made time blur. Izuku knew of nothing but dick, and he loved it. That is, until his head was suddenly jerked back, mouth empty.

“Not bad,” Katsuki told him, leaning down. “Not all I’m gonna do tonight, though.”

“Rate me,” Izuku told him, then wiped his mouth. After a moment, he added, “Bitch.”

Katsuki’s mouth twitched. “Don’t make me fucking laugh again, nerd. I'm tryna set a goddamn mood. Now spread your goddamn legs for me, yeah? Gonna take my sweet time with you.”

“Thought you were gonna go harder than this,” Izuku muttered. Katsuki barked out a laugh.

“Lil’ Deku, don’t worry your shitty head about it. I’ll fuck you good.” God, his voice was deep. Izuku felt it in his bones.

“When,” Izuku actually whimpered. He was so turned on it nearly hurt, and he wanted to be *touched* .

“After you quit bitching, you impatient idiot,” Katsuki told him, then kissed his forehead. Izuku groaned in frustration.

“I hate you.”

“You’re gonna hate me more,” Katsuki told him, taking a hold of his chin. “Baby. You say stop and I stop, okay?”

“Yes,” Izuku sighed, lifting his chin. Maybe he was hoping Katsuki’s hand would slide down to his throat. Maybe he had a thing for being dominated, for letting go of control, putting his life in someone else’s hands. “But don’t stop. Please continue,” he added. Katsuki’s hand trailed down his front, before settling on his sternum.

“So nice and polite,” Katsuki praised him, pushing him back onto the mattress.

“I am,” Izuku purred, lifting his hips and grinding against Katsuki.

“You talk so much,” Katsuki said. “If you don’t shut up, I’m just gonna fuck your face for the rest of tonight. You can try talking with a mouth full of cock. How’s that sound, Deks?”

“That sounds gr-”

“And then you’ll never get it up this tight little ass,” he added. Izuku’s mouth snapped shut. Then open.

“You didn’t shut up last time,” he protested, because it was unfair. Katsuki grinned, apparently pleased with himself.

“‘Course I didn’t. I’m the bitchiest sub in the country. That was me trying to *behave* .”

“Oh shit.” Izuku felt his dick actually throb like in shitty erotica. He changed his mind. Maybe he’d never been a dom *before* , but fuck if he didn’t want to ruin Bakugou Katsuki.

Katsuki grinned the worst shit-eating grin Izuku had ever seen. “You know you wanna make me behave.”

“Katsuki,” Izuku snapped. “You’re tempting me.”

“Sorry Midoriya, but we’ll have to do that another time. This ass is mine tonight.” Katsuki threw him a cocky grin and gave Izuku’s dick a little pat. “Ditch your undies, loser.”

“Why do I like you?” Izuku asked, but pulled off his underwear regardless. Katsuki looked victorious, and for a moment, Izuku was overwhelmed. He loved how Katsuki looked like that, grinning down at him, focused and dangerous. It was both familiar and thrilling. Katsuki was reaching towards him, putting two fingers in his mouth. Izuku let him, sucking on them, watching the arousal flutter across Katsuki’s face.

“Where’s your lube,” Katsuki asked, pushing his fingers deeper. Izuku wrinkled his nose in response, because obviously he wouldn’t be able to reply like this. Katsuki leaned in. “Where,” he insisted, pushing Izuku’s tongue down. “Tell me, Deku.” Oh. That was the point.

Izuku managed to mumble something that sounded like ‘drawer’ around Katsuki’s fingers. “Man, I love shutting you up,” Katsuki drawled, leaning over to investigate. Maybe he leaned some of his weight on the hand in Izuku’s mouth, and maybe Izuku bit down a little. Katsuki pulled his fingers away, looking at them with a frown.

“You’ll pay for that,” he said, lazily.

Izuku pointed at the lube in his hand. “Hop to it, turt-mmf.” Katsuki had lunged forward and covered Izuku’s mouth.

“Nope. No more turtleboys, or I’m fucking leaving you with blue balls. You’re gonna be nice for me, right?” Katsuki stared him down, fingers digging into his cheeks. Izuku nodded. “Good.”

Katsuki removed the hand, and Izuku deeply considered sassing him again to get him to put it back, but then again he actually did want Katsuki to get a move on. So he settled for sticking out his tongue.

Katsuki rolled his eyes, and thankfully went to find a condom (in his discarded pants pocket apparently). Izuku took the opportunity to spread his legs as sinfully as he knew how, propping himself up on his elbows in a way he *knew* made his abs look fantastic. When Katsuki turned back around, he dropped the newly found condom with a curse, then picked it back up.

“You look,” he swallowed, “Fucking good.”

“Yeah,” Izuku said, knowing he sounded smug as hell. Well, he was smug. Anyone would be, if the sight of their naked body made Katsuki drop whatever he was holding.

Katsuki just shook his head and climbed up behind Izuku’s thighs. Where he belongs, Izuku thought. “Fucking shameless,” Katsuki told him, lubing up his fingers. Izuku was nearly trembling in anticipation, knees open, feeling horribly exposed. Katsuki was clearly enjoying the sight.

“You said to be nice,” Izuku replied, sounding a lot more breathy than sassy. “So I’m being nice.” Katsuki’s eyes darkened.

“I did,” Katsuki said, his voice rough. “And you look so good. Makes me want to reward you.”

“Please,” Izuku said, lifting his chin to look at Katsuki through lowered lashes. God, he wanted him so badly. Katsuki gave him a half-smile.

“Such a good boy,” he purred, running his warm hands down the insides of Izuku thighs. Fuck. Izuku’s back arched off the bed. He felt fucking touch-starved.

“Kacchan,” Izuku whined. “Come on, I need you.” In answer, Katsuki’s hands curled around Izuku’s thighs and yanked him closer. Then finally, finally touched him, stroking his dick, down over his balls, down to his ass. Izuku’s mouth was dry with desire. He hadn’t been planning to beg, but he was damn well about to start if he didn’t get something in him right now. “Kacchan, come on,” he pleaded again. It was a good thing he was too horny to care how pathetic he sounded.

“So fucking eager,” Katsuki snorted and leaned over Izuku, propping himself up with one arm. Blessedly, his other hand stayed between Izuku’s legs, where it belonged. Izuku rose up the rest of the way to kiss him. Unceremoniously, Katsuki pushed a finger inside his ass, making Izuku swear into his mouth.

“There you go,” Katsuki said, voice hoarse. “Relax, baby. I got you.”

Izuku realized he was trembling. One finger was easy for him, but this was Katsuki. Katsuki leaning over him, kissing him, Katsuki’s finger in his ass and... fuck. He was too turned on. He let Katsuki ease him back onto the mattress, kissing him softly. He put his hands in Katsuki’s hair, pulling him closer, deepening the kiss, trying not to be too obvious about grinding against Katsuki’s forearm.

“Yeah yeah, okay,” Katsuki moaned into his mouth. “One more.” Izuku tried not to smile in triumph as Katsuki added another finger, and finally began to move them. Izuku was in bliss.

“Kacchan you feel so good,” he panted. Katsuki kissed him again, taking way too fucking long.

“That’s right, lil’ Deku. Want some more?”

“Fuck! Please!”

“So good,” Katsuki praised him, voice like gravel. Izuku moaned as another finger went in. He was losing it. It wasn’t just that it was Katsuki, there was a primal aspect to being pinned down by such a goddamn badass man. He clutched Katsuki’s shoulders, feeling the man’s fingers push deeper, accepting the uncomfortable feeling of being stretched that was quickly overwhelmed by the pleasure flickering up his spine with each thrust.

“God, Katsuki, please just fuck me,” Izuku hissed, nails digging into his back. Katsuki paused, pulling away enough to look Izuku in the face. Izuku’s heart squeezed; Katsuki looked fond. Affectionate. Like he was trying to memorize Izuku’s face, like he’d just been handed everything he’d ever wanted.

“Sure,” Katsuki said, smiling slightly. “In a bit. I’m enjoying this.”

Izuku was going to scream in frustration. Or cry. He loved him so fucking much, but he was so sexually frustrated. Katsuki kept moving, kissing Izuku again, maddeningly slow.

“Kacchan, I’m…” Izuku trailed off. “You’re driving me crazy.”

“That’s the idea, idiot,” Katsuki huffed. “Besides, I’ve wanted this for so long. I’m gonna fucking indulge.” His fingers curled, once, twice, and then molten pleasure shot through Izuku. He was left gasping, legs squeezing Katsuki’s waist.

“Fuck.”

“Soon,” Katsuki grinned, and kissed Izuku’s neck, curling his fingers again. Izuku moaned against his shoulder, taking deep, shuddering breaths. He just had to survive until Katsuki started fucking him, right?

“Kacchan, please,” he said hoarsely, distantly aware of how undone he’d come.

“You sound so nice when you beg,” Katsuki said. Was Izuku begging? He was, and if he was going to beg, he may as well do it properly.

“Please, Kacchan, I want your dick so badly,” Izuku whispered, letting his lips brush Katsuki’s ear. He could actually feel Katsuki tense up. Progress. “Please I just want your cock in my ass, I’ll do anything, please just fuck me.”

Katsuki sat up, looking down at Izuku. “You know what? Fine. I fucking will, you impatient piece of shit.” Izuku grinned up at him, victorious and still very horny. Katsuki looked like he was torn between being desperately turned on, annoyed, and affectionate. Izuku felt it was a good look on him. He waited eagerly while Katsuki rolled on a condom and positioned himself, slowly pushing in. Izuku shut his eyes, relaxing into the feeling. The feeling that suddenly stopped.

“Open your eyes,” Katsuki ordered. “Watch me.”

Izuku’s eyes flew open, and he felt his cheeks warm. “F-fine,” he stammered. Katsuki met his eyes, his gaze mercilessly intense. Izuku’s heart pounded.

“Good,” Katsuki told him. “I want to see your face when I push my cock inside you.”

Izuku made some sort of unintelligible noise, but somehow was able to keep his eyes on Katsuki. He had no idea what expression he was making, but Katsuki muttered something that sounded like ‘fuck you’re hot,’ so it couldn’t have been too bad. He effortlessly lifted Izuku’s hips onto his knees, lining himself up carefully. Izuku wanted to scream about how slow he was being, but he was so close to getting what he wanted and he didn’t want Katsuki to draw things out any further.

Then Katsuki was pushing inside, slowly but surely. “Fuck,” Izuku sighed, his head dropping backward. It was good, so good. “God, Kacchan, you feel perfect.”

“You too, Deks,” Katsuki said. Izuku reminded himself to look up. Katsuki’s eyes were still on his face, and Izuku drank in the sight. His goddamn sculpted body, the way his chest flexed as he carefully controlled Izuku’s hips, the trickle of sweat sliding down his abs.

Then he picked up the pace slowly. Izuku found himself breathing with each thrust, making pathetic little pant-moans that seemed completely unavoidable. And he was being fucked by Bakugou Katsuki.

Katsuki fucked him slowly, leisurely, like he had all the time in the world. Izuku lasted at least a few minutes before impatience took over. He found himself trying to push his hips against Katsuki. Katsuki breathed out a laugh.

“Nope,” he said, controlling Izuku’s hips to move at his pace.

“Kacchan, *please* ,” Izuku groaned. “How much nicer can I ask?”

“Guess you really want to get railed,” Katsuki told him, maybe picking up the pace the smallest amount. With a groan, Izuku laid back. Katsuki was apparently determined to drive him up a fucking wall instead of giving him what he wanted. Instead he concentrated on the feeling of Katsuki driving into him, the pleasure curling through his body, the quiet sounds Katsuki was making. It was good, too good to resist touching himself. He sighed in relief, gaining a few seconds of bliss before Katsuki grabbed his wrist, and firmly pulled it away.

“Why,” Izuku half-snarled. He hadn’t meant to sound angry, but goddamn he was starting to edge and god he wanted to come so badly. Katsuki pitched forward, hands landing on Izuku’s arms, pinning him down. The motion shoved him deeper into Izuku, making him cry out, his mind perfectly blank for a moment.

“Because, Deku,” Katsuki growled, head hanging over Izuku’s, *“I’m* fucking *you* . And you’re going to take. What. I give you.” He punctuated each of the last few words with a thrust.

“Fuck,” Izuku whispered. Katsuki had him half-folded over, and began to fuck him in earnest. “Fuck, *yes* ,” Izuku groaned.

"Shit," Katsuki snarled, thrusting harder. The obscene sound of balls slapping against Izuku's ass filled the room, and Izuku held onto the blankets for dear life. Katsuki's hands were driving his arms into the bed, hotter than was reasonable, but not quite enough to burn. Izuku

thought so, at least, but it was fucking hard to think straight. And honestly, he couldn't care less if he got burned in that moment.

Izuku was too far gone to care what he looked like. Was he crying? He didn't know, be he did know he was sweaty, panting, eyes glued to Katsuki's face. Katsuki was slowly coming undone, his face losing its reservation, becoming almost animalistic with desire. Izuku realized he was talking, muttering praise telling him how hot he was, how good he felt. Izuku felt the burn of pleasure building up as he watched Katsuki over him, arms flexing with each thrust, the pressure bordering on painful but it felt too good for Izuku to care.

It was overwhelming, it was ecstasy, it was killing Izuku. "Kacchan, fuck," he panted. "I'm-"

"Izuku," Katsuki breathed out, eyes locking on his.

"I'm so fucking close please just touch me," Izuku began, words petering out into a mumbled stream of consciousness that was probably incoherent.

"Shit, baby, I got you," he groaned, straightening up, shifting positions to lift one of Izuku's legs over his shoulders. One strong arm circled Izuku's thigh, and he started working Izuku's dick with his other hand. Izuku's head was thrown back, chest heaving. Distantly, he heard Katsuki say, "That's it baby, come for me, come on…"

Izuku came hard, mind swamped by pleasure, breath stuttering. It took him a while to come back around, and when he did, blinking away mental static, Katsuki was laying next to him. He was propped up on an elbow, looking down at Izuku. He looked as wrecked as Izuku felt; sweaty and exhausted and glowing.

"Izuku," he murmured, leaning in to kiss his temple.

"Katsuki," Izuku breathed, rolling to face him. God, he was tired. His whole body felt boneless, the pleasant-post orgasm buzz blocking out any discomfort.

"I got you this." Katsuki held up a wet wipe. "Can I?"

Izuku looked down. God, there was cum all over his stomach. Had he really just fucking lost his mind for a couple of minutes? When had that happened? "Go ahead," he mumbled, trying to sound coherent. There was something viscerally relaxing about Katsuki gently cleaning him up, and if anything, Izuku melts even further into the bed.

"Mm just gonna sleep," he mumbled, then grunted as a very warm Katsuki crawled onto his chest.

"Get ready for bed first."

"Tired."

"At least brush your teeth," Katsuki insisted.

Izuku cracked open an eye. Katsuki was smiling down at him. "You're fucking with me," Izuku sighed.

“Hygiene is no joke,” Katsuki told him. Of course it wasn’t a joke, because apparently Izuku had forgotten he was dating the most anal person ever, whether it was about nutrition or dental hygiene or being the best stupid hero in the stupid country. “Don’t worry, baby,” Katsuki went on. “I’ll help.”

Then he scooped Izuku up and carried him to the bathroom.

“You like being in control,” Izuku said, mouth full of toothbrush. Katsuki shrugged.

“Yeah, yeah, I’m a dick.” Katsuki was using Izuku’s spare toothbrush, which… was apparently Katsuki’s now. Huh. The thought made Izuku strangely happy.

“Like in sex,” Izuku clarified. Katsuki looked at him sideways.

“Good or bad?”

Izuku spat out toothpaste, making a face in the mirror. He looked, well, like he’d been fucked. His hair was a complete disaster, his eyes watery, and he was pretty sure he saw finger-shaped bruises forming on his arms.

“Izuku?”

“Oh! Uh, really good, perfect,” Izuku said, smiling at Katsuki in the mirror. The man’s expression went from worried to smug instantly, and Katsuki pulled him in for a minty kiss.

“I’ll stay till you fall asleep,” he promised, carrying Izuku back to bed. Izuku tried to remember the last time he’d felt so cared for by someone he’d dated, and failed. He fell asleep quickly, head on Katsuki’s chest, listening to his heartbeat.

Days later, Izuku had to quit ignoring his PR rep’s phone calls in favor of even more patrols.

“We want you to do news appearances together,” Suika was saying. Izuku stared at the ficus in the corner of Katsuki’s apartment, wondering how such an explosive person had managed to keep a plant alive, let alone healthy. Katsuki himself was out on patrol, but had lured Izuku over for Katsuki’s breakfast/Izuku’s dinner.

“I thought it would be bad for my reputation, or something,” Izuku said, trying not to sound resentful.

“Well, it would be if you two were exposed and it became a scandal. My plan - and Ono-san agrees - is to have you two naturally get closer over time. Then people will be excited to know you have a boyfriend.”

“We’re already close, though?” Izuku ignored the twist in his stomach at the word *boyfriend* , and the faint guilt he felt at not correcting Suika to say they were just dating. He was determined not to push Katsuki for more than he was willing to give. He just had to believe

that they would get there eventually, that Katsuki would tell him when he was ready. Suika's next words startled him from his thoughts.

“In public perception,” Suika said, very patiently. “Have you heard of shipping?”

“No,” Izuku said, which was a fat lie. Suika didn’t need to know that, though. Izuku knew everything about heroes, through copious amounts of searching. He’d seen things.

“It’s like, people who like to imagine a fictional couple. Anyway, if we make the public *want* you two together, it should go over pretty well if you decide to announce it.”

“That…” Izuku trailed off, turning it over in his head. “Might actually work well. I’ll talk to Kacchan about it, but I’m sure he’ll be fine with it.” It was weird to be able to say something like that about Katsuki, but it was true. Despite being unreasonably temperamental, Katsuki had become a relatively reasonable person.

Suika hung up shortly after, promising to add some joint interviews to his schedule. The first was a few days from now, on a hero panel about life after graduating UA. Izuku was excited to see that several other of their classmates had been tapped to participate, including Uraraka, Tsuyu, Jirou, Kaminari, and Sero. Izuku, Katsuki, and Uraraka were the big-ticket sellers on the interview, and Izuku strongly suspected Katsuki’s agency had only agreed to it in order to go along with their ‘ignite the shippers’ plan.

The interview came all too quickly. Izuku had only managed to see Katsuki a few times before, but he’d seemed relatively calm about it. That in and of itself made Izuku nervous. He made it all the way through the fancy lobby, up the elevator, and to the studio’s floor. Katsuki was waiting, dressed as Ground Zero.

“There’s a janitor closet around the corner,” he said by way of greeting. The lecherous grin on his face made the implication pretty obvious. Izuku looked at him, fighting with himself. On one hand, it was desperately unprofessional to make out with his fellow interviewee in a closet before going on air, but on the other hand… he’d never made out with Katsuki in his Ground Zero get up, and he was suddenly finding that he really, really wanted to.

“Is there?” Izuku said, his heart thudding in his ears. “Sounds interesting. Maybe you should show it to me.”

“Maybe I fucking should,” Katsuki snapped, and was off the wall and around the corner in an instant. Izuku followed him, giggling behind a hand. Katsuki opened a door, and waved a hand. “After you.”

Izuku went in, and Katsuki shut the door behind him. With Katsuki outside. Fucker. “Kacchan! You asshole!” Izuku shouted, slapping the door. He almost fell when Katsuki opened it, and slipped inside. He was doubled over laughing.

“Deku,” he gasped between laughs. “I couldn’t fucking resist.”

“This does not make me want to make out with you,” Izuku snapped, trying not to find it funny. He felt the situation called for more righteous anger then he could muster up, but then… when was the last time he’d seen Katsuki laugh that freely? Or even seen him prank someone, like pointless fun was worth his time? Suddenly Izuku couldn’t hold a grudge anymore. He pulled Katsuki upright and kissed him right on his stupid, smiling mouth.

“You’re giving me mixed signals, baby,” Katsuki told him, smiling into his mouth.

“Mmm,” Izuku said, ignoring him in favor of running his hands over that tight black tank top. It really did leave nothing to the imagination. Katsuki kissed him back, pushing him up against what probably was several brooms leaning against the wall. Izuku made some sort of sinful moan, because being pushed up against *anything* by Ground Zero was literally a situation straight out of his wet dreams.

“No, don’t tell me,” Katsuki murmured. “Of-fucking-course you’ve got a thing for hero costumes.”

Izuku jerked back, looking at him. Called out the fuck out. At least the closet was dim enough that Katsuki probably couldn’t see his blush? “Relax,” Katsuki snorted. “I don’t give a shit. You know I’d wear whatever weird shit turns you on.”

“W-would you,” Izuku stammered. He had too active of an imagination to hear things like that. He was going to have some very productive self-love time in the future.

“I’m gonna regret this, but yes, whatever you want,” Katsuki chuckled. “We should get going, though. Ono will castrate me if I miss this.”

“I can’t let that happen,” Izuku said, trying to keep a straight face, “For personal reasons.”

“Fuck you.”

“Please do,” Izuku winked.

“Get the fuck out.”

Laughing, Izuku pushed the door open before Katsuki could say anything else.

They were seated in a half-circle in front of a studio audience. They’d barely had time to chat and catch up before the show started up, but at least Izuku had been emailed a list of topics beforehand.

The panel was relatively easy, which Izuku figured had been by either Suika or Ono’s design. They were given softball questions, like what had it been like to go to UA together? What were some funny stories? What was it like to face villains at such a young age?

Still, it was fun to hear his old class mate’s responses. Izuku was sandwiched between Uraraka and Jirou, and Uraraka was kicking his foot any time there was a funny reply. Sero told them about the time he’d pranked their floor by taping everyone’s door’s shut (it had

gone over very badly), Uraraka talked about her internships and how she became an excellent martial artist, and Tsuyu gave them the insider's view of the Great 3rd Year Nori Incident (don't ask).

"So," the interviewer said, "Who broke the most rules? We've all heard Ground Zero was a trouble-maker."

"Katsuki? Good luck with that. The troublemaker was definitely me," Kaminari grinned, happy to take any title away from Katsuki, even if it wasn't a flattering one. "You wouldn't believe how much shi- stuff I snuck in the dorms."

"Please, just because you got caught the most doesn't mean you broke the most rules," Jirou snickered, waving a hand sarcastically. Kaminari was a good sport about it, because he's a good sport about pretty much everything. Jirou grinned at the audience. "That would be *me* . Because I have subtlety! Anyway, Bakugou always had a stick up his- uh, I mean, he wasn't a rule breaker at all, outside of like, property damage. He was just a dick. Um, a jerk."

Katsuki snorted loudly, but didn't seem that mad. "She's not wrong," he finally said, after realizing the interviewer was clearly waiting for a comment from him. "I've always been a fucking, uh, been a damn tryhard."

"It sounds like you all had a good time," the interviewer said, adjusting her glasses. "So, Deku. You have one of the highest popularity ratings among new heroes,"

"Oh, uh, thank you," Izuku blurted.

"But we know you had a rough start to your time at UA, with many self-inflicted injuries. What was that like?"

It was a topic Izuku had been asked about plenty of times before. "As you know, I got my quirk very late. It was definitely difficult to learn how to control it, and I am very grateful to Recovery Girl and the friends who supported me. That's why I think it's so important that organizations like the National Children's Quirk Support Agency exist now-"

"So, speaking of friends," she interrupted, leaning in. "Did-"

"So children with potentially destructive quirks can get the support they need to flourish." Izuku finished doggedly. "I think it's a very important cause."

"Right, of course," the interviewer recovered. "I wanted to ask about your relationship with Ground Zero. We have sources saying that it was a strained relationship." Izuku froze. This hadn't been on their briefings. Uraraka's hand discreetly landed on his knee, and she gave it a squeeze. Izuku was afraid to look at Katsuki. Ignoring the frigid mood, the woman continued, "He was a bully who targeted you viciously, correct?"

"I…" Izuku panicked. He didn't know what to say. Camera flashes were going off in his face. "He's uh, he wasn't that-"

“Are you afraid to speak up with him here? We can ask him to leave,” The interviewer said gently. Uraraka opened her mouth to interject, but Katsuki was faster, face hard.

“Look lady, I don’t know where the fuck you get off on blindsiding Deku with questions like that, but it’s goddamn unprofessional.” He spat the words out, hands making fists on his armrests. At least they weren’t smoking. Yet. Izuku swallowed, wondering if he should interject. The studio was deathly silent.

“Ah, Ground Zero,” the woman said. Her tone was measured, but the glee underneath it was apparent. She wanted drama, a scoop. Izuku’s stomach was twisting itself in knots. He should have thought of this, expected it. He’d rarely shared any media presence with Katsuki before, as they’d spent so many years avoiding each other. But if they were going to appear together, of course someone would dig up dirt. He could see the woman’s intentions despite her sugary smile. She stared Katsuki down. “Shouldn’t you let Deku speak? Haven’t you done enough already?”

Katsuki leaned back in the chair so suddenly it rocked. He crossed his legs, heavy boots pointing at the audience. It was a power pose. He lifted his chin, face hard. “Deku can say what he wants. But you want to know about it? Fine. I *did* bully the idiot for years, all through elementary school. It was horrible, and I was an absolute shithead,” Katsuki snarled. “And then I spent the rest of my life regretting it.”

The interviewer opened her perfectly lip-sticked mouth as if she wanted to say something, but Katsuki was on a warpath. He flung an arm out, pointing at Izuku. “But I’m lucky, because Deku? He’s a fucking angel. I am beyond grateful he let me back in his life.” Then he crossed his arms. “So here’s the deal. You want to throw bullshit questions around with no warning? Fucking go for it, but leave Deku out of it. He doesn’t deserve that crap.”

The studio was dead silent. Izuku was sweating bullets, wondering abstractly about why he felt the need to fall for possibly the most dramatic person in the country. Even his fellow heroes looked shell-shocked, staring at Katsuki like he’d grown a second head.

“Any questions?” Katsuki demanded, his voice full of gravel. Izuku wanted to either punch a hole in the ground and die in it, or possibly leap across his old classmates and kiss Katsuki on his angry, beautiful mouth in front of the entire studio.

“Uh,” the interviewer said faintly. She looked pale. Her eyes slid over to Uraraka, a much safer target. “So, Uravity, who was the hottest boy in your graduating class?”

“Huh???” Uraraka half-shouted.

“That was a disaster,” Tsuyu croaked. They’d agreed to go out together afterward, joined by an eager Kirishima who’d apparently been waiting outside for Kaminari. For hours.

“And asking me about the hottest men? It’s so sexist!” Uraraka steamed, savagely stabbing a fish ball in her soup. They’d reconvened in a private room in some chic restaurant that

Uraraka liked, and were sharing at least six pitchers of Sapporos between the eight of them. “I’m shocked they pulled that on Deku though!”

“That bitch shouldn’t have mouthed off,” Katsuki growled. He was sulking, and Izuku couldn’t help but find it endearing. Even if he was an overprotective asshole, he’d saved Izuku from hard-core panicking in front of cameras.

“She’ll probably be fired, or disciplined at least,” Uraraka said, her voice soft with concern. “It’s really frowned upon to blindside heroes with questions like that. No one’s gonna want to work with her after that.”

“I always get blindsided,” Katsuki huffed.

“Yeah, but you set the interview standard so low,” Uraraka snorted.

“It was surprising,” Izuku agreed, his chest still feeling tight. Uraraka leaned over and pulled him into a hug. Izuku let himself calm down, relaxing in his friend’s arms.

“It’s fucking bullshit,” Katsuki snapped. He was brooding, elbows on the table.

“It’s kind of your fault,” Tsuyu said quietly. Katsuki’s head snapped towards her, snarl already forming. “You’re the one with the bad reputation,” she said, completely unphased. “The people around you will get caught up in it. It’s your choice.”

“Go eat flies,” Katsuki said, without any venom.

“I like flies,” Tsuyu said thoughtfully. “Thanks. Though crickets are better.”

“Actually,” Izuku said, safe from in Uraraka’s arms, “It’s our choice. Like, it’s not like he’s forcing us to be around him? I’d rather have him and his bad press than have some weird, fake-nice version of Kacchan.”

Katsuki made a choking noise. “Some weird, nice version? The fuck’s that mean?”

“Mmmm,” Kirishima said. He had one leg on Kaminari’s lap, and was leaning into Sero’s shoulder. Sero looked very patient with it, but also faintly squished. “No, I’m feeling it. Like, imagine Katsuki being like…. ‘Hello, Good Morning. It is Nice To See You. My Name Is Katsuki. Let Us Be Friends,” Kirishima finished, making robotic hand motions in the air. Kaminari started snickering, and Katsuki put his face in his hands.

“So basically Katsuki but with Iida’s personality?” Sero asked, like he actually cared about the answer.

“I’m gonna throw up,” Katsuki groaned.

“It could be fun,” Uraraka said in a distant voice. Izuku looked at her sharply, and she winked at him. “You know what I mean.”

“What the fuck was that tone of voice,” Jirou said. “We know what *what* means?”

Uraraka blushed. “Nothing.”

“Nothing!” Izuku exclaimed, because he knew exactly what she was thinking about.

“I like this idea,” Tsuyu interrupted, saving them both from imagining Katsuki-as-Iida and Uraraka’s freak fantasies. “Not about Iida. But fake-nice Katsuki, I think it has merit conceptually. Katsuki-kun’s wearing, what is that? A minty green hoodie? It’s a nice color. It goes with his fake-nice personality.”

“Hello, My Name Is Bakugou Katsuki and I Wear Mint Green,” Kirishima snickered.

“Gonna kill all y’all,” Katsuki groaned, but his heart clearly wasn’t in it.

“Seriously, what the fuck are you wearing?” Kaminari said, too loudly. He’d had a lot of the Sapporos.

“I’m fucking in hiding, okay?” Katsuki growled, then downed Izuku’s beer, despite his own beer being right in front of him. Izuku pouted as Katsuki went on. “Goddamn people mobbing me ‘cause of the goddamn video and that shitty interview. Can’t even show my face without having people trying to photograph my fucking asshole.”

“It’s true, #BringDatAssBack is still top ten trending on Cheeper,” Jirou said, poking at her phone.

“I didn’t even know you owned anything in pastels,” Kaminari went on, risking life and limb. “What is that? Is baby green even a thing?”

“I bought it literally just to hide from the press,” Katsuki ground out, looking murderous. Izuku was infinitely amused, because now that he thought about it? Mint was a terrible color on Katsuki. The sweater itself was very soft, which he approved of, and it said ‘KIWI’ in sans serif pink on the front. Izuku couldn’t remember the last time Katsuki wore pink. He was pretty sure it had never happened, meaning that this was prime teasing material.

“Baby green’s such a cute color,” Izuku said, leaning his chin on one hand. “I think I saw some toddlers wearing it the other day. You look just like them.” Katsuki’s resulting glare sent an inappropriate thrill through him.

“Fucking tiny kiwi over here thinks he can mouth off,” he scoffed.

“I *know* I can,” Izuku said, demurely sipping Katsuki’s beer. He didn’t even bother looking at Katsuki. His pissed-off expression was too predictable, and he’d already learned he could torment him by acting nonchalant.

“Woof, that sass,” Sero cackled from behind Kirishima, which was arguably one of the safer locations at the table.

“Well, with #BringDatAssBack trending right now,” Kirishima smiled, looking devious. “Maybe people are taking pictures for social media. We could get material for BOOM 2.”

“Fuck that, I *know* they are,” Katsuki grunted. “I’m fucking tempted to go out in speedo or something so they can get it out of their pervert systems.” Izuku coughed slightly, thinking that speedo-Katsuki was an excellent idea.

“You probably shouldn’t,” Kaminari said, nodding sagely as he caught Izuku’s eye. “Deku looks like he’s about to pass out from just imagining it.”

Izuku didn’t even have time to protest, because Katsuki lunged at Kaminari. “Watch your fucking pervert mouth,” he snapped. Kirishima stopped his progress with a palm to the forehead, like someone pushing away a rabid dog. Kaminari cowered under his arm, shamelessly giggling.

“Bro it’s chill, Denki doesn’t mean anything by it. He’s just stupid,” Kirishima added, fondly. Kaminari stopped laughing to glare at him.

“It’s nice you guys made up,” Tsuyu said, her smile reaching her eyes.

“Yeah,” Izuku said, immediately thrown by how soft and fuzzy her words made him feel.

“Uh-huh,” Kirishima said with a shit-eating grin, “I think we all know the real reason Bakubro’s hanging out with us again. It’s ‘cause cute little D-”

“No,” Tsuyu said, slapping a palm on the table. Everyone shut up simultaneously. “I mean, it’s nice having you back like this, Bakugou-kun. It’s fun having you here with us.”

Everyone stared at her, and she suddenly blushed. It was… it was a really nice thing to say. Izuku felt like tearing up, but looked to Katsuki to see how he was taking it. Everyone’s heads turning to Katsuki as well, wondering the same thing: Was he going to snap at Tsuyu? Izuku might smack him himself if he tried it. No one snaps at Tsuyu. But Katsuki had just frozen, face blank.

Then it happened. It started as a faint pink on his cheeks, and spread across his face, down his neck. It was the full Katsuki blush. Izuku fell in love all over again.

“Um,” Katsuki choked out. “Thanks.”

Kirishima let out an ugly sob, threw himself across Kaminari’s lap and pulled Katsuki into a hug. “Bro,” he cried, tears spilling. “It’s so nice, I love you so much, oh my god.”

“Dude, I know,” Katsuki patted his head stiffly. “You gotta chill, damn.”

“See, it’s nice,” Tsuyu said, smiling wide enough her eyes closed.

“Yeah, it is,” Uraraka said, surprising Izuku. She’d always supported him, but still held a healthy skepticism of Katsuki. She gave the man a small smile. “I’m glad we’re friends.”

“Fuck off, round-face,” Katsuki muttered, face still red.

“That’s Katsuki-speak for he loves you too,” Kirishima blubbered. “I’m so happy.”

“And I thought I’d drunk too much,” Kaminari wheezed, still being crushed by Kirishima’s weight.

“Dude,” Sero said. “That thing today was fucked up. We’ve got your back, okay?”

Katsuki looked completely overwhelmed. Izuku threaded his fingers through Katsuki’s, giving his hand a squeeze. “We’re here for you,” he said.

Katsuki swallowed hard, and gave them all a smile. A real smile, like he actually felt safe and happy.

Chapter End Notes

Look, I know sternum is a weird word to use in a sex scene. I just love the word sternum and I’m not here to fight about it, plz let me have my fun.

~~...Anyone else wanna see Izuku try and make Bakugou behave? Bakugou’s so fucking sweet on him but like, he DOES have issues with authority lmao~~

Writing Bakugou is ruining my life. I actually am swearing like 1000% more in my personal life, like people have actually noticed the difference. I’m pretty sure I never used to say “dickhole” out loud, either, but now I fuckin do. I like to call it **method writing** (✿◠‿◠)

Just realized I’ve had an account on this site for 4 years and only now started writing fics. Am I sad or proud? Who knows?

Also um. I’ve been playing fast and loose with canon cause I’ve been catching up with the series while watching this. Two things on my mind:

1. I said Todoroki & Bakugou were the youngest peeps to hit top ten, but that’s apparently UNTRUE if they’re in their twenties since in canon some fucker did it in their teens. So let’s just pretend it’s true anyway lol ‘cause I don’t wanna retcon.
2. Not exactly sure how Bakugou’s quirk works in canon Like. I just wrote and deleted like 2 paragraphs of Izuku-type rambling so for the sake of my sanity, we are ignoring all that and saying it Bakugou has 100% control of when his sweat ignites or not.

Bros and broettes, I fucking read a really good fic right before posting this and somehow I've developed IMPOSTER syndrome for PORNY FANFIC. Too bad tho, cause I'm gonna post this anyway 'cause fuck my insecurity.

Once again, your kudos and comments mean the world to me and I can't thank you all enough <3 it really motivates me to keep working on this beautiful disaster!

Special Edition™

Chapter Summary

Izuku faces bad press for the first time. Bakugou makes a big choice. Suika nearly has about 10 heart attacks.

Chapter Notes

I made a shitty drawing of Bakugou in his KIWI sweater: my own damn fan art for my damn fan fic. Tbh outside of the sweater I put very little thought into how they look, so plz don't take my own goddamn drawing as fic canon and just go on imagining whatever you want <3

Content disclaimers:
-This chapter contains choking in a sexual way (tag has been added)
-That said, as someone who both loves submission wrestling as a hobby and (separately from that) being choked out sexually, CHOKING IS DANGEROUS. Please please please if you are ever choking someone or being choked, be safe & research how to do it safely first! I apologize if I'm being preachy, I'm just super wary of romanticizing anything that could be dangerous <3 I just care about y'all
-Mentions of homophobia (but not outright examples)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It started as a fun bonding idea. How long could Izuku and Katsuki ignore their phones after the disaster interview? Katsuki alone got forty-five texts during their post-interview dinner.

Izuku, being the good-natured one, caved first literally the very next morning (Katsuki was not impressed). Suika didn't deserve the silent treatment, and Izuku felt bad about all the missed calls. All thirty of them. To his surprise, Suika was horribly apologetic over the phone, and felt very distressed that he was a terrible agent and had let Izuku down. And in a way, Izuku realized, he was right. That question should never have been asked in the first place, and it was Suika's job to ensure that. Regardless, it had happened and now they had to deal with it. Izuku had never been someone to hold grudges.

"It's not great right now, honestly," Suika was saying, voice timid over the phone. "This soon in the game most articles will just be clips of Ground Zero snapping at the interviewer, although lengthier articles will be coming out soon and we really have two main options. Either you make a statement and hope it helps, or we say nothing and see how it plays out. I'm trying to set up a meeting with Ono and Ground Zero, to discuss media strategies. We

can’t have Ground Zero exploding like that every time something like this comes up, because it definitely will on the media's radar now.”

“I’ll make time for it,” Izuku sighed. “You think it’ll be bad?”

“Brace yourself,” was all Suika said. “Just remember that these kinds of low-tier articles don’t reflect who you are, okay? Some people will make anything toxic, no matter what the truth is.”

Izuku tried to keep that in mind, but two day’s time saw him sprinting around the track at headquarters, trying to burn off the sting of the articles about him and Ground Zero. Every time he checked, there seemed to be fresh idiocy in the gossip mills. Most of it Izuku could brush off, even though the digs at Katsuki made him burningly angry. One article, though, had made him furious. Furious enough that this was his fortieth lap, and he planned to run until he collapsed. Which would hopefully be soon, because he'd already been at it for what felt like hours. As his feet pounded over the astroturf, the headline of the article echoed in his head:

HOW CAN DEKU STAND UP FOR JUSTICE IF HE CAN’T STAND UP FOR HIMSELF

The article dug into Izuku for not saying something in the interview, implying a wide variety of horrible things, from saying that Izuku deserved to be bullied because he didn’t stand up for himself, to saying that since he was a victim of bullying, he couldn’t be a hero.

It brought him right back to before UA, when Katsuki had placed a burning hand on his shoulder and told him to not even bother applying. Okay, so Izuku was a little bit mad at Katsuki. He knew it wasn’t strictly fair, and that was why he was burning the emotions out by running to the point of exhaustion.

If Katsuki hadn’t bullied him, he wouldn’t be in this situation now. People wouldn’t be writing articles doubting that he, the past victim of a bully, could be a hero. People wouldn’t be writing articles wondering if a past bully could be a hero in the present. And then Izuku also felt a bone-deep weariness, born from the constant pain in the world. How many kids were still being bullied? How many people’s confidence had to be destroyed? Was it really so hard to be kind to people?

Izuku only stopped running when he saw Katsuki walking out onto the field. He was wearing baggy pants and a tight tank top, hands deep in his pockets. Izuku jogged over, trying to shove down the thorny feeling in his heart.

Katsuki jerked his chin up in acknowledgment, his posture softening only when Izuku came to a stop before him. Apparently sensing Izuku’s mood, Katsuki just said, “What the hell is wrong with you?”

The tangled mess in Izuku’s chest rose up. “What’s wrong with *you?”* He retorted. Katsuki’s eyebrows shot up.

“Well excuse the fuck out of me,” Katsuki folded his arms. “Am I not allowed to ask if you’re okay?”

“Why did you do it,” Izuku said, chest heaving. Sweat was running down his forehead, stinging his eyes, but he didn’t care.

“I’m not playing some goddamn guessing game,” Katsuki frowned. “Tell me what’s going on, or I’ll fucking go to the PR meeting by myself.”

Oh, they had the PR meeting this afternoon. Katsuki had said he’d come pick up Izuku. Some of the fight drained out of him, leaving Izuku feeling exhausted.

“The bullying, Kacchan. I know you apologized, but why? What did I do? Why did I deserve it?”

Katsuki froze. “The hell? You didn’t deserve it, Izuku. And I was just a shithead-”

“Don’t just insult your past self,” Izuku interjected. “I already know you were an ass. I want to know why. Why were you like that? Why to me? Why did I *deserve it?"*

Katsuki sighed, unfolding his arms. He was clearly fighting his temper, and seemed to be winning for the moment. “Do we need to do this right here? Right now?”

Izuku clenched his jaw. He could probably bury this feeling, push it down again, but it was there nonetheless, festering and he wanted to lance the wound. It was strange, but the nicer Katsuki was to him, the more he resented how he’d acted in the past. It was as if seeing Katsuki’s potential for kindness made him wonder why he couldn’t have been kind back then.

“I just don’t understand,” Izuku said, his voice catching. Katsuki took a step forward as if to hug him. Izuku took a jerky step back, unconscious. Katsuki’s face shuttered.

“It’s not fucking easy for me to talk about,” he ground out. “And I don’t like having it dropped in my lap out of the blue.”

“Well, I don’t like having my hero ability suddenly called into question because you just had to bully me as a kid! Because you couldn’t let me speak for myself when it came up!”

“What?” Katsuki’s face shifted from resentful to outraged. “Who said that? And I fucking couldn’t just say nothing when that bitch was gunning for you!”

“Article,” Izuku snapped. He wished he’d had his phone with him, so he could thrust it in Katsuki’s face. Regardless, Katsuki's posture shifted as he relaxed into a slouch.

“That's what this is about? Don’t read that bullcrap,” Katsuki sighed, the tension bleeding out of his words. “It’s all complete garbage. They’ve been spewing that crap about me since the fucking sludge incident.”

Izuku stared at him, throat tight. He was angry, but he hadn’t thought about it from Katsuki’s perspective. Izuku could count the number of negative articles he’d had written about him on both hands, which was astronomically low. Katsuki was just a kid when they’d started talking

shit about him. It actually hurt to think about. He'd always looked up to Katsuki, but in retrospect? Katsuki was only sixteen when the papers started to tear him apart. From an adult perspective, it seemed surprisingly cruel.

"How do you deal with it? I don't know what to do," Izuku said, his heart in his throat. He was a little mad, but now he just felt heartbroken. Heartbroken that people could talk so harshly about victims of bullying, that people would be so harsh on teenagers just trying their best. Catching Izuku's expression, Katsuki's face softened.

"Come here," he said. Izuku fell into him, and was immediately pulled into a hug. Katsuki was warm, solid, and Izuku was in tears immediately. There was something about being comforted that always made him cry harder. He heard Katsuki's laugh rumble in his chest.

"I dealt with it by being fucking angry and blowing shit up, Deku. Not sure that's your thing."

"It just hurts to know that people talk like that, that people pay to read it," Izuku sniffled. "I think about me as a kid, and how small and hopeful I was. It makes me so *angry* to hear people say kid-me couldn't be a hero just because of what he was put through. Just, how dare they? I was trying so goddamn hard!"

"I know, I know. It's fucked up," Katsuki agreed, squeezing Izuku closer. "I know it's a shitty cliché, but it's just a part of our job. We get glimpses of glory, but most of it's shit. Seeing people get hurt, bearing the blame, being an outlet for the frustration of every small-minded fucker out there. It fucking sucks sometimes, sweetheart." Izuku was really crying now.

"Such a crybaby," Katsuki said softly, stroking Izuku's back. "Look, I got you, okay? We'll do whatever we have to to get through this bullshit. You know I'd fucking murder the lot of them for you if you'd let me, right?"

"Don't murder anyone," Izuku mumbled, feeling a laugh bubble up. It came out wet and broken, but it was a laugh all the same.

"No promises," Katsuki frowned. Izuku looked up at him, blinking away tears. Katsuki took a deep breath. "About everything else. Why I bullied you and… it's honestly a hard thing for me to talk about. Can we talk about it another time? Maybe not in the middle of your HQ's rec area?"

"Kacchan," Izuku said softly. "I'm sorry I blew up at you."

"S'okay," Katsuki murmured.

"We can talk about it when you're ready."

"Thanks, baby." Katsuki took a deep breath. "And I'm sorry I exploded in that interview. I saw the look on your face and just fucking saw red. I wanted to rip out that woman's wagging tongue, but it wasn't my place to speak for you."

“It’s okay,” Izuku said, scrubbing his face against Katsuki’s chest, making his tank top wet with tears. “Honestly, I didn’t want to talk in that interview after what she said. I was glad you stepped in, actually. I was just mad about what that horrible article said and I’m sorry I took it out on you.”

“It’s alright,” Katsuki said, with a crooked grin. “I know you’re not used to this bullshit. Don’t read that garbage anymore, or at least take it with a grain of salt. A fucking mountain of salt, actually.”

“You’d take it with a mountain of chili flakes,” Izuku snorted. Katsuki flicked his nose gently.

“You know me so well.”

They cleaned up in the locker room and headed to Katsuki’s PR department. Izuku took a burning shower, and Katsuki had donned the KIWI sweater again and managed to look vaguely unrecognizable with the hood up. Izuku tried and failed not to make fun of him, because he enjoyed Katsuki’s shouted retorts. They held hands in the taxi on the way to the PR company's office. Izuku felt the frenetic energy of his run ebbing away under Katsuki’s warm hand.

Thankfully, no reporters had gotten wind of them, so they were able to meet Suika and Ono in front of the building. It was a scorching day, yet another note of weirdness this summer. It seemed every day alternated from burning heat to pouring rain, but meteorologists were stumped.

Anyway, it was hot enough that Suika wasn’t even wearing a blazer, opting for a salmon button-up over green shorts. Izuku bounded over and hugged him, earning an ‘oof’ from the slight man. Suika had been his rep since he graduated, and they’d been through a lot together. Katsuki followed more slowly, looking vaguely disgusted at the display of affection. He raised a hand in greeting, then flinched when Suika tore away from Izuku to bow.

“Ground Zero sir! It’s nice to meet you! I’m Suika Satoshi!”

“Calm your tits,” Katsuki drawled, and Ono reached up and smacked him on the shoulder with a newspaper.

“Manners! Suika is a very respected colleague of mine, and you will not bully him.”

“Yes, please keep telling me what to do,” Katsuki snorted. “That always goes well.” He turned back to Suika, who flinched at his look. “Just call me Bakugou, like a goddamn normal person.”

“Uh, let’s go inside,” Izuku suggested, then turned to Ono. “I’m Midoriya Izuku, also known as Deku. Nice to meet you!”

Ono bowed slightly, smiling. She was a short, slight woman with black, cropped hair. Her smile reminded Izuku of a crocodile. “Nice to meet you, Deku. I’ve heard so much about you.”

Izuku shot a suspicious look at Katsuki, but they finally headed into the building and out of the heat. The four of them hashed out their plan, which was about 50% strategy and 50% telling Katsuki he couldn’t just scream at everyone who pissed him off. Katsuki took this with minimal bitching, which Izuku assured Suika was a good sign.

Izuku left the meeting feeling considerably calmer, especially once Ono had showed him her collection of the Top Ten Worst Articles about Ground Zero. They were bad. Really bad, like, Izuku would be crying in his shower if it were about him bad. There were homophobic ones, biphobic ones, ones flat out announcing that Ground Zero was a villain, as well as a string of false accusations of everything from property damage to civillian attacks. Katsuki only looked a little grumpy about Izuku looking over his articles, but apparently it was worth it if it cheered up Izuku.

That didn’t stop Suika from leaning into Izuku and whispering, “You sure you like this guy?” which made Izuku snort so loudly Katsuki asked what was going on, which in turn made Suika bid them all a hasty farewell.

They made the best out of their mutual day off. Katsuki didn’t want to fuck up his sleep schedule, so he napped in Izuku’s bed while Izuku worked on research for his current cases. Katsuki couldn’t scold Izuku for working in his time off if he was asleep, after all. Izuku got a little too wrapped up in his work, because he didn’t notice Katsuki awaken, pad all the way across the room, and drop onto his hunched over back for a hug. He shrieked in surprise, trying to squirm away. Katsuki was too heavy though, and his arms were definitely holding him down intentionally.

“Morning, little nerd,” Katsuki rumbled in his ear, sending shivers down his back.

“Kacchan,” Izuku choked out, trying to shift mental gears from deep-dive research to… whatever this was. “What are you doing?”

“You, hopefully,” Katsuki said, tugging him away from the chair. Ah, that’s what this was. "My next day off is full of some signing and public appearance bullshit. I don't know when we'll next get to have some fun, Deks."

“Right, fun,” Izuku said, his head spinning. And then spinning more, as Katsuki picked him and set his back against a wall. Izuku blinked down at him, dizzied by the sudden change in position. “You’re very active for someone who just woke up.”

“True,” Katsuki frowned, then dropped him. Izuku landed on his feet with a squeak. Katsuki shot him a significant look. “Maybe you should do the work, then."

“I just spent four hours researching,” Izuku complained. “You’re well-rested and my mind is mush.”

Katsuki tilted his head, considering. Izuku was pretty sure he'd never been so thoroughly eye-fucked before. "Is this your shitty way of telling me to take control?"

"Mayb-"

"Because I will," Katsuki followed up immediately, leaning into Izuku's personal space. Izuku literally felt all his blood rush downwards. Katsuki's hand came to cup the side of Izuku's neck, before tracing a line up his jaw. He was avoiding Izuku's neck. He was sure of it.

"You don't like choking," Izuku blurted out. Katsuki froze.

"Uh."

"Am I right?" Izuku didn't mean to push, but he was curious. Given Katsuki's obvious enjoyment of being in control, he'd think it was right in line with everything else, but Katsuki's shoulders were drooping. Izuku was suddenly afraid he'd pushed too hard. "Kacchan, I'm sorry, I won't bring it up again."

"It's not that," Katsuki swallowed hard. "I just have, fuck. Baggage. I have baggage."

"Do you want to talk about it? Izuku asked gently. Katsuki met his eyes, reluctance written all over his face. Then he sighed.

"Not all of my exes trusted my hands. My last boyfriend was a model, and he was particularly… he ended up afraid of me," Katsuki said, voice measured. "He couldn't risk damaging his perfect fucking skin. Wanted to be the best model in the country, et cetera."

"Where's the risk?" Izuku blurted, outraged that anyone could think that of Katsuki. "Have you ever even accidentally hurt someone? Let alone someone you were with?"

Izuku had meant it as a rhetorical question, Katsuki held up his hands to consider them. How could someone think that of Katsuki? Katsuki who'd never accidentally hurt someone in his life? Notwithstanding intentional injuries… but he was someone with a naturally dangerous, hard-to-control quirk. He was also someone who'd developed an insane level of control over that destructive force.

"Not outside of collateral damage on missions," Katsuki shrugged. Izuku held up his hands, scarred and twisted as they were.

"I'm not worried about my skin," he said, wiggling his fingers. "I'm already grotesque."

Katsuki cracked a smile. "Don't fucking fish for compliments."

"But Kacchan, you dated models," Izuku whined playfully. "I can't compaaare."

"You could date models too, if you didn't have such shit taste in men," Katsuki grunted.

"I'm dating you," Izuku pointed out.

Katsuki's smile widened to a grin. "Exactly."

"And you've done modeling," Izuku clarified.

"That was ages ago. You saw that crap?"

Izuku thought about the saved picture on his phone, and blushed. Katsuki looked delighted, his smile stretching to look a little more dangerous. "Wow look at you, creeping on my shit way back when."

"I've always been creeping on your shit," Izuku said defensively. As if that made it less mortifying.

"Never stop," Katsuki said, fighting a smile. Izuku didn't try to hide the way that made him smile, the way it made his whole body feel warm. Maybe they were good for each other, after all. Maybe he had something to offer Katsuki, and vice versa. So he lifted his chin in invitation.

"I trust you," he said, meeting Katsuki's eyes. "And I like that kind of thing, so if you want to, you should. I know you'd never hurt me." He swallowed hard, feeling vulnerable. Katsuki's eyes were dark, examining him. Then slowly, achingly slowly, he lifted a hand. Izuku was nearly trembling with the tension of holding still, but then he felt the warmth of Katsuki's hand on his neck, feather-light and gentle. He felt Katsuki's thumb trace the vulnerable skin under his jaw.

"You always seemed a little fixated on my neck," Izuku risked saying, remembering the near-dozen hickeys he'd gotten that first night. Katsuki's hand twitched, the motion sending trickles of pleasure down through Izuku's body. "Thought it was strange you wouldn't do this."

"You might be right," Katsuki admitted, voice low, leaning in. "I might have a thing for this."

Izuku tried desperately not to be horribly turned on, but it was impossible. Just the knowledge that the hand on his throat could destroy buildings, that Katsuki held his life in his hands, was making Izuku feel all sorts of things. Filthy, delightful things.

Izuku focused on breathing. This was an important moment for Katsuki, and they were exploring their growing trust in each other and Izuku would *not* be a horny asshole about it. Not even when Katsuki's grip tightened, pulling Izuku away from the wall and into his face.

"You know how to tap out, right?" His voice was rough with excitement. Izuku gave up on not being a horny asshole.

"Yes," he said, breathless, and tapped Katsuki's shoulder to demonstrate. Katsuki let him go immediately, with a skeptical look.

"And since you're an idiot, you gotta promise not to push it. Don't want you getting hurt 'cause you think you're tough shit."

Guilty as charged. "I promise," Izuku told him.

“Good, cause I’m about to wreck you,” Katsuki growled, pinning Izuku against the wall. He kissed Izuku hungrily, one hand running up his abs, his chest, to land on his throat. Izuku moaned at the touch, his voice raspy. Katsuki swore under his breath, fingers squeezing against the side of his neck. Izuku sank into the heady feeling, the headspace where he gave up control, where he let his partner dominate him.

Katsuki backed Izuku up against the wall and kissed him sloppily, his mouth demanding and unrelenting. Izuku melted against him, lost in the sensation. He didn’t even notice he was getting light-headed until Katsuki let him go, and murmured, “Breathe for a second, baby.”

Izuku sucked in air and stared up into Katsuki's face like it was the only thing left in the universe. Katsuki's pupils were blown wide with desire, lips parted. Izuku kept his eyes on him while Katsuki's hand moved from his neck to his jaw, as pressed his thumb into Izuku's mouth. With a jolt, Izuku realized he'd been pathetically humping Katsuki's thigh. He made some sort of dismayed noise, and tried to stop.

"Nope," Katsuki growled, and ground his thigh between Izuku's legs. The contact sent waves of pleasure shuddering up his body, making him moan around Katsuki's thumb. "Keep it up, lil' Deku. I want to see you cum for me, and then I'm going to fuck your pretty ass up against the wall."

"Mmm," Izuku managed to say around the finger in his mouth, despite the dirty words melting the last of his capacity for rational thought. He was pretty sure he'd drooled a bit, and his eyes were wet. He was an absolute hot mess and it was turning him on probably more than it should. Katsuki mercifully removed the finger, and raised his eyebrows in silent question.

"Yes Kacchan," Izuku breathed out, grinding against Katsuki again."I want that, please."

Katsuki's mouth curved into a shark smile as he praised Izuku. "Good, you're so good. You look so fucking pretty like this, all fucked up and desperate for me."

"Mhm," Izuku encouraged him, sighing in pleasure as Katsuki's hand tightened around his neck. It allowed Izuku to let go of all his insecurities, his worries, his need to control any situation. It allowed him to give into the pleasure of Katsuki against him, thigh between his legs, hand on his throat, holding him tightly. Katsuki murmured filthy things in his ear, goading him on, praising him, and finally, finally Izuku lost himself and came, shaking in Katsuki's arms.

Katsuki cradled his face in his hands, looking into Izuku's eyes. "Hey, how you feeling?"

Izuku looked at him dreamily. "Plus Ultra," he sighed. Katsuki barked out a surprised laugh.

"God I fucking like you so much," he chuckled. "You're so damn stupid."

"I'm stupid," Izuku said agreeably, wondering if maybe he'd come hard enough to short-circuit his brain.

"Yeah, I think we're done for tonight. Wall-fucking can happen another day," Katsuki snorted. "Instead, I'm gonna run my favorite little idiot a bath. Does that sound good?"

"Yes!" Izuku said happily. "Carry me, Kacchan," he added, drooping against his chest.

"Anything for you," he grunted, lifting Izuku gently. "Anything for you."

Izuku was damp, hungry, and starting to worry that this was actually a bad idea. He was surrounded by rabid Ground Zero fans, all collected in a somewhat-orderly line despite the downpour. Somehow, his relatively non-descript outfit actually stood out in the sea of black, army green and bright orange.

He'd thought it was a good idea at first, until he realized he'd needed to wake up a lot earlier to even get a decent spot in line. As it was, he'd gotten there an hour early and was stuck in a line down the block, standing in the pouring rain. He was going to have to show up to surprise Katsuki while being damp and uncomfortable. Oh well.

Sometimes he forgot just how popular Ground Zero actually was. Now, surrounded by fans excited discussing the latest Ground Zero news, Izuku was beginning to regret it, regardless of how hilarious it would be to Katsuki's surprised face when Izuku showed up at his signing. He killed time by browsing news articles, if only to figure out what the people around him were screeching about. Unsurprisingly, it had to do with their disaster interview from the week before. The headlines ranged from speculative to outright toxic, and Izuku found himself getting angry all over again.

FRIEND OR FOES? TWO TOP HEROS AT ODDS IN SHOCKING INTERVIEW

ANGRY HERO SUSPECTED OF PAST MISCONDUCT: GROUND ZERO'S DARK SIDE

HERO DEKU VICTIM OF BULLYING: TRAGIC OR PATHETIC?

GROUND ZERO BARES ALL IN SURPRISE CONFESSION

GROUND ZERO HARRASSES REPORTER: BULLYING BEHAVIOR A WORRYING TREND

ANGEL AND DEVIL: DEKU AND GROUND ZERO'S SORDID PAST REVEALED?

Izuku texted the last one to Katsuki with no explanation. The reply was immediate:

Kacchan: *lol yeah i won a bet w/ kiri off that one*

Somehow that response leeched all of the rage out of Izuku. He wasn't alone in this, and Katsuki clearly didn't think these articles were worth any emotion. And if Katsuki wasn't going to rage about it, who would? Katsuki's standard for what deserved fury was consistently low, and it was hard to justify being mad about something even Katsuki wouldn't explode over. So Izuku let out a long breath and texted him back.

Izuku: *You were betting? On what??*

Kacchan: *how long b4 some fucker ran an angel/devil thing abt us. i said 3 days*

Kacchan: *kiri said a week, cause hes dumb af*

Izuku: *. ..aren't you at a signing right now?*

Kacchan: *i <3 it when you stalk me like the creepy fcker u r*

Speaking of stalking... Izuku looked around, feeling a bit guilty. He'd managed to make it to the just outside the mall's entrance, and was having to listen to everyone's favorite theories on what Ground Zero had done to bully him, whether it had even happened, whether or not Izuku had deserved it (????), and how dare anyone try to malign Ground Zero's already rough reputation, and also worryingly, whether or not they wanted to continue supporting Ground Zero after his admission. Izuku tugged his beanie down lower, feeling like he stood out. Maybe he shouldn't have brought his bright green frog umbrella, but it was raining hard, thunder cracking in the distance. Each crack made him wince - that'd be more debris for him to clean up on his next shift, more emergency responders he'd need to cover for.

Izuku: *You told me about it days ago, Kacchan. And uh, you didn't make any other weird bets did you?*

Kacchan: *hell YES i did*

Kacchan: *wanna know what*

Izuku: *You know what, I'll pass >.>*

Kacchan: *i got ¥10k that says we'll be trending on porntube b4 the end of the month*

Kacchan: *sparky says it'll take us 3 months but he obv doesn't understand how hot i am*

Izuku: *I SAID I'LL PASS*

Kacchan: *kiri wont bet w/ me on which porn stars will play us :^(*

Izuku: *THAT'S A GOOD THING!!*

Kacchan: *we're also betting on how many roundabout ways these reporter fucks try n figure out who tops*

Kacchan: *more accurately k&k are betting on how long it takes me to lose my everloving shit*

Kacchan: *fuckers wont let me in on it cause its "rigging the game" or sth stupid*

Kacchan: *do u think theyd charge me w/ assault for exploding nosy reporters or??*

Kacchan: *asking for a friend*

Izuku: *I honestly feel bad for Ono, you are a nightmare client*

Izuku: *Also, that's not how you use that phrase, I already know it's you and not a friend...*

Kacchan: *fuck u*

Izuku: *Sure, tonight?*

Kacchan: *i cant even be mad cause i def will ;)*

Kacchan: *but also fck off loser*

Izuku: *Aren't you still supposed to be like, interacting with fans right now?*

Izuku tried to see through the glass doors. The line folded around several times, but he was pretty sure he could see a spiky blonde head at the end of it.

Kacchan: *[quoted Kacchan] "fck off loser"*

Kacchan: ^

Izuku snorted, but figured he should leave Katsuki to his fan experience. He listened to two fans vehemently agree that Deku was a monster for besmirching Ground Zero's name, and ultimately lost his patience and finally put in earbuds. The sweet sounds of All Might intros drowned out the noise of the fans chattering.

Finally, about seven theme songs later, Izuku had officially made it inside the mall. He clutched his cardboard poster tube closer, and tried to quell his nervousness. He knew Katsuki liked him. He knew it. But would he want to see him here? He would, right? Now that he thought about it, they hadn't interacted as heroes in public, outside of the interview.

God, he was going to make this weird. His phone buzzed.

Kacchan: *where u at? im bored af, gonna blow this joint soon*

Kacchan: *u said ur off today right*

Shit. Izuku hurriedly typed back.

Izuku: *You shouldn't disappoint your fans like that*

Kacchan: *how else will i keep up my bad rep? cant have the bastards thinking i like em*

Izuku: *Well, I'm getting lunch later. You should chill out and do your signing, then join us for food after?*

There was a pause.

Kacchan: *Fucking fine.*

Capitals and punctuation? Somehow that made Katsuki seem angrier than his normal swearing did. Izuku forced himself not to read into it, and to just live to get to the front of the line. Hopefully, Katsuki would still be there.

Izuku managed not to be a nervous wreck by the time he reached Katsuki, but only just. There was a masking tape line on the ground, and Izuku waited patiently for the girl in front of him to finish up. Katsuki was leaning back in the flimsy chair, feet on the table, looking undeniably irritable as he muttered something to her. Eventually, he snapped *Fuck off* , which somehow seemed to delight her as she scurried away with a smile.

Izuku stepped forwards, finally. God, this was way more awkward than he'd expected. Katsuki was studiously ignoring him while typing on his phone. Izuku's pocket buzzed. Reflexively, he pulled his phone out to check it.

Kacchan: *losing my fucking mind*

"Hey fuckface! The fuck you doing on your phone when…" Katsuki trailed off, and Izuku pulled off the ridiculous sunglasses he'd brought. "Oh. What the-"

"Hi," he said, unable to stop his smile. Katsuki looked completely floored. Izuku defaulted to what he knew best - being a hero fanboy. "I'm here for the signing."

"I can't believe I didn't fucking realize it was you until now," Katsuki groaned. "The fuck are you doing here?"

"Getting my special edition Ground Zero poster signed," Izuku beamed. "Do you call all your fans fuckface, or am I special?"

Katsuki rubbed his face. "I shoulda expected this bullshit from you."

"Yep," Izuku said, trying not to let doubt curl through his stomach. "Um, I hope you don't mind that I came here."

Katsuki looked at him sharply, then sighed, pulling his feet off the table and leaning forward. "That's why you were weird about me ditching this shitshow, huh?"

"Obviously," Izuku muttered. He felt a meltdown looming. Maybe he shouldn't have shown up. He should have asked first, and made Katsuki was okay with it, and he was pushing boundaries and now that he really thought about obviously it was really overreaching to-

"Nerd. Quit muttering, you're scaring the staff."

Izuku's mouth snapped shut. Katsuki was right; the staff were eyeing him with concern.

"Sorry," he mumbled, and pushed the poster forward.

"I could have signed this anytime," Katsuki said, voice deep with amusement. "I literally saw you this morning."

"I thought it would be fun," Izuku blushed. He looked at his shoes and listened to the scritch of the sharpie on the poster.

"You think too much," Katsuki snorted, and pushed the poster back to him. Izuku picked it up, and looked at the signature. It wasn't Katsuki's signature (which he'd memorized, sue

him). His jaw dropped open.

Katsuki had drawn an admittedly angular heart, and beneath were the words *Your Kacchan* . Izuku was melting. He was having a whole other kind of meltdown now, the kind where his thoughts were drowned out by his heart pounding and how fucking happy he was. *His* Kacchan? Since when had Katsuki ever even slightly hinted he could maybe belong to anyone? Never, is when.

Finally, he was able to pry his eyes off of the message and look up at Katsuki, who was frowning.

“Shit, should I just have signed it normally?” Katsuki said, sounding concerned. Izuku stared at him, mind non-operational, as Katsuki kept speaking. “If it’s limited special edition crap then it’s probably less valuable now, I-”

“No! No. Kacchan, it’s…” Izuku cleared his throat, overwhelmed. “Kacchan, I love it. I love-” he caught himself just in time. *You* , he wanted to say. Instead, he lamely finished with, “It. I love it. It’s seriously the best thing I’ve ever owned and I will cherish it forever, actually, I should look into getting it preserved and what if it gets ripped when I bring it home oh god we’re going to lunch-”

“Jesus fucking christ,” Katsuki interjected. “Deku. I’m glad you like it, but stop freaking out.”

Izuku looked up at him, thoughts completely derailed. That’s the reason he blurted out, “My Kacchan.” Not because his mind was on a perma-loop of *your kacchan your kacchan your kacchan-*

“Yes, yes, I’m yours,” Katsuki huffed. “Fucking possessive little shithead. Got anything else you want signed, nerd?”

“I just brought the poster,” Izuku said, wondering if he’d offended Katsuki somehow. He’d stopped himself from accumulating Ground Zero merch over the years with a variety of mixed feelings, but he was more than ready to make up for lost time.

“You waited in this whole line for one shitty poster,” Katsuki said, incredulous. Izuku had come around from feeling insecure, and now he felt comfortable enough to be irritable with Katsuki’s nonsense.

“Maybe I’ll bring more stuff next time, if you’re nice,” Izuku said, carefully rolling the poster and putting it back in its tube.

“At least I’ll have one god-forsaken thing to look forward to in this hellscape,” Katsuki groaned. To look forward to. Katsuki had liked that he’d showed up. Izuku grinned with relief.

“So,” Katsuki waved a hand, “What else do you want from your favorite hero? Got any questions about the glamorous hero life? Want me to sign your asscheek?”

“Now there’s an idea,” Izuku said, mind taking a quick detour down the gutter. “But All Might is my favorite hero, not you.”

“You want *him* to sign your ass cheek?”

“Uh-”

“Do not tell me you just considered that,” Katsuki grimaced. “I can’t believe I fucking like you.”

“My Kacchan,” Izuku said in a sing-song voice. “You like me so much.”

“Yeah, so what?” Katsuki’s ears were turning a bit pink.

“I should probably let other people have a turn,” Izuku said, shooting a nervous glance at the people behind them.

“Fuck those extras,” Katsuki grunted. “I’ve been here for hours. How stupid happy would you be if I hooked up with more rare merch?”

“Extremely stupid happy,” Izuku said, trying not to look too eager. He was pretty sure he failed.

“Good to know,” Katsuki hummed, giving Izuku a burning look. “I’ll text you when I’m getting out of here, alright?”

“Y-yes, of course,” Izuku stammered, realizing he’d probably overstayed his welcome and he’s just been dismissed. “I’ll uh see you later bye!”

Your Kacchan. Izuku was giddy with happiness. He stopped by a craft store and bought a frame for the poster, because he had zero chill about this and he had no plans to change that. That’s why he killed time at his office in his sector’s headquarters, getting ahead on paperwork. More specifically, trying out strategic places to hang his newest prized possession while his paperwork sat innocently in his inbox.

Izuku decided that the poster belonged in a place of honor, directly in his line of sight from his chair. Then he remembered that they were supposed to be keeping their relationship a secret, and an 11x17 poster with a heart from Ground Zero wasn’t exactly subtle. With a murmured apology, the Kacchan poster was put into a locked drawer, safe and sound until he could bring it home. There was zero chance that Katsuki wouldn’t make fun of him for this, but it was a risk Izuku was willing to take.

He actually did get paperwork done after that, and endured the good-natured judgment from his teammates for being a workaholic, and was saved when Katsuki finally texted him.

They met outside the cafe Izuku had picked for lunch, only slightly late for their reservation. Izuku turned to go inside, but Katsuki held him back.

“I want to talk,” he said, voice gravelly. Izuku felt a line of dread worm its way through his stomach. He’d been wrong to show up at the signing, Katsuki had just been humoring him, and - something was thrust into his hands.

“Here,” Katsuki grunted, then shoved his hands in his pockets. Izuku blinked at him, trying to get a read of what he was feeling. He’d gotten used to Katsuki’s smug confidence, but right now he seemed… uncertain? Worried?

“What is it?”

“Shut up and open it,” Katsuki snapped. Izuku rolled his eyes, but opened the paper slip and pulled out what seemed to be a postcard? He turned it over and was immediately struck with Ground Zero’s face up close, with a very impressive scowl and angry eyes. The card had holographic print, and it was a style Izuku had never seen before.

“Oh,” Izuku said, wonderingly.

“First print of special edition cards,” Katsuki sighed. “Literally the first one in the print run.”

“Oh,” Izuku said, with the awed kind of voice King Arthur would use when finding the Holy Grail. He looked up at Katsuki, eyes threatening to get moist. “Oh.”

“You like such dumb shit,” Katsuki said. “So I grabbed you this."

“It’s not dumb-” Izuku started, but stopped as Katsuki’s frown deepened. He looked like he wanted to say something, as his face tensed up.

“Um, dating you,” Katsuki coughed. “It’s been nice.”

Izuku was getting dumped, holy shit. This was a goodbye present to soften the blow. He was frozen, unable to talk. Katsuki cleared his throat.

“Fuck. Um, you know we have a shitty history, and I hadn’t fucking talked to you in years before we got together so I didn’t know what to expect-”

“It’s fine,” Izuku said quickly. He couldn’t take this, he’d just make an excuse and run. “I’m just-”

“What I’m saying,” Katsuki cut over him, “Is that I fucking didn’t know how being with you would go. Like, it could have been really hard, or some shit. Maybe we wouldn’t get along or-”

“I thought we were getting along,” Izuku said, unable to hide the quaver in his voice. His fight or flight instinct was currently dead-set on flight.

“We are!” Katsuki yelled, then slapped a hand over his mouth as people passing by shot them dirty looks. He continued in a much quieter voice. “It’s easy. Being with you is so easy, okay?

I fucking love it. Be my boyfriend, Izuku. Please."

Oh. *Oh.* Izuku was not getting dumped. He was getting the opposite of dumped. He was getting a boyfriend.

He looked at Katsuki, standing nervously in front of him. He was oblivious to the pedestrians bustling past, to the sounds of chatter from inside the cafe. Katsuki, his childhood best friend. A man he'd always looked up to, someone he'd come to love, someone who made him laugh, someone he'd trust his life with. He felt wetness rolling down his cheeks, and he realized he was crying. Like, tears streaming down his cheeks, Niagara Falls-style crying. Katsuki looked horrified.

Izuku launched himself at Katsuki's chest, keeping the precious postcard out of harm's way (Izuku had his priorities), and flung his arms around Katsuki's waist.

"Okay, yes, please," he said between sobs. After a half-second of confusion, Katsuki wrapped him up in a hug.

"I shoulda known you'd cry your face off," he said, his voice a rumble in his chest.

"Of course I would," Izuku cried, indignant. Out of all things, this was the best to cry about. Katsuki's hand snuck up into his curls, holding his head closer.

"Well, that's all I wanted to talk about."

"That's all?" Izuku squawked. As if it was some kind of small thing that hadn't just shattered and reformed Izuku's entire world?

"We're gonna miss our reservation time."

"But you just asked me out," Izuku blubbered. How could they have lunch? How could anything happen? Wasn't there supposed to be some sort of momentous period of time where the universe appreciated that Bakugou Katsuki was his *boyfriend* and the world stopped turning? Apparently not.

"Yeah, and now I want food."

Izuku looked up, only to find Katsuki's face just above his own. "You're my boyfriend," Izuku said, trying the words out.

Katsuki kissed him for one, dizzying moment. "You're right, it does sound weird when you say it like that."

"S'not weird," Izuku protested, wiping at his eyes with his sleeve. Katsuki took over, running his thumbs under Izuku's eyes, wiping away his tears gently.

"Come on Deks, let's go have lunch. Your boyfriend's gotta sleep before his shift tonight, you know."

Yeah, Izuku would never get tired of hearing that word. He took a moment to safely stow the holy grail of postcards in his backpack, then followed Katsuki into the cafe. He was walking on air. It should be illegal to feel this happy.

It was the sort of happiness that seemed too big to exist, like a hot air balloon flying too high in the sky. Icarus and the sun, or something like that. Something would always bring it back down to earth, and Izuku's happiness was no exception.

Chapter End Notes

I think that despite Bakugou acting too cool to bet on things, he's too easily provoked to resist and after years of friendship with K&K he doesn't really try to resist anymore haha

Confession time: I only started watching bnha like a month ago tops so I'm basically a toddler in fandom... BUT I still feel like a goddamn idiot for not knowing that Ground Zero isn't even Bakugou's official hero name?? I just saw Ground Zero in so many fics that I assumed it was canon and I just hadn't gotten that far yet?? BUT NO Bakugou's just so aggro dumb he can't name himself jfc

Suika is named after my favorite Japanese restaurant. I just learned it means watermelon. I named my poor baby character "Watermelon" and I'm a monster. I'm sorry Suika T-T

I'm looking to wrap this baby up in the next 2-3 chapters! I'm excited. After this, I'm writing a one-shot of Bakugou & Izuku's shitty first kiss and it's gonna be angsty AF.

Your comments are the lifeblood that keep me writing fanfic in increasingly improbable places (writing a sex scene on my phone during dinner was a new high point for me). I am eternally grateful.

Wreckage

Chapter Summary

Things get rough.

Chapter Notes

Please check updated tags, and I've put more detailed disclaimers below!

Content Disclaimers:
-I feel like I'm really earning the "rough sex" tag in this chapter. Told you aggro Bakugou was coming up! You have been warned :^)
-This is probs covered in the "rough sex" tag but here's specific warnings: just like, really dirty talk / kinda derogatory words like "slut" / spanking
-Exhibitionism - specifically public dick-groping, though no one actually sees it
-Past verbal abuse is discussed

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"BAKUGOU!" Izuku screamed into his phone the very second his boyfriend picked up.

"WHAT THE FUCK DO YOU WANT," Katsuki screamed right back, not even waiting for context. It really said something that Izuku could tell the difference between Katsuki's angry screaming and his neutral/friendly screaming. This was downright jovial on the Scoville Scale of Bakugou Shouts ™.

"They saw us kissing," Izuku cried into the phone receiver.

"Shit, really? Where the fuck's all the news, then?"

"Hang on, I'll text it to you."

Izuku: *[link attached]*

There was a moment, presumably as Katsuki scanned the article. And then there was uproarious laughter.

"Deku, my god," Katsuki cackled. "They didn't fucking recognize you, oh my god."

“This is why everyone says I’m plain,” Izuku whined.

The article was titled: *BAKUGOU’S NEW MYSTERY SQUEEZE? WHICH CUTIE TAMED THE BEAST?*

To be fair, the picture didn’t really show anything to identify Izuku. It was grainy and clearly taken from a distance, although Katsuki’s face and blonde hair were unmistakable. Fat lot of good the stupid KIWI hoodie did if he didn’t have the hood up, though in this case Izuku supposed could forgive him for being distracted. Izuku just looked like any black-haired guy with his back to the camera.

“You’re not plain, just boring,” Katsuki said in his ear, still bubbling with amusement. “I guess I shoulda been more fucking careful, though. Wouldn’t want anyone to figure out who my *mystery squeeze* is.” He started cackling all over again.

“Yeah, you could have not asked me out in the middle of the street,” Izuku grumbled. Technically, it was good he hadn’t been recognized, but it did sting a little.

“You know I’m not a fucking romantic,” Katsuki scoffed. “You should take what you get.”

“Uh-huh,” Izuku said, trying to sound ungrateful and failing. Izuku couldn’t sound anything but fond, because he’d caught sight of the *Your Kacchan* poster, now hung up in a place of honor in his living room. And yes, Katsuki had already teased him mercilessly about it.

“You keep telling yourself that. My Kacchan.”

“Fuck you.”

“Anyti-”

“And quit turning my cursing into innuendos,” Katsuki grumbled, making Izuku laugh. “How else will I cuss you out?”

"Don't complain," Izuku admonished him. "We both know you like it. How's work been?"

"It’s balls," Katsuki said. "Turns out first responders have been targeted lately. Not sure who all's involved, but if we get hit by a major disaster it's gonna be fucked up."

"I've noticed the same thing," Izuku frowned. "I guess it's across sectors? Have you guys found the villain behind it?"

“Us guys?”

“Kacchan,” Izuku snorted. “I’m not stupid. It’s obviously a villain, and of course the city’s top heroes are on it. It’s gotta be your Striker case, because it’s confidential - and that explains why no one’s talking about it. I’m surprised you’ve been able to keep it under wraps so completely.”

There was a loud sigh on the other side of the phone. “Yeah, fuck, of course you put it together.”

Izuku warmed at the compliment. Maybe Katsuki liked him, but compliments were still a rare thing from the blonde. “Of course I did. What else would I do but obsessively think about the city’s heroes? Did you know that you and Shouto are now the top two in our city?”

“Of course we fucking are. Don’t give a shit about the city though,” Katsuki’s voice rumbled over the line. “Gotta top the country. Then the planet.”

“You can start by topping me.” Izuku was glad they were on the phone because Katsuki couldn’t see his tomato-red face. At least he *sounded* confident. The truth was that the article was a lame excuse to call Katsuki and see if he was free, because Izuku was trying to get some damn action from his damn busy boyfriend.

“Such a dirty fucking mouth, Deku. When’d you get so filthy, huh?”

“That’s a rhetorical question, isn’t it?” If Izuku was going to actually answer that, it would probably be in his early twenties, once he had some experience and had shored up his self-confidence. And then a lot of it came from Izuku’s pathological need to shock Katsuki. It was just so satisfying, okay? “I’m going to answer seriously, it would be back when I-”

“Wow, look, my boner’s already gone,” Katsuki snorted. Izuku heard sounds of laughter from the background of the call. Where exactly was he?

“That easily?” Izuku grinned, goading Katsuki intentionally. What’s the fun of having a fiery boyfriend if you can’t set him off?

“Hey, fuck you too,” Katsuki snapped.

“Sure, any-”

“I swear to fucking god I will end you,” Katsuki groaned. There was a pause as Izuku tried and failed to stifle his laughter. Katsuki sighed again, then said, “Anyway, I’m fucking finally off my night shifts. I’ve been transferred 24/7 on call, which is also balls but not quite as shitty schedule-wise.”

“Wait, really? Isn’t on-call usually for sidekicks or like, junior heroes?”

“Not anymore,” Katsuki growled. “It’s too dangerous for them now. Don’t know when these fucks are going to show up, or where. I’m being used like some fucking point-and-shoot canon for every incident in the city.”

“Well, hopefully it’s not too bad,” Izuku said, worrying a bit about Katsuki’s pride. To finally hit Top Ten and be put on-call like a junior hero?

“It’s fine. At least I can be free at normal fucking times. Case in point, me and the extras from work are at McMarin’s right now. Wanna come by? You’re off now, right?”

Izuku glanced at the clock. It was 10:00 PM, and he’d called knowing Katsuki would probably be getting ready for an upcoming shift - which he no longer had. 10:00 PM also meant Izuku was exhausted, and he probably could convince Katsuki to come over but

then… Katsuki hadn't invited him out with his coworkers before. Izuku wasn't about to let this opportunity pass.

"Do they know we're together?" he asked.

"They're fuckin' about to," Katsuki said, sounding unworried. "You coming?"

"I'll come for you," Izuku said lightly, then hung up.

Izuku wore exactly the same thing as he had on his last trip to McMarin's, because he really just didn't have a lot of clothes with that vibe. He found the group in a booth in the back of the room, and approached nervously. It felt weirdly like meeting Katsuki's parents, except that he already knew Katsuki's actual parents. He had dinner with them and his own mother every few months, with Katsuki notably absent every time. He guessed that would change, now.

Timidly, Izuku tapped Katsuki's shoulder. Katsuki whipped around, face in his default snarl. Upon seeing Izuku, the snarl morphed into his shit-eating grin.

"Hey nerd," he said, and reached up, pulling Izuku down to his lips for a lingering kiss. The rest of the table erupted in noise. Startled, Izuku jerked away, looking up at everyone.

"That's Midoriya!" Onito was shouting, looking overjoyed. "Katsuki you absolute dog! You didn't tell me it worked out! I thought I'd ruined everything this whole time!"

Katsuki scooted down, squishing the man on his right in order to pull Izuku down next to him. He looked over at Onito with a shit-eating grin. "I know, fishface. You deserved to suffer after that crap you pulled. You're lucky I didn't fucking cut you up for sashimi."

"Hi," Izuku gave him a little wave, and Onito beamed back, displaying rows of sharp teeth. "Nice to see you again!"

"You too! Everyone, this is Midoriya Izuku, Katsuki's long-lost love."

"Shut the FUCK up," Katsuki snapped, an effort that was completely ignored by everyone else. Onito pointed at the woman next to him.

"This is Tanktop Tiff," he said. "The big Triple-T!" Tiff waved one huge hand, smiling slightly. She had cropped hair, and maybe the biggest muscles Izuku had seen outside of All Might. And yes, she wore a pink tank top with a yellow T on it. Izuku gave her one of his friendliest smiles. These were Katsuki's friends!

"Nice to meetcha," she laughed, her voice lighter than you'd expect from someone who looked like the embodiment of a Russian tank.

"And this sweetheart's Dovetail," Onito went on, pointing at the man Katsuki had squished up against the wall. He had long, rose-colored hair and doe eyes.

“You guys are cute,” Dovetail said, leaning on to the table, chin in his hand.

“I’m not fucking cute, asshole,” Katsuki snarled at him. Dovetail didn’t even blink, but Izuku interjected anyway.

“Mmm, I think you’re kind of cute.”

Katsuki rounded on him, fire in his eyes. “ *Kind of* cute?”

Shit, he hadn’t called Katsuki cute in public before, had he? He obviously hated it. Izuku opened his mouth to apologize, but Katsuki bull-dozed on, leaning into Izuku’s space. “And who the hell is cuter than me, huh?”

“W-what?”

“I said who the fuck is getting off on being cuter than me, huh? I'll go kill those fuckers right now.” Katsuki did look ready to kill, but in the particular way that told Izuku he was joking around. His angry snarl merely sent Izuku into fits of giggles. The rest of the table was apparently used to this behavior, because Tiff had just face-palmed and Dovetail had whipped out his phone to take a video.

“Uhh,” Izuku managed to say between laughs, “Uraraka’s pretty cute?”

Katsuki gave him a homicidal look, and pulled out his phone. Confused, Izuku watched as he hit Uraraka Ochako’s contact, and held up the phone as the line rang.

“Hello?” Uraraka’s voice was faint over the phone. Katsuki met Izuku’s eyes with a searing look.

“Hi chubby-cheeks, prepare to get fucking MURDERED-”

Izuku snatched the phone away, shrieking. “I’m sorry I’m sorry I’m sorry,” he chanted into the phone.

“Um, what?” Uraraka’s voice sounded deeply confused. Izuku sighed, slumping in his seat while Katsuki cackled next to him.

“Nothing,” he groaned. “Kacchan’s just being really extra again. I promise he’s not coming to kill you.”

“I could take him,” she said, mock-serious. “Tell him to try me!” Then she hung up.

“ *Kacchan?”* Tiffany crowed, as Dovetail wrapped his arm around Katsuki’s bicep.

“Oh, Kacchan,” he purred, leaning into Katsuki. Katsuki violently yanked his arm away, nearly pushing Izuku out of the booth in the process.

“I’ll fucking rip your tongues out,” he growled.

“Aw, Kacchan, don’t be mean,” Onito grinned.

“Deku, why would you ruin my life like this,” Katsuki groaned, face in his hands. “They’re never gonna stop.”

“Poor Kacchan,” Izuku said, and patted his head. “I’m so sad for you. Alexa, play All Might’s theme song.”

Katsuki turned to face him, expression dark. “Oh, you’re gonna get it for this, Deks.” Desire shivered through Izuku. Whatever Katsuki meant by *it,* Izuku was definitely interested. Work had kept Katsuki away from him for way too long, and they hadn’t had any quality time since the signing.

“I’m so scared,” Izuku stuck out his tongue, ignoring the laughter from Katsuki’s coworkers. His current plan was to rile Katsuki up now, and see what he got out of it once they went home. Hopefully, a very wound up Katsuki.

“Quit flirting at the table,” Onito chuckled. “Tiff, weren’t you telling us how you arm-wrestled a villain into surrender?”

Tiff went on with her story, giving some spirited demonstrations of the event. Izuku was absorbed, happy to learn about other people’s quirks and villain fights. Well Izuku *should* have been absorbed, but he wasn’t. No, Izuku was busy subtly moving his hand onto Katsuki’s thigh under the table. Katsuki’s head jerked around to look at him, eyes wide. God, he was so damn handsome, and Izuku wanted him bad. That stupid automatic frown, his jagged blond hair, his intensity…

“Sh,” Izuku said, quietly as he could, and squeezed his thigh. After a moment’s consideration, Katsuki narrowed his eyes and looked away. Then he deliberately slouched in his seat, making Izuku’s hand slide up his thigh to decidedly more interesting areas. The invitation was clear, especially when Katsuki put an arm around Izuku, pulling him closer.

Izuku tried to look focused on Tiff explaining how the villain’s elbow had popped, but he couldn’t think past Katsuki’s firm thigh. He slid his hand further down, massaging his inner thigh, running his fingers over the soft fabric of his sweatpants. Katsuki’s knees twitched apart, giving Izuku better access. That little movement was making Izuku’s head spin with desire. Could Katsuki get any hotter?

Katsuki pretended not to notice Izuku’s hand, humming in agreement or nodding along with what everyone was saying. Izuku knew he was affected though, for each time he ran his hand a little higher he could feel Katsuki’s knee twitch against his.

After a moment of laughter when everyone was distracted, Izuku risked looking down at Katsuki’s lap. His mouth went dry. Katsuki was hard. Like, completely hard, painfully obvious in his sweatpants. Izuku wanted him so badly he felt drunk with it. He tore his eyes away from the sight, looking blankly at Onito and Tiff across the table. He’d never felt more obsessed with dick, and he wanted nothing more than to jerk Katsuki off under the table, regardless of how filthy the thought was.

Izuku managed to restrain himself a little longer, until he pinched lightly at the sensitive area up the inside of Katsuki’s thigh. He swore he heard Katsuki moan under his breath. Izuku

was broken, and it was his own fault. In a move probably more daring than anything he'd done in his life, he put his hand lightly on Katsuki's hard dick.

"Fuck!" Katsuki barked out, jolting. The table turned to stare at him.

"What?" Dovetail asked, looking confused. Katsuki gritted his teeth.

"Fuck that," he said, voice raspy. His legs were tense, but Izuku didn't remove his hand. God, Katsuki was going to wreck him for this. Izuku was just deeply thankful for the booth's narrow seats, and the way the table covered this fucking bed of sin.

"Fuck whatever you just said," Katsuki continued, obviously trying to salvage his slip-up. Obvious to Izuku, at least.

"That Dovey found a nice hotdog stand yesterday?" Tiff snorted. "You're such a dick, Bakuboy."

"Yeah," Katsuki coughed. Izuku ran his hand down Katsuki's length. "Fuck!" Katsuki swore again, then went on, "That. Fuck that. Hotdogs are… shitty. Not spicy. You lot should eat proper fucking food. Nutrition is important." Izuku relished his last few breaths before Katsuki murdered him.

"Wow, Kacchan, you're so touchy," Izuku said, trying to remember if he'd written a will or not. He'd definitely need it after this. Katsuki glared at him, hands deliberately flat on the table, attempting to look casual.

"Look who's fucking talking," Katsuki snapped. Izuku knew he was referring to how he was touching Katsuki right now, but Onito looked confused.

"Katsuki, you're going to scare off Midoriya if you keep being such a dickhole," Onito frowned. Katsuki barked out a laugh.

"Oh yeah, I'm the fucking asshole." Katsuki's voice was dripping with sarcasm. "Deku's just a fucking sweet baby angel who's never done a fucking dirty thing in his goddamn shitty life!" Izuku always knew he was getting under Katsuki's skin when every third word was a curse.

"That's right, I'm a sweet angel," Izuku said, smiling beatifically in the face of his certain death. For good measure, he squeezed Katsuki's achingly hard dick. With a jolt, Katsuki slammed both hands down on the table, making everyone jump.

"That's it!" He shouted. "I'm fucking out of here!" He turned and bodily shoved Izuku out of the booth, following closely behind. He paused before getting up from the table, and aggressively threw his hood over his head. Then he blurted, "It was fucking great to see you guys but something came up so we are going and goodbye."

Izuku bowed quickly, saying, "It was nice to meet all of you, I hope I see you again!"

Katsuki slid out from the table, strategically angling his hips to hide his boner from the group. Izuku felt a little bad, but the feeling evaporated when Katsuki pushed him out of the

bar like a human bulldozer. He didn't stop until they were halfway down the block, when he grabbed Izuku's hips and yanked him against his dick, grinding hard into Izuku's ass. He leaned down to snarl into Izuku's ear.

"Bet you think you're real fucking cute, pulling shit like that." Then he bit Izuku's neck, hard. Izuku jumped against him, becoming worryingly hard himself. Thankfully, his jeans were tight enough to disguise it for now.

"I do think I'm really cute," he said, giving Katsuki an impish smile over his shoulder.

"Oh fuck you, I'm going to goddamn rip you apart," Katsuki growled. Izuku shivered in anticipation.

"Anytime, baby," Izuku purred, pulling out his phone to call a taxi. "Your place or mine?"

"Mine's closer," Katsuki breathed into his ear. "I'm not fucking patient. Hope you don't have any regrets in your life, 'cause I'm going to end you tonight." His hips jerked forward in an aborted thrust, making Izuku gasp.

"Hashtag no regrets," Izuku said happily, and scampered into the taxi when it pulled up.

The ride was tense, the air swampy with tension. Katsuki led the way up to his flat in stony silence, leaving Izuku's very active imagination to consider what Katsuki might do to him. Izuku was nearly crawling out of his skin with anticipation by the time they got to Katsuki's door. Wordlessly, he let them in.

The second the door shut and locked behind them, Katsuki turned and slammed Izuku back against it, knocking the breath out of him. Katsuki seized both of his wrists and pinned them against the door, muscles bulging as he tensed.

"You're such a filthy slut," Katsuki snarled, eyes burning into Izuku's. "Fucking grabbing my dick in public, huh? You wanna get railed that badly?"

"Yes," Izuku said, his voice coming out as a breathy whine. Katsuki gritted his teeth for a moment, then dropped his wrists in favor of grabbing his face. He leaned in, close enough their breath mingled.

"Rough sex," Katsuki said. Izuku blinked up at him, confused, but then Katsuki continued, his voice low and steady. "Rough sex is about trust. We both know I've been holding back with you."

"Right," Izuku looked up at him, utterly captivated. Nervous energy was running through his veins, burning him up from the inside. Was he actually going to get Katsuki to let loose? Maybe all it took was some questionably dick-grabbing, and-

"I have to be able to trust that you won't let me do anything you don't enjoy, Deku. Because I'm not feeling particularly *nice* tonight." Katsuki's voice interrupted his thoughts, and sent desire ricocheting through Izuku's nerves.

"You can trust me," Izuku whispered. "I promise. I want this so badly, Kacchan."

“You said there’s nothing you don’t want me to do,” Katsuki pressed, lips brushing his.

“That’s right,” Izuku breathed, heart in his throat. Katsuki’s nails dug into his head, creating small bursts of pain.

“What if I make you scream?” Katsuki’s gaze burned into him. “What if I'm *mean* ? What if I make you cry?”

“Please,” Izuku whimpered, painfully hard now.

“And if I slap the shitty smile off your face? Fuck you ‘till you sob into the mattress?”

Izuku’s legs probably would have given out if Katsuki hadn’t been holding his face up. He wanted it so badly. He wanted to be fucked until he couldn’t think, until the constant churn of his mind was blissfully silent, until he couldn’t see anything except the man before him.

"Please Kacchan," Izuku whined. "I just want you to fuck me until I can't think of anything except you."

Katsuki's breath caught. "You fucking asked for it," he said. Then unceremoniously gripped Izuku's hair and yanked his head to the side.

"You knew this would happen, didn't you," Katsuki murmured into his exposed neck. Tears were forming in Izuku's eyes from the tugging at his scalp, but he tried to nod anyway. "Couldn't fucking keep your hands off my dick, huh? Bet you were hoping I'd fuck your brains out. Un-fucking-believable."

Katsuki's hand was between his legs now, hot and rough, jerking him off firmly. Izuku's resulting moan was horribly dirty, drawn-out and desperate. Katsuki laughed, teeth sharp as he sank them into Izuku's shoulder. Izuku shouted at the sudden pain, but it didn’t stop him from mindlessly thrusting against Katsuki’s hand.

Then suddenly he was moving, pitching forwards onto Katsuki’s arm. Before he knew it, Katsuki had him bent over the kitchen island countertop. The black granite was cold on his chest, hard and unpleasant. Izuku tried to lift himself up, but there was suddenly a warm hand in the center of his back, shoving him back down.

“Take it off,” Katsuki ordered. Izuku glanced over his shoulder, and was struck dumb. Katsuki’s face was vaguely pissed-off, horribly handsome, and completely overtaken with desire. Izuku swallowed hard, not even wanting to tease him at this point. He struggled out of his shirt, the movements difficult while pressed against the counter. It was digging painfully into his hips, but he refused to complain.

Slowly, deliberately, the hand on his back slid up his spine, coming to a halt on the back of his head, when he pushed Izuku’s face into the countertop. Katsuki’s other hand began undoing his pants, yanking them down to his knees. Judging by the sudden cold against his skin, he was naked now.

“Is this what you wanted?” Katsuki asked, sounding faintly amused. “Bent over in front of me, ready to be used?” Izuku breath caught. Katsuki made a fist in his hair, pulling his head back. “Answer me,” Katsuki said, his voice gaining a rough edge that went straight to Izuku’s dick.

“Y-yes,” Izuku said, words muffled by the countertop. Then, because he was daring and apparently had a pathological need to antagonize Katsuki, he added, “Please use me.”

“Demanding slut, aren’t you?”

Izuku murmured something that sounded vaguely affirmative. After a moment, he felt Katsuki grinding against his ass, pushing him rhythmically against the counter. As good as it felt, the edge of the counter was digging into his hips.

“Kacchan, the edge is hurting my hips,” Izuku gasped out. Then there was a smack, and his ass stung. Katsuki had spanked him. The knowledge fizzed in his head, settling through his limbs. Izuku wondered what he’d need to do to get spanked again, and promptly forgot about his poor hips. Izuku tried to turn and look, but Katsuki pushed his head back down.

“And?” Katsuki ground out. “I don’t remember fucking asking.” Another slap, and Izuku found himself moaning into the countertop, ass stinging deliciously. And if Katsuki was now holding him slightly further away from the counter's edge to lessen the impact, Izuku wouldn't tell. Damn, he liked this too much.

And there it was. *It* being what Izuku had been fantasizing all those years, the vicious side to Katsuki that the man kept strictly in check. The side of Katsuki that wouldn’t hold back, that had the urge to win, to dominate no matter what. Izuku had just never imagined it tempered by tenderness. Tempered by the sure knowledge that if he asked, Katsuki would stop everything in an instant and fuss over him like a mother hen. Izuku wasn’t about to tell him to stop though, because goddamn he was finally getting what he wanted.

He whimpered when Katsuki spanked him again, hard enough to hurt. And again, and again, until Izuku was crying into the counter. His tears puddled next to his face, coming more from cathartic release than from pain, and the desire for anything, everything Katsuki had to give him.

“Kacchan,” he said, trying to sound alluring despite his mouth being smushed. “Want to feel you.”

“So fucking needy,” Katsuki said from behind him, and spanked him again. Izuku yelped in surprise. He flinched away from the contact, but the movement made his dick thud against the cabinet. It was pathetic that even that small contact threw a wave of need through him. Then Katsuki's hands were gone. Upset by the lack of contact, Izuku twisted around to look.

Katsuki was getting something out of a cabinet? A bottle of lube. Izuku stared. That was being prepared to the max. Before he could think better of it, he said, "You keep lube in the kitchen?"

Katsuki scoffed. "Yeah, so it’s on hand when I fuck needy little sluts like you."

"That's uh, very prepared of you," Izuku mumbled, knowing he was blushing. Katsuki never shut up. Not when he was fighting *or* fucking, and he had a goddamn filthy mouth. Izuku was blessed. Katsuki's grin was sharp.

"You're not the first slut I've bent over my counter."

That was an image. Izuku turned his face away, trying to hide how much the thought turned him on. That Katsuki could have anyone he wanted, but it was Izuku that he went home with.

"You like hearing that, huh?" There was a hand on his dick, wet and cold. Izuku moaned mindlessly, trying to process the question. Distantly, he knew it was Katsuki checking in, wondering if he'd gone too far.

"You're mine," Izuku choked out, letting himself be a little possessive. Behind him, Katsuki chuckled.

" *You're* mine," he retorted, voice rough as he ran a hand over Izuku's ass. "Gonna show you exactly who this ass belongs to. Nicest damn ass I've ever seen."

Izuku figured that was Katsuki's way of reassuring him without breaking character. He didn't have any more time to think, because Katsuki was pushing a slick finger inside him. Izuku reached up to grip the far side of the counter, half because he needed to steady himself and half because he knew it made his back look damn good.

"More," Izuku moaned. "Fuck me up, Kacchan."

"Dirty little thing, aren't you," Katsuki chuckled, but sounded pleased. "But don't worry, I will."

He rewarded Izuku with another finger, stretching him with the ease of practice. Izuku hadn't really expected to end his night getting fingered in Katsuki's kitchen, but he sure as shit was loving it so far. Before he knew it, Katsuki had three fingers in and was finger-fucking him, occasionally muttering filthy words of approval. Izuku moaned shamelessly, holding onto the edge of the counter for dear life. Then, mercifully, his fingers hit Izuku just right. Izuku gave a surprised shout, then whimpered as Katsuki changed angles. He let go of Izuku's hair in favor of leaning over the counter, resting his chin on his hand.

Izuku tried to focus on his face, but it was hard to concentrate when the sensation of being stretched was so intense. He knew his eyes were watering from the pull on his hair, and he may or may not have drooled on the counter. Without pausing his movement, Katsuki raised his eyebrows.

"Looking a little messy there, Deku," he teased.

Izuku only managed to say something that sounded like, "Hhrggn."

"Aw, can't talk with my fingers in your ass? You like it that much?"

"Y-yes," Izuku gasped out. "I'm such," he stuttered, "I'm such a, a slut for you." Katsuki's eyes darkened.

“Yes, you are,” he hissed, then pulled back. Izuku mourned the loss of his face in his view. Even worse, Katsuki pulled out his fingers.

“Where are you going?” Izuku cried.

“Good sluts get cock,” Katsuki snorted, and Izuku heard the sound of pants hitting the floor. Fuck yes. Before he knew it, Katsuki was pushing in, slow but implacable. Izuku whimpered at each inch, enjoying the feeling of being so full. Then he felt Katsuki start to jerk him off again.

“How’s my cock in your ass, Deku? Everything you fucking hoped and dreamed of?” Katsuki thrust in, and Izuku saw stars. It was too much; he was already overstimulated, Katsuki’s dirty talk was breaking his brain and he really couldn’t be blamed for coming pretty much immediately.

“It’s good,” Izuku said weakly, hiding his face. He’d tried not to finish so soon, and the failure had left him feeling strung-out and weak as he slumped against the counter.

“Fucking hell,” Katsuki snorted. “You came all over my cabinets.”

“Sorry,” Izuku muttered, peeling his face off the counter. It was objectively pretty gross. Behind him, Katsuki appeared to be washing his hands. As soon as he managed to stand up, Katsuki pulled him into a hug.

“I’m not done with you yet,” he purred in his ear. “But you can have a break, okay?”

Izuku let himself be steered into the bedroom, and be deposited on the bed. Katsuki left to clean the cabinets, because apparently he didn’t want cum drying on it. Which was fair. Katsuki might love dirty sex, but he loved a clean kitchen more.

Izuku was considerably more clear-minded when Katsuki came back, still naked from the waist down. He crawled onto the bed, and sat down, leaning against the headboard.

“Up for more, Deks?” Katsuki had dropped the arrogant act, and it was a genuine question. Izuku thought about it for a moment, appreciating the gesture.

“I just need a few moments,” he said, feeling a little shy. Katsuki reached out, and pulled him closer, letting Izuku rest on his chest.

“Take your time, sweetcheeks.”

Surprised by the endearment, Izuku looked up.

Katsuki’s smile was wicked. “But I’ve got something you can amuse yourself with in the meantime.” He looked very pointedly down at his crotch, where he was still somehow very hard. Izuku stared, blown away for a moment. He never really took enough time appreciating Katsuki’s body, his fine blond hair, the solid, powerful thighs.

“What’s the matter? You had no problem grabbing it in front of my goddamn coworkers.”

“Just admiring the view,” Izuku told him, then licked his own hand to jack him off with. Katsuki hissed in pleasure at the touch, hips bucking upwards. “Was that okay, by the way? I probably should’ve asked first.”

“Fuck, baby,” Katsuki groaned. “I didn’t mind, but asking would have been smart. Then I could’ve warned you that it drives me batshit crazy.”

“I see,” Izuku hummed, leaning in to lick Katsuki. “That’s good to know.” He’d definitely not ever take advantage of that knowledge, no way. Izuku was nice.

“You’re a monster,” Katsuki growled and took hold of Izuku’s hair, controlling his pace. He slowed him down considerably, fucking his mouth slowly. “But damn, you suck cock good.”

And the praise went on, and Izuku really hadn’t known anyone could find so many ways to describe sucking dick, but Katsuki had apparently figured out how much talking affected Izuku. It wasn’t that long before Izuku was half-hard again, bleary-eyed from having something in his mouth for so long.

Finally he pulled away, mouth dripping. “Kacchan, break’s over.”

“Fucking finally,” Katsuki muttered, getting up. “Don’t know how long I can last at this point.”

Almost business-like, he flipped Izuku over, pulling his hips around. In no time, Izuku felt him pushing in again. He was already sensitive, and it was a lot. He tried not to moan horribly as Katsuki pushed deeper. He almost succeeded, too, until Katsuki bottomed out.

“Hold on tight, baby,” Katsuki said, which was all the warning Izuku got before he pulled out and slammed in. Izuku took it with a shout, as he lurched forward on the bed. Katsuki didn’t let up, making good on his promise to fuck him through the mattress. Izuku was out of his mind, nerves humming with pleasure despite the crushing pace Katsuki had set.

“Damn, I love fucking you,” he heard Katsuki say, and a brief pause. Katsuki tugged his hips up enough to get a hand around in front of him. Izuku whimpered at the touch.

“Kacchan, it’s too much,” he cried. Katsuki paused.

“Should I stop?”

“No,” Izuku hissed, and in case that wasn’t clear enough, “Touch me, I want to feel it it’s just so damn much and please just-”

“God, shut up, I got the message,” Katsuki snorted. “I’ll fuck you up real good.”

“Please,” Izuku choked out, crying out as Katsuki started moving again. Izuku was lost, burning up with pleasure. Katsuki came first with a string of curses, yanking Izuku back against him mercilessly. Then, holding him tight, Katsuki jerked him off, murmuring mindless words of praise. Izuku’s orgasm ripped through him, leaving him breathless and generally dead to the world.

Not dead enough that he couldn't nuzzle into Katsuki's neck when the man pulled him close. They stayed like that for a while, breathing hard. Katsuki was the one who started moving first, running his hands over Izuku's sweaty back.

"How are you?" he murmured.

"Dead," Izuku sighed in contentment.

"I get the idea, but can you please tell me you're okay," Katsuki grumbled. Izuku pulled himself upright with a groan.

"I'm great," he hummed. "This was uh… I like this kind of thing a lot."

"Don't tell me that's why you're into me," Katsuki snorted.

"One of many reasons," Izuku shrugged, completely shameless. It's not like he was never self-conscious around Katsuki anymore, but something about being fucked within an inch of his life burned away his insecurities.

"Our Lord and Savior, Jesus H Christ, please fucking deliver me from this horny monster," Katsuki sighed.

"Don't bitch, you love it. And we're gross," Izuku told him. "I want another bath. Bath me, Kacchan."

"Demanding," Katsuki's head fell back on the blankets. "So demanding! After I just put so much effort into fucking your shitty brains out."

"And I put so much effort into being fucked," Izuku poked him in the side. Katsuki opened one eye.

"You were pretty good, I guess. Alright, you can have a goddamn bath."

Izuku relaxed in the bath, his back up against Katsuki's chest. His boyfriend's arms were around his waist, holding him loosely. Izuku couldn't remember the last time he'd felt so weightless, so light. Maybe the last time he'd had really rough sex, but it wasn't hard to admit that it was different with Katsuki. It wasn't just that Katsuki apparently knew how to push all his buttons, and had a consistently filthy mouth… it was that Katsuki really cared. It was obvious in his every moment, every touch, his laser-focus on Izuku.

"Deku," Katsuki said, interrupting Izuku's thoughts. "You awake? How ya feeling?"

"So nice," Izuku murmured, and slid a little further into the water. "I'm not really sleepy. Just relaxed."

"Izuku," Katsuki said slowly. Izuku sat up a bit. Katsuki was using his real name? "I want to talk to you about it. I mean, what you asked me a while ago, the uh," he cleared his throat,

“Bullying thing. It’s easier when we’re like this. I mean, easier for me to be. You know. To be vulnerable.”

“Oh,” Izuku said, trying to switch gears from ‘blissed out’ to ‘helpful boyfriend.’

“It doesn’t have to be now,” Katsuki said quietly.

“No, talk to me,” Izuku told him, turning around to face him. He could count on one hand the times he’d seen Katsuki being truly vulnerable, and if he felt safe enough to be like that now… then Izuku wanted to be there for him. Katsuki looked at him for a long moment, looking sad.

“I’ve actually thought about it for years, about why I bullied you and why I was such a shit. I can’t, I mean, you don’t know, well. Fuck. You already know I’m sorry, so I won’t just keep fucking apologizing over and over like it changes anything.”

“Katsuki,” Izuku whispered, his heart wrenching. While maybe Izuku hadn’t entirely forgiven his past treatment, he didn’t hold it against the man he was with now. And that man? Izuku cared so damn much about him, and hated to see him hurting.

Katsuki shook his head slightly. “Well there’s the stuff you know about. My huge ego being enabled by every fucking authority figure, my inferiority *and* superiority complexes, and just my natural shitty personality.”

“Right,” Izuku said, trying to sound soft and encouraging. Trying to hide the shaking of his hands under the bathwater. He wanted to be here for Katsuki through this, but he was about to hear the answer to one of the biggest questions of his life. Why him? What had ruined their friendship?

“Another part of it was just that I didn’t always fucking like you,” Katsuki said, avoiding Izuku’s eyes. It hurt to hear, but it was the unadulterated truth. “Probably because I knew you were better than me, and I hated it.”

“What?” Izuku looked up in shock. Katsuki met his eyes with a half-smile.

“I wanted to be a hero, but I acted like a villain. Fucking villains are still trying to recruit me. No, I knew you were always going to be better at it than me.”

“I’m not-” Izuku tried to say, but Katsuki cut him off.

“You are. I’m a fucking brawler that HQ just points and shoots at villains. I’m barely a decent rescue hero, just fucking good for beating the shit out of people. Which is fine and has its place, whatever. My point is that I wanted to put you down because I was threatened. And that was really wrong.”

“I didn’t know you felt like that,” Izuku whispered. Katsuki shrugged.

“That’s the easy part.”

“Easy?” Izuku choked out. He already wanted to cry, half for himself and half for Katsuki, for a kid who had such a twisted sense of himself and his self-worth that he couldn’t have any healthy relationship with the world around him.

Bakuguo reflexively rubbed his face, then looked faintly disgusted when he realized his hands were wet. Izuku smiled despite himself.

“Izuku, this is the hard part for me,” Katsuki told him, voice faint.

“I’m listening,” he just said, scooting in so that their knees touched.

“I uh, I was a pretty quiet infant,” Katsuki said, out of all things. Izuku was completely thrown. Thankfully, Katsuki continued as if this made sense. “Everyone thought I’d be just like my dad. Obviously that didn’t happen, but uh…”

He trailed off, face tense. Izuku found his hand and squeezed it. He had no idea where Katsuki was going with this, but it seemed difficult.

“Obviously. My mother was always loud, you know? I just kind of picked it up, even as a toddler. Not that I’m blaming everything on her, I know I’m responsible for my own actions but my old counselor said she thought the hag was maybe verbally abusive or whatever, and fuck, she threw things and screamed at me and dad all the time but I just thought it was normal.”

Katsuki stopped suddenly, and took a deep breath. His grip on Izuku’s hand was getting painfully tight.

“I, I didn’t know,” Izuku whispered. He’d always figured it was just how the Bakugous showed affection.

“I didn’t either,” Katsuki ground out. “It’s fucking… I don’t know. I don’t know if I’d call her that, call her abusive… but she definitely taught me really toxic ways of relating to people. Like, to curse and shout at the people I care most about. When I was a kid, that was you.”

Oh. It felt like the floor had fallen out from under Izuku. Katsuki kept talking, face angled down, his expression set as if he was determined to get this out if it killed him.

“It’s like, shit, like what I talked about with my counselor. Abusive people stop seeing their victims like individual fucking people, and just see them as extensions of themselves that need to be beaten into a shape that satisfies them. But it doesn’t fucking work because you can’t treat people like that and it just makes this horrible fucking toxic cycle and-”

He let out a choked sob. Izuku’s heart stopped for a moment, and he tried to move closer. He stopped when Katsuki kept talking, his words coming out fast and harsh.

“That’s what dad and me were to my mother, just fucking puppets she tried to force into whatever vision she had for us. I was never good enough, I’m still not and I never will be because it’s not a fucking real expectation! She doesn’t want me to succeed! She just wants to have something to hold over my head and beat me with. And it’s fucked up because she was

a good mom a lot of the time, and I still love the hag but fuck, some of the shit she did really fucked me up and I still don't know what's normal, sometimes."

"Katsuki, I'm so sorry," Izuku whispered. Katsuki shook his head, still looking down. If this was how it was, no wonder he wouldn't talk about it in the damn rec center.

"No, no. You can't be sorry for me because I-" another choked sob, "That's how I was looking at you. When we were kids. I was fucking turning into my mother and because I fucking saw you as mine, I took it on myself to treat you badly and push you down. And I'm so fucking sorry and I should never have done it."

Katsuki looked up finally, meeting Izuku's eyes. He was crying, actually crying, tears rolling down his face. "I'm so damn scared, Izuku. I'm so fucking scared I'm going to end up like her and mistreat everyone I care about. Because I," he sobbed again, "I already did. And it's so damn bad because it was *you* , and I care about you so damn much and knowing I treated you like that kills me. It fucking kills me, Izuku, and I'd rather fucking end myself than ever do that to you again and, and, and…" and he was breaking down, his face twisting before he let out another choked sob.

Unthinkingly, Izuku reached out and pulled the man into a hug. Katsuki buried his face in the crook of Izuku's neck, and sobbed. Really, truly sobbed, his whole body shaking, his fingers digging into Izuku's back like he was holding on for dear life. He was saying half-formed sentences between sobs, fragments of apologies, how afraid he was, how horrible he'd been, how Izuku shouldn't have to comfort him through this, and so on.

Izuku just held him, stroking his hair, and let him cry. He held him until the sobs faded into harsh, jagged breathing, until his breaths evened out slowly, until the bathwater became lukewarm.

Finally, Katsuki pulled away to look Izuku in his face. His eyes were puffy and bloodshot, and he looked exhausted. "I'm sorry," he murmured. "For dumping all this on you."

"I'm glad you did," Izuku told him, reaching out to cradle his face. "Thank you for telling me."

Katsuki shut his eyes for a moment, and nodded tightly. Izuku was overcome by just how much he cared for this man.

"Bakugou Katsuki," he said. Katsuki met his eyes, looking a little afraid. Izuku took a deep breath. He wanted Katsuki to hear him, understand him. "Kacchan, I'm glad you told me. I don't want you to think that I've ever downplayed how you treated me, but I want you to know that I accept your apologies. I know how bad it was, and I forgive you."

"I… I don't deserve it."

"No," Izuku said, resolved to get his point across. "You do deserve it. I'm not dating the version of you from back then, Katsuki. I wouldn't. For all the great things about you, you were awful back then, and you'd have been an awful partner. You were also a child, and as soon as you learned how, you chose to be better."

“I guess.”

“And now I’m your boyfriend,” Izuku told him, brushing away Katsuki’s tears. “This relationship is good. You’re good to me. I’ve never felt afraid of you, or threatened by you. I can talk to you more easily than anyone I’ve ever been with, and maybe that’s not saying a lot about my communication skills but there’s no one else I would want to do this with.”

“Izuku,” Katsuki trailed off, the pain on his face slowly replaced with wonder. Izuku pressed a kiss to his mouth, brief and soft.

“I’m not trying to sweep our past under a rug, Kacchan, but you should understand I’m with you for who you are *now* . Because you’re a great hero, you’re ambitious, because you never back down, because you never compromise on who you are or what you want. You’re so damn brave, and it’s inspiring. I love how much you care about everything, how your personality fills every room you walk into, and how you’re so aggressive and sweet and over the top about everything.”

Izuku took a deep breath. “I’m just saying I want to be with you because of who you are right now. And I’m really happy with you, and I wouldn’t be with you if I had any doubt that you wouldn’t treat me well.”

“You’re going to make me cry again,” Katsuki said, his voice hoarse.

“Cry all you want,” Izuku smiled, and kissed his forehead. “I’ll be here for you.”

“You fucking…” Katsuki trailed off. “You mean the damn world to me, Izuku. I honestly can’t tell you how much this means to me. I’m so fucking grateful to be in your life.”

What could Izuku say to that? He just kissed Katsuki’s salty, tear-stained face, trying to smother him with affection. Finally Katsuki shoved him away with a grunt, insisting on showering off after sitting in the bath for so long.

Izuku ended up rinsing off with him. It felt like they were finally washing away the pain of their past, and Izuku finally saw the person he was with. He was an amazing man, and Izuku felt damn lucky to be in his life.

They ended up on the couch, and Katsuki switched the TV on. Food Network popped up on the screen, which once Izuku thought about it, really wasn’t that surprising. He just laid in Katsuki’s arms, watching Gordon Ramsey curse out some questionable cooks. Izuku drifted away in thought, as Katsuki absentmindedly played with his hair. So many more things made sense, now. Why Katsuki had been so reluctant to start a relationship, how stressed he was about hurting Izuku or communication badly, and Izuku felt like he finally understood Katsuki as a person. Why he’d worked so hard to become a better person after so much time spent angry and violent. Izuku’s mental and physical exhaustion caught up with him fairly quickly, and soon enough they’d fallen asleep on the couch, holding each other.

Katsuki walked him out of his apartment the next morning. His boyfriend was being extra affectionate, keeping an arm around him until they went through the gates. Izuku was in his hero costume, and currently was at very high risk for running late. Katsuki was waiting for an inevitable call from his on-call status, and in the meantime elected to lounge around in a loose band tank top and standard-issue Hero Association sweats with ‘Ground Zero’ down the side in orange. Casual, and unforgivably hot. How had Izuku managed to snag such a catch?

“What are you looking at?” Katsuki said, trailing after Izuku.

“Checking you out,” Izuku grinned. “See anyone else around?”

Katsuki peered up and down the street, but it was ass-early on a Saturday and the area was deserted. “I see this really embarrassing nerd, but that’s it,” he grinned. Izuku rolled his eyes.

“And are you gonna kiss the embarrassing nerd goodbye before he leaves to be the world’s best hero? Izuku fluttered his eyelashes.

With an impressively loud snort, Katsuki grabbed his hips and yanked him in. Giggling, Izuku threw his arms around Katsuki’s neck.

“Hey, nerd,” Katsuki smiled down at Izuku. Izuku was utterly taken with him. Katsuki bumped noses with him, out of character but devastatingly adorable regardless. Impatient, Izuku lifted his chin and kissed him sweetly, lingeringly, enjoying the feel of Katsuki’s smile against his.

“Hi,” Izuku smiled up at him.

“Go wreck some villains, baby,” Katsuki murmured. Izuku turned to go, then froze. A slim woman was approaching, hands held up. Izuku jerked away from Katsuki like he’d been burned.

“Gotcha,” she said, holding up a phone screen and a malicious grin. It took about 0.5 seconds for Katsuki to have a sparking hand in her face.

“Delete it,” he snarled. Izuku jogged up behind him, frowning.

“Oh, I couldn’t possibly,” she said, in a horribly sing-song voice.

“I’m sure I can persuade you,” Katsuki sneered. The sparks danced higher from his hand, and the air started to smell like smoke.

“It’s already posted,” she shrugged. “And Ground Zero? You can quit the fireworks, I know you won’t actually hurt me.”

“He’d better not,” Izuku said. “But please delete that photo, or take the post down. I’m sure we can make some kind of agreement.”

“Yeah,” Katsuki growled, fists clenched. “She takes it down and I don’t rip her fucking head off.”

“It’s been shared two-hundred times already,” the woman shrugged. “Would you like to add an official statement to go with it? I’ll make sure Heroes Weekly publishes it with a photo you approve of.”

Katsuki snatched the phone from her, and frowned over the post. Izuku leaned in. It was just a picture of them kissing, Izuku obviously in his Deku costume. Katsuki was unmistakable in the Ground Zero sweats. Shit.

“It’s kind of a nice photo,” Izuku said, reluctantly.

“Oh for fuck’s sake,” Katsuki groaned, running a hand through his hair.

Well, it *was* a nice photo. Katsuki was leaning down to kiss him, and Izuku’s arms were around his shoulders, pulling him closer. It looked lovely and intimate, and now it was on display for the world to dissect. Izuku felt sick. The caption beneath read: Hottest new hero couple? Sparks fly between @OfficialGroundZero and @HeroDeku in a heated morning kiss! <fire emoji><bomb emoji>

“Heated morning kiss?” Katsuki scoffed.

“Hey, I was in a rush,” the woman protested. “I’m Kazuko, by the way. From Heroes Weekly. Nice to meet you both!”

“Kazuko,” Katsuki said, slowly. “Well. Congratulations on breaking the news! You and your entire network are now officially blacklisted by me and my public relations team, effective now. Permanently.”

She paled. “Wait, don’t be hasty-”

“Also mine,” Izuku added, because this was actually one of the things they’d discussed with Ono and Suika. Bless those two for knowing their jobs.

“And any other heroes that I can persuade,” Katsuki added, showing teeth. “And I'm very goddamn persuasive.”

“About as persuasive as a machine gun,” Kazuko muttered. “Fine. What do you want? The post isn’t coming down, and the cat’s already out of the bag.”

“I want positive press,” Katsuki said. “You and Heroes Weekly’s entire staff are going to be so fucking supportive of our relationship. I’m honestly fucking humbled by how diligently you work to uphold our public image. We’re both so grateful for all your hard work.” The sarcasm in his voice was damn near corrosive, eroding Kazuki's bravado.

“I- I can’t promise that…” Kazuki said, looking a little nauseous. News agencies thrive off of scandals, and this wouldn’t bring them that much money. But then, it was likely better than being blacklisted by several of the most prominent heroes in the city.

“I think you’d better fucking work on it,” Katsuki snapped, handing her phone back. “We’ll be awaiting documents. Send copies to both of our PR firms. If I don’t hear back in twelve hours, I’m personally going to end your fucking career. Got it?”

“Okay,” she ground out, teeth clenched. “You’re such an asshole.”

“You invaded our privacy,” Izuku told her, feeling deeply unsympathetic. “Ground Zero’s being generous; you deserve worse.”

With a last glare at them both, Kazuko stormed away.

Izuku blinked after her. In an instant, his world had changed. “You didn’t even explode her phone,” Izuku said distantly.

“I like when you back me up,” Katsuki told him, pulling him into a hug.

“Fuck,” Izuku said, eloquently. "We're fucked."

“And it’s cute when you swear.”

“Calling me cute won’t make me feel better,” Izuku grumbled, despite already feeling better. He could hear Katsuki’s laugh in his chest.

“At least we don’t have to hide anymore, right?”

That was actually a good point. Izuku hadn’t really thought about what it would be like to have a public relationship, or at least, he hadn’t thought about the benefits of being public. It *would* be nice not to have to hide.

“Which means I can do this,” Katsuki added, and stepped in to kiss Izuku right in the middle of the street. Like, tongue-down-his-throat levels of making out. Izuku tried to kiss back, but kept laughing until he was uncontrollably giggling while Katsuki sloppily kissed his cheek.

After far too long of that nonsense, Katsuki pulled back. Fondly, he wiped the saliva off Izuku’s cheek. “See? It’s not gonna be that bad.”

“As long as I’m with you,” Izuku said, still giggling. Katsuki looked like he was about to accuse Izuku of being a cheesy motherfucker (which was true), but the world exploded in white.

Izuku was blinded for too long, eyes burning from the shock. Then thunder rolled, deafening. He’d fallen to his knees, clutching his ears in pain.

“Striker,” Katsuki hissed, eyes wide. “Fuck, she actually fucking did it.” Izuku could barely hear him over the ringing in his ears.

“What?” Izuku said, shell-shocked. Around him, the power was out, people were screaming, and several buildings were already on fire. A powerline pole had crushed a house, and Izuku could barely gather the strength to stumble to his feet.

Lightning had struck, and it had struck *everywhere* . One had stuck near them, but they weren't the only place. He could see plumes of smoke rising across the city in every direction.

Chapter End Notes

Bakugou "Clean Kitchen > Dirty Sex" Katsuki lol

I was highkey nervous to post this cause of the copious amounts of rough sex, but tbh this is how I imagined Bakugou acting in bed from the beginning - I just felt like he couldn't feel comfortable acting like that until he & Izuku had built up a foundation of trust.

Lol I know I said there were 2-3 chapters left but it'll probably be more than that if I keep including so much smut, jfc… honestly you guys saying you'd want more is the sweetest thing ever and I am EASILY peer-pressured, ijs. Hope you guys are enjoying the side helping of plot with your porn T-T

I included some heavy stuff in this chapter. This is a wholesome (albeit porny?) fic, but it's also meant to explore what it would take for them to have a healthy relationship as adults. Which means Bakugou processing & addressing whatever the hell made him such an asshole. I don't add abuse to a story lightly, even when it's just mentioned in the past, but it IS something that affects a lot of people. Everyone has different experiences, but in this case I've mirrored Bakugou's struggles pretty directly with my own - right down the panic attacks about being terrified of hurting someone in the way I've been hurt.

THANKS EVERYONE FOR READING AND COMMENTING SRY IT GOT RLY HEAVY ILY ALL (っ˘̩╭╮˘̩)っ

Striker No Striking

Chapter Summary

Izuku and Katsuki get a little shock.

Chapter Notes

Content Disclaimers:
Guys, no matter how much I injure people, I would tag major character death if there was any so do not worry <3
Also this has canon-typical violence, so while it's not more violent than the show/manga, this chapter is more violent than the rest of the fic so far, so there ya have it

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Katsuki staggered to his feet and grabbed Izuku's arms, his eyes wild. "Get to the Central Mall, the plaza with the fountain behind the building. That's the rendezvous. I've got to get dressed. Find hearing protection if you can." He turned to run, but Izuku stopped him.

"Kacchan, wait. The power's out, so no one without comm quirks is getting any communications. We need to coordinate."

"Right, I'll-"

"I'm faster," Izuku cut over him. "I'll go touch base with every sector's headquarters. What should I tell them?"

To his credit, Katsuki didn't pause to question him, instead launching into an explanation. "Extremely strong villain, codename Striker, is attacking the city. Her objective is to turn the city into a safe zone for a villain society, and she's been weakening our defensive abilities and disaster response for months. People should evacuate to past the city limits, and all heroes should avoid contact with her or her associates and focus on rescue and relocation." There was something deeply compelling about the way Katsuki snapped into Ground Zero mode.

"Anything else?"

Katsuki paused, his eyes locked on Izuku's. "Be careful, Deks. I wasn't joking about hearing protection." Katsuki wouldn't - his hero costume had included high-tech hearing protection

since before graduation.

Izuku nodded shortly, and spent one more second looking at him. Then he surged forwards to kiss him, wrapping his arms around Katsuki's neck. Katsuki kissed him back, clutching at his back. One sweet moment before he pulled back, red eyes searching Izuku's.

"I meant it," he said. "Be careful."

"You too," Izuku whispered. He wanted to say something else, something more, but saying *I love you* sounded too much like *goodbye* . So he just said, "I'll be quick," and took off running.

He hated that he thought like this, but he had a chance here. New of their relationship had just gone public, and this was a great chance to draw the press's attention away from it. If he could successfully take down Striker, and *that* would be the headline. Not something idiotic about him being Katsuki's new squeeze. It had been so long since Izuku had had a real chance to prove himself, and he was itching for the chance.

He'd join up with the Striker taskforce and do a damn good job, so much so that no one could question his morals, priorities, or abilities as a hero.

Izuku was fast. With Full Cowling and adrenaline pumping through his veins, he made the rounds in record time. He also stopped any hero he saw in order to pass on Katsuki's message, despite hating every second that slowed him down. He'd even ended up having to rob a convenience store of a pair of earplugs, but he resolved to pay them back later.

Finally, Izuku could head to the rendevous point. He landed in the Central Mall Plaza so hard he left a crater, green lightning flickering out. His legs hummed with the aftershock of using Full Cowling for so long, but it wasn't anything he couldn't deal with, hadn't dealt with innumerable times before. He looked around, finally spotting a familiar head of blond hair. It was Kaminari, or rather Chargebolt, poking aggressively at what must be a comm unit. Izuku let out a small sigh of relief; he wasn't sure what he'd do it no one had been here. Panic a little. Worry about Katsuki? Go randomly hunting for Striker all over the city?

"Chargebolt!" Izuku shouted, jogging over. Kaminari was already staring at him, looking from his face then back to the crater Izuku had left behind, then back up again.

"Nice landing?" Kaminari's grin was a little doubtful. Izuku gave him a double thumbs up.

"Kacchan told me to come here," Izuku explain, and examined over the comm unit. It looked fine, albeit didn't seem to be working. With all the electrical damage running around, he wasn't really surprised. "I alerted every sector's headquarters of the situation."

"Right, Ground Zero would have explained…" Kaminari seemed to be playing mental catch up. "I'm here to direct any stragglers. Twice's clones aren't as powerful as the Striker herself, but they still need to be taken out."

“Sorry, Twice? Like League of Villains Twice?” Izuku was shrieking a little bit. That man was supposed to be in a secure mental health institution! Reports had said he’d been showing improvement, and a desire to reintegrate into society, of all things. Still, that would mean that Striker couldn't just create lightning over an entire city; she'd needed help. And somehow got Twice to help her?

“Striker’s quirk is Ion Shift,” Kaminari went on, apparently focused on more important information. “She teleports short distances, and wherever she appears, lightning strikes.”

“What distance? How strong is the strike?” Just the name of that quirk birthed a million questions in Izuku’s mind, but he needed to stay focused on combat stats.

“Furthest recorded distance is about 400 meters, but the strike strength varies. Stronger strikes take more build-up, and I can usually tell how bad it's going to be. I think she can teleport most places with minimal charge, but truly big strikes take a lot more time to start up. Damage today was minimal because her clones could only charge up so much, I think. They must have lower capacity than she does.”

“So everyone’s out after clones?” That would explain the empty meeting point. Izuku's mind was whirling with the complications of fighting someone who could not only electrocute on impact, but also teleport. Wasn't that overpowered? Izuku happily ignored the hypocrisy of the One for All user calling someone else overpowered.

“That's right. I’m the only one who can sense her charges building, but it’s freaking unreliable from so far. I sent Ground Zero and Shouto after the strongest ones, so hopefully one of them will find her and take her out.”

“Do you need me anywhere? Otherwise, I’m going out to help with rescue efforts,” Izuku said, his tone a little too sharp. He could feel the pull of it now; the destruction had been catastrophic; he'd seen it first hand while alerting every hero he could find. His people needed help, and he was just standing around in an empty mall. He shifted from foot to foot, agitated beyond believe. There'd been no warning, no chance to evacuate. Sure, *now* people were being directed out of the city; the mall itself was already deserted. But the initial strike had destroyed so many buildings, and the weakened infrastructure had only made it worse. Izuku needed to help the people who still lived.

Kaminari was clearly deliberating, but they were interrupted by a brief flash of light and a deafening clap of thunder, rolling so loud it hurt despite Izuku's stolen earplugs. Blinking away the afterimages, he realized he'd fallen to his knees, clutching his head futilely. Kaminari was down too, draped over the comm equipment and holding his ears. And there, on top of a fountain, stood a woman that could only be Striker.

She was tall and thin, her silvery bodysuit showing off bones too large for her skin. Ignition-blue hair crackled upwards above her head, and her teeth were shark-sharp.

“Chargebolt,” she purred, blue eyes trained on Kaminari’s limp form. “Got any juice for me?”

“Screw,” Kaminari huffed out, struggling to his feet. “You. Gonna take you out, once and for all.”

“Striker,” Izuku spoke up. “You’re outnumbered. Surrender now, and avoid more damage.”

To his surprise, both Kaminari and Striker laughed.

“She’s batshit, Deku. She won’t give in.”

Striker grinned, lips stretching wide. “Who are you, little boy?”

In response, Izuku kicked up One For All, and clocked her in the face. The crunch of his fist on her face was satisfying, as was the way she flew backward, smashing into a sedan. Then Izuku’s muscles locked up, the electricity in his limbs sharp and jittery. He looked up at her in shock. She was glaring right back, her cheek red and puffy. Blood dripped from her nose. Her mouth opened in a bloody snarl.

“Who the hell are you, huh? Green Sonic the Hedgehog? Goddamn Hero Association been hiding you away somewhere? Why don’t you run along somewhere else, and let me get some alone time with my favorite battery pack?”

Izuku’s hands finally stopped shaking. He clenched his fists, relishing having his body back under his control. So no direct hits, then. Ranged strikes it was, then. Not necessarily Izuku's forte, but he was more than comfortable with it. Without preamble, he flicked a torrent of wind her way, gripping his own forearm for support. Thunder cracked, and she was behind him, having avoided his strike completely. Izuku jerked away, turning to see a lightning-clad hand reaching for him.

“Sonic’s quick, ain’t he?” she laughed. “But I’m quicker.” She flashed forwards another few feet, and Izuku jerked back just in time.

“Why are you doing this?” Izuku snapped. “These people don’t deserve to be hurt! You have no reason to hurt them!”

“Oh, sure,” she waved a hand, static sparks popping at each movement. “And *I* deserved to be hurt, didn’t I? The story’s always the same, Sonic. A prospective hero goes bad, corrupting influences, et cetera. Who cares?”

“I care,” Izuku ground out, because it was true. She blinked at him, then teleported a good ten meters further away. The flash of light was softer than her initial entrance, so Kaminari had to be right about the distance. It remained to be seen if she could control the strength without distance, but…

“Damn, you mean that don’t you?” She shouted. "You actually care? Pathetic."

“He always does,” Kaminari grumbled. He’d regained his feet, falling into a fighting stance.

“Well then, here’s the real truth. Nothing corrupted me. Or you could say that everything corrupted me. Explain to me why I should be a hero these days? Society is crumbling, Sonic. Heroes are commodities, reality shows to bottle feed a population that doesn’t realize we are

dissolving into horrifying chaos. You call us villains, but we are the only ones really living. The laws are all too late, Sonic the Hedgehog. You understand that the ruling class just makes everything up to oppress us, right? That people don't matter if they don't turn a profit? We are animals! We are born animals, and only get further away from humanity every generation!"

"She's nuts," Izuku breathed.

"I'm taking this city, and I'm going to show the world that your laws, your rules are just muzzles on what humanity is meant to be. We were born to live in chaos, and I'm going to return us to our proper state."

"Yeah, that's the speech," Kaminari sighed. Izuku couldn't help the smile pulling at his lips. Apparently this wasn't her first time monologing?

"You'll thank me later," Striker screamed at them, then vanished. Then reappeared between them, hands diverting glittering arcs of energy towards each of them. Izuku barely dodged, relying on instinct only to jerk backward just in time. His skin was starting to hurt from the heat. Kaminari took the lightning to the chest, the energy passing through his body to uselessly putter out on the ground.

"You know that doesn't work on me," Kaminari said, cracking his knuckles.

"You gotta take her out," Izuku breathed. "You're the only one who can touch her."

"I know," he growled. But that was the problem, wasn't it? Because by the time he reached her, she'd long since flashed away. Kaminari didn't have Izuku's speed and maneuverability, no matter how much his combat had improved since UA. Even worse, each shift generated a blinding amount of light, and Izuku suddenly appreciated the usefulness of Kaminari's tinted glasses.

"I'll distract her, and then we'll wear her down together," Izuku told him grimly, throwing another gust of wind her way. They were in for a long fight.

Kaminari gave him a grim nod. It had come down to them, and they wouldn't fail their city.

Ground Zero was on his ninth clone, and shit was getting *old.* The pattern was familiar now, yet still exhausting. He'd slam a mid-range explosion towards Striker, and then she'd mouth off with something stupid like, "I'm having a bomb time!" while shifting near-instantaneously away from his attack.

Then he'd chase her from that location too. He'd notice the pattern early on: she rarely shifted back to the same place. Maybe Deku could figure out why, but Katsuki was just concerned with the *what.* Because by the fifth or so shift, he'd be able to guess where she turned up. It was instinctive, a feeling born both out of years of combat and also weeks of

tracking this bitch. He'd always been an instinctual fighter, and it made him damn near godly now.

This time, he targeted the corner with the stop sign. Timing was essential, and so as he threw an explosion at Striker, he simultaneously blasted himself towards the sign, catching her in her stupid, smiling face with a full-force explosion, heat blossoming around his palm. Perfection.

The clone melted into mud.

"Fuck!" he shouted. The real Striker was faster, wilier, and wouldn't fall to the same strategy nine times in a row, so of course this was another clone. Still, the disappointment was still bitter. Katsuki viciously spat on the mud, then decided it was time to check in with Kaminari. As much as he didn't want Todoroki to steal the spotlight, he *hoped* that Todoroki had already taken out the real Striker. The alternatives were worse.

He gritted his teeth and blasted off. He'd been fighting for nearly forty-five minutes straight, not to mention jetting over the whole goddamn city. He was a one-hit-wonder kind of hero; he liked to keep his fights hard and fast. He could have endurance when he wanted to, damn it, but even he had limits. Forty-five minutes of continuous quirk usage was pushing it. His forearms burned, and fiery pain lanced through his bones as he soared into the skyline. It didn't matter. Ground Zero had places to be, even if it felt like he was plunging his arms into boiling water to get there.

And no matter how painful it was in the moment, flying was always a trip. He hit the zenith of his arc, hanging for one weightless moment, taking in the city. Destruction was rampant, little blips of emergency vehicle lights fluttering between buildings. Smoke rose from countless areas, and the air stank of ozone.

Katsuki let himself fall, using explosions only to aim himself at the Central Mall. In a matter of seconds, he was close enough to see the tell-tale flashes of light. He instinctively knew it was the real Striker, and redoubled his speed. His vision blurred, wind tearing at his face, until he broke his momentum with an explosion and rolled to a stop on the concrete. Shit, he was going to feel that tomorrow.

And then there was Striker's grating-ass, high-pitched, piece-of-shit voice. "Aw, he found us!"

"Bitch," he stood with a snarl, taking in the scene. Kaminari was there, and… a wall imploded from a gust of wind. At the other end of the gust stood Deku, looking pissed, hand outstretched. Fucking hot as hell. Katsuki's heart lifted in a stupid, light way. He raised a hand and waved, feeling like an idiot. Wasn't he supposed to be pissed at Striker? Yet all he felt was pride at seeing Deku take her on, the intensity of his focus, the way he'd immediately adapted to fight her despite never having heard of her before that morning. Fucking awesome.

"Sup, nerd," he grinned, unable to help himself. Deku blinked, his concentration momentarily broken as he stared at Katsuki.

“All clones?” Deku asked, getting right down to business; clearly Kaminari had updated him on the situation.

“That’s the real one,” Katsuki said, pointing at Striker. He didn’t like the calculating look in her eyes. "We still haven't found Twice."

“Where’s the pretty red-and-white one?” she asked. “I’d like to take you all out at once, you know.”

“Cocky piece of shit,” Katsuki snapped, tossing an explosion her way. He was at a slight disadvantage here, not knowing where she’d already shifted to… but Deku would know. He blasted himself across the pavement towards Deku, the tips of his boots sparking on the ground. Deku caught his arm, swinging him around to kill his momentum, somehow knowing exactly what Katsuki wanted of him. Amazing. His boyfriend was amazing. Katsuki landed with a thump at his side, and ignored the twin stares from Striker and Kaminari. They were just jealous of their synergy. Katuski graced Deku with his best cocky grin.

“Kacchan,” Deku said, his cold expression warming slightly. Katsuki would have to talk to him about using hero names on the battlefield… but maybe not. There was something badass about being called ‘Kacchan’ before exploding a building, wasn’t there? And if there wasn’t, he would make it badass. Shit, he was a professional. He wasn’t here to daydream about exploding things in front of Deku.

“She avoids shifting to the same place more than once,” he muttered to Deku, not wanting Stiker to know they knew. They'd need any advantage they could get. Deku’s eyes lit up, verdant green with understanding.

“Fountain. Blue sedan. Every corner already, and the comm unit. 2, 7 and 9 o’clock on the roof. The red fire hydrant, and most places around the fountain’s base.” It took Katsuki a moment to realize Deku was rattling off every place she’d shifted to. He’d never wanted to kiss anyone more than in that moment. Who knew battle tactics was such a turn on?

“Fucking fantastic, Deks,” he said, instead. “We’re gonna have to wear her down. You want to strike or predict?”

“Strike,” Deku said, probably guessing Katsuki had more experience at prediction. And he wasted no time, dropping into a combat stance and flicking more high-pressured air towards her. Katsuki blasted towards a likely patch of concrete, only to be off by about a meter.

“Oh, I don’t like that,” Striker said, flexing. “Why don’t you slow down?” She dropped to the ground-no, teleported in place to a crouching position, and let out a net of electricity, crackling over the ground. Katsuki was in the air instantaneously, but he needn’t have bothered. Kaminari had copied her stance, and the power fizzled out. The stink of burning things was starting to fill the roundabout.

They didn’t slow down. Rather, Izuku sped up, his strikes sometimes so quick that Katsuki had trouble dodging them on his way to Striker. Kaminari’s Quick had little effect on Striker, except to mitigate the electrical charges she left over everything, and thank god for that.

They kept at it for so long that when Katsuki actually landed a hit, it fucking shocked him, figuratively and literally. He caught her with an explosive fist to her bony chest, slamming her down onto the concrete. He could see the fire of his explosions reflected in her glassy eyes. He was so shocked he'd actually hit her that he paused for one, critical moment.

"Gotcha," she croaked, blood dribbling from her lip. Then pain stabbed through Katsuki, like a thousand needles in his arms. He stumbled away from her, screaming. He scrambled away from her, nearly out of his mind. His body twitched mindlessly, making it impossible to regain his footing. He didn't have to, though, because Deku was there. He threw an uppercut so hard the electric bitch flew straight up in the air.

Deku turned to him, fear in his eyes. Katsuki thought distantly about how strangely uniform his freckles were. "Kacchan," Deku said, his voice sounding choked. Then his face was thrown into sharp relief, as that horrible flash of light hit again. Katsuki rolled over on the ground to see Striker teleport herself out of the air and onto the ground. She fumbled the landing, falling to her knees.

"You okay?" Deku insisted. What a perfect goddamn rescue hero, always making sure everyone was fine. Katsuki just wanted to beat that power-tripping asshole into the pavement, but he needed to wait out the shock's aftereffects first. He ignored Deku's concerned look in favor of staring at his hands. They were shaking, but responded when he tried to move them. Relief rushed through him, easing the tightness in his chest. Despite the way his bracers were cracked and partially melted, his hands seemed to be fine; apparently, his gear had taken the brunt of the attack. With a grimace, he stripped the bracers off, silently thanking them for their service. Katsuki was nothing without his hands, he knew that very well. Quirkless Katsuki was just a useless asshole. Even Deku wouldn't want him then.

"Fucking fabulous," Katsuki grunted, and pulled himself to his feet. He was going to knock this asshole right the fuck out. He staggered towards Striker, death in his eyes.

"That's right," Striker croaked, one hand clutching her jaw. "Come closer."

Katsuki froze. "Not here for your games," he growled, and raised a hand. He really didn't want to start fighting without bracers, and if he did, he needed to finish it fast.

"Ground Zero!" Kaminari's panicked shout stopped him dead. The words ripped from his throat, harsher than he'd ever hear him sound. "Get out of there! She's set up something big! I don't know how-"

"No spoilers!" Striker shouted back, getting to her feet. Both her arms stretched up to the sky, and Katsuki could practically see the tension in the air above them. Katsuki met Deku's eyes.

"Out!" Kaminari screamed. They turned and ran.

Striker struck. It wasn't like her little electricky teleports. No, whatever she'd done brought down a hellish plume of lighting, large enough it branched over the entire plaza. Large enough that it hit Deku in the back, branching around his limp body as it fell to the floor. And

suddenly Deku was all Katsuki could see, not the roar of thunder that shook his bones, not the cracking of asphalt, not the shrieking laughter of Striker. Just Deku, prone on the ground.

It felt like he had died. It didn't feel like a survivable kind of thing, except that Katsuki was still breathing which was *wrong* when he could see Deku's limp body draped over the curb. Denial. That's what he needed. Izuku was fine. FINE. Because if he wasn't, Katsuki was going to lose his shit and he couldn't win like that. And he need to *win.*

He was going to win. He'd managed to turn around, but froze. Nothing outside of their immediate radius had been destroyed. At the center of it all stood Kaminari Denki, smoking slightly. The fucker had absorbed the blast enough to stop her from straight up incinerating Katsuki and Deku. Then, before Katsuki's eyes, he collapsed. Katsuki's heart climbed into his throat as he stared at Kaminari's body, crumpled on the ground. The man was a damn good hero. Still, that just left Katsuki to deal with Striker.

Speaking of the devil, Striker had fallen to her knees. Apparently she didn't have many blasts like that left. Fine. Katsuki didn't have that much firepower left either, but he was damn well going to give her everything he ad. He stormed towards her, palms crackling in anticipation.

"You're finished, sparkles," Katsuki snarled.

"You're cuter when you don't talk," she coughed, spitting blood on to the ground. She backed away slowly, and something about that was deeply disconcerting. Katsuki was sure he'd never actually seen her *walk* before. She did it strangely, in an almost reptilian fashion, as if using her quirk so much had eroded her ability to backtrack like a normal fucking person. Katsuki shook the thought away, ignoring the ringing in his ears the movement generated.

"And you're dead, regardless of how much you run your mouth," Katsuki snapped, stalking forward. He didn't want to waste his strength on a gap-closing explosion, so he kicked into a sprint. Just as he was about to slap her with an explosive palm, she shifted away, maybe ten feet back. Katsuki blinked the light from his eyes. So it was going to be like that, then. She couldn't seem to go far, though, because whatever she'd done to Denki had taken too much out of her. He caught up fairly easily, grabbing the back of her neck and forcing her to the ground.

"One move and I explode your fucking vertebrae, got it?" He needed to subdue her, not kill her. That's what heroes did, and he was a damn hero.

"Mmm, rude. You're going to let me go, nice and easy." She didn't sound nearly afraid enough.

"The fuck you think-"

"Or I'll zap your cute lil hedgehog so his heart really stops beating."

Katsuki stopped dead. "Fucker, I really will kill you. Don't think you can goddamn move an inch-"

Striker turned her head to looked up at him, apparently unaffected by the grind of pavement on her pale face. Her voice was hoarse as she said, “Let me leave, and he keeps running around all cute and stuff.”

“We don’t negotiate with terrorists,” Katsuki ground out. Izuku wouldn’t want him to give in, and even if he did let her go, there was no guarantee she wouldn’t zap Izuku anyway. Grinding his teeth, he reached for Quirk-nullifying handcuffs.

He’d spend countless hours later wondering why he hadn’t just knocked her out, but the answer was simple. Quirk-nullifying cuffs were procedure, and had been drilled into him over countless hours of training, utilized in countless fights against villains. But as he reached for the cuffs, she twitched, one shiny eye visible against the pitted concrete.

“Wrong answer,” she spat, and vanished. Katsuki watched her reappear over Izuku with a flash of light and a foot on his back. His limp body jerked at the bolt, then collapsed. Katsuki saw red.

He didn’t even feel the pain crackling up his arms as his palms lit up. He was on her in an instant, but she vanished just in time. She reappeared halfway down the entryway to the plaza, stumbling out of her shift, little sparks of electricity arcing from her legs to the pavement. Katsuki was after her like a comet. Inevitable, burning, apocalyptic. His world had ended, and he was going to end her's too.

He’d caught up to her a couple of blocks away, and threw himself into the fight. She was too exhausted to shift far enough to escape, but not too tired to dodge his every fucking blow. It was hell, and he was tiring quickly. The pins-and-needles feeling in his muscles hadn’t left entirely, and the sinkhole of worry for Izuku was dragging at his focus. Why had that idiot needed to get hit by lightning?

It all came to a head when Striker landed a hit on him. Instead of running, she’d flashed behind him, tagging him in the back. The shock was small compared to the others he’d endured, but he still stumbled.

“Bitch, you’re making this hard,” Striker snapped. “It doesn’t gotta be like this.”

Katsuki dragged himself to his feet, and point-blank dropped an explosion at her chest. She was gone before the smoke cleared. He wasn’t going to win like this, he realized.

“You’ll never catch me!” She shouted. The words echoed in Katsuki’s empty chest. She was right. He couldn’t catch her, not with her infuriating ability to teleport away.

But maybe he didn’t have to catch her. He attacked one more time, just to judge the distance she was able to run. It looked like half a block was her limit. Good thing the Striker taskforce had evacuated this area after meeting in the plaza, because Katsuki was about to go nuclear.

Arms trembling, he blasted off, gaining height at a breakneck pace. He could see Striker far below him, attempting to run like the cockroach she was. Well, she could wave her little

insect life goodbye. He let himself fall, effortlessly throwing himself into a spiral. From this height, the Howitzer Impact would obliterate everything in a good two-block radius. Far enough away from the mall to avoid the fallen heroes, but still safely within the evacuated zone.

He'd done this too many times to get dizzy, but he'd only used explosions this large once or twice before. The strain was blurring his vision, stealing his breath as his rotation pulled oxygen from his long. The ground flew up to meet him. How was he going to land? Didn't matter. He could see Striker's terrified expression as she tried to blink away, only making it about half a block from Katsuki's point of impact. Not far enough.

"You won't catch me!" She was shouting, but fear tinged her words. Katsuki was screaming something, god knew what, and then he released his explosion seconds before hitting the ground. The world turned yellow-white, and the recoil violently threw Katsuki back into the air. He flipped over and over, completely unable to control his spin. His arms weren't working, but the pain was a distant afterthought as explosions ripped apart the very street she'd stood on. The ground disintegrated in the blast, carving a crater deep enough that Katsuki found himself in free-fall when he should have been hitting the pavement. He managed to keep consciousness long enough to see Striker's body melt in flames. Then his world went black.

Chapter End Notes

Kaminari is the real MVP!! Honestly I don't know why I decided to just toss a bunch of action in this fic? Like, I struggled SO MUCH with this chapter. On the upside, I've finally managed to write a chapter at ~5k words again, because the last few were ridiculously long. Why is a couple of punches suddenly harder for me to write than like, straight-up porn??

I just realized this is the first time we have Bakugou's POV while he's in the same space as Izuku! Fun! He loves him so much!

Also like, I've now realized I've used both the metric and imperial system, as well as USD and yen all in this one fic. I know I am a hot mess and I am sorry. I promise I'm going to go back and make everything consistent, please excuse my errors ;-;
...I'm also eventually gonna change the 1,000,000 Bakugou's into Katsuki's where it makes sense to switch over in the narrative (there's literally over 2k Bakugou's in this fic jfc)

Striker's Ion Shift quirk is weird and very very very very loosely based in science. I'm gonna explain it more later when Izuku regains consciousness and starts analyzing it.

You can find me on twitter at @useless_donut. I make announcements about new chapters & new fics there too :^) bless you all for reading and tho I am super unconfident about this chapter I hope you enjoy it <3

Hate You Forever

Chapter Summary

The fighting isn't over yet.

Chapter Notes

DISCLAIMER:

Hello all! As of 4/1/20 I've edited and re-released this chapter.

After rereading the chapter and seeing your comments (which I am v grateful for!), I decided this chapter was hitting A LOT harder than I wanted it to. My original goal for this story was to look at a healthy relationship between two people who had a lot of conflict in their past - I don't want to remove all the conflict and tension, but I do want to make sure I'm hitting the right note for how their relationship is progressing. With that in mind, I've rewritten parts of this chapter.

Please keep this in mind when reading any comments from before 4/1/20! Many of them may not be in context anymore, and I don't want people to be misunderstood. Here's a link to the original chapter if you're curious or want to see what people were talking about - please keep in mind the dynamic is p toxic, so read with care: Chapter 17, Reject Writing Edition
I want to say **thank you** to everyone who read the original version of this chapter. I know I threw a lot of angst and feelings around, so I am very sorry if it feels like I've cheapened anything by changing it after you spent time reading and commenting. I am BLESSED to have so many people spend time reading my work, and I read & treasure every comment. Thank you so much. Honestly, I just wanna do a good job at writing - please don't that think I'm hurt or unhappy; I just want to make a good story! So thank you all for your encouragement and feedback, and please bear with me while I try to write the best story I can.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Izuku woke up to a splitting headache. He didn't move for a long moment, as he tried to catalog his injuries. His cheek ached, but that might just be from hitting the curb. Slowly, he

tried moving each limb. To his surprise, it seemed like he could move. Painfully, but not painful enough to signify broken bones. Cheered by the idea, he tried to stand.

Then fell back down, his head swimming, vision blurred. His heart seemed to flutter in his chest, struggling to circulate enough blood for movement. Slowly, slowly the world seemed to come back into focus. He was still in the plaza, or rather what was left of it. His skin burned as he moved, pain lancing deep. Shit. Gingerly, Izuku looked down. Much of his hero costume had been burned away, and red, angry-looking burns covered his body. The injuries hurt, but he figured they wouldn't kill him if he walked around. Once he'd verified that he could walk, he looked around for Kaminari and Bakugou. The former he found quickly, collapsed next to the fountain.

Pushing away thoughts of Bakugou, Izuku ran over to Kaminari, worry clawing up his throat. He ignored the shake of his muscles, the ache of his joints, the shooting pain from his burned skin stretching as he moved. None of it mattered because Kaminari wasn't awake. He ran through the standard first aid check-ups and was relieved to find a steady, albeit faint heartbeat. However, Kaminari was out cold. Izuku wouldn't risk moving him in this state, so he set out to find help.

Maybe he was more injured than he realized, because the next thing Izuku knew he was being wrapped in a foil blanket and tucked into the back of an ambulance. Well, sitting on the back edge of one, as it seemed to be functioning as an emergency first aid station.

He'd told them about Kaminari. He thought he had, at least, and the last time he'd tried to tell someone they'd shushed him and said I know, so that was good, right?

He didn't relax until a stretcher bearing Kaminari's body came into view.

"He's alive but unresponsive," a kind man told Izuku.

"Thank you," Izuku said quietly. "And Kacchan?"

"We don't know who that is," the man said, a note of frustration lacing his voice. As if it wasn't the first time Izuku had asked. Izuku forced himself to focus on the man's face. He had a broad nose, and smile lines around his eyes. He looked nice. Izuku could tell him things.

"Katsuki," Izuku managed to say, his tongue feeling thick. "Why am I so, uh, it's so hard to think?"

"You were unconscious for several hours," the man sighed. "You're suffering from shock, electrical burns, and we suspect a mild concussion. You also may have heart issues and experience confusion or dizziness from the electrical charge affecting your brain."

"You sound smart," Izuku told him.

“Was Katsuki nearby?” The man asked, very patient. The sort of patience a very rushed person has. “This area was evacuated before most of the damage, but there could have been stragglers.”

“Bakugou Katsuki,” Izuku explained, trying to pull his thoughts together. “Ground Zero. Hero. We were fighting Striker and…”

The man’s mouth scrunched into a frown. “We recovered Ground Zero already. He was about half a kilometer away from here. The madman leveled four city blocks! We can only hope no one was there when he did it.”

“Is he okay?” Izuku was getting a little loud. He tried to stand but immediately was forced back into a sitting position.

“He’s fine. Idiot knocked himself out, but woke up soon enough. He’s over by triage if you want to see him.”

Izuku was up and walking before the man’s sentence was over, looking for the triage. He felt a hand grab his shoulder, presumably to stop him, but he jerked away violently. His searching gaze finally found what must be Katsuki, lying on a stretcher while several people hovered around him. As Izuku watched, one of them did something to his arm. There was an audible sound to it, then Katsuki screamed. The kind of scream that came from horrible pain, so loud and sudden that the people helping him flinched away reflexively. Izuku ran to him, foil blanket flapping behind him.

Izuku was at his side in an instant, rudely shoving an EMT out of the way. Izuku could only see Katsuki's face, clenched in pain, eyes screwed shut.

"What did you do to him?" Izuku was shouting.

"Set the bones in his arm," the EMT said, sounding miffed. "He was out for the other one. Would you mind backing up? We need to finish wrapping it."

"I would mind," Izuku hissed, dangerous as a viper. He bent over Katsuki's head and cradled his cheek. His too-pale cheek. Tracks of dried blood traced down his forehead, evidence of bashing his scalp open on something. Izuku ran his thumb over one sharp cheekbone. "Kacchan, I'm here. Can you hear me? Can you-”

“Zuku,” came a hoarse mumble. He was awake. Izuku suddenly breathed again, the knowledge that Katsuki was alive and awake somehow righting the universe. And just like that, the fight left Izuku, and he collapsed onto Katsuki’s chest.

“Deku,” he heard Katsuki rumble, almost soundless. “Get the fuck offa me.”

Helping hands pulled Izuku upright, and the world swam before his eyes. “I got electrocuted,” Izuku told Katsuki, feeling like he had to excuse his behavior. He completely ignored the EMTs around him, too distracted to feel bad about it. They took the chance to wrap up his arm, and Katsuki hissed in pain. His costume had been partially burned away,

and there were bloody gouges on his chest and shoulders. Katsuki coughed, hacking up blood onto his chest.

“Izuku?” his voice was hoarse. “This is real?”

“Kacchan,” Izuku said, throat seizing up. Was Katsuki delirious? Then his eyes snapped open, and he sat up suddenly.

“Izuku,” he snarled, turning on him. “You’re here?”

“I’m here, we’re okay,” Izuku told him, reaching out to take his face carefully in his hands. Katsuki’s expression was fierce and angry, but Izuku knew it was all just how he was processing the intensity of everything that had happened. Izuku gently pressed a kiss to Katsuki’s forehead. Katsuki let out a shuddering breath.

“Deku, my hands. How are they?” His eyes were locked on Izuku’s face, like he was afraid to look down at his arms.

“I-I don’t know,” Izuku stammered. One of the paramedics huffed in annoyance.

“If you’d let us do our job, we could tell you,” she snarked. Izuku allowed it only because he knew how thinly spread they must be. “We can’t completely diagnose it in the field, but you’ve broken your hands and forearms. Both sides. You’ll need surgery in a hospital; there are too many shards to successfully set it now. We can’t tell how well they’ll heal without better equipment.”

Katsuki hissed out a breath. “But otherwise… I’m fine?” He looked at the splints on his arms. The paramedic sighed heavily, pushing sweaty bangs from her face.

“Sure, if that’s what you want to call it.”

“Great, I’m getting up,” Katsuki growled, swinging his legs over the side of the cot.

“You shouldn’t-”

“You’ve got people dying out there,” he sighed, meeting the paramedic’s eyes. “Pretty sure all I did was bust up my arms and fuck up my landing.”

Izuku slipped an arm around his waist steadying him. He guided them to a nice chunk of rubble and sat them down with a sigh. Katsuki stared at his hands, wrapped tightly up to his biceps.

“They’ll probably be fine with a healing quirk,” Katsuki said, almost inaudibly. Like if he spoke too loudly, it might not be true. He might not be fine, his arms might not heal, and... it was hard to even imagine Katsuki with shattered arms, Katsuki with no quirk. It hurt.

“I’m sure it will be fine,” Izuku told him, but the words tasted ashy in his mouth. They weren’t enough; nothing would be enough until Katsuki was healthy again.

“Speak for yourself,” Katsuki snorted. “You smell like burned hair. It’s disgusting.”

“Wow.” Izuku laughed slightly, then winced at the pain in his ribs. Katsuki leaned in, as if to kiss his hair. But he stopped short and sniffed.

“Yep, really gross.”

“Kacchan,” Izuku protested, but he found himself smiling for the first time since he’d woken up. Katsuki sneered at him, but the menacing expression only comforted Izuku. It was something familiar and safe and a desperate, tragic situation. Next to Katsuki, he found himself relaxing slowly. He was alive, Katsuki was alive. They would both recover from their injuries, at least for the most part.

Some of the fog was slowly clearing from Izuku’s head. The first responders had set up the triage site around them, complete with equipment to treat minor injuries and triage worse ones. Katsuki had been on one cot of many, and more people were arriving on stretchers every so often. If this was anything like the typical disaster response,, this was the first stop for emergency treatment or triage before people were transported to the hospital. Then Izuku turned around and nearly fell over in shock.

The street behind him continued for maybe thirty meters, then vanished in a jagged edge. Where he’d expected to see streets, abandoned shops, maybe some crumbling buildings, there was a vast, gaping crater. It had to be at least four city blocks in diameter, curving downwards. Chunks of concrete and rebar littered its slopes, having slid down at some point.

“Um,” he said, his voice hoarse and frail. “What the fuck?”

Katsuki didn’t bother turning around. “I got a little upset.”

“Katsuki! You did this?”

Katsuki threw him one burning, red look. “Who the fuck else would?”

“That means… Striker?”

“Dead.” The word was ground out between clenched teeth.

“Oh.” Izuku bit back the flurry of questions rising in his throat. Katsuki, like every other hero, avoided killing except when there was no alternative. Whatever had happened, it couldn't have been good. And as destructive as he was, Katsuki was usually painfully precise about what he exploded.

“Yeah.”

“If you want to talk-”

“I don’t,” Katsuki said quickly, biting the words out.

Izuku bit his tongue and nodded. It was his nature to poke and pry until he dislodged answers at any cost, but he’d spent a long time learning when to back off. He knew he had to trust that Katsuki would come to him when he was ready. Still, a small doubt-shaped feeling sat in his chest - had Katsuki killed her out of revenge for hurting Izuku? Was Izuku the cause of her

death? He couldn't tolerate that. Katsuki's career had so far resulted in a statistically normal amount of villain deaths. Izuku's time as a hero had resulted in absolutely zero. But this was about trust, and Izuku had to let Katsuki bring it up when he was ready. With a light sigh, Izuku gently leaned against his shoulder.

"It's a pretty impressive crater," he said, foregoing everything else swirling in his mind. Ego-stroking was always a safe bet where Bakugou Katsuki was concerned.

"You're not slick, Deku." Katsuki snorted.

"So big, so impressive," Izuku insisted, grinning at his boyfriend. "Best crater I've ever seen."

"You think I'm a fucking preschooler who can be cheered up by praise?"

"I know you are," Izuku said, and kissed his dirty, handsome cheek.

"I hate you." But despite his words, Katsuki's mouth twisted into a reluctant smile.

"You can hate me all night long, baby."

"You're ridiculous. And I hate it." It was said fondly though, and Katsuki's gaze caught his. Katsuki's eyes burned like embers, sending warmth through Izuku's chest.

He leaned in until his forehead bumped Izuku's. "Gonna hate you for the rest of my life."

Izuku's heart swooped like a bird in flight. It felt like a confession of something. Something like commitment, love, something bigger than what they'd expressed before. "Kacchan, I-"

His words were cut off with a scream. Izuku's head snapped around so quickly it hurt. A streak of red ran past, skidding to a halt by Kaminari's cot. Izuku's heart sank. It was Kirishima, and he was screaming Denki's name. The paramedics were talking to him, trying to calm him. Eventually, something must have gotten through because he collapsed on Kaminari's chest, sobbing.

Izuku was on his feet before he knew it, held back only when Katsuki snarled, "Deku, wait!"

Izuku turned, angry, then saw Katsuki's splinted arms raised uselessly. "I should go-"

"Give him space," Katsuki insisted, his face uncharacteristically serious. "He's not… there's stuff he doesn't want to express with an audience, okay?"

Izuku frowned and looked back at his friends. Kirishima looked completely wrecked, his face buried in Kaminari's neck. They'd been flirting, hadn't they? They'd seemed more than just friendly at the club months ago, and suddenly Izuku wondered how deep that affection went. Katsuki was watching with a frown.

"We'll be here for him when he's ready," was all he said.

The light atmosphere had dissipated, though. Izuku was too aware of Kirishima's shaking form, of Katsuki's labored breathing. He knew that sound well, the broken, aborted breaths that came from forcing down pain. Katsuki hadn't complained about his arms, but he didn't need to. Whatever painkillers he'd been given wouldn't be able to cover that kind of damage.

Izuku awoke with a jolt, jerking sideways. He'd barely even processed that he'd somehow drifted off against Katsuki's shoulder, when he saw Katsuki storming towards Kirishima.

Katsuki was on a warpath, lifting a foot and literally kicking someone away from Kirishima. Then Izuku saw the video camera, the man behind him with a boom. The press had come out. Izuku got to unsteady feet and headed over. At the very least, he could prevent Katsuki from kicking anyone else.

"Back the hell off," Katsuki was saying, his voice tight with anger. Behind him, Kirishima was holding one of Kaminari's hands, his face wet with tears.

"Red Riot," the reporter said, pushing past Katsuki. He hissed in pain, moving his arms out of the way. "Can you tell us your version of the attack?"

"He can tell you later," Katsuki snapped. Kirishima looked up, obviously trying to pull himself together.

"I, um," he said. His eyes looked empty, his cheeks wet with tears. "A lot happened. I just-"

"How is Chargebolt? You are close friends, right?"

"Hey, dickface, I'll be the one answering questions." Katsuki's snarl was getting more pronounced. He was losing his temper. Izuku hurried over, catching his eye. "Deku, get them out of here," Katsuki snapped.

"Exactly how close are you to Chargebolt?" another reporter asked Kirishima, who just looked panicked. He looked down at Kaminari, then back up at the camera, mouth working silently.

"Is now the fucking time?" Katsuki shouted, reaching critical levels of pissed. "We just had a fucking catastrophic villain attack!"

"We report what the public's interested in," the second reporter said cooly, adjusting her glasses. Katsuki shot a pointed look at Izuku. Right. He hurried over to Kaminari. Thankfully, the cot had wheels on it, and he was able to wheel it away. That effort alone left his limbs trembling. Kirishima trailed after him, looking broken. Suddenly, Izuku was really glad Katsuki had intervened with the press. Behind him, he heard Katsuki shouting about something along the lines of how villain attacks were more important that who was fucking who, a sentiment Izuku heartily agreed with.

Kirishima didn't say a word the entire time, which was deeply disturbing. He hadn't even checked in to see if Izuku and Katsuki were okay, and that was shockingly out of character. Izuku reluctantly left him and Kaminari in the hands of one of the transport teams, and only left once he'd been repeatedly assured they were on their way to the hospital.

It was easy to find Katsuki afterward. One of the perks of having a nuclear reactor for a boyfriend was how easy it was to find him. Just follow the screaming, and bam, there he was, the epicenter of whatever shit was going down.

Katsuki was surrounded by a small crowd of reporters and was flipping his shit. Izuku hung back, not wanting to get involved in the middle of live TV. Well, that and the shouting was making his ears ring in a really bad way. He could still hear at a respectable distance (it was hard not to) and was vaguely enjoying the sight of Katsuki spewing filth at the press.

That is until he heard Katsuki shout, "You want gossip so damn bad? Fucking fine!"

That couldn't be good. The next thing Izuku heard was Katsuki's indignant shout.

"I'm with Deku now! Yes, the goddamn hero. There's your fucking hero gossip. Now can we PLEASE talk about the goddamn villain attack?"

"Deku? Weren't you two already friends? That's not news." the reporter said, shoving a mic in Katsuki's face. Katsuki wasn't able to push it away, his arms rigid at his sides. Despite how little Izuku wanted his relationship discussed on live news, he felt a surge of anger. This was way out of line. Who were these reporters? It couldn't be a major network; the press could be bad but most of them were honest, hard-working journalists from reputable organizations. For a dizzying moment, he saw Striker's point. Were they heroes, or were they reality show stars? How could they risk their lives and then be subjected to this?

"Of course it isn't!" Katsuki was snarling. "The news is the catastrophic attack that just half-destroyed our goddamn city! So if you're interested in that, we suspect Striker was-"

"No one cares that you two are friends again," the reporter snorted. "Now, Red Riot is known for being a manly hero. Will that hold up if he's-"

"No one's talking about Red Riot," Katsuki said, an edge of desperation in his voice. "Now can we-"

"After we talk about Red Riot, I'm happy to-"

"We're talking about me," Katsuki snapped. "Red Riot's out of the picture, now. I'm the one who took down Striker."

"Don't hog the spotlight, Ground Zero," the reporter said insistently. Izuku was honestly taken aback. Who was this person? How dare they? Even the man next to her looked horrified. "Your friendship with Deku isn't what's concerning here. I want to know if Red Riot is-"

"Not what we're talking about," Katsuki cut over her.

“What, do you have something better to talk about?”

“Oh, I don’t know, the fucking villain attack that literally just happened?”

“Spicy Heroes Weekly is a gossip magazine,” the woman sighed. Why the hell were they the first on the scene? “I’m getting a scoop no matter what, and your little friendship isn’t newsworthy compared to Red Riot-”

“What friend thing? We’re FUCKING,” Bakugo shouted, covering whatever the reporter was about to say. Izuku’s stomach dropped.

“Don't make up things for attention,” The reporter laughed, as camera flashes went off in Katsuki’s face. “Your friendship with Deku means nothing, I want to know about how gay-”

"I'll show you gay-"

"Your friendship-" the woman insisted, and Izuku saw the moment his self-control irrevocably snapped, as his posture turned aggressive, the words ripping out of him like shotgun blasts.

“What fucking friendship? It's DICK IN ASS SEX! GAY ASS FUCKING SEX! IS THAT ENOUGH FOR YOU? NOW can we talk about the goddamn VILLAIN or so help me GOD I’ll-”

“So, about Striker,” another reporter said quickly, shoving the offending woman back. She stumbled back, looking offended at the intrusion but still delighted. She’d gotten what she wanted, at least.

Izuku didn’t hear the rest of it over the buzzing in his ears. Katsuki recited what clearly was a prepared statement to the press, and Izuku waited it out numbly. It was all too much. The frustration with reporters, the deathly worry about Katsuki’s safety, and the abject humiliation of having his sex life shouted about on TV. Somehow, Katsuki’s tantrums had never included Izuku as collateral damage until now and… Izuku’s face burned with shame. He was a family-friendly hero! Children looked up to him! What would they think after hearing something like that? His mother was probably watching this! He wanted to die on the spot. He’d worked so hard to get where he was, and Katsuki had thrown it all away.

He’d ignored Katsuki’s attempts to talk all the way to the hospital. He was obviously worried, but Izuku brushed him off, citing lightheadedness. It wasn’t even an excuse; Izuku felt like he needed to sleep for a week.

He wanted to sleep for a year. Sleep until the humiliation of having someone shout about their dick in his ass faded into a distant memory. He'd wanted to show the world he was a good hero, no matter who he dated. So much for that.

Instead, he was almost nodding off in the chair next to Katsuki’s hospital bed. His own tests were scheduled for that night because despite being knocked out first, Izuku’s injuries were

fairly easy to heal, since they were mostly skin-level, or would recover given proper rest. He'd been given a touch up already by a very tired-looking doctor with a recovery Quirk, and his burns had faded from livid to merely red and painful, but he desperately wanted to sleep.

Katsuki needed surgery on both of his arms. That thought alone was taking the edge of Izuku's anger. It was difficult to be upset with the guy when he was sitting in a hospital bed, IV in, looking broken.

"Surgery's in three hours," Katsuki said, quietly. "I'm gonna be out for a while. Can we talk first?" Izuku looked down, staring at the linoleum as if it had personally offended him.

"It's not okay for you to talk about me like that in public," he said, finally. He was shaking a little, maybe from exhaustion and maybe from holding back how hurt he felt.

"I know. I'm sorry."

Izuku looked up and met Katsuki's gaze. His expression was tight, closed off. The apology wasn't enough, but Izuku badly didn't want to fight.

"I appreciate that, but what were you thinking? I can't- I don't have the same image you do! People are going to be shocked, there are children that look up to me and god, our parents…"

"Yeah," Katsuki said, uncharacteristically quiet. "I shouldn't have let that woman get to me."

Izuku could feel the hurt crackling through his chest, and as much as he wanted to fall in that chasm and emerge with righteous fury, he couldn't. Katsuki looked haunted, and vulnerable, and Izuku wanted to be there for him. He swallowed his anger, and sat down in the chair next to Katsuki.

"Kacchan, can you tell me what happened? I know you care about my reputation, so I don't understand. But I want to." Izuku's words were rewarded with Katsuki finally meeting his eyes. To his horror, Katsuki's lips were trembling.

"Izuku," he said shakily. "I know what I said was way over the line. I can't… sometimes I scare myself, and I can't fucking control what I say."

Izuku forced himself to be patient, as he realized that whatever had set off Katsuki must have been really bad. He hesitantly put a hand on Katsuki's shoulder, in lieu of his bandaged arms. "Kacchan, I'm really hurt right now, but I can tell something happened. It would help me to understand why you felt you couldn't control yourself this time."

Katsuki shook his head slowly, hair falling in his eyes. "I thought you were dead, Izuku," he said, instead, voice cracking. "I *killed* someone. My arms are fucking broken and they think they'll heal but they aren't sure! I'm freaking the fuck out, okay?" His voice was tight and low, and Izuku could see the glimmer of tears in his narrowed eyes. "I know I was way out of line and I could have handled it way fucking better but, honestly? I fucking couldn't, okay? Seeing them go after Ei while he was dealing with Denki's shit made me lose my everloving shit."

“Kacchan-” Izuku tried to say, but Katsuki bulldozed on, apparently unable to stop once he’d started.

“I’m really fucking sorry, Izuku. I should’ve put you first. I should’ve seen a way out of that situation without hurting you, and now that I think about it it seems like there were so many other options but in that moment? All I could see was Ei sobbing over Denki, and how fucking cruel it was to take advantage of him in that moment. I couldn’t think straight. I said whatever shit came into my head.”

Self-hatred drenched his voice, thickening Katsuki’s voice to a barely-audible rasp. “I get it, if you don’t trust me after this. I’m at my fucking worst right now, Izuku. I’m just hoping you’ll let me keep trying to be better.”

“Kacchan, *stop,*” Izuku said, loud enough that Katsuki’s mouth snapped shut, his eyes flying open to lock on Izuku's. “Can I hold you right now? Please?” Katuski gave a sharp, aborted nod. Izuku leaned over the bed, carefully sitting next to him, helping him move his arm across his body. Izuku pulled him against his chest, running his fingers through Katsuki’s hair in what he hoped were comforting circles.

“Kacchan, I’m so sorry.”

“Shove it,” Katsuki mumbled, muffled against Izuku’s chest. He didn't sound antagonistic, just weary. “You don’t gotta apologize for shit.”

“I was really mad,” Izuku whispered into his hair. “But I wasn't thinking about how hard it was for you. I’m so sorry you had to go through all of this. I love that you wanted to protect our friends, okay? I’m glad you could.”

“Izuku, you don’t have to be like this.” Katsuki’s voice was barely audible, and Izuku’s heart broke a little. Did he think he didn’t deserve understanding, forgiveness?

“Kacchan, listen to me. You did go over the line, and I’m *not* okay with being spoken about like that. But I get how hard it was, and I know you did your best. After everything’s settled down, we can talk about it more, figure out what to do in future situations like this. For now though, I just want you to know that I support you. And I’m here for you.”

Katsuki’s heart seized up. He pulled away enough to look up into Deku’s green eyes. This close, they were mesmerizing, brimming with tears and with care. Care for him, like he deserved it for some reason. He’d never felt so simultaneously vulnerable and safe in his entire life, and it was ripping him apart. He hated the way his throat was closing, hated how the wetness of his eyes overflowed. Hated how Deku was bearing witness to some of the worst moments of his life, hated how he didn’t think he could bear it if Deku wasn’t there with him. It had been a long, long time since Katsuki had been so scared by anything.

“I’m scared,” he whispered, barely able to get the words out of his burning throat. Deku’s lips parted, soft and kind as always. Katsuki held still, stiff as a board while Deku pressed a gentle kiss to his forehead.

“I was too,” Deku said. Katsuki nodded, his head jerking. God, he hated everything about this. Deku’s voice lowered to a whisper. “That fight was really hard, and she was so… some of the things she said hurt to hear.”

“I killed her,” Katsuki choked out. He’d killed her, Deku had nearly died, he’d fucking betrayed Deku on live TV and his friends were hurting worse than he was. “I’ve never done it like that, you know. Never meant to. But I meant for her to die.”

“God, Katsuki,” Deku trailed off. “It was a hard situation, okay? It’s gonna take time to process. You know I’ll be here.”

“I don’t deserve you,” Katsuki murmured, almost experimentally. Deku leaned in, resting his forehead against Katsuki's.

“Sure, big guy. Where else will I find a boyfriend who’ll destroy four city blocks for me? Hmm? That’s right, nowhere.”

“Cute,” Katsuki grumbled, but Deku’s gentle sarcasm was comforting. Deku’s rough hands moved to his face, tracing his cheekbones, achingly gentle. Katsuki let Deku touch him, his eyes fluttering shut.

“We’ll handle everything,” Deku promised him. Katsuki was starting to believe him.

“I’m sorry that you’re the one who has to fucking support me right now,” Katsuki sighed, finally opening his eyes. “I know I hurt you, and I’m going to make it up to you. I swear it.”

Deku hummed, considering Katsuki’s words carefully. It was frightening sometimes, how much thought Deku put into what he said. Katsuki was pretty sure his words didn’t usually have nearly as much meaning as Deku could get from them. However, it could also be helpful because Katsuki could admit it wasn’t easy for him to put everything into words in the first place.

“Okay,” Deku finally said, a slight smile on his face. “I’m going to trust you, alright? I think if we approach it together, we’ll get through it no matter what.”

Katsuki loved the shit out of this guy, but couldn’t quite bear to say it right now. He didn't want that moment to be about hysterical bonding, and he wanted to tell Izuku just how he felt at a better, safer time. So instead, he settled on just saying, “Thank you.”

He leaned back onto the hospital bed, making the stiff fabric rustle behind him. Somehow the distance between them made him feel a little more ahold of himself, like a baby bird jumping out of the nest. Deku had his back, and he could handle this.

“Deku, you were basically deep fried. Have you gotten checked up yet?” Deku flushed red, which was a sure sign he hadn’t. Katsuki gave him the best glare he could muster up at the

moment, which probably was a fairly pathetic one, all things considered.

“Not in the hospital,” Deku admitted, eyes sliding away from Katsuki, obviously guilty. As he should be, Deku never took care of himself. Well, at least not up to Katsuki’s standards, which were sky-high when it came to Deku’s health.

“Look, I’ve got three hours until they put me under. You go get taken care of, okay?”

“I don’t want to leave,” Deku mumbled, getting that stubborn edge to his chin. Too bad, Katsuki knew how to deal with *that.*

“Deku, I don’t want to go into surgery worried about you. Please go get checked out?” He watched in satisfaction as Deku’s stubbornness crumbled away.

“You did say please,” Deku admitted. Katsuki grinned triumphantly until Deku went on, “And I want to reward you for having good manners since it’s so rare.”

What a sassy little bitch. Before Katsuki could think up a retort, Deku pressed a kiss to his lips and slipped out the door.

Katsuki hated the empty hospital room. The TV hanging in the corner seemed to mock him, reminding him of all his failures. Well, screw that. He was going to fucking take responsibility for what he’d said, and Deku would come out of it fine. He’d managed to half doze off before his phone buzzed. Thank god for voice activation, because without it he wouldn’t be able to read the text without calling a nurse, which would be humiliating. He still had to listen to a fucking computer voice tell him,

I am going to help the relief efforts. Kacchan it’s so bad out here, I can’t stand by and do nothing, I just can't. I’m really sorry I won’t be there but I am not that injured and the people need help. I will come back as soon as I can.

Shit. Fucking shit. Fear coursed through Katsuki’s veins, and he was suddenly furious at the situation. Furious his arms were broken, furious he was stuck in this bed and *furious* that Deku would head out again. He should have fucking tied him to the bed, he knew how Deku could get in these types of situations.

Katsuki knew he wasn’t really furious. He was terrified. Not just by Deku’s absence and self-sacrificing bullshit, but by his surgery and by the fact he’d apparently *intentionally killed* someone. He took, long, slow breaths, focusing on the feeling of his lungs filling and emptying. Damn, his ribs hurt. He felt himself slowly begin to regain some sense of groundedness. He wasn’t going to freak out. He could do this. So, he carefully used voice-to-text to send Izuku a text.

Bakugou Katsuki: *Izuku come back. You are too injured to work right now. I want you here, please come back.*

What else was there to say? He could only hope by some miracle Deku would look at his phone and actually choose to come back. At this point, knowing Deku, the chances were slim. His calm lasted another hour of Deku not walking back through that damn door.

Fuck.

He'd been through surgeries alone before, sure. He was used to relying on no one. He'd liked it like that, damn it. But somehow along the way he'd started looking to Deku when he was stressed, upset, or frustrated. Deku's kindness and optimism were dependable as bedrock, and Katsuki hadn't considered what it would feel like to lose that when he needed it.

Doctors came in, explaining what they'd be doing and why, preparing him for the upcoming procedure. Katsuki let it happen, feeling numb as he watched the door. Hoping it would open, and Deku would walk through it.

But he didn't, and Katsuki went unconscious under the careful supervision of a room full of strangers.

Izuku meant to go to his check-up. He really did, but somehow he ended up lost in between two of the hospital buildings. His mind was still a little blurry from everything, and something about the esoteric hospital diagram was incomprehensible to him. It wasn't really a surprise he ended up in the small lawn in front of the hospital.

What he saw horrified him. There were people everywhere, many crying or moaning. Some sported lightning burns like him, but more seemed to bear the type of injuries that came from collapsing rubble, from a city that had failed them. Heart in his throat, Izuku asked one of the harried nurses about it. His tears weren't even looked at twice. They weren't out of place in this horror scene.

Apparently, all the petty villains in the city had taken it upon themselves to take advantage of the chaos. Izuku wondered if this is what Striker had wanted all along. If that was why she'd crippled their emergency response system long before striking, if she'd wanted to prove how ineffective the system of heroes really was.

The stress of being embarrassed on live TV faded in the face of what Izuku saw on the hospital's lawn. He was still walking, he could still fight (probably). He saw the people sobbing through pain, calling out for lost loved ones, and he did the only thing he could.

He sent Katsuki a message, hoping he would be forgiven.

Izuku: *I am going to help the relief efforts. Kacchan it's so bad out here, I can't stand by I just CAN'T. I'm really sorry I won't be there but I am not that injured and the people need help. I will come back as soon as I can.*

Then he headed out into the city and began to look for survivors. Izuku knew what he was doing wasn't the safest idea, but he couldn't stop it. The stream of victims seemed endless, the mountains of rubble insurmountable. While plenty of places weren't harmed by Striker's coordinated attack, they were pillaged by villains in the aftermath. First aid stations had popped up all over the city, and Izuku assisted them with anything they needed. Heavy lifting, search and rescue, fighting off the low-tier villains that threatened them.

It was strange because Izuku didn't technically feel weak. Sure, his skin was a mass of shapeless pain, but with Full Cowling, he could move fine. And though his heart felt weak, and he wasn't sure his limbs would keep obeying him, he was still able to lift slabs of concrete weighing hundreds of pounds.

The only thing Izuku really did wrong was that when the supervisor told Izuku his shift was over and he needed to go home, Izuku had agreed. And then he *hadn't* gone home, but rather to a different sector, and kept on working. He lost track of how many people he told he was going home. He couldn't leave, not when he was still standing and there were still people out there whose lives were in danger.

Izuku reached for his phone, wanting to call and at least leave a message. Shit, it was dead. He had no idea how long it was dead for, and he felt the sinking guilt of not having checked it sooner. With a defeated sigh, Izuku realized he'd just have to wait until he could make it back to the hospital. Hopefully, Katsuki would understand.

He set out, planning to head back. Of course that would be too easy, because on the way back, there were people trapped in a building. Then there was a young woman being harassed by a villain. There was an ambulance that had crashed, and before he knew it, Izuku was all the way across the city again, wrapped up in countless rescues.

Night brought different complications. It was hard to find survivors in the rubble, every triage center needed lights to keep working on patients, and much of the city's electrical grid was still down. Izuku helped electricians get where they needed to go, fending off villains and moving rubble blocking vital roadways.

By morning, he was exhausted. No, he'd started this whole mess exhausted. Now he was just utterly spent, unable to take another step Yet another supervisor told him to head home, and this time Izuku heartily agreed.

He didn't make it. He'd been running Full Cowling non-stop just to keep himself on his feet, and it finally flickered out. He was still way too far from any hospital, from his apartment, from anywhere he could rest.

But he could let people see his weakness. Not if he wanted to be a symbol of strength. So he stumbled into an alleyway and collapsed behind a dumpster, and fell asleep immediately.

Izuku awoke to something kicking his thigh and the sound of shouting. Groaning, he covered his ears. It was hard to open his eyes past the accumulated crust, and the light was blinding. What time was it? What *day* was it?

“Oy! Izuku! Wake the fuck up!” The words were angry, harsh, and unmistakably Katsukis. Izuku’s eyes flew open, and he winced at the brightness.

“Kacchan,” he groaned. “I don’t feel well.”

“No SHIT!” Bakugou shouted at him. “What the hell are you doing out here? Do you have any idea how fucking worried I was? No one could fucking find you!”

It hurt too much to think about, so Izuku ignored it in favor of just drinking in the sight of his (angry) boyfriend. Katsuki was wearing hospital clothes, and his arms were both in casts that went past his elbow. Izuku couldn’t take it. He'd failed everyone. He'd failed to save his city, he'd failed to be there for Katsuki, he'd failed himself by letting this happen in the first place. He broke down, shallow sobs wracking his body. He heard Katsuki swear softly above him, and suddenly Katsuki was kneeling in front of him, precariously balanced on the balls of his feet.

“Baby, I was so worried,” Katsuki told him, voice hoarse. “Shit, okay. Look, I can’t fucking pick you up I’m gonna call for help. I need you to stay with me until they get here, okay?”

Izuku nodded, the movement making his head throb. “Kacchan, I messed up,” he sobbed. Katsuki took a deep breath.

“Yeah, you did,” he said softly. “But I got you now, okay? We’re gonna get you all fixed up, then I’m gonna chew your ass out for being a reckless idiot.”

“Sounds good,” Izuku breathed out. God, he felt terrible. His head ached, deep and hard and relentless. He wasn’t sure he could stand, or even move. Deep down, he knew he was so fucking lucky Katsuki had found him. He managed to stay awake until Katsuki called 119, then he drifted out of consciousness.

Chapter End Notes

***DISCLAIMER:* As of 4/1/20 I’ve edited and re-released this chapter. Please see the top of the chapter for more notes on that! Please keep this in mind while reading any comments from before this was revised.**

--

I feel like Bakugou going apeshit on reporters who aren’t behaving at villain attack sites actually happens *all* the time and most people are used to it now. However, the whole “dating Deku” thing is new and… Maybe I just wanted Bakugou to say “DICK IN ASS SEX” on TV, okay?

LOL @ this fic only being “nearly over by now,” I was wrong and I apologize. It’ll take a lot longer than I expected :) hope y’all don’t mind :)
Also PLEASE I am dying, should I retcon most of this fic and call Bkg Katsuki (when it

makes sense to switch over in the narrative)? Or keep it Bakugou? At this point I've thought about it so much both options sound weird to me >_>

I'm on twitter talking about my BS writing @useless_donut

I lowkey (highkey) live for your comments & kudos and thank you so much for sticking w/ me and this story <3

Media Fellatio

Chapter Summary

Everyone works on recovering. Izuku reconsiders some things.

Chapter Notes

DISCLAIMER: Hello! This is your formal warning that I changed a lot about Chapter 17 after I initially posted it. If you haven't read the updated version of Chapter 17 yet, Chapter 18 will probably be confusing :^)

If you don't want to go back, here's the tl;dr version of the changes: The beginning's the same, Izuku & Bkg more or less make up abt the TV thing after it happens (Bkg's a sad boy), Izuku runs off to search and rescue but gives Bkg a heads up first, Bkg still finds him collapsed somewhere like a trashbag days later and is very angry but isn't "done." He is still loving & just wants his nerd home safe. The end!

Also in case anyone was worried, the change in Chapter 17 actually didn't affect the overarching plot outside of how long they have to spend reconciling and how secure they feel about their relationship afterward. I did write the resolution to what happened in the OG version, so DM me on Twitter if you want a link to the Google doc :^)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Izuku woke up slowly. He was getting really sick of passing out in different places, but at least he was waking up somewhere surprisingly nice this time. He was warm, the bed was soft, and his head felt clear for the first time since the Striker incident.

Izuku pried his eyes open and looked down to find a mess of blond hair next to his hip. Katsuki was passed out, face pressed into the mattress, drooling a bit. His arms were still in casts and sat uselessly in his lap. Izuku's heart twisted. Katsuki had stayed with Izuku, even after Izuku had run off and nearly worked himself to death.

Hesitantly, he ran a hand through Katsuki's hair. With a snort, Katsuki's head jolted up. Sleepy red eyes met his, and Izuku was pained to see the relief that filled them.

"Deks, how're you feeling?" Katsuki's voice was raspy, bordering on inaudible. Izuku's heart lurched at the nickname, and he found himself tearing up. He'd made it through, he was okay, and Katsuki was calling him stupid nicknames again. All was right in the world. Or at least, close enough to being right that Izuku could finally relax.

“Better,” Izuku said, taking a moment to find his voice. His throat was dry and rough from disuse. Katsuki wiped the drool off his mouth with his shoulder, looking over Izuku appraisingly.

“Can I get you anything? Shit, I should probably call a nurse or something.” Katsuki eyed the call button next to Izuku’s bed meaningfully, so Izuku hit the button himself. In no time, he was being subjected to a round of questions from a nurse.

He’d apparently suffered from exhaustion, dehydration, and lack of food in addition to his injuries from Striker. He’d been out for days, which was disorienting but a little comforting in a strange way. At least he hadn’t had to see the first rounds of the news cycle.

Once the nurses left him in peace, Katsuki reclaimed his seat next to Izuku’s bed.

“I’m getting discharged tonight,” Izuku told him. “They just need to watch me for a while longer.”

“That’s good.”

“Thanks for staying with me,” Izuku said, mindful of everything that had happened. He knew he had a lot to apologize for.

“Shove it, Deku,” Katsuki scoffed, finally showing a bit of his normal spirit. “Of course I did.”

The fact that Izuku hadn’t done the same for him remained unsaid. The moment stretched, ending only when Katsuki cleared his throat. “Deku, you feel good enough to talk?”

Bitter dread filled Izuku’s stomach. He didn’t want to be lectured on how unsafe he’d been, how awful it must have been for Katsuki. He *knew* . But he nodded anyway because if Katsuki needed to talk about it, Izuku would listen.

Wordlessly, Katsuki leaned over to the remote and switched on the TV. He awkwardly flipped through a few channels, punching the buttons with stiff, bandaged fingers until he found one with Ground Zero on it. The banner beneath it said, D*** IN A** S**?

“I don’t want to see the news,” Izuku protested, looking down at the blankets bunched over his legs. He heard Katsuki sigh.

“I wanted to wait for your input before making a statement, but you were out for fucking ever,” Katsuki told him, and turned up the volume. “So you get what you get.”

Ground Zero’s hoarse voice became audible from the TV set. Izuku looked up reflexively and was immediately unable to look away. It clearly wasn’t the start of the segment, but he could see Ground Zero standing in a studio, casts on his arms instead of his usual grenade-like bracers. He was clearly in the middle of giving an apology.

... was inappropriate. I apologize to Deku and his fans, as well as anyone watching the broadcast. I was not in a good state of mind, but that’s not a fu-, that’s not an excuse. I only

ask that you don't hold this against Deku, and know that my words only represent me, not him. If you need to judge someone, it should be me.

The voice faded out, overlaid by newscasters discussing it. Katsuki switched the TV off, sighing again. "They've been running it non-stop. I fucking hate apologies, but it's helped at least a little. The news has left you more or less alone, so don't worry your shitty brain too much, alright? I'm gonna do as much as I can to stop it from affecting you."

"Kacchan, thank you," Izuku whispered. In truth, it was a massive weight off his shoulders. He hadn't realized how much he'd dreaded dealing with that mess. While he probably would still have to say *something* about it eventually, Katsuki's statement would take the edge off the worst of it. Now that he thought about it, it was far from the first time he'd seen Katsuki intercede to save face for him. Izuku narrowed his eyes at him, watching as Katsuki shifted his chair closer to Izuku.

"I signed up for counseling again," Katsuki said abruptly, slouching back in his chair. Izuku was unable to stop his quick intake of breath. Katsuki shrugged, ignoring Izuku's surprise. "There's a lot of shit going on for me right now," he said gruffly. "Figured it might be fucking useful. I don't want to get so overwhelmed I lose my shit again."

"Kacchan?" Izuku stared at him and saw determination written in his expression. Sure, Katsuki had made a mistake, but wasn't that allowed? Izuku wanted to spend his whole damn life with him, and mistakes were going to happen in a lifetime spent together, no matter how hard they tried. He was just glad to see that Katsuki was someone determined to learn from his mistakes.

Izuku wanted to do the same for him, as well. He didn't want to make this moment about himself, though, so he just said, "I'm proud of you for doing that. And I'm here to support you, too."

"Fucking hell, Deku," Katsuki murmured. Despite his words, he sounded grateful. Slowly, he stood and leaned over the bed, brushing Izuku's forehead with his lips. He pulled back slightly, searching Izuku's face. "We're gonna be okay, right?"

"We will," Izuku promised him. And it was a promise that Izuku intended to keep. As long as Katsuki was willing to work with him, there wasn't anything they couldn't overcome. Even with Izuku's own shortcomings and Katsuki's persistent flaws, they'd be able to get through anything together.

Izuku's friends found him shortly after, and in no time they'd crowded into the room. He was also hugely relieved to see they were all okay, although Uraraka was still bed-ridden, apparently still unable to move much due to severe nausea. It looked like Izuku wasn't the only person who'd pushed himself too far. And then there was Kaminari, who hadn't yet regained consciousness.

His friends were kind enough to not mention Katsuki's outburst, but the knowledge of it laced their interactions. Tsuyu said something along the lines of, "You know we support you no matter what," at least five separate times, and Iida heavily insinuated that he'd fight an unnamed someone if it came down to it. Izuku was touched, enough that he was tearing up by the time they'd all left. Shouto hung back, hovering by the door.

"Can I say something about Bakugou?" Shouto said, obviously hesitant. Izuku was a little wary, knowing how harsh Shouto could be sometimes. Still, Izuku always wanted to hear what Shouto had to say. When he nodded his permission, Shouto came and sat next to the bed.

He looked tired, and had his bangs clipped back. The mess of red and white hair mixed to a pale pink in places, an endearing detail that softened the dark circles beneath his eyes.

"Look, right after I graduated I… I made a serious mistake." Shouto took a deep breath, like it was hard to admit. Izuku tried to think of what he could mean, but Shouto had never mentioned anything like this. He adjusted his collar uncomfortably.

"I was teamed up with Bakugou for a mission; I guess they thought since we'd interned together, we could work together well? Anyway, it was pretty terrible, the idiot refused to cooperate and..." he trailed off.

"Anyway, that's not the point. I made a mistake, and he took the blame. He can tell you about it if you really want to know, but I wanted to say something. Our friends are being pretty harsh on him, and I don't know what happened between you two, but I'm going to guess it was something like this? Sorry, I really don't want to overstep. I just know that you two weren't close for a long time, so you might not know about this kind of thing, but he is a really good friend-"

"Wait, *what?"* Izuku was getting whiplash from this conversation.

"We're friends," Shouto laughed slightly. "Me and Bakugou. It's actually nice to be able to tell you this. I always felt like I had to keep you two separate, what with everything."

"You're messing with me," Izuku said, warily. Shouto shook his head.

"He's a lot easier to deal with than he used to be. I guess you already know that, though. Anyway, he likes to act like he's a bad bitch, but that wasn't the only time he helped someone out. Like the time he was criticized for getting caught out by the villain with the undressing Quirk?"

Izuku would never forget the image of Bakugou's naked body running around in public, fighting a very overdressed villain. "They said he stole the credit from Aoyama, because it wasn't even in his sector and he hadn't been called to the fight." But he'd looked so glorious.

Shouto huffed out a laugh. "It was a coincidence that he was there, but he actually was helping Aoyama. Apparently, Aoyama is really worried about his appearance and was terrified of being naked in front of the public. Maybe something about his navel laser?"

“That sounds about right,” Izuku conceded. It was a lot to ask of a hero, or of anyone.

“Bakugou didn’t give a shit, and that’s a direct quote. I guess he realized that he can get away with a lot of things, because people expect him to act like that anyway? And then sometimes he uses that for a good cause? I’m just saying that while it’s not okay that he hurt you, he probably had good intentions. Even *I* know he’s a good person despite his delinquent personality, for whatever that’s worth.”

“You know, I never thought you’d be encouraging me to get along with Kacchan,” Izuku laughed, still a little thrown by the admission.

“Oh, I was always encouraging you two,” Shouto said, blinking at him. “You couldn’t tell?”

“Uh, not really,” Izuku admitted. “But I appreciate it? Anyway, we already talked through that, and I think it was pretty much what you described. It’s just that this time, he threw my reputation in the dumpster along with his, and I don’t have the same ability to deal with it.”

Izuku’s stomach sank just thinking about it. Sure, Katsuki had alleviated some of the pressure, but it was still *Izuku’s* image. He was the one who looked bad. Or at least, he was the one who cared if he looked bad.

“Why can’t you deal with it?” Shouto said. Izuku was tempted to scoff, but Shouto’s serious expression stopped him.

“What do you mean? You know how people see me. I’m not controversial, and I’m famous for being a, you know. A good, moral person, I guess.” He could see Suika’s imageboard for him in his mind now, filled with things like *virtuous, moral, innocent, determined* .

“That’s true, but it doesn’t mean you have to sit there and take whatever people say about you. That image of you isn’t wrong. You are a good person, and an amazing hero. Those things don’t change just because of some pointless scandal, and you shouldn’t act like it either.”

“Shouto,” Izuku said, choking up again. Shouto put a cool hand on his.

“I know you like to avoid interacting with the press, but maybe it wouldn’t hurt.”

“Like how?”

“People probably want to see you stand up for yourself,” Shouto said. He put a cool hand on Izuku’s arm, and gave him a comforting squeeze. “I know I do. I want you to know I support you. But I also want to watch you tell every judgemental prick out there that they can’t touch you.” His voice was fierce, and Izuku was taken aback. It was uncommon to hear him swear, and the sentiment behind the words was making Izuku tear up a little.

“Thanks, Shouto.” He put as much sincerity into the words as he could.

Shouto gave him one of those half-smiles that can stop someone’s heart. “Of course, Izuku. Call me if you need anything, okay?”

Izuku promised. *Stand up for himself.* Had he not been? If he was being honest, he realized that he had been acting passively, letting everything play out. Letting a hurt, drugged-up Katsuki talk to the press, hell, not even being able to answer the interviewer's questions in the panel ages ago. He'd been unconsciously relying on Katsuki to deal with all the difficulties that would come with this, and it wasn't working. No matter how well Katsuki represented them (which was honestly debatable, at this point), it would only show one side of their dynamic. He resolved to do better.

Katsuki took him home. Home in this case was Katsuki's flat, because Katsuki sheepishly admitted that he'd bullied Kirishima into breaking into Izuku's apartment to see if he was there, which he obviously hadn't been. Kirishima's version of breaking in was very literal. Apparently his door didn't lock anymore, and it wouldn't be fixed until the weekend. There was a hole in Izuku's door where the handle used to sit, and his landlord had apparently elected to cover it with duct tape. Izuku had stayed there only long enough to pack his things and grab any confidential case materials.

The idea of staying in Katsuki's flat after everything felt a little strange. A little too domestic, and a little too safe. In a way, it was just what Izuku needed. His own bed would be better, but there was something comforting about laying on Katsuki's couch while listening to the man curse about the difficulties of changing clothes in the other room.

He finally stormed out of the bedroom, only wearing underwear. Izuku stared at him. He was covered in yellow-purple bruises, and there were lines of stitches across his chest.

"Like what you see?" Katsuki said, predictably smug. Izuku was starting to realize that this was something Katsuki was going to say literally any time Izuku was caught checking him out. So, very frequently. But this time was different, because Izuku was worried instead of horny.

"You look… rough," Izuku managed to say. He was a little horrified, because he hadn't really realized the extent of Bakugou's injuries. Katsuki just scoffed.

"Oh, I can be rough alright."

"Kacchan!"

"What!"

"You look like someone ran you over!" Izuku protested. Katsuki finally looked down at himself, and made a face. "I only knew about your arms," Izuku pressed. "What happened?"

"Howitzer impact," Katsuki said, frowning slightly. "I can't handle one that size without my bracers, so once I set it off my arms were toast. And that meant I couldn't control my fall, and I ended up falling a hell of a lot further due to the crater. I just got knocked around a bit, it's nothing to worry about."

“Well, I’m worrying,” Izuku announced, closing the distance between them. He put his hands on Katsuki’s stomach, feather light. “Does this hurt?”

“Nah,” Katsuki breathed out. “Not really. Feels good to have you touch me again.”

“Right,” Izuku murmured, his heart aching a little. He could felt it too. After the stress and tension of the last week, what with his frantic search and rescue efforts subsequent time spent unconscious, it had been a long time since they’d just been together. He slid his arms around Katsuki’s waist, and tucked his head against his chin. “I missed this.”

“Me too, baby.” Katsuki’s voice was soft and deep, and Izuku wanted to sink right into it and never surface. “It’s been a long day, okay? Let’s get some sleep.”

Izuku woke up covered in sweat, his phone buzzing on the nightstand. Apparently his *do not disturb* setting had been on a timer, and now he was getting flooded with notifications. Bleary-eyed, he sat up and picked up his phone. Most of the messages were from earlier in the week, but he’d recently gotten a whole string of videos from Shinsou. Weird.

He clicked on the first one, and jumped when it immediately blasted full volume. He frantically tried to mute it, but the words were unmistakable.

The words *dick in ass sex, gay ass fucking sex* echoed through the room, mutated by copious amounts of auto-tune and a trap beat. Next to him, Katsuki groaned, blinking up at Izuku. Izuku gave him an awkward, apologetic grin.

“Sorry?”

“The hell,” Katsuki groaned, slowly managing to sit upright.

“Shinsou sent it,” Izuku just said, and held the phone up in lieu of any other explanation. The video went on. It was a whole two-minute-long song of Katsuki’s audio clips. Shinsou had followed up with a message saying, *Too soon? Lmao*

And Izuku busted up laughing. Katsuki looked deeply disgruntled, which only made Izuku laugh more. “Kacchan, I’m sorry, it’s just so funny,” he choked out, wiping tears from his eyes.

“You’re lucky I like you,” Katsuki grumped, then flopped back down onto the bed. “Go the fuck to sleep, Deku.”

Izuku kissed his forehead, holding back more laughter. “I can’t sleep; I’m gonna get up. Maybe I’ll make you breakfast.”

“Please don’t,” Katsuki grunted, turning his head away. "Don't want food poisoning, thanks." That sent Izuku into another fit of giggles. It felt so good to feel normal again, it was making him feel giddy.

Izuku looked at the rest of the videos from Shinsou in the living room, curled up on Katsuki's couch. There were five or so, and at first glance seemed to be about various times Ground Zero had fucked something up. Most notably, though, the first about the house Shouto had set on fire.

The second was about Aoyama. The creator had pixelated Bakugou's middle section as per YubeTou's terms and conditions.

The others were all times Katsuki had done something that looked bad on camera, and Izuku deeply suspected it was to cover for someone else. Izuku was hooked. Despite the fact that it was maybe four in the morning, he went on a hard deep dive about Ground Zero and every mistake he'd ever made.

There were a lot. If Izuku's career had been spotless, Katsuki's was pretty much a dumpster fire from the start, filled with bad press, errors, injuries, and more. They were always just excusable enough, and never going so far that anyone could *really* say he shouldn't be a hero.

And there was the whole thing where he was damn good at what he did. Pretty much no one could currently match his sheer firepower, and he was one of the rare heroes who had the analytical mind to match it.

But the temper, oh the temper. Maybe seven pages into YubeTou, Izuku found a video claiming to be Katsuki's coming out video. However, it was just a blurry close-up of his face as he was being mobbed by reporters. Izuku could recognize his post-hook-up look from tabloids, and apparently everyone was very excited to see him leaving a *man's* house. Someone had the nerve to say he probably topped. Katsuki had rounded on them and screamed,

WHAT, YOU THINK I'M TOO FUCKING WEAK TO TAKE A DICK HUH? WANT ME TO FUCKING SHOW YOU? HUH??

Apparently their more recent fiasco hadn't been Katsuki's first time losing it on live TV. Then Izuku found an auto-tuned version of that encounter, and then he was lost in a sea of low-tier Ground Zero edits mixed in with the occasional conspiracy theory video.

He awoke to Katsuki unceremoniously sitting down on his stomach. Izuku jolted upwards with a panicked snort, making Katsuki laugh.

"Deks, it's 3:00 PM. I ordered lunch ages ago, get your ass up."

Izuku tried to make sense of where he'd slept and what time it was. He'd fallen asleep at some point, watching video after video. Was this why Shinsou always looked so tired?

"Kacchan?"

“Yes, Deku?” Katsuki gave him a very skeptical look, apparently not over Izuku’s audacity to sleep past 8:00 AM. Well, Izuku had more important things to talk about.

“How long have you been taking the fall for other people?” Izuku looked up at him, trying to gauge his reaction. Katsuki went still, his eyes widening.

“What are you talking about?” He said. He sounded cagey and defensive. Izuku glared at him. He hated not knowing things about Katsuki, and he couldn’t figure out how this fit into Katsuki’s personality.

“Bakugou Katsuki, also known as the hero Ground Zero, who wants to be the #1 hero in the country- no, in the world,” Izuku said mildly, “Also has been letting his public image suffer to cover for other people?”

Katsuki sighed, slouching into the couch. “Half n’ half was the first one,” he admitted, finally. “Guess the asshole finally let it slip.”

“He was trying to convince me to forgive you, actually.”

Katsuki rolled his eyes. “Meddling bastard.”

“Why do you do this?” Izuku demanded. He didn’t understand it, and he hated not understanding anything about Katsuki.

Katsuki’s face darkened considerably, likely because Izuku had the sheer audacity to question his ambition. “Do you really not know? I graduated with perfect attendance, perfect grades, perfect combat, glowing fucking reviews from my internships, and you know what I see in the paper the next day? *Bakugou Katsuki: Most Likely UA Student To Become A Villain!* And that’s just one example.”

Izuku had seen that article in Ono’s collection of terrible articles. He swallowed hard, hearing the old hurt in Bakugou’s voice. “So you what, gave up?” It came out harsher than he intended, but Bakugou just shrugged him off.

“Hell no. I just dropped the nice guy act-”

“UA was a nice guy act?” Izuku couldn’t help laughing, sudden and bright against the tension in the room. Bakugou wrinkled his nose at him, somehow managing to look adorable.

“You saying I wasn’t fucking nice?”

“Um.” Izuku wasn’t going to answer that.

“Nah, I know what you mean,” Katsuki snickered. “I got sick of the bullshit pretentious pro scene really quick. I wanted to kick ass and take names, not kiss ass and… well, I actually talked to Aizawa about it a lot. Sleepy bastard is fucking on it, said I just got jaded a little early in my career.”

“So, early as in before it even started?”

“Exactly, but you know me. I’m an ambitious fucker, so I decided I’d be number one anyway. I just wasn’t going to do it while sucking media dick, you know?”

“Wow.” Izuku couldn’t keep the skepticism from his voice.

“I think it worked out well,” Katsuki threw him a razor-sharp grin. “I checked the rankings today. I’ve dropped to #10, sure, but I also wasted Striker and shouted about sex on TV, so I think that says a lot.”

“I don’t think most people boast about those things,” Izuku sighed, giving up. Bakugou was gonna be Bakugou.

“Can’t stop, won’t stop,” Katsuki said, leaning back with a grin.

“Shouto thinks I should stop sucking media dick,” Izuku murmured, making Katsuki choke on a laugh.

“Oh really? Tired of deepthroating every newspaper you see?”

“Gross, Kacchan.”

“All that practice has paid off, you’re really good at-”

“ *Gross,* Kacchan,” Izuku protested, trying to be serious. “I’m just thinking I’ve been too much of a pushover. Like, I get so caught up in being a hero sometimes that everything seems exciting and sacred, you know? But it’s not like that, in reality. And me acting like everything is fine doesn’t actually make it any better.”

“Fuck yeah,” Katsuki grinned. “I’ve got your back.”

Izuku gave him a long look, because very recently Katsuki had failed to do just that. To his surprise, Katsuki flushed faintly. “Come on, Deku. I just meant I’m here for you while you do your thing. Fucking supportive fucking boyfriend, and all that.”

“Mm, and maybe if you swear more it’ll be more convincing,” Izuku teased. Katsuki scowled at him.

“Just wait till I get these shitty casts off. I’m gonna wreck you, you sassy little asshole.”

“You can try.”

“Oh, I will,” Katsuki said, his words holding a burning promise.

“Let’s have breakfast first,” Izuku snorted. Katsuki was, well. He could manage to be attractive trotting around in underwear and arm casts, but it wasn’t really the most intimidating of looks. Izuku wanted to kiss him silly more than ride his dick into the sunset.

“It’s lunch at this point, dumbass.”

“Dinner?”

“Just fucking eat.”

Katsuki hadn’t talked to him about Izuku’s ill-advised rescue rampage through the city. The absence of conversation was wearing away at Izuku. He knew Katsuki wanted to talk about it, but the man was just mindlessly flipping through TV channels on the couch. Izuku had insisted on cleaning up after they ate, but he was getting more and more nervous with every minute.

When he thought about it, Katsuki wasn’t one to talk about his feelings. More accurately, he seemed willing enough if it concerned Izuku’s feelings or wellbeing. Izuku couldn’t think of any time Katsuki had brought something up because he needed help or support. Or because Izuku had hurt him.

Izuku suddenly realized it might be on him to do it. He’d had good intentions, and he didn’t regret the lives he’d saved. But he did regret leaving Katsuki like that. It hurt to imagine him lying in the hospital bed, alone, wondering where Izuku was. Katsuki deserved his best attempt at communication.

Izuku sat next to him on the couch, and started simple. “Kacchan, I’m sorry.”

Katsuki’s head swung towards him slowly. It hurt Izuku to see how guarded his face looked. But then he said, “I know. Thanks, Deku.”

And was quiet. Izuku waited at least a minute, hoping he’d say something else, before he gave up.

“Shouldn’t we talk about it more?” Izuku asked, nervously. Katsuki looked back at the TV, but clearly wasn’t watching it. His posture was stiff, tension written all over his body.

“I,” he said softly, then muted the TV. “I’m just glad you’re okay.” His breathing was shaky and irregular, betraying how worked up he was.

“It’s okay if you’re angry,” Izuku murmured, venturing to put a hand on his shoulder. “I should have been there for you. I shouldn’t have stayed out in the field so long. I know that. I know you’re probably really upset.”

In a strangely robotic motion, Katsuki’s head turned back towards Izuku, as if he had to force every inch of movement. His face was twisted up with emotion. When he spoke, his voice was hoarse and hardly audible.

“I thought you were dead, when I found you. I couldn’t even check your fucking pulse because my hands were bandaged and all I could do was shout at you and hope you woke up. You were just laying there, covered in dirt and blood and pale as a ghost and I thought you were dead.” His voice cracked on the last word, and he suddenly hung his head, hiding his face behind a fringe of blonde hair.

Izuku was horrified. Horrified at what he'd put Katsuki through, and that he hadn't realized how hard it had been for him this whole time, that Katsuki had been bottling it up with apparently no intention of letting it out.

"I'm so sorry Katsuki," Izuku said, reaching out to him, pulling closer. "I'll do better, I promise. I know being a hero is unpredictable but I won't take pointless risks and make you feel like this for no reason again, I'm so sorry." Somewhere along the way, Izuku had started tearing up.

Still looking down, Katsuki said, "I thought Striker might have killed you, and I lost it a little bit. I wasn't sure, and I was in denial, but I didn't really believe you survived until I saw you in the first aid center and then right after I got you back I lost you *again."*

"Katsuki…" Izuku couldn't say anything. In Katsuki's place, he'd be furious and terrified. He couldn't imagine Katsuki putting him through that, actually. Katsuki was dangerously reckless, sure, but he wasn't mindlessly self-sacrificing like Izuku was. When Katsuki looked up, Izuku could see the lingering embers of the fury he must have felt.

"I made them call everyone, Izuku," Katsuki said between gritted teeth. "Followed up with every supervisor who'd reported you heading home, followed sightings of you on the news and fucking social media-"

"The tracker in my suit-"

"Was fried by Striker, you dumbass!" Katsuki shouted, then snapped his mouth shut. "Sorry. Want to know how I found you? Fucking bullied Kirishima into making a map that triangulated your probable position based on recent sightings and your average travel speed. I was doing a goddamn grid search when I found you. I looked behind hundreds of fucking dumpsters expecting to see you dead somewhere, 'cause I damn well knew you'd never want to collapse in public. And despite all that, seeing you lying there shocked me so bad I thought my heart fucking stopped."

They sat in silence for a moment. Izuku had to admit he'd been avoiding thinking about what he'd done, because he knew just how dangerous it had been. He hadn't really realized he'd been assisting the rescue effort for *days* . Not hours, days.

"I was so scared, and that made me angry," Katsuki sighed. "And it's hard to be mad at someone for saving other people, and that made me angry too. I fucking know how you are, but this was just too much. Even for you."

"I know," Izuku said, feeling tears of shame prick at his eyes. "It felt like I wasn't even there. I just kept moving, I was barely thinking at all. The last thing I remember was wanting to go back to the hospital and see you, but I got distracted, and everything after that is a blur. I don't think I was thinking straight after everything with Striker," Izuku finished lamely, hoping it didn't sound like he was just spouting excuses. Katsuki looked tormented.

"I shouldn't have let you go," he growled. "I should have said something to the staff, that you'd been fucking fried by that bitch twice and-"

“It’s not your fault,” Izuku interrupted firmly, putting his hands on Katsuki’s shoulders. “Don’t go there. It was all me, being reckless and having a dangerous hero complex.”

Katsuki nodded sharply. “Look, Izuku, I’m kind of a volatile person. There’s a reason my life is so full of routine. I don’t… I don’t handle this kind of stuff well. I need to be able to rely on you not to do shit like this.”

“You can,” Izuku said, his heart in his throat. He could hear the unspoken words. If he wasn’t able to be someone Katsuki could rely on, then he wouldn’t be a good partner for Katsuki. Katsuki would leave, and Izuku wouldn’t blame him. “I’m going to work on it, I promise.”

Katsuki let out a long, slow breath. “I’m sick of this shit.” Ice ran down Izuku’s spine, and Katsuki must have noticed the change in expression because his mouth quirked up. “No, Deks, I just mean like all this bullshit. I’m ready to put it behind me. Now I just wanna stay inside and smother you until my suspension is up.”

Izuku blinked. "Wait, your *s uspension?”*

“Yeah,” Katsuki grinned. “The whole Striker team is under investigation for how it went down. Me especially, because I KO’d her. I’m suspended for the next month, which is coincidentally my exact projected recovery time before returning to active duty. Sure is funny how that works.”

“Kacchan, I’m so sorry,” Izuku whispered. “I can’t believe they’re investigating you-”

“We’re also under consideration for receiving national awards for our work,” Katsuki scoffed. “So don’t get your panties in a twist. It’s just bureaucrats pushing paper, it’ll come out fine.”

“Unbelievable,” Izuku muttered. It had been a long time since he’d been completely blind to the flaws in their society, but sometimes it was more apparent than others. To be condemned and rewarded for the same action simultaneously? It was clear it wasn't about Katsuki's actions, it was about how it looked. Who it benefitted. It made Izuku irrationally angry, but Katsuki interrupted his thoughts.

“I get this bullshit off tomorrow, though,” Katsuki said, holding his arms up and looking pleased. “They’re flying a specialist out from Nigeria. She should be able to sort out Denki too.”

“That’s good!”

“Top heroes get top treatment,” Katsuki snorted. Izuku couldn’t tell if he was gloating, or if he was bitter that a hero's non-fatal injuries received so many resources while plenty of civilians were likely suffering fatal injuries.

They woke up early the next morning to head to the hospital for Katsuki’s appointment. They made it all the way down to the front door before they realized the front of the building

featured reporters camping out.

“I wonder if they’ve been here this whole time,” Katsuki grumbled. Izuku glared at them, starting to feel righteous indignation burn in his heart.

“Wait here,” Izuku said, snatching Katsuki’s keys.

“Deku?”

“I told you, I’m tired of sucking up to the media,” Izuku snapped. Katsuki’s eyebrows shot up.

“Pretty sure you called it sucking media *dick* -”

“I’ll be right back,” Izuku snapped. He stormed back upstairs and made a beeline for Katsuki’s closet. He dug through it, grabbing whatever Ground Zero gear Katsuki, which ended up being his standard-issue Ground Zero sweats and what apparently was an ancient orange hoodie. It would have to be good enough.

Katsuki was obediently waiting in the lobby, looking vaguely bored. He perked up when Izuku arrived, but Izuku pushed right past him and out the door. “Wait here,” Izuku told him sternly.

“Have you talked to Suika about whatever you’re about to do?” Katsuki called after him. Izuku paused.

“I’ll talk to him later,” Izuku said, feeling a little guilty, but not guilty enough to stop.

“Knock ‘em dead,” Katsuki waved him on, looking both amused and concerned. Well, all that mattered to Izuku was that he stayed in the lobby while Izuku went to talk to the press.

As soon as he stepped out of the gate, cameras began flashing in his face. He never used to hate this part, but now? Now he remembered Katsuki standing in front of Kirishima, looking like a cornered animal. Izuku wasn’t going to lose his mind, though. He waited until they’d lost some of the fervor, and pointed to someone at random. Their question didn’t matter, Izuku was going to say the same thing no matter what.

“Deku, what do you have to say about the recent announcement by Ground Zero? The-”

“Thank you for the question,” Izuku cut in forcefully. He could be loud when he wanted to, and now his voice carried across the street.

“However, I am not accepting questions right now. Instead, I’d like to say how disappointed I am with the way Ground Zero was treated at the disaster site. This kind of unprofessional behavior has no place near crisis sites where heroes need to communicate timely, crucial information to the public. It is also incredibly disrespectful to direct such invasive questions towards heroes who were risking their lives for everyone’s safety merely hours before.”

Izuku paused, and silence rang on the street. He was sure there were plenty of honest, hard-working journalists out there, and likely in this crowd. However, he wasn't feeling merciful.

"I don't know why you have been camping outside of Kacchan's apartment building, but we both deserve our space and privacy. That includes the ability to leave the damn building without sneaking out to avoid paparazzi. I'm asking you all to politely leave, right now."

A few people raised hands, and Izuku felt a scowl descend over his face. He knew he looked angry, and he was glad of it. "Now. We will make statements to reputable news sources when we feel it is appropriate."

Then he stared them down, glaring at them one by one until they all slunk away. After several minutes, Katsuki ambled out of the building and nudged him with a shoulder.

"Looks like you scared 'em off," he remarked, glancing around the empty street. "Did you really have to raid my closet for that?"

"It's called a show of support," Izuku said, and was surprised how shaky his voice sounded. That had taken a lot more out of him than he'd expected. He summoned up a smile for Katsuki. "How's that for not sucking media dick?"

"I think you graduated from sucking media dick to straight-up ass-fucking the media from behind."

"Ugh, Kacchan," Izuku groaned. "Do you have to be so vulgar?"

"In fact, you could even call it dick in ass se-"

"Kacchan!" Izuku protested, laughing. "No! No. Just… no."

Katsuki was still snickering to himself by the time their taxi arrived, but Izuku was lost in thought. He couldn't believe how powerful standing up to the press had felt. Sure, he stood up to villains on a near-daily basis. Somewhere along the way, that had become routine. Now, Izuku was determined to stand up for everything he believed in. It wasn't just about villains anymore. It was about creating a just, safe world where people could be the best versions of themselves.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you all for being patient with the long wait! Hopefully my other fics have been entertaining in the meantime (◡‿◡✿)

Izuku's really out there pulling the "I'm not mad, I'm disappointed," thing with the city's entire press corps (but seriously imagine Izuku telling you he's disappointed in you. I would d i e.)

I'd like to say a serious THANK YOU to Horikoshi for making Bakugou a crier in canon. I think it's meaningful on so many levels that I don't need to get into but just. I appreciate it.

I think Todoroki & Bakugou would be really good friends as adults, assuming Bakugou gets over himself at some point. Bakugou needs friends who aren't spooked by his trashcan personality, and I feel like Todoroki would find him amusing in the way you'd find an angry puppy amusing, and he'd respect Bakugou's work ethic and aggressively strong morals etc.

Writing Bkg without using hand gestures was a lot harder than I expected. I struggled so much. The auto-tuned clips of Bkg screaming things are inspired by this clip.

Thank you to everyone for all your comments! I always read & treasure every one, and the response to this fic has been really wonderful. I was so touched so many people shared their thoughts on the last chapter!! As always, you can find me messing around on twitter @useless_donut

ALSO WE HIT 100k WORDS EYYY TY ALL FOR THE SUPPORT! \o/

Boundaries

Chapter Summary

Katsuki deals with being stuck and home and Izuku deals with Katsuki dealing with being stuck at home.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The specialist from Nigeria was frighteningly efficient. No sooner had they arrived at the hospital then Katsuki was hustled away into a backroom for treatment. Izuku was instructed to wait in the waiting room, with beige chairs and the wavering light of the aquarium.

From what he'd gleaned from their conversation, she had a Quirk that focused on reassembling things that had been destroyed in whichever way. It just needed to be used very precisely and carefully, but all of his questions had been shut down because she 'had more important things to take care of than his curiosity.' Which was fair.

So Izuku sat in the waiting room next to the aquarium and watched a pair of yellow tangs swim aimlessly through some rocks. The light flickered every few seconds. Izuku wondered if it bothered the fish. He couldn't shake his bone-deep worry about Katsuki's well-being, but something about sitting in a waiting room felt strangely domestic and comforting. Katsuki's parents knew everything, but similar to Izuku's mother, they didn't come to the hospital every time they were injured in the line of duty. Izuku had always felt it was too much to ask, so he'd ended up doing the same thing that Katsuki and many other heroes did. Called their folks to reassure them they're okay, and deal with the rest on their own.

But Izuku could be there for him.

The aquarium lights flickered again, reminding Izuku of lightning. Striker haunted his thoughts, more than any other villain he'd had a part in taking down. The weather had calmed noticeably since she'd passed away. Since she'd been killed. By Katsuki. Izuku's hands made fists on his knees. Maybe if he'd been better, stronger somehow, he could have neutralized her first. It had only been a few days since he'd been released from the hospital, but he already had countless notebook pages of theories on her Quirk. The best he could guess was whenever she teleported, it disrupted the electrical charge of her atoms. Somehow she'd been able to control how much, or sense what type of charge would result in what.

Izuku should come better prepared. There shouldn't have been any villain he wasn't prepared to fight. His mind began wandering the familiar circles of self-doubt, inevitably spiraling into a montage of the destruction he'd witnessed in the aftermath.

It was so hard not to blame himself for everything, harder even when he knew the city was still rebuilding and he was still stuck at home. He'd called Suika pretty much immediately, and they'd agreed lying low was the best idea. He'd decided to take a break from media exposure until he went back to work. Suika had promised to get back in touch if anything was urgent. He'd sternly instructed Izuku to focus on healing up, and not on the news.

Thankfully, he'd be allowed on desk duty soon. As it was, he was strictly forbidden from any physical hero work until he'd fully recovered. HQ had given him official notice that he was blocked from all emergency channels until he was working again. Izuku had taken this to heart, and outside of reassuring his friends and family that he was alright, he'd just focused on recovering with Katsuki. They'd needed the time to themselves.

Izuku still felt a little too fragile, like if maybe a few things aligned in just the wrong way he might shatter all over again. He couldn't speak for Katsuki, but the man was still a little too quiet. He took a little too long to respond when Izuku called him.

They were both still healing.

And if Izuku was completely honest, maybe it wasn't *just* about focusing on himself and recovering. There was a large part of him that was becoming afraid to look at the news, afraid to see his image torn apart by people judging him based on Katsuki's worst moments.

He was deep enough in thought that he actually jumped when a slight shadow fell in front of him. He looked up to find a middle-aged woman standing before him, nervously twisting her hands.

"You're Deku, right?" She sounded both hopeful and worried. Izuku sat up a little straighter, wishing the clothes he'd snatched from Katsuki's closet were a little more presentable.

"Yes," Izuku said, standing automatically. "Is there something-"

"Sorry to disturb you," she said politely, then looked flustered as she realized she'd interrupted Izuku's brooding. "Uh, I just wanted to say thank you."

It took Izuku a few seconds too long to realize he must have helped her at some point. "I'm happy I could help," he said, forcing himself to smile. It was jarring to go from being so deep in thought to dealing with the public. Anxiety crept in around the edges. Had she seen Katsuki's outburst? Did she think less of him? Feel sorry for him?

"You saved me," she said, her voice thick with emotion. "The news said you were just resting, but I saw how hard it was for you."

Izuku wasn't able to speak. He wasn't sure what she was talking about. "It was a difficult situation for everyone," Izuku said in a way he hoped sounded reassuring. "We are all recovering and rebuilding."

"Yes, of course," she said fretfully. "I just saw you, saw what it was like. After you pulled me from the rubble, I had to help you walk to the first aid camp."

“I’m sorry…” Izuku trailed off, lost. He remembered none of this, just hazy images of rescue after rescue.

“I was so worried about you,” she said, fretfully. “You went right back out after saving me and no one heard from you after that. We told them, though. About what you did.”

“What I did?” Izuku asked, just barely keeping his voice steady. The woman looked at him in confusion.

“It took a while ,” she continued, folding her hands nervously. “But we all called in. The people you saved. I’m-” abruptly, she teared up. “I’m sorry. You deserved better than what they gave you, but you’re so good. Just a truly good person. You inspired so many people. Thank you so much.”

“I uh,” Izuku said, still pretty thrown. As always, he had to fight the urge to brush off the thanks, and accept it gracefully. “Of course. I’m glad I was there for you.”

“For everyone,” she said, and gave him a firm, albeit teary nod. “We’re all supporting you. I am. Please keep being an example of everything a hero should be. Sorry to take up your time!”

And she left, taking hurried little steps. Izuku watched her go, deeply shaken. She’d said things that would normally touch him deeply, but he didn’t know exactly why she was saying them.

He considered checking the news, but the dread loomed again. Instead, he called Suika.

“Hi, Suika? Do you have a moment?”

“Of course! How are you, Midoriya? Recovering well? Still avoiding the media?”

“Yeah, I’m fine,” Izuku said, gathering his thoughts. “I ran into this woman, and it was strange? Did I do something? Would you mind telling me if there’s anything I should know?”

“Well, it’s taken a while for everything to get back up and running,” Suika said. “But you know, you made a very big impression.”

“I saved some people,” Izuku said, bitterness welling up. “Nearly got myself killed because of my recklessness.”

Suika was quiet for a long moment. “I was really worried about you too, you know. Ground Zero contacted me when you were missing, but I didn’t know where you were either.”

“I’m sorry,” Izuku whispered. Suika’s quiet laugh was barely audible over the phone.

“Well, you don’t have to apologize to me.”

“But I-”

“You saved thousands, Midoriya. You bumped up to #9 with the first post-disaster rankings.”

“Sorry, *what?* ” Izuku hated the surge of victory he felt when hearing those words. It felt wrong to be rewarded for something like this.

“Well, as of this morning you’re #6.”

“What?” Izuku practically shouted. “Why? I was reckless, I went rogue and,” he cut himself off, his throat closing.

“Basically saved half the damn city single-handedly, Midoriya,” Suika said quietly. “It’s been incredible. I’ve never seen anything like it. There were small articles run on you *everywhere* , because apparently you were all over the place in the three days following Striker’s attack. And people started to notice, and finally bigger networks picked up on the fact that you managed to single-handedly rescue more people than everyone else combined.”

“Everyone was really busy,” Izuku said numbly.

“Yes,” Suika said simply. “You probably were too reckless, but that doesn’t change the impact you had in people’s lives. You recovered several *thousand* people alone. You did something to be proud of.”

And those simple words broke Izuku. “T-thanks,” Izuku choked out, trying to hold in tears. He desperately didn’t want to break down in a hospital waiting room. As it was, people were already giving him strange looks after the woman had talked to him.

He hung up quickly, and spent the rest of the time with his face buried in his hands, crying silent, burning tears. He propped his heels up on the edge of the chair, and curled into a ball, just letting time pass as he tried not to be overwhelmed.

This wasn’t how he wanted to reach the top ten. It wasn’t how he wanted to beat Katsuki.

He didn’t feel heroic.

He was half asleep by the time Katsuki found him. Gentle hands landed on his shoulders.

“Deku? You asleep?”

Izuku reluctantly looked up, revealing his mess of a face. Katsuki’s smile immediately fell.

“Deku, what’s wrong?” Katsuki’s eyes searched his face, as if he could find the answer written in Izuku’s red eyes and tear-stained cheeks. Izuku wished he could, because he couldn’t quite articulate what was wrong. He was supposed to be happy about this, but just the thought of it made his stomach turn in nausea.

“I’m number 6,” Izuku said thickly. He could see the worry overtaking Katsuki’s face. It was strange. He expected to be congratulated, or even for Katsuki to start spouting some jealous bullshit about how he was a higher rank at the moment. Instead, gentle hands rose up to cup his cheeks.

“Then why do you look fucking wrecked?”

“Not here, please,” Izuku whispered.

Katsuku was clearly stressed, but stepped the fuck up and shepherded Izuku out of the hospital. Izuku hated it. He felt weak. He’d wanted to be there for Katsuki, but yet again he was the one being taken care of.

Katsuki’s flat felt different. Katsuki’s arms felt different, when he held Izuku once they’d gotten inside. Izuku felt terminally restless, like he was doing something wrong or should be doing something he wasn’t, or he couldn’t stand to keep doing whatever it was.

He’d made several circuits around the living room before Katsuki stopped him.

“Time to spill, Deku,” Katsuki said, hands heavy on his shoulders. “Quit pacing and talk to me.”

"This isn't how I wanted it to happen," Izuku said, looking at the floor. "I barely remember what I did. And it's not that I regret saving people, but I nearly destroyed myself doing it. But no one will talk about that, and it's not that I want them to but it feels wrong. And then I feel ungrateful for not being happier about this, and then I hate that people celebrate the results of my recklessness and part of me feels that it's okay if I die trying to help others because how can I decide my life is worth more than theirs?"

He heard Katsuki take a deep breath, but kept looking at his feet. His eyes were starting to swim again.

"That's a lot," Katsuki said thoughtfully. "Honestly, this shit is complicated. I had a lot of conflicting opinions about my rank for a long time, but for someone like me, it doesn't matter too much."

"Someone like you?"

"Someone volatile," Katsuki said. Izuku could hear the smile in his voice. "Public perception of me swings so wildly and so often that my rank changes constantly. I just moved to #9 today, for whatever reason. I honestly didn't expect to be moving up for a long time, but I guess my rank is still unpredictable."

"Kacchan," Izuku trailed off. He wasn’t sure what to say to that. Izuku’s rank had been steadily climbing since he’d graduated, albeit without the leaps or setbacks like Katuski had. It was rarely worth commenting on, outside of the typical milestones of top fifty, thirty, etc. Well, that is until now.

"That's not the point. I just mean that the system doesn't exactly reward having healthy fucking boundaries and a sense of self-preservation. That's one of the things I've been talking about, actually. With my counselor."

"I'm not sure heroes are supposed to have a sense of self-preservation."

"You're a person before you're a hero," Katsuki told him. Izuku said nothing. That was the heart of the issue, and Izuku couldn't honestly say that his personhood felt more important than his identity and work as a hero. He'd always felt they were one and the same. Katsuki made a noise of frustration. “Deku, come on. You know you can’t damn well save any more people if you’re dead. If you want to be strictly logical about it, your life *is* worth more.”

“It doesn’t work like that.”

“Don’t care,” Katsuki said. Izuku could hear the irritation picking up in his voice. “Yeah, you fucking scared me when you went out there and damn near ruined yourself. But you’re obviously good at what you do. You deserve your rank. You’ve deserved it for fucking ever, and I’m glad you got it. It’s also fucked up that that’s what it took for you to be recognized, but that doesn’t mean you didn’t earn it.”

“It feels wrong to be here because of a *mistake* ,” Izuku hissed. “I wasn’t the one who took out the villain. I didn’t stop her from using her OP as fuck finishing move. Kaminari isn’t even awake yet!”

“The doctor is looking at him now-”

“I shouldn’t have to nearly kill myself to be acknowledged!”

They were both quiet for a moment. Izuku finally met Katsuki’s eyes, and was surprised to see he didn’t look upset. He looked… proud?

“Yeah, you shouldn’t.” Katsuki’s voice was low and steady. “I’ve thought about this a lot, you know. Especially since we got together. You know with All Might is the oldest One for All user, right?”

“Yeah,” Izuku murmured. He could tell this was heading towards some kind of lecture.

“Because everyone else died *young,* Deku. They didn’t have long-term relationships, they pushed away their children, none of them lived a long, healthy life.”

“And?” Izuku’s throat was dry.

“I don’t think that’s the life you want for yourself.”

“Maybe it’s the life I have to lead,” Izuku said hoarsely. Katsuki shook him slightly.

“Bullshit! You don’t *have* to do anything! And damn it Izuku, but *I* don’t want that life for you! That’s not good enough! You know what I want?”

“What,” Izuku whispered. Katsuki tilted his chin up, forcing him to meet his eyes.

“I want us to live a goddamn happy life and grow old together. Can’t do that if we die young for some dumbass reason. It’s fine to be the best heroes we can be, and I can’t believe *I* have to be the one to say this, but there is shit more important than being the best hero.”

“Really.”

“Yeah, dumbass. Gotta be the best version of yourself first, and you can’t do that if you’re fucking dead. I’m not gonna quit dating you just so you can have some weird solo hero martyr power trip bullshit, so suck it up and take care of yourself.”

Izuku blinked at him, trying to absorb all that. Katsuki had just told him he wanted to grow old with him? Something warm and hopeful was blossoming in Izuku’s chest. Katsuki’s face softened, the agitation bleeding away.

“It’s okay to let yourself be happy, Deks. You don’t have to give everything to being a hero. You get to be yourself, too.”

“Kacchan, that’s uh,” Izuku said slowly. “Weirdly mature, coming from you.”

Katsuki huffed. “I’ve been to a *lot* of counseling. Eventually that shit rubs off on you.”

“Well, I’m glad it did,” Izuku said, and stepped forwards to hug Katsuki. Katsuki wrapped his arms around him, squeezing him tight. “I think you’re right. I’m gonna think about boundaries, because I um,” Izuku blushed hard, tucking his face into Katsuki’s chest, “I want to grow old with you too. So I’ll be more careful. Not just for us, but for myself.”

“Good,” Katsuki kissed the top of his head. It felt like a promise.

It felt like clarity.

Izuku wondered how much of his life he’d felt torn between trying to be himself, Izuku, and trying to be himself, Deku, One for All holder, the legacy of All Might and new Symbol of Hope. Maybe he had needed to step back a bit, and realize that he still had a choice. And he wanted to choose himself. He wanted to give himself the gift of living a long, full life but…

Katsuki had wandered off to make tea, and Izuku couldn’t quite squash the last wriggling shreds of doubt. It still felt like he needed permission. And maybe he shouldn’t, but, he did. He sent a quick text to All Might, and put the matter aside to tend to more pressing matters.

Pressing matters like investigating just how recovered Katsuki actually was.

Turns out Katsuki had recovered enough to goad Izuku into doing things that he *probably* wasn’t quite supposed to be doing yet but…. Katsuki had also recovered enough to be very, very persuasive.

There was a time in Izuku’s life where he’d held onto Katsuki like his life depended on it. No matter how hard Katsuki had pushed him away, Izuku had refused to leave him alone.

That version of Izuku probably would have died in shock at Izuku’s current predicament. Izuku stared at his phone, sitting innocently on his desk. He was back in the office, working on paperwork. He had a lot to catch up on, not to mention all the statements and witness accounts required for what he’d seen of Striker.

It was almost overwhelming, and he didn't have the catharsis of a good workout to process it with. He was on desk duty for at least another week or so, depending on what his doctor said. And even after that, he was still supposed to take it easy. He sighed, running a hand through his hair.

He'd been back in the office for over a week already, and while the paperwork was pretty dreadful Katsuki was even *worse.*

Katsuki was a lot of things. Ambitious. Driven. Reckless, hot as hell, arrogant, protective… the list went on. And nowhere on that list was "capable of dealing with being stuck inside for more than twelve hours." Izuku loved being his boyfriend, really, and he reminded himself of that when he became Katsuki's primary outlet for all that pent up energy.

Izuku thought he had a high sex drive. Nope! Not compared to Katsuki after being stuck home alone all day. Izuku's neck and chest were smothered with concealer, and he could only be thankful he wasn't doing anything strenuous enough to wear it off.

Izuku thought he had a particular tendency to obsess about things, but just the other day he'd come home to a veritable conspiracy theory board of the best curry powders, where they were located, where to purchase them, and something about deep fakes and counterfeits? It was a lot.

Izuku had thought he was maybe a little clingy. But no, not compared to Katsuki, who apparently didn't feel comfortable being needy with anyone else. Which was kind of sweet, but *god* it was a lot of text messages.

His phone buzzed. Izuku ignored it. He'd checked it ten minutes ago, and had already replied to Katsuki. There were thirty more notifications since then. Three messages a minute, and Izuku was pretty sure that was Katsuki holding back.

Katsuki was officially going insane from being stuck at home, and Izuku was bearing the brunt of it.

Izuku took yet another selfie of himself, captioned it "i miss you and i'm turning my phone off 'till i leave work" and turned his phone on silent. He couldn't quite bring himself to turn it off. What if Katsuki actually needed him?

Only seventy+ notifications by the end of the workday. He took a bus home, and read through them. Katsuki had discovered the spice shop across the city was price gouging. He'd cracked two cold cases with files he was definitely not supposed to have at him. He'd been chewed out by his doctor for repeated requests to speed up his physical therapy schedule, which (thankfully) he was strictly adhering to. He'd also asked Izuku what he wanted for dinner, and then sent about fifteen different suggestions.

It was a lot, and yet it had Izuku feeling warm and buoyant the whole ride home. It didn't matter that he was overwhelmed, that Katsuki was kind of overwhelming. When it came down to it, he was just grateful he could be close enough to Katsuki to experience this kind of thing.

Izuku opened the door quietly, figuring Katsuki might be asleep. He hadn't gotten a text from him in maybe thirty minutes, which was indicative of a nap.

However, when Izuku slipped inside he saw Katsuki sitting on the couch, lit by the glow of the TV. From this angle, he could only see the back of his head and the video of Izuku on the TV. More accurately, the video of hero Deku fighting a villain. Katsuki was watching videos of him? It was surprisingly sweet.

"Yeah babe," he heard Katsuki murmur. "Get 'em."

Izuku was touched. It wasn't that often that Katsuki was bone-achingly adorable, and he wanted to savor it.

"Yeah, that'll show 'em," Katsuki sighed, as Deku KO'd an opponent on screen. Then he moaned, and Izuku knew *that* sound. The knowledge skittered down his spine, kicking off a chain reaction of arousal that left heat pooling in his stomach. He must have made some kind of noise himself, because Katsuki's head rolled back on the couch, leaning to the side so he could send a half-lidded look at Izuku.

"Hey, Deku," he said. His voice was husky and carried all kinds of promise.

"Kacchan," Izuku said, and dropped his things on the floor in favor of heading straight to the couch. What he saw froze him in place. Katsuki was slouched on the couch, legs spread and sweats pushed down enough to let his hard cock spring free. His shirt was pushed halfway up his stomach, and one hand was lazily stroking himself.

"You're uh," Izuku stammered. Katsuki's answering grin was soaked with lust.

"Jacking off to videos of you? Yep. Thought it'd feel a lot weirder than it does." He gave himself another languid stroke, keeping his eyes on Izuku. "It's actually real good."

Izuku watched the progression of his hand up and down, up and down. His throat went dry. Something about this situation was driving him absolutely mad.

"Do you do this a lot?" Izuku's voice was hoarse with lust.

"First time was after I got the casts off," Katsuki said, then moaned softly. "It's fuckin' good, Deks. You should try it sometime. Unless you already have?" His grin was knowing, and Izuku felt white-hot shame flash through him. He *had* tried it, shortly after Katsuki's first videos as Ground Zero began circulating, and it had resulted in the most shame-filled orgasm of his life.

"I did once, years ago," he mumbled. "I felt really guilty about it, so I never did it again."

Katsuki blinked up at him, but Izuku didn't miss the way his hand gained speed. When he spoke, his voice was rough with desire. "That's too bad. If I were you, I wouldn't have stopped."

“Oh,” Izuku said, hopelessly turned on. He loved a shameless Katsuki. “Um, I don’t mind, anyway.”

“Well then. Now, you just gonna watch me jerk off or what?”

Izuku’s eyes were drawn back to his hard cock, how obscene it looked when Katsuki was still largely clothed. He swallowed hard. He really didn’t want to leave. “Did you want me to go?”

“Nope. I like it when you watch,” Katsuki said, his voice dropping to a lower register. Before Izuku knew it, he’d dropped to the floor in front of Katsuki’s knees, staring up at him. He drank in the sounds his hand made as he jerked himself off, the muscled stomach half-hidden by his shirt, and the lazy amusement in Katsuki’s eyes as he looked down at him.

“What if I do more than watch,” Izuku whispered, his mouth practically watering. He ran his hands up Katsuki’s thighs, offering more.

“Deku,” Katsuki groaned. Izuku took it as encouragement.

“Don’t you want to get off to videos of Deku while the real thing’s sucking your cock?”

Katsuki made a strangled noise, sitting up enough to stare down at Izuku. “Hell , Deku, you’re gonna fucking break my brain.”

“That’s a yes, then?”

“Suck my dick, loser.”

Izuku couldn’t help his small laugh, but he obediently did. And god, was it electric. No sooner had he taken Katsuki’s cock in his mouth than he felt fingers tangling in his hair, pushing his head down.

“God, you’re so fucking hot,” Katsuki sighed, his eyes fixed on the screen. “Fucking love watching you kick ass.” Katsuki punctuated the last word with a long, lazy thrust. It was hard not to gag, but it was worth the tortured groan it tore from Katsuki. Katsuki set a slow pace, gently thrusting in his mouth, occasionally murmuring praise either to Deku on the TV or Izuku.

Izuku felt kind of used, and it was making him extremely turned on. His own hard-on was getting uncomfortable in his pants, but he forced himself to focus only on Katsuki.

“Fuck, Deku, your mouth feels so good, you’re so amazing, shit,” Katsuki rambled, praise pouring from his tongue even as Izuku’s eyes watered. Izuku held onto his thighs for dear life, trying to stop Katsuki’s thrusts from hitting his gag reflex too hard. Katsuki didn’t let up, but he apparently couldn’t last long at that pace, because soon Izuku was frantically trying to swallow down Katsuki’s cum.

“So hot,” Katsuki drawled, sinking back into the couch. Izuku wiped at his mouth, wincing slightly. His throat would be sore the next day. “Come here,” Katsuki told him, and switched off the TV.

“How was it?” Izuku rasped, crawling onto Katsuki’s chest. Katsuki wrapped his arms around him and kissed his temple.

“Felt dirty,” Katsuki murmured. “I liked it. Let me do you next time.”

“Next time?” Izuku nipped at his neck. “Maybe I want you *now.”*

Katsuki hummed, the sound low and thoughtful. “Take me, then.”

Izuku froze, his mind turning over what Katsuki was offering. “You want me to…”

“I’m not supposed to do anything too strenuous,” Katsuki told him, mouth lifting in a crooked smile. “But I’m sure you’ll take such good care of me, won’t you? How good are you gonna be for me Deks?”

Izuku made a pathetic choking noise, before pulling himself together. “Really good, Kacchan,” he croaked. Katsuki’s eyes lit up in approval.

They rarely made love like this. Or rather, they rarely *made love* at all, Katsuki typically preferring to be teasing or rough or cocky or any number of things. Mixing real emotional vulnerability with sex was rare for him, and Izuku could read his hesitance a mile away. So he'd never pushed it, because Katsuki was already opening up to him far faster than he’d ever anticipated.

Sometimes, he worried that one wrong move would have all of Katsuki’s walls going right back up. But then other times? Like now, with Katsuki beneath him on the couch, all relaxed and happy? Izuku felt like he could get away with asking for a little more. So he leaned down, pressing a soft and lingering kiss to Katsuki’s lips.

“I really care about you, Kacchan,” he murmured. Katsuki hummed, apparently willing to let Izuku take the lead with the mood. Which was fair, considering what Izuku had just done for him.

Izuku ran a hand down his chest, his stomach, admiring the curve of each muscle, the potential for explosive power, the trust Katsuki put in him. It was completely intoxicating. “I think you’re amazing,” Izuku whispered into his neck, letting his hand dip between Katsuki’s legs. He was rewarded with a soft sigh from Katsuki.

“That’s nice,” Katsuki said. Izuku was once again glad for the way Katsuki had lube stashed all over his apartment, and allowed Katsuki to sit up enough to fish some out of the coffee table drawer. He held it up in front of Izuku with a proud smirk. “Got you something, baby.”

“I’ll put it to good use,” Izuku laughed, and snatched it away. Katsuki obediently let him have it, then dropped his arms up above his head. And damn, that pose did really nice things for his shoulders. “You’re being so good,” Izuku said, wonderingly. Katsuki’s grin showed teeth.

“I’m the best, nerd. Don’t forget it.”

Izuku detected a little bit of sass in there, but he figured he could allow it. “Yes, you’re the best, Kacchan,” Izuku told him. Katsuki arched a little, clearly showing off, his eyes half-lidded and fixed on Izuku’s face. Izuku suddenly felt like he’d been dropped in front of a banquet he could only have dreamed of. Here was Katsuki, lying here just for his pleasure. A literal dream come true. Right.

“You’re a dream come true,” Izuku went on, and began to gently prep Katsuki. Katsuki only grumbled a little, but quieted as Izuku pressed soft kisses all over his face. “Thanks for letting me pamper you, Kacchan. I really like this.”

“It’s fine,” Katsuki said, just a little gruff. Izuku caught the slight tinge of pink on his cheeks.

“How’s it feel, Kacchan? Is it nice for you?” Izuku was up to two fingers now, and was trying not to drool at the thought of being inside Katsuki. Katsuki nodded wordlessly, and tilted his head to the side, allowing Izuku better access to his neck. Izuku tried to be patient, he really did.

But he’s been hard and needy from the moment he’d dropped to his knees to blow Katsuki, and god he wanted him so bad. He felt hot all over, torn between slowly making love to Katsuki and just taking what he wanted as fast as he could get it. It was so hard to hold back, but Katsuki was starting to breathe harder, to shift his weight to get more from Izuku’s fingers and *damn* that was delicious.

When Katsuki let out a breathy little whine, Izuku suddenly couldn’t wait any longer. He practically ripped off his pants, and quickly repositioned himself. “Ready, Kacchan? I’m gonna make you feel so nice. Gonna show you how much I want you.”

“Hell, Deku,” Katsuki groaned, his arms flexing as he gripped the couch behind him. “Show me what you got.”

So Izuku did. And since Katsuki was being *so* nice, Izuku was nice too, pushing i n slowly. It felt overwhelmingly good. Katsuki was tight and hot around him, practically heaven on earth. Izuku couldn’t stop the way his breath stuttered, the sudden clench of pleasure in his gut. Katsuki didn’t miss it either, grinning at him in that smug way of his.

“Aw, you like it that much?” he teased. There was no edge to it though, not when his face was flushed like that, not when his sharp eyes were soft with affection. Izuku nodded, not trusting himself to speak. He bottomed out, and took long, steadying breaths.

“Sorry,” he breathed. “It’s just- you’re so good. I like you so much. I’m so happy, Kacchan. Seriously, I-”

“Can you fuck and talk at the same time?” Katsuki groaned. “This is torture.”

Izuku’s gaze dropped down to where Katsuki was getting hard again. Right. Izuku moved slowly, carefully, taking care to note each of Katsuki’s reactions. What made him twitch, what made him whine, what made him shiver with pleasure. It was so luxurious to have Katsuki spread out beneath him like this. It made Izuku feel a little high with it, drugged up on intimacy and affection and the heady, lust-filled atmosphere of the room.

He kept moving, but leaned in to keep kissing Katsuki. Katsuki kissed him back, a little breathless, but clearly happy. It was unusual for him, but that just made Izuku treasure it more. He wanted to remember how Katsuki looked now forever. The way the soft blue light of the TV lit up his face, the rosy flush of his skin, the way he allowed Izuku to take the lead.

That was the rarest part of it, really.

Katsuki almost never gave up control. It was something Izuku admired about him, really, because for the most part he channeled it in positive ways. But to let Izuku take the lead, and hardly fight about it? To refrain from his typical snarky, heated comments? There was an emotion welling up and sticking in Izuku's throat that had nothing to do with sex, and everything to do with the trust and intimacy he'd gained with Katsuki.

But the sex was still electric. Izuku's steady, careful pace was starting to build. Not in the blinding, searing way it did sometimes, but with a sustained build that was irresistible all the same. Izuku sung Katsuki's praises, telling him how beautiful he was, how perfect, how Izuku would never change an inch of him.

And soon Katsuki was rock hard in Izuku's hand, attempting to push back against his hips to speed things up. But this was Izuku's show, so he fucked him slowly, lovingly, until each thrust drew a choked groan from Katsuki's lips.

"God, Izuku, you're so damn amazing, so good, please never stop," he was murmuring, his fingers digging into the couch behind him. "God you're fucking perfect, I want you so bad," he broke into a long groan as Izuku pushed in hard, grinding against him. Katsuki finally came undone beneath him, panting and shaking in a way that pushed Izuku straight over the edge. He was seized by pleasure, held captive as he came hard, his head dropping onto Katsuki's sweaty chest. Katsuki held him tight, murmuring soft words of praise against his hair. Izuku felt so relaxed and happy he wouldn't be surprised if he was literally glowing.

"Kacchan, that was…" he mumbled, trailing off. His head moved with Katsuki's chest as he laughed quietly.

"Yeah, that was something. Just let's stay here for a while, yeah? I want to hold you."

"Mkay," Izuku said, too blissed-out to protest about how gross they were. He knew he was drifting off, but he couldn't be bothered to do anything about it, not when he felt so warm and safe and happy and cared for.

They ended up falling asleep on the couch, sweaty and exhausted, but in the best way possible.

Chapter End Notes

"Suck my dick, loser" - Katsuki, speaking to the love of his life. What a catch.

Ok not to be weird about it but I was kind of caught up w/ Izuku's numbers:

So we're saying he recovered several thousand people (between 1k-3k). Izuku was out there for around 3 days. That's 72 hours total, and I'm assuming he had OFA on the entire time and was able to recover an average of 1 person every few minutes (with minimal bathroom & snack breaks). So one person/minute would be 4,320 people, but that's a bit MUCH so I cut that in half, to ~a few thousand, including the times Izuku saves groups of people from falling debris etc. which I'm adding to the count. So in conclusion Izuku is saving an average1 person every few minutes (assuming his bathroom/snack breaks vaguely cancel out the times he saves multiple people at once). I figure that's both enough to run Izuku nearly to death despite his extreme OP-ness, and also to earn him the much-awaited acclaim he deserves.

ALSO it's been ages since I've written bkdk smut! It was fun to get back into it (and also refreshed my crippling nervousness about posting it, woohoo). This one is actually a scene I've had in mind for ages, and gave birth to that one tweet

If you can't tell, I love the nickname deks, because a) it's intimate and casual and familiar and b) it sounds like "decks" which is incredibly stupid and I love stupid things

Thank you all for reading and sticking with this fic! It sure has gotten long, huh? I *think* it'll be wrapping up in the next two chapters after this, if you can believe it! I super struggled with writing how Izuku's processing his self vs. hero-self debate. I feel like in canon he'd just be totally hero-self until he inevitably dies too soon like all the other OFA users, but sue me I want him to grow old and happy w/ the love of his life ;-;

Kiss Me Thru The Phone

Chapter Summary

It’s Izuku’s turn to slip up on live TV, and Katsuki multitasks to the best of his abilities.

Chapter Notes

i sort of know i should stop making joke chapter titles but.... i will not stop

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“They’re called Lichtenberg scars,” Izuku said, shivering as Katsuki’s hands traced the branching patterns on his stomach. They were pink and angry now, but he’d been assured they’d fade with time. Izuku was far past caring about scarring now, though. Especially not if it gave Katsuki’s fingers interesting things to do on his skin.

“You’re gonna run outta skin to scar soon,” Katsuki told him, and pressed a kiss into his side. It tickled, and Izuku squirmed away.

“Then I’ll just have scars on scars, it’ll be fine,” Izuku mumbled, pulling the blankets over himself. Katsuki’s derisive snort was deafening.

“Deku.”

“I swear I’m being really careful!” Izuku pleaded, grabbing Katsuki’s sulky cheeks. “Don’t pout! I know it’s just cause you’re jealous I’m actually in the field again. Besides, you’re a cute housewife.”

Katsuki’s eyes narrowed, maroon in the morning light. “Don’t get smart with me.”

“I’m literally always smart,” Izuku chirped, dramatically shoving off the blankets and sitting up. “And in two days, I’m allowed to patrol at full strength!” He was currently working short shifts, and found them incredibly frustrating.

“You’re just rubbing it in, you little asshole,” Katsuki growled, shoving his head into Izuku’s chest like an overgrown cat. A lion, probably. Izuku petted his head despite himself. He needed to get up, and Katsuki made it so hard to leave bed sometimes.

“I gotta go,” Izuku murmured. Katsuki made a wordless noise of protest into his chest, then slowly untangled himself from Izuku. Izuku gave him a smile, easy and fond. “I’ll be careful,

okay Kacchan? You know I'll be back right after my shift's over."

"Should charge you rent," Katsuki grumbled, his eyes flicking down Izuku's bare chest. It was obvious what kind of *rent* he had in mind. Izuku poked his forehead, pushing him away.

"You know my place will be fixed up soon, and I'll be out of your hair! I guess most contractors were busy repairing the city, but things are settling down so they finally could get someone to fix my lock…" Not to mention that Katsuki had working arms again, even if he still had a good chunk of physical therapy to get through. He didn't need Izuku here all the time, even if he'd been very welcoming.

Katsuki stared at him for a moment, then his shoulders drooped. "Yeah, makes sense," he said, avoiding Izuku's eyes in favor of staring out the window. Little fireworks started sparking in Izuku's heart. Katsuki wanted him to stay, didn't he?

"It's pretty soon for me to move in permanently," Izuku said, making his tone as light as possible. They'd only been officially dating for a few months, even if it felt like far longer. Izuku was the type to move glacially slow in relationships, but maybe that was because he'd never been moving towards Katsuki before.

"Whatever," Katsuki huffed, and Izuku sighed. It *was* way too early to expect any kind of mature conversation from the man, anyway. The clock read 5:37 AM in blinking, red letters. Katsuki glanced at it, then back to Izuku and visibly softened. "Not gonna act like I don't want you around. I like having you here," he admitted.

"Sure you do," Izuku teased, and Katsuki pounced on him, hands on his shoulders and staring down at him.

"No," he said quietly. "I'm always gonna want you around, Deku."

"Don't get all serious," Izuku said, blinking up at him. Katsuki still had a tendency to get abruptly moody when he was reminded of their past, and Izuku found it helped to keep him grounded in the present. "I know how you feel now, Kacchan."

Katsuki blinked at him slowly. His lashes looked almost white in the morning light. Izuku could stare at him all morning, but Katsuki interrupted his thoughts.

"Do you?" Katsuki's voice was suddenly serious, pregnant with meaning.

"What?" Izuku was having trouble reading his expression. It was something between soft and constipated, which was hard for a normal face to achieve. But Katsuki's face was so expressive, and Izuku was completely at a loss until he said,

"Do you know how I feel about you? You know I…" he trailed off, looking pained. It was Izuku's turn to blink stupidly at him. Katsuki cleared his throat.

"Like you," he finished, sounding defeated.

"I like you too," Izuku said, trying to sound cheerful. He was struggling to parse the moment, because for one golden moment, he'd been sure he was about to hear the word *love.*

Katsuki… obviously cared about him. Izuku knew it in his bones, could feel it in every interaction they had. Was it love? He was waiting on Katsuki to confirm it, but maybe there was a tiny part of Izuku that still expected to never hear it.

Bakugou Katsuki in love with Midoriya Izuku? *More likely than you think* , supplied the meme-infested side of his brain. It just seemed cosmically impossible. Too good to be true.

Izuku sighed massively, feeling disappointed with himself. He knew how *he* felt, and yet had been too cowardly to say it. Maybe Katsuki did still intimidate him, just a little.

“I *really* like you,” Izuku finally said, feeling like a coward. Katsuki wrinkled his nose at him.

“Yeah, yeah, you sappy nerd. Be careful today, okay?”

“Kay, mom,” Izuku said, and scurried out of bed before Katsuki could retaliate. As it was, he could hear Katsuki’s vaguely worded threats all the way in the bathroom.

And he was technically very careful on his patrols, even if most of his headspace was dedicated to what it would feel like to see Katsuki’s lips shape the word *love.*

“Deku, Ei’s coming over! You should shower!”

Izuku blurrily opened his eyes. It was… the evening? He’d been napping, he realized, curled up in Katsuki’s bed. He often spent evenings like that, especially after working the ass-early shift. Usually, Katsuki would cook something while he slept, and then kick him out of bed when it was ready. It was great.

Today was different though, because Katsuki wasn’t tackling him. Why was he shouting again?

“Deku!” Another drawn out shout. He must be shouting from the kitchen, and was apparently in the middle making something that smelled really, really good, enough that Izuku could smell the sauteed onions all the way in the bedroom. God, Katsuki was the perfect man. Izuku yawned, making no move to get up.

“Get your ass out of bed! You’re gross and guests are coming over!”

Almost the perfect man. Izuku could suddenly think of improvements. With a groan, Izuku dragged himself into the shower, and enjoyed the burn of scalding water on his skin. He could hear the muffled sounds of voices as Katsuki shouted something, and Kirishima shouted something right back. Joyful shouting, to be precise. With a lurch, Izuku recognized Kaminari’s voice. He was out of the shower and dressed in moments, barrelling into the kitchen.

He drew up short, stopped by the sight of Katsuki bear-hugging Kaminari, nearly lifting him off the ground. Kirishima hovered nearby, looking worried.

“Bro, he just got out yesterday, be careful!”

“I’m fine!” Kaminari squeaked, looking happy. “Dr. Tinubu was amazing! I feel amazing!”

Katsuki gently set him back down, throwing a glance towards Izuku. “She was really good. I think my arms are actually *better* than before. Apparently she can even reverse past complications from too much quirk healing.”

“I wish she’d let me ask her more questions,” Izuku muttered, but was quickly overwhelmed by both Kirishima and Kaminari descending on him.

“Dude, that fight was nuts,” Kaminari said, draping himself over Izuku’s shoulders right before Kirishima managed to wrap his arms around both of them, squishing them all together in a giant hug. “I’m so glad you guys were okay! I was worried!”

“You saved our sorry asses,” Katsuki said, watching their antics approvingly, specifically because they were climbing on someone that wasn’t him. Izuku was more than happy to take the fall, and embraced his friends.

“Yeah, that was really badass,” Izuku told Kaminari, who was hanging off of Izuku’s neck. “What was it like absorbing her quirk? Did it feel different from your electricity? Can you tell electricity apart by its origin? Did you-” he caught himself and took a deep breath. “When you’re recovered, I’d love to talk to you about it.”

“Sure, sure,” Kaminari said easily, finally releasing Izuku after a failed attempt to ruffle his wet hair and a subsequent disgusted look at how damp it still was. “I’m gonna back in action any day now! I’m like, super popular now.”

“Yeah babe,” Kirishima said, pulling Kaminari against his chest. “Right after you follow the recovery instructions to the letter.” *Babe?* Izuku stared. Had they finally started dating? He remembered that night in the club, and how close they’d seemed. Maybe they’d been dating already?

“But Ei,” Kaminari whined, “I feel fine. I’m lightning in a bottle, baby... or however that song goes.”

“I think it’s genie in a bottle,” Kirishima said, pressing a kiss onto his head. “See, you still need to recover if you’re messing up Christina Aguilera.”

“I think he’s always been that dumb,” Katsuki offered, completely unphased by the familiar way Kirishima was kissing Kaminari. Izuku’s jaw was currently collecting dust on the kitchen floor (or it would be if Katsuki would ever let dust build up.)

“Uh,” Izuku said. Kirishim and Kaminari blinked at him, then Kaminari jabbed Kirishima in the stomach.

“We still gotta tell him! We talked about this, remember?”

“Yeah,” Kirishima blushed. “It’s uh, still not that easy.”

“It’s gonna be fine.” Surprisingly, that was from Katsuki. His gaze was trained on Kirishima, a slight frown on his face. Izuku realized suddenly that he was really out of the loop on something.

“We’re together,” Kirishima finally said, and Kaminari laced their fingers together.

“Congratulations?” It came out like a question, because Izuku didn't understand what was going on. It should be exciting, but Kirishima sounded *guilty.* Still though, Izuku couldn’t see how this wasn’t a great thing. “I’m really happy for you guys!”

“We’ve *been* in a relationship,” Kaminari clarified, blushing a little. Katsuki snorted.

“For how long again?” Katsuki’s voice was sly, drenched in satisfaction that the truth was finally coming out.

“Uh,” Kirishima looked a little shame-faced. “Six years.”

Izuku’s jaw was back on the floor. *“Years?* So wait - this whole time, everyone’s been wondering when you’d get together and-”

“We were together,” Kaminari said, flashing them with his signature cocky grin, “Ei-babe was shy about telling people, so we just kept it on the DL.”

“You guys weren’t fucking subtle,” Katsuki snorted. “You swear me to secrecy then make out in every damn bathroom in the city.”

“A man has needs,” Kirishima said weakly. Katsuki just laughed, and turned back to poke at the in-progress omelets.

“Uh-huh. I’m just glad I don’t have to cover for your sorry pervert asses anymore.”

“You knew,” Izuku said, staring at him.

“God, I walked in on *so* much shit back in the day,” Katsuki sighed, pulling a world-weary face.

“Sorry bro!” Kirishima didn’t sound sorry at all. He turned back to Izuku with an apologetic smile. “Anyway, I wanted to tell you because of what happened after the Striker thing,” he trailed off, looking guilty again. When he spoke again, it was with quiet intensity. “I know Katsuki was covering for me with the press back then, ‘cause I couldn’t hide what I felt for Denki when I saw him like that and Kats didn’t want us to be outed like that.”

“It’s not your fault, Ei,” Katsuki said gruffly. It was a little uncomfortable to be reminded of their recent problems, but Izuku’s heart ached at the shuttered expression on Katsuki’s face. So Izuku went over to him, forcibly tucking himself under Katsuki’s arm. Katsuki gave him a brief, grateful smile.

“Yeah, that woman was awful. Heard she got fired, though!” Kirishima grinned sharply. “Anyway, I felt super bad for putting you in a tough spot because I was too scared to face the world. It’s not very manly of me…”

“Hey, don’t say that,” Kaminari said quickly. “Remember, we talked about this. You don’t owe anyone your personal life! I never minded Ei, you know that.”

“Anyway,” Kirishima squared his shoulders, “We’re going public.”

“Just do a better job than I did,” Katsuki snorted. “Shouldn’t be hard.”

Izuku might have been annoyed at the flippant way Katsuki was talking about something painful, but Katsuki’s hand was rubbing comforting circles into his side. He obviously didn’t mean to be hurtful. Izuku also couldn’t fault that way his words managed to make Kirishim look a little more relieved.

“Yeah, we’re gonna look so cool and mature after what you did,” Kaminari stuck his tongue out. Izuku snorted so hard it hurt.

“The bar is set pretty low,” Izuku added, nudging Katsuki.

“Fuck off,” Katsuki said mildly. “You guys’ll be great. And I’ll murder the shit out of anyone who gives you crap, okay?”

“Thanks bro,” Kirishima said, wiping away a tear. “But homicide is unmanly.”

“Then I will be unmanly,” Katsuki said, with a decisive nod. “Now quit whining or I’ll make the food too spicy for you weak fuckers.”

“You wouldn’t!” Kaminari whined, striking a wounded pose.

“I would, and you know it.”

But Katsuki didn’t end up making the food too spicy, because he was obviously soft on everyone present. And Izuku didn’t fail to notice how Kaminari *did* end up with a suspiciously large amount of meat in his serving. Katsuki always had ways of showing he cared, after all, if you knew where to look. Watching Katsuki mother-hen his friends was undeniably heartwarming, and Izuku was once again overcome with just how much he adored this man.

“So, you knew all along?” Izuku was helping Katsuki with the dishes. Kirishima and Kaminari had left earlier, apparently to hype Kirishima up for another meeting with their publicists.

“Yeah,” Katsuki said, looking down. “I was the first person Kirishima came out to, actually. Kinda on accident, but yeah. His folks are really… really old school. Nice in a lot of ways, but made Ei super scared of talking about that kind of thing. It’s really shitty to have that kind of problem nowadays.”

“Mhm,” Izuku hummed. “You’re a good friend.”

“Eh, I just wasn’t a huge asshole about *one* thing,” he shrugged. Izuku put away another plate, and tried not to let it get to him. He hated to feel jealous, and he knew their situations were different but still, *he’d* always wanted that kind of friendship with Katsuki. He’d always wondered why Kirishima was good enough to be Katsuki’s friend, but Izuku hadn’t been. He swallowed hard, shoving the thoughts down.

Katsuki obviously adored him now. That’s all that should matter. He was reaching up to put away a glass when soapy hands wrapped around his waist.

“Nerd,” Katsuki grumbled, “I can hear your shitty thoughts again. What’s eating you?”

“It’s dumb,” Izuku protested, not wanting to admit to even more of his insecurities. Katsuki leaned in, lips brushing his neck.

“It probably is,” Katsuki hummed agreeably. “But I wanna hear your dumb thoughts.”

Oh, that was pretty nice. Izuku felt the tension suddenly leave him, and he relaxed back against Katsuki’s chest. “That’s better,” Katsuki murmured. “Now spill.”

“I guess I just get a little jealous,” Izuku admitted, turning around in Katsuki’s arms. “I know I shouldn’t, but *I* wanted to be your friend all that time. Kinda hurts that Kirishima got to be, and I don’t know… it feels like you kinda put him before me back then, and yeah.” The words came out awkwardly. Izuku was reluctant to bring this kind of thing up. He was torn between wanting to be honest about his insecurities, and wanting to avoid bringing up the past for no reason.

“Deku,” Katsuki said slowly. “I get what you mean, but Ei’s been my best friend for almost a decade. He’s always going to be important to me.”

“And that’s a good thing,” Izuku said quickly, hiding his face. Even if he knew Katsuki cared about him, it was hard to ask for more. “I just want to be put first, too. I mean, we’re together now, and everything. You didn’t even tell me why you were so protective of him back then.”

He could feel Katsuki’s hum in his chest. “It wasn’t my place to say,” Katsuki said eventually. He was clearly choosing his words carefully. “I couldn’t think of the right thing to say in the moment, and you’re right. I threw us both under the bus, because I felt like Ei was too vulnerable and I couldn’t just let it happen.”

“Yeah,” Izuku said, quietly.

“You and I have a long history, but we’ve only been together a few months,” Katsuki said. “And we weren’t really close since we were kids. My friends are important too.”

“I wanted to be your friend that whole time,” Izuku whispered, his throat raspy. Katsuki sighed.

“Honestly Deku? I don’t think it would have been good for us.” Izuku looked up at him, surprised. Katsuki stared down at him, completely serious. “It took me a long time to face my issues. I’m glad that I had time to face my shit before getting close to you again.”

“Sometimes I get caught up in thinking about what if we’d gotten together sooner,” he admitted. Katsuki kissed him on the forehead.

“I’d have driven you off by being a huge dick, probably. This way is better, ‘cause now I’m smart enough to keep you around.”

“I don’t know, you’re still pretty stupid,” Izuku smiled, sly and ready to let things lighten up. Katsuki didn’t take the bait, though.

“Hey, Izuku, you know you’re a priority for me, right? I do get what you were saying. It’s just been a long time since I’ve been in a real relationship, and I’m still figuring out what that all means. I honestly don’t think there will be many more situations like this, but I never wanna make you feel like you’re not important to me.”

“Kacchan,” Izuku trailed off, touched by his sincerity.

“I’m sorry I made you feel like you didn’t come first, baby,” Katsuki said, his voice low and soft. Izuku’s heart lurched with affection.

“It’s okay,” he said. “I guess I’m still getting used to this, too. I know you meant well.”

“You’re too nice,” Katsuki grinned, looking suspiciously mischievous. “You should be harder on me.”

“Harder?” Izuku purred, catching on immediately. He ran his hands up Katsuki’s chest, lingering over his pecs. “Exactly how hard should I be?”

Katsuki’s eyes drifted down as he made a pleased hum. Then he leaned in, rolling his hips against Izuku. “How bout I demonstrate, hm?”

Izuku was very happy with that idea.

Kirishima and Kaminari made a joint press release in the following week. It went over magnificently, and everyone who’d made bets lost a significant amount of money (except for Katsuki). Still, there were plenty of celebrations, and Kirishima was buoyed up by the somewhat aggressive support of all of their friends.

Thankfully, it was only a few more weeks until Katsuki was allowed back on patrol. By that time Izuku was already in the field and dealing with the attention that came from being in the top ten. Katsuki was notably less clingy once he was back at work, and while it was nice to have some space… Izuku couldn’t deny he missed it a bit.

But it was a little disingenuous to say that, because it wasn’t like Katsuki wasn’t still lavishing him with attention. Izuku had somewhat reluctantly moved back into his own apartment once his door was fixed, but still found himself spending the night with Katsuki half the time.

Maybe they could get a two-bedroom? Just to have a little extra space.

Izuku wondered briefly if Katsuki would think he was moving too fast, before realizing that even if he was, Katsuki wouldn't be bothered. Izuku came to the strange conclusion that he wasn't actually afraid to fuck up anymore. He could trust Katsuki to tell him if someone was pushing his boundaries, and then they'd fix it together.

It was relaxing, really. Izuku couldn't remember the last time he'd felt this secure in a relationship. He'd always struggled with anxiety in his past relationship, but Katsuki had a special way with words that seemed to slam the door shut on Izuku's baseless fears-even if that method included a consistently large amount of cursing.

He even made time to visit All Might at his house. It was an hour or two out of the city, but All Might claimed he liked the peace and quiet of the suburbs. Something about having constant problem children at UA, and absence making the heart fonder. Apparently Izuku and Katsuki weren't the last troublemakers UA saw by far.

It was really, really nice to see him, and Izuku felt faintly guilty about not visiting more often. Still, All Might was clearly happy to listen while Izuku told him about everything that happened, his fears about not dedicating enough of himself to being a hero, how Katsuki didn't want him to die earlier and somehow everything came pouring out.

Izuku was crying over his cup of tea, All Might watching him patiently. When Izuku finally calmed down enough, he looked up to see All Might beaming at him.

"Young Midoriya, this is wonderful news! I have to say, when I said you and young Bakugou would make good partners, I didn't quite expect this!"

"Heh, I guess it was kind of surprising," Izuku said, with a wet, awkward laugh. All Might winked.

"Not *that* surprising. I always thought he watched you very closely. Very *closely*," he said again, drawing the last words out. Izuku blushed bright red.

"Um! I'm sure it wasn't like that!" He protested automatically—even if he knew it was exactly like that, he really didn't need All Might noticing those kinds of things. All Might just laughed loudly, slapping the table.

"I may be old, but I'm not blind!"

"All Might!"

"Okay, okay," All Might subsided, still smiling. "Well, I never had long-term relationships, as I'm sure you know." He said it with just enough implication to nod at Izuku's irrepressible fan-boyness. "I regret that, now. Sometimes I wonder if I had someone to come home to, if I would have…" he trailed off, looking thoughtful.

“Well,” he went on, waving a hand to dispel the thought, “It’s not bad to have someone who makes you want to stay safe! And young Bakugou is so strong… I always worried whoever I was with would be used against me, but I believe it would be very troublesome to try and use Bakugou against anyone. He’s always been very headstrong.”

“Yeah,” Izuku laughed nervously. “So, um…”

“So!” All Might said, clapping his hands together, “You came here for a reason! You want to know if I think it’s okay not to dedicate your life to being the next Symbol of Peace, don’t you?”

“I’m not saying I’m not going to,” Izuku said quickly, but All Might cut him off.

“Young Midoriya, I gave this power to you for a reason. It is yours to do with as you see fit. You do not have to follow my path. I don’t want you to. I want you to follow your own path, Midoriya. You are an excellent young man, and I trust your judgement.”

“All Might,” Izuku said weakly, tears springing to his eyes.

“You don’t need my permission for this,” All Might went on. “But you have it anyway. And nothing would make me happier than knowing you lived a long life alongside someone you love.”

“All Might,” Izuku said again, this time blubbering. The tears were really flowing, twin rivers running down his cheeks. All Might took the chance to top off Izuku’s tea, relatively unaffected thanks to years of exposure to Izuku’s impulse-sobbing. Izuku tried to calm himself, watching the steam curl and twist in the air between them. “Is it really okay?” He hiccuped.

“Yes, really,” All Might nodded decisively. “I’m glad you came to me with this. I always wanted to talk to you about this, really. I wonder if I failed you students, sometimes. Hero life chewed me up and spit me out-” he raised skinny arms, showing his skeletal form “-and I wanted better for all of you.”

Izuku wiped at the tears in his eyes, feeling strangely seen. Validated, once again, by his personal hero. All Might have him a sad smile.

“People like us… it’s hard for others to be in our lives. Don’t take what you have for granted.” There was a certain wistfulness to his tone, and Izuku wondered suddenly if All Might had done just that, at one point. “Bakugou is a, well, an excitable young man. But sometimes I think we need people like that. Someone bright enough, strong enough that even when you feel like you bear the weight of the world, they make you feel like you can set it down for a moment and rest.” All Might stopped, and cleared his throat uncomfortably.

“Sorry, excuse the ramblings of a sentimental old man. I just want you to be as happy and safe as you can be, young Midoriya. Just take care of Bakugou, and let him take care of you. And if I can ever help, you know where to find me.”

Izuku nodded, wordless and overcome with emotion. All Might took pity on him and changed the subject, rambling on about his current batch of students at UA while Izuku mastered his emotions. And when he left, he gave his mentor the biggest hug, nearly lifting him off the ground.

It was a while before Izuku was ready to make an actual statement about the entire Striker incident to the press. All agencies involved, including Izuku's, already released their respective statements. Izuku's agency had done a good job explaining his actions, but it was still expected for individual heroes to have opinions, and Izuku had been in the center of the action. Seeing as he was finally back in action, he really didn't have an excuse to put it off any longer. And besides, this statement was more of a PR opportunity.

Neither he nor Katsuki had made any further statements to the press about their relationship, and things were getting a little out of hand. According to their staff, a measured, reasonable statement of facts would help - if only to provide *some* frame of reference for the wild rumors that were flying around. One article had even hypothesized they were *twins* .

Anyway, Suika had spent several meetings coaching Izuku, talking about the kinds of questions to expect, the ones they'd approved beforehand, and the ways he could be blindsided. Izuku still felt dwarfed by the flashing lights of his headquarter's conference room.

It was strange how he'd face down villains without hesitation, but the second cameras were in his face he was nervously sweating like a highschooler again. Still, he managed to make himself stand in a relaxed, open pose while he answered question after question about the fight with Striker, explaining his actions and those of his team.

Why were there only three heroes teaming up against Striker?

What motivated Deku to keep going against all odds in the rescue work?

How did his recovery go?

What were his thoughts on Ground Zero's solution to the Striker issue?

What did Deku think about the use of lethal force as a pro hero?

Did he think the Striker Taskforce was well prepared?

What could the city do to handle a situation like this better in the future?

Izuku had answers to all of these questions. This type of thing was pretty much the norm in post-disaster hero life, and he was feeling pretty good about it.

That lasted right up until they started asking about his relationship. Izuku refrained from telling them to rudely leave, because he was all too aware this was being streamed live. He wasn't going to pull a Bakugou, after all. He was determined to represent himself well.

“So, we hear you are in a relationship with Ground Zero, can you confirm this?”

“We have released a statement already,” Izuku said calmly. It had been two short sentences sent out by Bakugou’s agency, and had not satisfied *anyone’s* curiosity. Even Izuku’s friends were hounding him for details. Izuku took a deep breath and said, “We are in a relationship, and have no plans to publicly discuss it.”

“Still, doesn’t the public have a right to know? Will your relationship affect your hero work?”

These questions would normally be off limits, but Suika had explained there was no getting past this. Sometimes, it was just better to get it over with and out there. Hopefully, if Izuku addressed enough things now, it would take away momentum from the rabid speculation that half the city seemed to be indulging in.

“Neither my nor Ground Zero’s work will not be affected by our relationship,” Izuku said, resisting the urge to fold his arms like a cross schoolteacher. “We are perfectly capable of handling our careers and personal lives. If anything, it’s easier because we understand what it’s like to balance your personal life with a hero career.”

“Yes, yes,” said another woman, “that sounds very nice, and you seem to be doing very well! We were all very impressed by your post-disaster work Deku, thank you very much.”

“I am always grateful for the chance to serve our citizens,” Izuku nodded, happy with the change of subject. That happiness lasted right up until she added,

“But Ground Zero seems to be as volatile as ever. He certainly flew off the rails during the Striker Incident. It will take a long time to repair the damage he caused!”

“The damage done by allowing Striker to continue terrorizing the city would have been significantly worse,” Izuku said sternly. “It was a difficult decision, and he had to make it in a split second.”

“Do you condone lethal force?”

“I trust Ground Zero’s decision-making ability,” Izuku said instead, because he absolutely did not condone it. But in this case? Even he couldn’t see another way out, not without letting Striker become an even bigger problem. “I believe he took the only available course of action.”

“And what about his rather surprising outburst afterward? I think we were all quite surprised to hear that.”

Izuku reigned in his temper. “It was a difficult situation. Everyone was trying their best. I believe I’ve made my opinion clear on this, already. Those questions were invasive and unprofessional. Kacchan dealt with it as best as he could.” Damn, Izuku had to stop making that mistake, but he was losing his temper and that made it hard to think before he spoke… and he really could understand how Katsuki had flown off the rails. Hearing people talk about Katsuki like this was *infuriating*.

“Ah, we wanted to know… Kacchan?”

“It’s the nickname I’ve always used for him,” Izuku said, making himself smile. “As you know, we’ve known each other for a long time.”

“It seems a little out of character for Ground Zero. Does he really let people call him that?”

“He lets me. You are welcome to try,” Izuku laughed. “But I can’t promise it will go well.”

“Well, we wouldn’t want another outburst,” the reporter said smugly, instantly snuffing out Izuku’s good mood. “Everyone was quite surprised to hear such… explicit details about your relationship. Do you think it was appropriate to share that on live television, Deku? It must have been quite surprising for you, unless you actually *want* him to talk about you like that.”

“I will not answer this kind of question,” Izuku said from between clenched teeth.

“I mean, you have to have an opinion. It was certainly surprising to hear about what kind of things the hero Deku gets up to! And Ground Zero is a surprising choice for you, I have to say.”

Some of the reporters exchanged uneasy glances. Izuku clenched his fists. Suika had said to put everything to rest so… “We are adults in a happy relationship, and our sex life is part of that. I have no intention to discuss our private lives with the press, however. All I will say is that I am very happy with him, and I love and support him no matter what. Now, does anyone else have any questions they’d like to ask? About actual hero work?”

Izuku left the interview feeling completely exhausted. He’d deflected countless more questions about him and Katsuki’s relationship, but ultimately he thought it was successful. The interview was being broadcasted with only a slight delay, a concession made by the media company as an apology for the unprofessional behavior by others in their field.

Izuku made it all the way out of the building and onto the street before he got a call from Katsuki.

It was weird, because Katsuki was on patrol and he usually wouldn’t call unless he was on break. *Especially* now that he was so excited about being back in action. Izuku shrugged, and picked up the phone.

For once, Katsuki had been minding his own blessed business. He was after someone with a lizard quick, and the villain had already regrown several limbs Katsuki had removed via explosion. It was gross. Katsuki was focused, right up until Deku’s interview started playing on every TV on the damn city block.

Katsuki was professional. He was focused, and had finally closed the distance on the villain when he heard it. Deku, looking straight at the camera, unbearably handsome and adorable in his hero costume.

"...I love and support him no matter what."

The word *love* punched Katsuki's heart straight out of his chest. He stumbled over a trash can, flipped through the air and crashed into someone's shitty silver sedan.

"Fuck!" he swore, clutching his shin. But the pain was a distant afterthought to what he'd just heard.

Deku… loved him? Maybe not enough to say so in person, but enough to say it in an interview? Katsuki felt hot all over, his chest unbearably tight. He'd never dreamed—well, he had *dreamed* of this, but Katsuki had never completely felt worthy of it actually happening.

He knew Deku cared about him. Deku was never shy about showing how he felt, but Katsuki felt so fucking blessed to have gotten this far that he couldn't contain it.

"Hey, fuckface!" he shouted at the villain. The villain stopped, turned, and stuck his tongue out at Katsuki. "Did you hear that?"

"What, how you're failing to catch me?" The villain snickered, tongue flicking out. Katsuki picked himself up off the ground, and brushed himself off.

"My fucking boyfriend loves me!" Just saying the words out loud had him brimming with happiness. The villain stared at him.

"Uh-"

"This is the best damn day of my life," Katsuki shouted, advancing on the villain. "I gotta call my boyfriend and tell him he's stupid, so I'm gonna need you to just give up now."

The villain gave him a very skeptical look, and took off running. Katsuki cursed, whipped out his phone, and called Deku. He had his priorities, after all. Katsuki took off after the villain, the phone's dial tone ringing in his ears. This was why he'd added comm units to his ear protection, right? Right?

"Hi, Kacchan! I just finished the interview!" Deku's cheerful voice came through the phone line.

"HEY DEKU," Katsuki roared. The villain flinched so hard from the sudden shout that he smacked into a store sign and went flying, tumbling out of control.

"Uh, what's up?" Deku said hesitantly. Katsuki barrelled forward, taking advantage of the villain's fuck up to close the distance.

"Die, you scaly fuck!" He shouted, slamming an explosion into the side of its head. The villain tried to dodge, but Katsuki was fast as hell and another perfectly-timed explosion sent the villain flying.

“Um, Kacchan…”

Shit, right. “Deku!” Katsuki roared again, storming over to the villain. “You *love* and support me?”

Silence, over the phone. Katsuki flipped the villain over, and snapped on a pair of cuffs.

“Oh, uh—”

“Yeah, dumbass. Don’t think I didn’t hear you saying you love and support me?! Deku, do you, do you-” Katsuki’s voice suddenly broke. “Do you love me?” he whispered, strong-arming the villain to his feet.

The villain’s golden eyes blinked up at him. “I don’t love you,” he hissed, clearly furious about being caught. Too bad Katuski didn’t care.

“Not you,” Katsuki growled, pushing the villain down the street before him. The closest precinct wasn’t too far from here, thankfully.

“Um, Kacchan, are you with someone else right now?”

“Yes, you idiot!” Katsuki shouted. “I’m catching a villain, and—”

“Um! Shouldn’t you focus on that?!” Deku laughed nervously.

“How can I, when my dumbfuck boyfriend says he loves me on live TV?!”

“Kacchan,” Deku trailed off. Katsuki's heart was climbing out of his throat, too big to be contained in his body any longer.

“I love you too!” Katsuki shouted. The villain sighed dramatically, but now that he was cuffed Katsuki really wasn’t paying attention to him anymore. His phone was clutched in one gloved hand, and he was seriously fighting tears welling up in his eyes.

“Sorry, I, it just kind of slipped out,” Deku said. He sounded like he was crying, which would just be typical. Damn, Katsuki loved him so much. If Deku hadn’t meant to say it, Katsuki didn’t want to push him.

“Well,” Katsuki said, his voice gruff with emotion, “It’s fine if you’re not ready to say it, Deks. But I meant it. I’m, uh—” he swallowed hard, “—in love with you. So now you know.”

There was a long moment of silence, interrupted only by sniffling sounds. “Kacchan, really? You really love me?”

“Of course, baby,” Katsuki said gruffly. “I mean what I say, damn it.”

“I meant it too.” Deku’s voice was small, but filled Katsuki with warmth. “I, um, well.” His voice got even quieter. The villain was making some kind of noise, and Katsuki briefly shook him to shut him up. He needed to hear this.

“I love you, Kacchan,” Deku whispered. Katsuki’s knees felt weak. He felt like he was going to crawl out of his skin, like his body couldn’t possibly contain the magnitude of what he felt in that moment.

“Fuck, Deku, I’m really fucking happy,” Katsuki rasped. “Look, let me hand in the villain and I’ll come find you. I really wanna see you right now, okay?”

“But your patrol?” Deku said, like the nerd he was.

“Fuck my patrol! Onito can cover, he owes me. Now where the hell are you?”

“Heading to my place,” Deku said, finally sounding a little more alive.

“I’ll be there in thirty,” Katsuki promised.

Chapter End Notes

Good news everyone! I’m back on my “Katsuki calls people ‘baby’” bullshit, so I hope you enjoyed it! Tbh Katsuki's kind of a hot mess at the end of this, but if you've read "I'm Kissing You, Nerd" you know he's only been waiting for this for like 7 years or something so I don't blame him <3 he's just happy <3

I said on twitter this would be the last chapter, and I was quite honestly planning to have this chapter be like 10k words and call it a day. Then I got to this point, and felt like it was a really nice place to pause SO we will have one more chapter after this!

I am both sad to close out this story, and very excited to see it to its finish!

Black Lives Matter Resources

The First Step of Many

Chapter Summary

Izuku is a man on a mission, and that mission is Katsuki's [redacted]. Katsuki gives Izuku some papers.

Chapter Notes

Content Disclaimers:
-Light Exhibitionism - We get a new tag for semi-public sex acts! Look no one sees anything but I can't promise no one hears anything
-I added a "degradation kink" tag bc I think Bakugou's dirty talk is pretty much in the "degradation zone" now! Hooray! However, the dirty talk in this chapter is not at all any worse/dirtier than what you've already read, don't worry. I just wanted to be careful w/ my tagging <3
-This is probs covered in the "rough sex" tag but here's specific warnings: dirty talk / throat-fucking
-Hope you guys weren't expecting me to end this fic with anything but gratuitous fluff and smut haha

Any resemblance between McDonald's and DcMonald's is purely coincidental and I'm fucking stupid and therefore not responsible for anything. :^)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Six Months After Striker, Tamari Group Breaks Ground on Mall Expansion

The headline sat bold across the front of Katsuki's newspaper. He and Katsuki were at a cafe, getting coffee because neither of them had slept much the night before. The remains of a scone were scattered across a delicate plate.

"You see about the mall thing?" Izuku asked, trying to catch Katsuki's eye.

"Took 'em long enough," Katsuki grumbled. He shook the newspaper vigorously, in an attempt to straighten the pages that spectacularly failed. He sighed explosively and tossed the paper on the table. "They're making a statue, did you hear?"

“I bet Kaminari’s happy about it,” Izuku said, reaching over to steal Katsuki’s coffee. “He’s always wanted a statue. He says it’s too short, though.”

“Don’t listen to his bitching, I bet he’s shitting himself with joy,” Katsuki snorted, “and don’t drink that, you’ll be up all night again.”

Izuku pouted, and pulled the coffee towards him. “You like it when I’m up all night.”

“I’m sore, leave me alone,” Katsuki pouted and pulled the coffee back across the table. Izuku made grabby hands, but Katsuki just scowled at him.

Not to be weird about it, but Izuku *had* been tracking exactly how susceptible Katsuki was to his puppy eyes, and there had been a definite downwards trend over time. There were even graphs proving it in some of Izuku’s journals. Maybe it was time to get some more data points, because Katsuki developing an immunity to puppy eyes was frankly unacceptable.

“But Kacchan, we can always do something else,” Izuku said slowly, emphasizing the *else* with a flutter of his eyelashes. Hand on chin, head tipped down, eyes wide. The works.

“We have plans tonight,” Katsuki told him flatly, and looked somewhere off to the side. Ah, the classic evasive maneuver. Izuku leaned back into his field of vision, heroically keeping up his pose.

“But Kacchan, we finally took a day off at the same time. We should put it to good use.”

Katsuki’s head jerked around to face Izuku. With a scowl, he yanked the neck of his shirt down to reveal a cluster of hickeys on his chest, creeping up over his collarbone and partway up his neck, where they were mostly hidden by concealer. Fine, maybe Izuku had gotten a little carried away.

“I had to pick a new outfit for the damn rehearsal dinner, *again* , just to cover up this crap!” Katsuki smiled. It was one of his fake smiles, brimming irritation. Katsuki had wanted to wear some low-cut designer top, and *that* had already been a second choice. Izuku waved a careless hand.

“Not my fault Kaminari vetoed your weird skull button-up, Kacchan.” Izuku had seen it. It also had skeletal hands holding up middle fingers, and apparently Kaminari was concerned about offending Kirishima’s parents. Izuku couldn’t blame him, but Katsuki was less forgiving.

“It’s *fashion!”* Katsuki protested, letting go of his shirt. “If you put any more damn hickeys on me I’ll need to take a bath in concealer and wear a fucking ski mask!”

“I—”

“There’s one on my cheek, Deku,” Katsuki went on, jabbing a finger into his cheek. “My *cheek* . What the fuck were you doing last night? If I have to hear you bitch *one* more time about how long I take to get ready after I’ve spent a damn hour trying to cover up *your* mess, I swear to god I’m never touching you unless you’re wearing a fucking dog cone thing.”

“Dog cone thing?” Izuku was cracking up, and Katsuki sipped his coffee in the way he always did if he was trying to hide a smile. “That doesn’t sound hot, Kacchan.”

“Neither is looking like a fucking dalmatian. Deku.”

“We have three hours before the dinner starts,” Izuku said, pouting again. Katsuki’s eyes flicked away from his face and back out the cafe window. “Look at me.”

“Don’t think I haven’t noticed your goddamn weaponized pouting, you little asshole,” Katsuki scoffed, but there was a smile pulling at his lips. “Come on baby, you know we don’t have time.”

“We were supposed to do fun stuff together today.”

“Deku, we got out of bed at one in the afternoon. Why was that?”

Izuku hated it when Katsuki made sense. “We went to bed late,” he mumbled, glaring at Katsuki’s profile. Even in the afternoon light, the sharp planes of his face cast shadows. Izuku found himself particularly interested in the shadows dripping down Katsuki’s neck, how they pooled by his collarbone, his strong shoulders…

“How late?” Katsuki asked flatly.

“5 AM.”

“And why were we up at 5 in the fucking morning, Deku?”

“You know why,” Izuku grumbled, and took Katsuki’s refusal to look at him as an opportunity to steal his coffee again.

“Because *someone* had a lot of caffeine yesterday and would not stop *fucking* me,” Katsuki proclaimed, a little too loudly. The couple the next table over gave them dirty looks, and Katsuki flipped them off. Izuku flipped them off too, because Katsuki was a bad influence and also got this weird affectionate look whenever Izuku was rude. And true to form, he was finally looking at Izuku with a soft little smile on his mouth. “After their party, okay?”

“You’re so good to me, Kacchan,” Izuku smiled, and made a mental note that flipping off strangers seemed to work better than puppy eyes. Maybe he needed to rotate his tactics to preserve their effectiveness and prevent Katsuki from having a chance to build up immunity.

“You’re plotting,” Katsuki said, “quit it. We’re gonna finish our breakfast—lunch, whatever, go home and get ready, then be extremely well-behaved guests for Ei’s rehearsal dinner.”

“And afterward?” Izuku drew the words out, unable to keep the smirk off his face.

Katsuki leaned across the table, grabbed his chin, and said, “Then it’s payback time.”

Izuku was not particularly drunk, even after two flutes of champagne. He *was* drunk enough to be groping Katsuki's ass maybe slightly more than he should, but those dress pants were flattering and it was rare to see Katsuki in formal wear.

Maybe more of their friends should get married, and then Izuku can spend more time ogling Katsuki.

Sometimes it's still hard to believe they're actually together. Moments like this remind him of how incredible it is—that the man over by the catering table is *his* boyfriend. Izuku's gaze traced the perfectly tailored lines of his suit, his eternally messy blond hair, the way his suit jacket betrayed his muscles when he crossed his arms. He looked like he was sulking about something on the catering table, which honestly wasn't surprising.

Kirishima had asked Izuku to keep Katsuki away from the food, but was dragged away before explaining why. Despite his promise Izuku had declined to run interference, mostly because he wanted to see what would happen when Katsuki found out that Kirishima and Kaminari had included DcMonald's in their catering options.

The answer was, apparently, that Katsuki would sulk like a toddler. Izuku was endlessly entertained. Katsuki lasted for about ten minutes, gradually growing redder and redder with rage, before he stalked over to Kirishima and said something like,

"How could you do this to me I thought we were friends and we *talked* about this I did food tastings for you and was *nice* and there's DcNuggets here!" Katsuki was clearly trying to keep his voice down, and was only moderately successful. Izuku had followed him over in case he needed to intercede. Or in case he needed to tease Katsuki further, because this was a golden opportunity.

Kaminari was delighted by the whole thing, and held up a fries container and pointed at the yellow D. "It's our colors, *Kacchan!* Red and yellow!"

"Red and yellow is a great color combo," Kirishima added, biting into a Big Mac. Katsuki looked like he was about to retch.

"It is not," he growled. Izuku held up the DcNugget he'd brought over for this specific purpose.

"Want a DcNugget, Kacchan? You get grumpy when you're hungry."

Katsuki stared at him, his face slack with betrayal. "I'm divorcing you." Kirishima gasped so loudly Izuku's throat hurt in sympathy.

"We're not married—" Izuku started to say.

"We can change that," Katsuki said instantly, snatching the nugget out of Izuku's fingers and chucking towards a corner of the room. Kaminari's head turned to follow the DcNugget, Kirishima made some kind of excited wheezing noise, and Izuku was pretty sure his heart stopped beating. They hadn't talked about marriage yet, but maybe Katsuki was already thinking about it?

“Are you saying that—”

“Yes. We’ll get married and then I will *divorce* you for trying to feed me trash, Deku,” Katsuki informed him matter-of-factly.

“Ha,” Izuku said weakly.

“You shouldn’t joke about those things,” Kirishima said, clutching his heart. “I almost passed out, I… where’d Denki go?”

“After the nugget,” Katsuki said tonelessly. “I can’t believe how fucking stupid you all are. If this shit is at your wedding tomorrow I am disowning you.”

“And divorcing me, don’t forget,” Izuku added helpfully. Katsuki growled, then grabbed Izuku and pulled him into a too-tight hug.

“Don’t tempt me, nerd.”

So Izuku proceeded to tempt him again and again throughout the night. Kaminari caught on, and they made a game of attempting to sneak DcNuggets onto Katsiki’s plate during speeches that Kaminari definitely was supposed to be paying attention to.

There was a really lovely slideshow showing all of Kirishima and Kaminari’s memories playing. A lot of them were pictures that most of them had never seen, taken during the years the two had kept their relationship hidden. It would have been more bittersweet if the photos hadn’t been consistently and incredibly stupid.

Kaminari attempting to cut Unbreakable with a chainsaw, sparks flying everywhere, Kirishima cackling? Check.

Kaminari kneeling and holding up a croc like he’s the prince and Kirishima slipping his massive hairy foot into it like he’s Cinderella? Check. “They made me take that,” Katsuki had muttered under his breath. “Fucking miserable being one of the only ones who knew. I’m never doing that shit again, Christ.”

There were countless photos of terrible angled-selfies, plenty of nearly-obscene pictures of them making out, and also more recent ones of them embracing and surrounded by friends. There was some crying, a lot of it done by Izuku himself.

It ended with a video showing how Kaminari had proposed. Apparently, he’d done some really questionable electrical work and shorted out Kirishima’s home gym while he was working out. The clanging of weights signified Kirishima had dropped them in surprise, but that’s just the advantage of being with someone unbreakable. They won’t break when you surprise them in the gym and they fling their weights everywhere.

Then fairy lights flickered on, and revealed Kaminari down on one knee right next to Kirishima and his pile of weights. There was a lot of crying (mostly Kirishima), and then

furious nodding and some really impassioned making out that was suddenly cut off by the video ending conveniently before any clothes came off.

All in all, it was really nice. Izuku honestly did pay attention to most of it, even if five more DcNuggets made it onto Katsuki's plate throughout the slideshow. By the fifth one, Katsuki looked Izuku dead in the eyes, picked it up in his fist, put his hand under the table, and there was a small *boof* and a puff of smoke. Katsuki held up an empty, smoking palm.

"Don't make me set off the fire alarm with motherfucking nugget smoke," Katsuki scowled. Izuku lifted a small bag of the remaining seven nuggets.

"Have you ever thought about making a living as a garbage incinerator?"

"Deku. You do that shit again and next time it'll be your face. *"* Katsuki held up a threatening palm. Izuku plopped his cheek down in his hand and grinned up at Katsuki.

"Oh no, whatever will I do? You know how I hate it when you get all hot and burny." Izuku couldn't be more sarcastic if he tried.

Katsuki sighed, but his thumb betrayed his affection by brushing all over Izuku's cheekbone. "Deku, my love, my incredible boyfriend—"

"Yes?"

"—can you stop being a horny freak for *one fucking dinner,"* Katsuki hissed.

"Fine, but only 'cause you asked so nicely," Izuku conceded, and stole one last kiss before promising to leave Katsuki alone.

They were in a bar now, an afterparty for the rehearsal dinner. Iida was particularly confused about why they needed an afterparty for what was essentially a before-party for Kirishima and Kaminari's wedding. Ochako was still attempting to explain it to him, drunkenly and half in his lap. Iida was doing a very exceptional job of not staring at her cleavage. So well, in fact, that it was perfectly clear he was painfully aware of its proximity.

Izuku shot them both a thumbs up, and hoped for the best for his friends. He couldn't do much more, because Katsuki had gone to get beer for the table and Izuku needed to go bother him.

Izuku intercepted Katsuki at the bar and dropped both elbows down next to Katsuki's arm. He looked up at Katsuki with half-lidded eyes. "So, can I be a horny freak now?"

"You're trying to rile me up again, you little piece of shit," Katsuki said mildly. He seemed to be watching the bartender, who was assembling drinks to bring to the group.

“I would never,” Izuku said, following his gaze. They should be able to sneak away for a couple of minutes, right? It *was* true that their time together was relatively limited thanks to their caseloads and general pro hero fuckery, and Izuku fully intended to take advantage of a rare day off. Even if it meant stealing away when they maybe shouldn’t.

“Hey, can you bring those to the table?” Katsuki was saying. The bartender gave Katsuki a quick affirmative. Katsuki turned to Izuku and looked down at him with a world-weary expression. “I’m gonna head to the bathroom.”

Izuku blinked at him. Katsuki stared back, unmoving.

Then Katsuki groaned, rubbing his face with a hand. “Fuck, I mean we should *both* go.”

“I don’t need to—”

“Deku, you dumbass, pull your brain cell out of your dick and figure out that I’m trying to get you *alone* , in a *private space,* to do—”

“Oh, I get it,” Izuku said happily, and instantly speed-walking down the hallway and towards the bar’s bathroom before Katsuki could get another word out.

Should they do this?

Maybe not, but Izuku was learning to lighten up about certain things. Their lives were still high-octane adrenaline-fests, and being Iida-strict about everything wasn’t always for the best. Sure, Izuku wasn’t going to do anything actually dangerous or detrimental to his career. But was he willing to get nasty with his very attractive boyfriend in this particular bathroom?

Yes, yes he was.

To his dismay, it wasn’t a single-occupancy bathroom. Instead, the door opened to a room with a sink and two bathroom stalls. Not ideal, but Katsuki threw the door open and stormed inside before Izuku had a chance to think better of it.

“Deku,” he growled, the nickname ripping from his throat. Izuku pointed at the door, adopting what Katsuki called his ‘baby deer’ expression.

“It doesn’t lock,” Izuku pouted. He could see the irritation ripple across Katsuki’s face, but he also knew that for Katsuki, irritation and arousal often went hand in hand. It made him *so* easy to torment. Izuku fluttered his eyelashes. “Whatever will we do?”

Katsuki rolled his eyes, and locked the door. “These things always lock, dumbass.”

“Oh.”

“Are you fucking disappointed? Did you *want* someone walking in on your exhibitionist ass?”

“That would be inappropriate,” Izuku demurred. Katsuki grabbed his shoulders, spun him around, and slammed him up against the door in the way that Izuku particularly liked. Katsuki leaned in, close enough that Izuku could see the points of his canines.

“They’ll have a hard time opening the door when I’ve got you pinned against it.”

“So, not just because you locked it?” Izuku couldn’t help himself, and tried to hide his smirk by looking at the ground. Katsuki grabbed a fistful of his hair and yanked his head backward, forcing Izuku to look up at him. Katsuki was crowding into his space, caging him against the door, every inch of him dripping arrogance and entitlement. “You wanted it like this, didn’t you,” he accused.

Izuku bared his teeth. “Surprised it took you this long, Kacchan.”

“Bitch, you were slacking today,” Katsuki huffed, and briefly smiled. “You’re off your game.” A pause, then he added with intention, *“Slut.”*

Izuku let out a sigh that was almost a moan, and let Katsuki tilt his head to the side. Katsuki didn’t bother with kissing him. Instead, Izuku felt his teeth biting into the crook of his neck. This time, Izuku really did moan.

“There you go, baby,” Katsuki purred, “keep making those noises, and someone’s gonna come in here to check on you.”

Izuku’s next noise was more of a cut-off whine, when Katsuki grabbed his dick suddenly and without warning. “Kacchan, please,” Izuku pleaded, more for show than because he was pleading for anything specific. What he *wanted* was for Katsuki to do whatever the fuck he wanted with Izuku right at that moment.

“Kacchan, please,” Katsuki mocked him, in a fake high-pitched voice. “Please *what?* Make you come in your pants? Finger you in the bathroom? Whatever’s gonna get your slutty ass off fastest, hm? You know people are gonna notice if we’re missing for much longer.”

“Please,” Izuku whimpered. The hold in his hair was starting to hurt in the way he likes best, and pleasure was trickling down his spine in a relatively shameful way.

“Use your big boy words, Deks,” Katsuki growled into his neck, “or you’ll be sucking my cock and nothing else.”

That was… an appealing idea. Izuku’s eyes drifted downwards, and he could feel Katsuki’s hard on pushing against his hip. Katsuki’s eyes tracked where he was looking.

“Damn,” Katsuki groaned, grinding against him, “you want it that bad?”

Maybe it was a little embarrassing, but that was all it took for Izuku to drop down to his knees. He looked up expectantly, waiting impatiently as Katsuki undid his pants and fished his dick out. “Kacchan,” Izuku murmured approvingly, and reached up to wrap a hand around the base of his cock. Katsuki groaned above him, leaning against the door with his forearms, head dropping down to watch Izuku.

“That’s it, baby, make it quick,” he hissed. Izuku knew what that meant. He also knew Katsuki’s body nearly as well as his own by now, so it wasn’t hard to make him come undone. Izuku cupped his balls, and licked a long stripe up the underside of his dick. It was a nice view, because he could see Katsuki’s face twist up in pleasure above him.

But the real secret wasn’t anything particularly special. No, Katsuki just liked it fast and dirty, so Izuku took as much of his cock down his throat as he could before straight-up choking, and moved just enough to tease. Then he pulled away.

With a growl, Katsuki dropped one hand down to grip Izuku’s hair. “Come on, gimme more than that,” he groaned. Izuku looked up at him, letting his tongue poke out obscenely.

Then he said, “Then take what you want, Kacchan. Fuck my throat like you mean it.”

He could *see* the change in Katsuki’s expression, the feral delight he got whenever Izuku gave him permission to be particularly nasty. His grip tightened in Izuku’s hair, and he forced Izuku back onto his dick, starting to fuck his face without preamble.

“Fuck, baby, feels so good,” he groaned, *“shit,* such a little slut for me, fuckin’ love you so much you nasty little fucker—” His words cut off as Izuku tilted his head, letting him thrust back further. Izuku held onto his hips for dear life, and let himself slide into the heady experience of swallowing down Katsuki’s cock.

Katsuki didn’t last long, not once Izuku started tearing up. Katsuki was always weak to that, and Izuku couldn’t try to deny the sense of victory he felt when Katsuki shuddered and spilled down his throat with a broken moan.

Then Katsuki dropped to his knees and tipped Izuku’s chip up. Izuku blinked at him through teary eyes. “Was it good, Kacchan?”

“Real damn good,” he purred, then kissed Izuku deeply. “You’re next, baby. How ‘bout you tell me whatever’s been knocking around in that pervert head of yours?”

Katsuki helped him to his feet and kissed him until Izuku was able to form rational thoughts again. Or he would have, until someone pounded on the door.

“Fuck off!” Katsuki shouted.

“Hurry up!” the voice shouted back.

“Shit,” Katsuki mumbled. Izuku grinned at him.

“You know what this means? Speed run!”

“I—” Katsuki looked like he was about to protest, then shook his head at himself. “Damn it, you’re horrible for my decision making. You better be fucking quiet because my hands are gonna be busy.”

Izuku nodded furiously, demonstrating how quiet he could be. Katsuki kissed him, and wasted no time undoing his pants, yanking them down halfway around his thighs.

He pulled away long enough to put his fingers in front of Izuku's face. "Suck, Deku," he whispered. Izuku obeyed, trying not to groan as Katsuki's warm hand wrapped around his dick.

After blowing Katsuki, he was already a little too sensitive and almost painfully hard. The fingers in his mouth weren't nearly enough to distract him from the feeling of Katsuki's hand jerking him off.

Then Katsuki's hand moved from his mouth, trailing a wet line down his back to his ass.

"Oh *yes,"* Izuku sighed. Katsuki shushed him, then kissed him again, stopping any further sounds from coming from his mouth. It was a good thing, because Katsuki's mouth only slightly muffled the whine Izuku let out when his Katsuki's fingers started to gently press into his ass. Izuku wrapped his arms around Katsuki's shoulders and held on, willing his legs not to give out under the overwhelming sensation of Katsuki's hands and mouth fully devoted to making him come undone.

Izuku forgot about where they were, forgot the mess of paper towels someone had left on the sink, the pervasive smell of *toilet* , and whoever was waiting outside.

There was only Katsuki's teeth on his lip. There was only Katsuki's hand on his cock jerking him off with the precision borne of countless times doing exactly this, there was only the feeling of a fingers up his ass, filling him, forcing him over the edge.

Maybe the knowledge that there were people waiting for the bathroom was turning him on too, as bad as that was—or at the very least, it added to the sense of urgency. Izuku was rocking back and forth against Katsuki's hands, not fighting the building pleasure except for when he tried to swallow his moans.

He pulled away just long enough to gasp, "I'm *close* ." Katsuki gave him a sharp look, then grabbed the hem of Izuku's shirt and pushed it into his mouth.

"Don't wanna get this dirty, Deks," he grinned. The fluorescent shadows made him look a little manic, but in a way that made Izuku's heart pound. Izuku *loved* being with Katsuki like this, loved when he looked so dangerous, loved the feeling of being at his mercy while knowing he was completely safe. Then Katsuki leaned in, his head touching the door next to Izuku's head as he whispered filth into Izuku's ear. "Come on baby, aren't you gonna cum for me? Such a dirty slut, letting me finger you in a public restroom, huh? You like that, don't you?"

Izuku's chest was heaving with effort not to make any sounds above a whisper, and Katsuki was relentless, his hands were merciless and suddenly Izuku was whimpering as he came all over his bare stomach.

Katsuki gave him a quick kiss on the cheek before grabbing paper towels to clean him up. Izuku leaned weakly against the door. The whole thing seemed like slightly less of a great idea now that he wasn't horny, and the amused little smirk on Katsuki's lips told him that he felt the same way.

“Should we have not done that,” Izuku mumbled, after extracting the shirt from his mouth. Katsuki shrugged, apparently satisfied with Izuku’s cleanliness enough to go thoroughly wash his own hands.

“Was hot as fuck, and no one caught us,” Katsuki said, as if that absolved everything.

“Someone’s gonna catch us eventually.”

“Then someone’s gonna catch an explosion to the face.”

“Kacchan, that’s the opposite of how you should—” Izuku shut up as Katsuki opened the door and strolled right out, ignoring Izuku completely. An irritated man was waiting outside, one leg crossed over the other like he really needed to pee.

“Sorry, had to shit,” Katsuki said offhandedly, before sauntering off towards their friends. Izuku speed-walked past the man with his hands over his face and wished he could melt into the floor like Mirio.

They slid back into the booth. Izuku was still a little shame-faced, and tried not to be obvious about looking at the floor. Katsuki entirely failed to look ashamed though. He looked completely cocky sliding into the booth next to Izuku.

“You didn’t,” Mina said, her eyes flicking back and forth between them.

Izuku poured them both a beer. Katsuki grinned like a shark.

“It’s not my fault Deku’s—”

“There’s literally no way you’ll finish that sentence with anything that isn’t revolting,” Ochako cut in, putting a stop to something that probably *would* have been revolting.

“You are a goddess,” Izuku told her, clapping his hands together in thanks.

“She is,” Iida said, then snapped his mouth shut. Izuku exchanged significant looks with pretty much everyone at the table except Katsuki, who’s still looking cocky. Cocky, but in the vague, empty-headed kind of way he gets after some good head. Somehow, he’s both more annoying and more endearing when he was like this.

“Well, now that everyone’s here,” Mina says, glaring meaningfully at Izuku and Katsuki, “let’s make some toasts!”

“We just spent like, hours toasting,” Kaminari whined. Kirishima looks stupidly happy regardless, which is how he’d been looking for the entire day. Maybe too happy to form coherent words, after several beers, so his head just dropped onto Kaminari’s shoulder and he said something about *manly* and *love* and *grateful for you guys* . Definitely positive stuff.

“But there were parents there,” Mina protested. “Now we can say anything!”

“This is not going anywhere I’m going to like, is it,” Iida groaned. Ochako poked his cheek, telling him to lighten up. More significant looks were exchanged. Katsuki’s hand found its way onto his knee.

“The first of the gang to shack up,” Sero said, raising a glass, “I can’t believe Denki’s finally being deflowered.”

“I—” Kaminari sputtered.

“A virgin for so long,” Mina sighed, “incredible, isn’t it.”

“I *wish* they were,” Katsuki snapped. “Can you believe I walked in on them doing—”

“Don’t finish that sentence,” Kirishima said suddenly, jerking out of his lovesick stupor long enough to defend his fiance.

“Cheers for the idiots finally getting together,” Katsuki said instead. That, at least, got everyone in a good mood. Izuku was tucked against his side, Katsuki’s arm around his shoulder. It felt good. Peaceful.

He knew he had to treasure moments like this. No matter their imperfections or the tangled paths they took to get there, his friends were alive, safe, and beloved.

They were almost all the way back to Katsuki’s apartment. They had a bad habit of walking across the entire city whenever they’d been out drinking and needed to get home. There was something peaceful about walking around a night, when they weren’t on duty and someone else was responsible for keeping the city safe.

Besides, there wasn’t a whole lot out there that could take on Ground Zero and Deku, even if they were a little drunk. They’d made it all the way to the gate outside Katsuki’s apartment complex.

A lot had happened there. Being hounded by reporters, the picture of their kiss that had made its round through the media, the internet, and a disturbing amount of photoshop.

Now, though, Katsuki stopped outside the gate.

“Deku,” he said.

“Sup, Kacchan,” Izuku giggled. Maybe they’d make out against the gate? Then he caught the serious look in Katsuki’s eyes.

“Izuku.”

Izuku tried to sober himself up, because Katsuki looked serious. Katsuki put a hand on his shoulder, leaning in until their foreheads almost touched.

“Yes, Kacchan? Katsuki?”

Then Katsuki’s face split into a drunken grin, his eyes lighting up. “I call dibs.”

Izuku wasn’t sure if this didn’t make sense because he was drunk, or because Katsuki wasn’t making sense. Maybe both.

“Uh, dibs?”

Katsuki leaned in even closer, eyes gleaming despite the dark night. “Dibs on proposing. I wanna do it.”

Six words, but that was more than enough to steal Izuku’s breath away. He couldn’t see anything except Katsuki’s eyes staring into his, the complete delight and sincerity he felt at the idea of proposing to Izuku.

Izuku’s heart welled up with love.

“Kacchan, we haven’t even talked about marriage yet.”

“What, you don’t wanna? I know we’re going to. We just gotta talk and shit first, but when it’s time,” Katsuki paused, narrowing his eyes, “I want dibs.”

“I—”

“Gimme,” Katsuki said, in what was almost a pout. Izuku couldn’t help his happy little laugh. The whole thing felt surreal, but the chill of the air and warmth of Katsuki’s hand on his shoulder grounded him inescapably. Anyway, there was absolutely no way Izuku could deny him this, even if he did maybe have a few ideas of how he’d like to propose to Katsuki.

“Alright Kacchan, you can have dibs.”

“Yes!”

“But you owe me.”

“Bitch,” Katsuki said, but looked way too happy and fond for the word to have any bite. He leaned in, kissing Izuku hard enough Izuku’s back bumped into the gate. Izuku parted his lips, giving in to the kiss, no longer caring they were out where anyone could see them. Thankfully, it had been a long time since they’d needed to have secrecy. (Sometimes Suika was on their case about having *tact* , though.)

Something beeped to his left, and the gate swung open. Izuku stumbled backward, and Katsuki followed him cackling.

“Come on nerd, I got you something inside. Wanna show you right now.”

“Kacchan… you can’t just propose right after calling dibs. We still have to talk—”

“First off,” Katsuki said, way too loudly, “I can do what I want. I have dibs. Secondly, *if* I was going to propose—”

“If?!”

Katsuki gave Izuku a toothy, joyful look, and punched the call button for the elevator. “Don’t sweat it, Deks. Besides, that’s not what I have for you. It’s not that big a deal, or whatever.”

“If it’s a ring I’m gonna smack you.”

“It’s *not,”* Katsuki howled. The elevator pinged open. Soon, they were scrambling to get into Katsuki’s apartment. He opened the door, and Izuku darted through, haphazardly abandoning his shoes and jacket before hopping onto his normal perch on the counter.

He held out both his hands, staring at Katsuki while he tried to untie his shoes with fumbling fingers.

“Give!”

“Fuck, be patient,” Katsuki snarled, yanking off a shoe in a way that looked bad for his ankles. Then he was flying through the kitchen, opening cabinets at random before descending on the couch. “Hah!” He held up a plastic folder and jetted across the room to appear between Izuku’s knees.

Izuku was completely at a loss, but happy to be receiving something from Katsuki in general. He’d managed to burn away most of the buzz from the bar, and Katsuki had a certain clarity to his eyes.

They stared at each other for a moment. Then Katsuki pushed the folder into his chest.

Izuku grabbed it with clumsy fingers and opened it carefully. Katsuki was dead-still, his gaze intense like high-beams on a deserted highway. Izuku looked at the first page. It was a print out of an… apartment listing? Three bedrooms, two baths. A balcony. State-of-the-art kitchen. Izuku flipped the page and found another listing. Another page, more listings.

“You’re moving?” Izuku asked. Katsuki bit his lip and looked like he really, really wanted to talk about how stupid Izuku was.

Instead, he just said, “Not if you’re not.”

Izuku took a moment to process that. Three bedrooms. An unnecessary luxury for one person, but for two pro-heroes with a solid income? Izuku’s eyes jumped from the page to meet Katsuki’s. “T-together?” he stuttered.

“Yeah, if you want,” Katsuki said quietly, “there’s a bunch of good places in there, but it’s just for starters.”

“You want to move in together.”

Irritated, Katsuki tapped the paper with a finger. “So what if I do?”

“You’re being bashful about moving in together like, ten minutes after aggressively begging to propose to me, Kacchan.”

“Yeah, well, this is the first step, asshat. The first of many. You wanna take it with me?”

Izuku swallowed hard, unable to look away from his eyes. Katsuki’s gaze searched his, vulnerable and sincere, his brows drawn together in tension. When Katsuki looked at him like that, Izuku felt invincible. Larger than life. Like his soul and their love could maybe contain the entire universe, just as long as Katsuki would keep looking at him.

“Yes, Kacchan. I do.”

Chapter End Notes

THAT’S NOT THE ONLY “I DO” IZUKU WILL BE SAYING IN THE NEAR(ISH) FUTURE HAHA

(Okay guys, it’s time to admit it. There’s a ton of going out and drinking in this fic and i WILL NOT pretend that it’s not because of quarantine and because I’ve been stuck inside without work for about 3 months and goddamn it’d be nice to be in a room with other people.)

Sorry for writing a five-paragraph A/N but if you can't tell I tend to write a lot :^)

I’m sort of emotional about ending this one. Fireball is both the first fanfiction I’ve ever written, and the first I ever posted. Those first sentences of chapter 1 are the first pieces of my writing that I really, idk, released to the public. I can’t tell you all how much it’s meant to me that you all read my work, took the time to kudos or comment or share your thoughts with me, and I’m so grateful for everyone for going on this journey with me! I’ve learned a lot while writing this, including my love of fic & also this community. Super in love with the idea of creators coming together over a shared passion, and the communal enjoyment & idea-sharing is just heartwarming. Warm and fuzzies all around.

Yeah, I’m over here, sobbing into my tub of Ben & Jerry’s new flavor, *Emo About Porny Fanfic.*

Anyway, I’m still writing other stuff. I’ve got a bkdk big bang fic coming up, and some other fun ideas as well! It's all in progress for the moment though :^) I want to write more bkdk oneshots.

...and I’m working on some other things! Trying out writing for new ships! Yeah. I admit it. It’s just TONS of bakugou/shinsou because I adore them both and they’re so, so, so much fun together. And by fun I mean rude. And bitchy. Ah, good times. So if you’re into that, my fic NyQuil is complete and currently being posted on a weekly basis! I put a fuck ton of effort into that one, and it's actually like, put-together in a way

my other chapter fics haven't been yet. I'm hoping to write another long-ass bkdk fic with everything I've learned so far!

Much love from ur friendly internet donut <3

if u miss me call me at 1-800-@useless_donut

You guys are LUCKY i called it DcMonald's and not **Dick**Monald's like I wanted to. Everyone can thank walkingcatfish for their part in explaining to me how extremely important it was to include DcMonald's/DickMonald's in this fic. (if you like baku/shin or dabi/hawks don't miss out on their work!)

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!